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The social drama of everyday life

A festschrift for Ann-Carita Evaldsson



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Introduction

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How is an academic career shaped, and where does one begin to tell such a story? It becomes an especially poignant question in this type of publication, which is a tribute to a beloved and respected friend, colleague, supervisor, teacher, and life partner. The question is interesting for all of us, both in an ontological and epistemological sense. When do we begin to be formed as intellectuals, and how did we end up where we are as academics? Where did the influences come from, and what were the conditions that shaped our lives and careers?

In research on scientific biographies, the focus is on how a person's central research interests emerged and how they developed in harmony with family background, the social and cultural environment, and, of course, the material conditions. In humanistic and social science biographical research, life and career are woven together in an obvious way. That we, as researchers, work with questions close to our hearts is often quite apparent, but there is also a scholarly and societal interest in showing how science develops under different circumstances. In other words, it is both an interest in individual life stories and in larger structures. Not infrequently—or perhaps almost always—the individual is driven by an emancipatory project, that is, a desire to shed light on and create change.

In a *festschrift* of this kind, it is naturally the intellectual contribution that is highlighted, and it is not a life story with biographical details from cradle to present that stands at the center. But a few biographical details are still worth mentioning, because it is difficult to understand Ann-Carita's research and intellectual career without also understanding the people and values she has cherished and carried with her throughout an academic career spanning more than 40 years.

A brief outline of a successful career

Ann-Carita was born in Gothenburg on 14 March 1958. Her parents, Rune and Greta, chose the name Ann-Carita as a combination of their wish that the girl be named Ann and the fact that her father thought the small fashion shop *Carita* in Gothenburg had a stylish name—so Ann-Carita it became. A search in the Swedish Tax Agency's population register in March 2026 shows that no one else in Sweden has the name Ann-Carita with a hyphen. A unique name for a unique person.

When Ann-Carita was four years old and her little brother Per-Anders had just been born, the family of four moved to Järnbrott, a suburb of Gothenburg in Västra Frölunda. Rune and Greta, who had grown up in the rural parts of Småland in the 1930s and 40s, moved from central Gothenburg because they wanted to get out of the city and closer to nature—and they did. But it was also a suburb with tough conditions for many families.

Her father Rune trained as a florist through a one-year folk high school program at Östra Grevie in Skåne and worked as a florist throughout his life. His intellectual and poetic talent would, in another era, most certainly have led to higher education. Greta took care of the home and managed to make ends meet on a modest florist's salary. Later in life, she worked in home healthcare. There was generally little extravagance, and when their first grandchild, Fanny, was born, they celebrated by sharing a pineapple pizza from the local pizzeria in Järnbrott.

The distance to academia was considerable in their generation, but the higher education system opened up for the next. Ann-Carita became the first in her family to begin and complete higher education.

Ann-Carita initially studied psychology and philosophy at the University of Gothenburg but later switched to speech and language pathology at Lund University, where she graduated as a speech and language pathologist in 1986. Her final thesis bore the somewhat pompous title *"The Nature of Communication" (Kommunikationens väsen)*, but in many ways it also came to set the direction for the career that was taking shape. Key concepts in the thesis included language systems, dialogue, and interaction, and the major theoretical influences were Gregory Bateson and Basil Bernstein.

During the spring of 1986, she noticed an advertisement at the Department of Speech and Language Pathology and Phoniatrics in Lund for doctoral studies at the interdisciplinary Department of Communication Studies (Tema Kommunikation) at Linköping University. Without really knowing what doctoral studies entailed, she applied and was admitted for the autumn term of 1986.

The relatively new research environment at Tema Kommunikation—with professors Per Linell, Roger Säljö, and Karin Aronsson at the forefront—was a creative and lively research hub with broad interdisciplinary expertise in language, communication, dialogue, cognition, microsociology, ethnomethodology, and conversation analysis. The international exchange was extensive, which was relatively uncommon in Swedish behavioral and social science research environments in the 1980s. Through their networks, professors Linell, Säljö, and Aronsson invited researchers primarily from Europe and the United States. Ann-Carita became part of these networks early on and has since contributed to their development in several areas, such as children's language socialization, multimodality, and interaction—first based at Linköping University and, for the past 20 years, as a Professor of Education and scientific

leader of the research environment *Studies of Childhood, Learning and Identities as Interactional Practices* at Uppsala University.

After defending her dissertation in 1993, *Play, Disputes and Social Order: Everyday Life in Two Swedish After-school Centres*, she has consistently advanced research on children's social interaction, multimodal interaction analysis, video ethnography, the micro-dramas of everyday life, relationships, friendship, and social order—and not least children's agency and social competence. She has further developed a wide range of themes she first encountered during her speech pathology and doctoral training. She combines this with a strong social commitment, which she herself relates to her upbringing in Järnbrott.

About the contributions

In this *festschrift*, we wish to highlight both the breadth and depth of Ann-Carita's research, where colleagues she has worked with, supervised, or been supervised by, in various ways relate to her work through their contributions.

We start the book with William A. Corsaro's chapter *Micro-dramas in children's peer culture: theoretical and research potential for the study of social interaction* that lays the groundwork for the children's peer group studies. It discusses the theoretical importance of understanding how children actively engage in the creation of their own unique peer cultures through interpretive appropriation, that is the process through which children address their own peer concerns while appropriating knowledge from the adult world. The chapter describes how children's peer cultures, and micro-dramas in children's everyday life can be explored through intensive micro analyses.

The theme of children's peer play, its social, verbal and embodied organization and impact on the social organization of children's everyday activities is developed in a number of contributions. Children use a broad array of resources to negotiate their activities and positions, including the social organization of the peer group. Katarina Gustafson in her piece on *Children's collective and creative play on the preschool bus* points out the time-spatial organization of recurrent cultural routines and highlights how waiting time on a mobile bus is utilized by children to create a collective space for play.

Children's use of material artefacts and social space is further exemplified in Asta Cekaite's and Polly Björk-Willén's study *Uninvited diners in children's kitchen play: Embodiment and materiality of territorial takeovers.* It describes a potential peer group conflict between boys and slightly older girls during a free play activity, demonstrating that children do not necessarily engage in conflict, using various spatial and silent methods to avoid conflict and neglect an emerging "territorial dispute".

Magnus Karlsson's contribution *The transformative, shifting and multilayered nature of young children's situated play* discusses how studying play *in situ* provides insights into "the diverse sociocultural meanings of children's

play activities from the children's own perspectives" and deepens the understanding of the interactional and social dynamics of the peer group.

Helen Melander Bowden and Pål Aarsand in their chapter *Embodied performance in gameplay narratives* direct their analytical gaze at everyday gaming narratives. Such narrative performances draw "on shared knowledge and interactional histories of specific games" and were used to claim epistemically competent positions, in such way contributing to the social organization of the peer group.

Heteroglossic (e.g., multilingual) practices can also be used to claim an epistemically hierarchical position. As demonstrated by Amanda Bateman, children use a rich array of available and spontaneously co-constructed resources, including bilingual English-Fairy talk to progress their careful negotiations of peer pretend play in an orderly manner.

Matthew Burdelski's study shows that multilingual—heteroglossic—practices at an international school in Japan "are implicated in the negotiation of stance and authority within the peer group". The peer group socializes each other by using "corrections, directives, and negotiations over who speaks, reads, or controls the book" when positioning themselves and others in relation to their multilingual knowledge, utilizing these discursive resources for identity work, and inclusion vs. exclusion in the peer group.

In her contribution on *Social voices and knowledge displays: children orchestrating participation in the literacy corner* Amy Kyratzis demonstrates that children use various authoritative voices—teacher talk and reading voice—when claiming the epistemic authority through the teacher or reader role. In such way children's pretend play reflect "power relations in the larger social world".

The theme of multilingual, multimodal and heteroglossic practices is further explored in Luna Zejia Xu's chapter on children's participation in a heritage language classroom. She details how a teacher's multimodal storytelling practices support young Chinese–Swedish bilingual children's creative engagement and heritage language learning. The study highlights the importance of teachers positioning children as "creative agents who actively shape storytelling through embodied stance, shifts in footing, and multilingual resources".

Rickard Jonsson and Karin Aronsson in their contribution *Stylizations and classroom performance: Taboos, bonding and the co-creation of jokes* shift the focus to an older group, examining stylizations in adolescents' classroom performance as identity work. Stylizations are here related to various cultural stereotypes enacted through the use of different voices that attest to the youth's sociocultural skills in claiming not only present, but also various future identities.

Another set of chapters direct attention to methodological issues in research on and with children and youth. Sofia Lundmark and Janne Kontio in their study *Narcissism or masquerade? Selfies as visual communication in*

Vocational Education classrooms examine how youth's selfies and visual interaction constitute means for their impression management, as when they "curate images of themselves in order to align with friendship norms and negotiate membership within both peer and professional cultures".

In a similar way, Fredrik Andréasson and Johanna Svahn point out the importance of video-ethnographers taking seriously situations when children use or explicitly interact with the video-ethnographer's camera. The camera is used agentively for children's own local social purposes within the context of peer interaction. It can also be used as a tool for guiding the researcher or as a means of addressing moral transgressions among peers.

Several contributions touch upon the methodological and theoretical perspectives on social interaction. In the chapter *On social categories in peer interaction,* Nicola Nasi discusses the theoretical perspective and the analytical procedures relevant for exploring how members' "everyday understanding and management of their social life-world" become operational in the routine flow of the everyday through the use of social categories, their predicates and attributes.

Another group of chapters contribute to delineating the broad array of resources that participants, here teachers, parents, and other adults, use in categorizing and socializing children in educational settings, and in families. In *Tracing the accomplishment of disabilities identities: The case of a student on the autism spectrum,* Friederike Kern and Vivien Heller draw on the notions of *category-sensitive action*, and intercorporeal participation framework, following Ann-Carita's proposal to combine multimodal interaction analysis with membership categorization analysis.

Mathilda Tassinari Rogalin's essay *The importance of others in identity construction* highlights the importance of others in one's identity construction. She examines how a student's identity becomes linked to a medical-psychiatric diagnosis in a special educational setting, where multiple perspectives on the diagnosis—the students', teachers and peers' perspectives—become relevant, cross-fertilize or contradict each other, all contributing to student's identity formation.

Marjorie H. Goodwin, Lourdes de Leon and Hilario Chi Canul, a team of anthropologists in their comparative piece on family life *Morality and accountability in directive trajectories: Notes from US and two Mayan contexts* show that these cultures socialize children into different notions of accountability and respect towards one's elders. Among the rural Maya, moral behavior is cultivated by indirectly assessing children's conduct; in the US, moral metacommentaries spell out normative expectations or identify normative transgressions and are delivered directly to the child.

Cecilia Wadensjö in her chapter on *Repair in an interpreter-mediated asylum interview – an interactional perspective* showcases how an interpreter-mediated encounter can be understood as a *situated activity system* (Goffman 1961: 96), i.e., as a shared communicative event. The piece shows that other-

initiated other-repair, contrary to what is common in everyday conversations, does not constitute a face threat, instead serving to resolve problems related to the lack of linguistic and factual knowledge.

Questions that concern the role of social interaction and language for cognitive and epistemological development in cases of autodidacticism, are discussed in Per-Anders Forstorp's study *Can do it myself: Some insights into the history of autodidacticism from Ibn Tufail to Ivan Illich and Everett Reimer.* Autodidacticism is here linked to the desire for intellectual independence, that is informed by the self-same institutional features it "seeks to transcend".

The final contribution is by Per Linell who in his essay *Do linguists know what a natural language is?* discusses theoretical assumptions concerning what natural language is and how we— 'experts' and 'ordinary language users' —understand language and languaging. The chapter reflects upon such at times implicit but always powerful assumptions about languages such as the idea of unitary, integrated languages, language as systems of sign or practices, words as potentialities or fixations, and, last but not the least—what and where is language?

Ann-Carita, this is our gift to you.

Micro-dramas in children's peer culture: Theoretical and research potential for the study of social interaction

William A. Corsaro
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Introduction

I have a long relationship of over 35 years with Ann-Carita Evaldsson as a colleague and dear friend. She spent several weeks visiting and working with me at Indiana University, Bloomington and I visited her both in Linköping and Uppsala where I received an honorary doctorate and was a visiting professor. I learned a great deal in my time at Uppsala from Ann-Carita and her many stimulating and wonderful colleagues and students. Ann-Carita and I have published together and have made each other better scholars and teachers in our shared scholarly and personal history.

I first became aware of Ann-Carita's work given her methodology and interest in children's friendships and peer cultures. Regarding peer culture, Ann-Carita in her work as I have in mine has focused specifically on children's peer values and concerns and their behavioral routines and artifacts. Her methodology, like my own, has involved long term longitudinal comparative ethnography and the collection and analysis of video and audio recordings of naturally occurring activities among children. Ann-Carita has worked primarily with pre-adolescent children in after school programs and other settings. In our joint publication, which has been well cited by many scholars, we discussed and compared our work on children's play and games as situated activities in children's peer cultures (Evaldsson & Corsaro, 1998). I focused on several play routines of American and Italian preschool children including spontaneous fantasy play, sociodramatic role play, and a type of run and chase play I termed approach avoidance play. Ann-Carita focused on Swedish elementary children's games in after-school program one involving marbles and the other jump rope.

In our analysis we discuss and extend the work of G. H. Mead and Vygotsky in line with my notion of interpretive reproduction (Corsaro, 1992; Corsaro & Everitt, 2024). We also demonstrate how children in the production of play and games simultaneously use (as well as refine and develop) a wide range of communicative skills, collectively participate in and extend their peer cultures, and appropriate features of the wider adult culture. Also, it was Ann-Carita's analyses of a variety of jump rope called the Cradle of Love with children as players and participants that first sparked my insight into and the

later development of the topic of this paper "micro-drama in children's peer culture."

Micro-drama in everyday life: Emotional and social transcendence of routines

A key feature of young children's peer cultures is their collective production of a number of play routines that have social, cognitive, and emotional elements. Most of these routines are not games with set rules and generally fit Mead's play stage. However, in expanding the notion of the play stage and actually focusing on play and games themselves rather than stages, I have demonstrated how young children's play routines display their agency and creativity. I identified a wide variety of play routines over a long period of time and among different cultural and ethnic groups. These routines involve various types of role and fantasy play, language and discussion routines involving debates and teasing, and nonverbal run and chase play activities. I extend this earlier work on play routines to develop further their importance in peer cultures. I focus on how they often serve as shared frames and safe havens for what I call *micro-dramas*. In micro-dramas, children collectively address personal concerns and interests while developing knowledge of the wider culture beyond the peer group. My thinking about these micro-dramas has been much influenced by Marjorie Goodwin's (2006) work on American children's play in school and playground settings and Ann-Carita's (Evaldsson, 1993) work on elementary school children's games in Swedish after-school programs (Corsaro, 2020). I first consider one example of micro-drama from Ann-Carita's work on games and then go on to discuss micro-drama in my work with American and Italian preschool children.

Micro-drama in the cradle of love

In her work on children's games as situated activity, Ann-Carita (Evaldsson, 1993) found that in one of the after-school centers she studied, both boys and girls engaged in jump rope activities on a regular basis. A frequent game was the Cradle of Love: A jumper jumps as turners and members of an audience call out the letters of the alphabet. If the jumper misses on a particular letter, others call out the name of another child or of some media character, who then becomes the potential (or pretend) love interest of the jumper. If a jumper succeeds in moving through the entire alphabet, she can propose the name of the love interest without the constraint of the initial letter. In this case, however, other children quickly offer up potential names for the jumper to evaluate. Repetitions of this game among children who spend a lot of time together take on characteristics that have as much to do with their developing relationships toward the opposite sex as they do with their competitive skill in jumping.

In an example from Ann-Carita's work (Evaldsson, 1993, pp. 117–19), Sara has just successfully jumped through the alphabet. She gets to pick a name, and two children suggest Dag, who is one of the most popular boys with girls in first grade. Sara seems a bit embarrassed and quietly says ''no.'' Then the children suggest comic book or super-hero characters like Superman, and Sara responds ''no'' to all these suggestions. The children then return to offering names of other boys.

Ania: Leif?
Sara: No.
Paul: Paul?
Fred: Someone in your class?
Paul: Axel?
Ania: Paul?
Fred: Paul?
Sara: Nope.
Axel: Per-Ola?
Paul: We've already had Per-Ola.
Sara: Dag [very quietly]. I'll take Dag then. Yes, Dag then.
Mona: Dag in our class?
Sara: Nope.
Ania: Dag sitting over there in the green cap?
Paul: Is that him?
Sara: Tuuurn!
Paul: Him [pointing].
Fred: Wowww! Wowie!
All: Dag Do You Love Me Tell Me Truly Aye or Nay [turning faster now]
Yes-No Yes-No [turning stops]
Yeeeessss!
Flera: Yeesss ho [laughing]
Fred: Dag! [Calling to Dag]
Flera: Ha ho ho [laughing]
Ania: Yells and waves saying Congrats, Dag!

Ann-Carita suggested that Sara was probably too shy to reveal her true preference for Dag when the name was first suggested. Also, because there was more than one Dag in the group, the matter was somewhat ambiguous. However, Sara clears up the ambiguity later and takes the game seriously when she chooses the boy that she is fond of in real life. Now this ordinary, everyday

game of jump rope is *intensified* and *transformed* as the pretend versus real frame is blurred. A micro-drama ensues with Sara and Dag as the central figures and the other children as active audience and participants. This transformation is richly signaled with the children's laughing, shouts of ''Wowie,'' and teasing of Dag and Sara. In this way, amid the jump rope game, love becomes a public topic that can engage nearly all the children at that center. Sara takes a chance by addressing her real concerns, feelings, and uncertainties about boys, but she is protected by the safety of the play frame, which in this case she dares to stretch (adapted in part from Corsaro, 2020 and Corsaro & Everitt, 2024).

Micro-drama in the play routines of preschool children

In considering micro-drama in my work on children's play routines I discuss two examples. In my research. The first arose during a run and chase routine I have termed approach-avoidance (Corsaro, 1985; 1988; 2012; Corsaro & Everitt, 2024). The actual approach-avoidance play in a preschool in Berkeley, California was video recorded spontaneously. It emerged when a group of two boys Peter and Larry descend from the climbing bars and threaten two girls Antionette and Lisa, who are inside an overturned pipe that children normally crawl through near the bar. I was standing nearby the pipe with a microphone and the children at times incorporated me into the play (see Corsaro, 1985). Some additional context is needed before examining the approach-avoidance play that becomes a micro-drama.

First, Antionette a Latina girl (the other three children are Caucasian) had a reputation as being one of the toughest kids in the school, often played with boys, and challenged them in many types of play. Lisa, on the other hand, mainly played with girls, but she did play with Larry on occasion and liked to tease him. The two children were exploring a sort of attraction or crush. Finally, Peter primarily played with other boys, but at times liked to challenge girls and chase after them. All the children were around 5.6 years old.

> Peter and Larry have been playing with ropes in the bars, and they descend from the bars and approach the girls in the pipe. The boys then move up close to the pipe and swing their ropes at the girls and Peter hisses as if he is a snake. Lisa sits on top of the pipe and Antionette gets out and taunts the boys. Eric chases after her with Benjy trailing behind. Benjy is a bit afraid of Antionette and when she turns and runs back towards the boys he says, "She's charging for us!" After a couple rounds of approach avoidance with the boys running after Antionette, who continues to taunt them while Lisa stays inside the pipe, Peter abandons the play. Larry tries unsuccessfully to get him to return while the girls sit on the pipe talking and daring Larry to come back. Larry

on his own now observes the girls from a distance standing on a rocking boat. The play has now been transformed from typical approach-avoidance to a micro-drama mainly between Lisa and Larry. However, Antionette complicates things for Larry as he is still afraid of her.

The girls talk with each other about what happened, and that Larry is watching them from a distance. Lisa tells me "Bill if Larry comes back tell him that were not here." I say "Ok" and then the girls yell out at Larry taunting him. Larry gets down from the rocking boat and slowly moves toward the girls rope in hand. The girls pop down into the pipe pretending to be afraid. This feigning of fear (the stereotyped girls afraid of boys) *intensifies* the micro-drama and is ironic as in real life Larry is afraid of Antionette. Larry cautiously approaches and swings his rope at the girls hitting the pipe. I say, "Larry they are not here," as I was instructed. Both girls pop back up from the pipe now and scoff at me for saying what is obviously not true. Then, Lisa responds, "Get Out!" and Larry says, "No you get out!" Then Antionette gets out of the pipe and taunts Larry saying, "You can't catch me—nanny-nanny-nanny!"

Larry chases after Antionette half-heartedly and she easily escapes to a nearby climbing house while Lisa remains in the pipe. Larry now moves away again, and Antionette returns to the pipe and asks Lisa to get out, but she refuses so Antionette gets back into the pipe sitting on top next to Lisa. Larry now returns close to the pipe and Lisa swings her hand at him saying, "I'm gonna kill you Larry!" Larry replies, "Un-huh," and swings his rope and hits the pipe again and Lisa shouts, "Miss me. Missed me. Now gotta kiss me!" With that dare, Larry turns and moves away and then at a distance turns and says, "You said you would kiss me, why don't you try!" Lisa clearly hears this retort but does not reply and continues to sit next to Antionette in the pipe. The girls discuss what happened as Antionette says, "He really tried to get us," as if she were afraid which of course she is not. But she continues in this stereotyped frame of timid girls being afraid of aggressive boys. Meanwhile Larry has now abandoned the micro-drama and goes off to join Peter who is now playing with some other boys in another part of the outside yard.

(Adapted from Corsaro, 1985, pp. 242-247)

In the original approach-avoidance play all the children are using knowledge of stereotyped sex typed behaviors (aggressive boys chasing after timid girls) which had been a theme in other approach-avoidance play routines in this

school. However, in this case the participants are forced to link this stereotypical knowledge to features of the interactive scene (for example Antionette's reputation as the toughest kid in the school and Peter's leaving the play). As the routine becomes a micro-drama in which Lisa and Larry can safely explore their cross-gender attraction, things become more intense and complex. Larry finds himself both threatening the girls as he cautiously approaches them as if they were a threat to be avoided. The girls, on the other hand (most especially Lisa), take on dual roles simultaneously taunting and approaching Larry and threatening him as well. It is unclear if Antionette and especially Peter are aware of the full extent of this micro-drama. Yet, their participation in the routine most especially that of Antionette, and their presence as an audience are very important in the emergence and unfolding of the micro drama. I as a researcher was also part of the audience and was brought into the play by the girls but derided for taking my instructions to literally.

A second example of a micro-drama emerged during a stylized debate or *discussione* among Italian preschool children I studied in Modena. The debate occurred after the preschool children made visits to the elementary school they would be attending in the fall after they completed preschool. In our work (Corsaro & Molinari, 2000, 2005) we refer to these visits of several types of *priming events* that prepared children for this important transition in their lives. After the visits the children and their teachers discussed how things would be different in first grade as there would be less time for free play, the children would sit at individual desks, they would have homework and so on. While almost all the children would attend the nearby elementary school they visited, a few children would be attending private Catholic elementary schools. One was a boy Angelo who was very popular among his classmates, and he had made the visit to the elementary school, but there was some sadness among his peers that he would soon no longer be together with them on a regular basis.

A few days after the visits and discussions Angelo got into a playful *discussione* with Marina and several other children as we see in this example from my field notes.

> Marina claimed Angelo had broken Elisa's pencil. I did not actually hear this since Marina left the area and supposedly told Elisa this, who also was no longer present. In any case, Marina returned, and Angelo followed her, saying she is a liar and that her nose will grow longer than Pinocchio's for telling lies. Marina denies that she has lied, and after several exchanges in which other children gave their opinions on the matter, Angelo and Marina start making threats. Angelo says his brother in first grade will beat up Marina. Then Marina says her brother in second grade will beat up Angelo's brother in first grade. Angelo now says that his brother in third grade will beat up Marina's brother

> in second grade. Angelo still seems to be taking it pretty seriously, but Marina starts to smile, and she is laughing when she says that her cousin in fourth grade will beat up Angelo's brother in third grade. Angelo smiles at this and the dispute ends. (Corsaro, 2020, p. 20).

Marina and Angelo could have followed up on some of these threats since they both have a brother in elementary school. Reality is clearly being stretched, however, as the threats become more fanciful and these routine *discussione* has now been transformed into a micro-drama. There are several elements that enliven the micro-drama for Angelo and Marina and their audience of several peers. First, was Angelo's use of the stock phrase regarding Pinocchio's nose which was often used when a child was accused of lying. Second, was the buildup of the humor of the "reality play" regarding the collaborative threats based on the impossibility of having siblings or relatives in the early grade levels of elementary school. These fanciful threats were much appreciated by the audience of peers and me to the micro-drama and clearly by Angelo and Marina as well. Finally, and more subtly, the two were using the discussion to address the changing nature of their friendship, most especially the realization that they would soon not be seeing each other on a regular basis again (see Corsaro, 2020; Corsaro & Molinari, 2005).

These micro-dramas among preschool children can be compared to the example from preadolescents in Ann-Carita's work I discussed earlier. For example, two of the children involved in the approach-avoidance routine took a chance to explore their liking for each other and went on to flirt using references to kissing as a threat which the girl and boy involved were exploring. Also, the main participants in the Italian example were very aware of the changing nature of their relationship with the coming transition and used discussione in an elaborate way to explore it. However, the micro-dramas of the preschool children in both settings were much less reflective and communal compared to the preadolescents where the primary participants who are exploring a love or liking interest *and* the audience are very aware of and excitedly build and intensify the micro dramas.

Micro-drama in Ann-Carita's later work

While I borrowed some examples from Ann-Carita's early work in the development of my notion of micro-drama, she expands the concept in her later work. Ann-Carita does so by drawing on new data beyond her original work in 2003 and 2004 generated in ethnographic observations and video recordings of children's cultural routines and peer language in playgrounds and after-school settings (e.g., Evaldsson & Aarsand, 2023). The analyses from these new data document how children within collaborative peer play performances created micro-dramas that serve as cultural frameworks to: (1)

dramatize and transform experiences from the outside world; (2) playfully subvert play hierarchies and gendered orders; and (3) comment upon and unravel controversial issues in their social life (Evaldsson, 2021, p. 72). Overall, Evaldsson extends my concept of micro-dramas by capturing them in a range of types of play in which they serve as important frameworks for preadolescent children to collectively address, play with, and pull apart some of the ambiguities and tensions they are exposed to in their everyday lives with peers and adults in educational settings (2021, p. 83). She concludes by noting as children engage in micro-dramas to address "ambiguities and tensions in social relations at school, after school, and in the family, it is not surprising to find that various aspects of social life, including asymmetries, ranking, and foolishness—but also trustworthiness, intimacy, and friendship—are commented upon and reinterpreted in children's peer play interaction, including children's experiences of their own relationships with one another" (2021, p. 84).

Conclusion

In concluding this discussion of micro-drama in my work in that of Ann-Carita, I review some key points and look to the future. The first is the theoretical importance of recognizing that children actively engage in the creation of their own unique peer cultures while appropriating information and knowledge from the adult world to address their own peer concerns. In the process children come to reproduce and extend the adult world in what I have termed interpretive reproduction (1992, 1993, 2020; Corsaro & Everitt, 2024). In her research alone and with colleagues Ann-Carita has taken up and expanded this theoretical view in work with older preadolescent children. In doing so she linked it to other related theoretical work on children's games as situated action in line with the views of Goffman (1974, 1981), Aronsson (2020), Marjorie Goodwin (1985, 1990, 2006; Goodwin & Kyratzis, 2014) and recent work of Ann-Carita and her colleagues (Evaldsson, 2021; Evaldsson & Melander, 2016, Evaldsson & Svahn, 2017). In fact, Aronsson initially put forward the term micro-drama in reviewing work in a special issue of *Text & Talk* shortly after I proposed the concept in my acceptance of the Cooley-Mead Award (Corsaro, 2020). In that published acceptance talk entitled "Big Ideas from Little People: What Research with Children Contributes to Social Psychology," I discuss how numerous findings from research on children including improvisational fantasy play, priming events, and of course micro-drama can contribute to future insights regarding the peer cultures, friendships, and social interactive routines of adolescents and adults. Future work by Ann-Carita and her colleagues will add to these insights to demonstrate the deep theoretical insights of work on children and youth for social psychology more generally.

Finally, there are the important contributions of my and Ann-Carita's work and that of others on micro-drama and peer culture for methodology in sociological and educational research. These contributions can be seen in long term, longitudinal and comparative ethnography where researchers carefully enter the worlds of children and gain their trust. Then "gradually [get] to know the children and how they organize their everyday lives, which in turn offers a deeper understanding of the interpretive procedures children employ in situated meaning-making" (Evaldsson, 2021, p. 69). Comparative longitudinal ethnography of this type is also often intensified with the inclusion of video recording leading to key insights and the more active involvement of children and other participants in the research process (see Corsaro, 1985, 1993; Corsaro & Molinari, 2005, 2017; Evaldsson, 1993, 2003; 2021; Evaldsson & Aarsand, 2022; Goodwin, 2006; Goodwin & Cekaite, 2018).

Intensive micro analyses often involving transcription following conventions within conversational analysis (Jefferson, 2004) are additionally combined with selective frame grabs from the videos and even drawings to capture the complexities of children's production of and participation in their peer cultures (Evaldsson, 2021). In the process video data can be brought to life for the reader in published work in ways that go beyond earlier discourse and conversational analysis especially in most of my own research. In some ways, it was the complexity of children's lives and multi-modal forms of communication that has led to these innovations, and which again have great import and insight for studying the interactive worlds of adolescents and adults. A sort of micro-drama in the methods themselves.

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Children's collective and creative play on the preschool bus

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Children creating space for play within the cultural routine of sitting on the preschool bus

The time-spatial organisation of daily life in early childhood education includes a range of recurrent cultural routines, such as educational activities, outings, play and meals. This short analysis aims to explore children's situated play and interaction on a mobile preschool bus[1]. The examples show how children collectively interact—through talk, bodies, gestures and movement as well as materialities (e.g., bus seats, sounds from loudspeakers, clothes and small artefacts)—when creating space for play within the cultural routine of sitting on the bus. Mobile preschools, an early childhood education practice, travel by bus on a daily basis to various locations, where teachers and children conduct their daily activities. As underlined within mobility studies (Hannan et al., 2006), movements include both moving and mooring. This becomes clear when looking into children's everyday life in the mobile preschool. Along with conducting ordinary preschool activities and routines in different places, being a mobile preschool child entails participating in specific routines conducted on the bus, such as meals and educational activities as well as departure preparations and travelling. Hence, several times a day, when waiting for departure and meals as well as during the journey itself, the children sit on the bus in small groups for shorter or longer time periods. The familiar and well-known patterns in these mobile preschool routines—including safety routines—are carried out by teachers and children in interaction and allow the children to also engage in their own activities with peers while participating in reproducing the routines (cf. Corsaro, 2018; Evaldsson, 2009). The chosen examples show how a group of children collectively play and interact while seated on the bus during 20 minutes of waiting for departure, 30 minutes of travel and an additional 25 minutes of having a snack and waiting to disembark. These waiting routines are not unusual within the mobile preschool, especially during winter when the preschool group spends more time on the bus (cf. Gustafson & Ekman Ladru, 2015; Litsner, 2019).

[1] The empirical data derive from a long-term ethnographic fieldwork in mobile preschools conducted together with associate professor Danielle Ekman Ladru, Stockholm University, supported by the Swedish Research Council (grant number 2015-01260).

The bus has been specially designed for the mobile preschool practice, with a small kitchenette, toilet and storages. The children sit in groups of four, two and two opposite each other with a small table in between. For safety reasons, they sit in child car seats placed up high in the bus seats, giving them a good view through the window and letting them dangle their legs. Where the children sit and how the educators move through the aisle while the bus is parked is significant for interactions, both between educators and children and for peer group interactions and play (cf. Melander Bowden & Gustafson, 2021). The children have allocated seats that shift every month, and here we will look further into how four of them, whom we call Kim, Sarah, Ruth and Anna, creatively play while sitting together on the bus. See figure 1 for outline of the bus and the four children's seats marked in grey. The examples show how the children are collectively engaged in; i) *playing with 'smuggled-in' artefacts*, ii) *dancing in the seats* and iii) *playing with their bodies.*

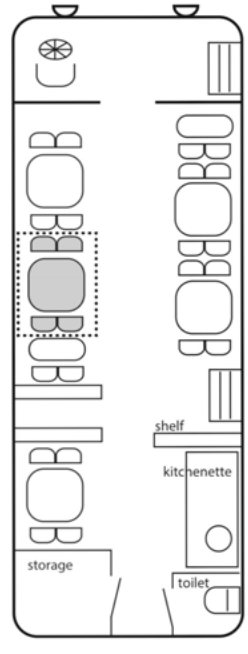


Figure 1 Outline of the bus

Playing with 'smuggled-in' artefacts

It is morning in the mobile preschool and Kim, Sarah, Ruth and Anna have just embarked on the bus and taken their seats. The four children chat and comment on activities that are going on inside and outside the bus. While waiting for departure, they are engaged in a range of activities, both

individually and between the four of them. For instance, even though caps and mittens are supposed to be put on a shelf by the bus's back door, Sarah and Ruth have brought theirs to the seats. They sit next to each other and begin playing with the caps, putting them on and taking them off. Sarah tries to put her cap on Ruth's head, but Ruth leans away to avoid it. In response, she tries to put her own cap on Sarah. They laugh together as they move around in their seats, playfully dodging each other's attempts to place the caps on their heads. Meanwhile, Anna sits in silence and looks out the window. Kim tinkers with pocket tissues and a lip balm that he has brought with him. He plays with his tissues and takes off the lid of the lip balm and puts it back on again and again. All three girls start looking at Kim, who keeps saying 'Lypsyl' (the lip balm's brand name) several times. When he drops the lid on the floor, Sarah quickly jumps down to pick it up and hands it back to Kim. He continues to tinker with the lid and puts it in his mouth. A few minutes later, a teacher passes by in the aisle, looks at Kim and says, 'Hey you!' and holds out her hand. Without hesitating, Kim spits out the lid into the teacher's hand and she walks on with no further comment. Neither Kim nor the three girls comment on the teacher's request.

Even though the children are not allowed to bring such artefacts onto the bus, as in many preschools, it is not unusual to 'smuggle in' little things to show to others and play with together. The two girls have brought their caps to their seats and creatively use them in their collective play. Even though Kim mostly played with his artefacts himself, he also gained a lot of attention from the other three children in their seating group and Sarah supported him by picking up the balm from the floor. Since the bus still was parked and the children were not having safety belts on, Sarah could quickly jump down and back to her seat again.

In order to be able to play with 'smuggled-in' artefacts, children have to know how to do it in a way that does not attract too much attention from teachers. This is in line with Corsaro's theories of how *'children attempt to evade adult rules through collaboratively produce* ***secondary adjustments****, which enable children to gain a certain amount of control over their lives in [early childhood educational institutions]*' (2018, p. 45). Corsaro transforms Goffman's concept '*secondary* adjustments', originally describing adults and the underlife of total institutions, to show how also young children – when knowing and seemingly performing in line with institutional rules – are engaged in '*getting around assumptions as to what he should do and get and hence what he should be*' (Goffman, 1961, p. 172). The children in the example show knowledge of the routines and rules as well as what is expected of them as mobile preschool children. They know from earlier experience that they can get away with playing with little things, as long as they remain in their seats looking prepared for departure and the play is not regarded disturbing or too loud – sound volume is a recurring issue on the bus – or a safety risk. Traffic safety is important on the mobile preschool bus (cf. Gustafson &

Ekman Ladru, 2020), and when Kim immediately spits out the lid, he demonstrates knowledge of the safety rule of not having anything in one's mouth while travelling on the bus. The teacher is seemingly satisfied with Kim's respond and not keeping a potentially dangerous piece in the mouth during travel. As shown by Corsaro (2018), teachers are not seldom aware of preschool children's secondary adjustments and accept them as long as it is not challenging the social order or regarded a safety risk. In our fieldwork we have examples of how teachers' sanctions vary depending on situation, from interacting with an individual child – as here – to gathering the whole preschool group for a collective orientation to rules (see also Gustafson & Ekman Ladru, 2020; Melander Bowden & Gustafson, 2022). While sitting in the bus seats and waiting for departure, the children are engaged in creative and collective play. Together in company, they continue to play with clothes and small things they brought along, talk, sing or just sit quietly and look out through the window.

Dancing in the seats

During the journey to the location of the day, the four children together engage in play activities that involve collective movements and singing. As always when the bus is moving, all children sit up straight in their seats wearing safety belts, but they still find creative ways of dancing together. Usually, a fairy tale or music is played on the loudspeakers while travelling. During fairy tales the children are supposed to be quiet and listen, but when music is on, there is often lively talk and activity on the bus. Today, a mix of popular songs is played, and Kim, Sarah, Ruth and Anna sing along with the music. They are obviously familiar with the playlist and sing some lyrics already before the artists; one child starts and the others join in. All four make rhythmic dance moves with their heads, arms, hands and upper bodies while they smile, look at each other and sing. Even though the children are belted in, they collectively create a playful sing- and dance-moment in the seats. The well-known routine of sitting together with the same peers and the physical design of the seats that both limits and enables bodily movements and interaction (cf. Corsaro, 2018; Melander Bowden & Gustafson, 2022), together with the recognition of the music in the loudspeakers all become part of the composition where the children creatively engage in a collective dance in their seats (cf. Ekman Ladru & Gustafson, 2020; Nansen et al., 2015).

Playing with their bodies

When the preschool bus arrives at the place where the day will be spent, a teacher welcomes the children to the destination and says, 'now it is okay to unlock your safety belts'. Immediately, everyone starts unlocking their belts but they remain in their seats. They know the routine of having the morning snack on the bus and the rule of staying seated until it is time to disembark.

Without the safety belts on, the children are now able to move more freely within the seats. Anna and Ruth, who sit opposite each other, quickly lean over the table and start to play with each other's hands. They press their hands towards each other, challenging the other to prove who is strongest. Sarah and Kim first sit and tinker by themselves. After a few minutes, all four of them are involved in a play where they lean over, press a finger on the other's nose and say 'boop on the nose' (see figure 2).

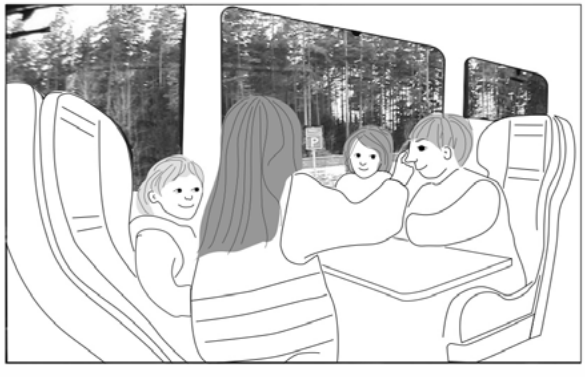


Figure 2, Boop on nose

As morning snack, the children are served bananas. While eating bananas they plan what to do and play when they get off the bus. Sarah and Kim fiddle with the banana peels and Kim's lip balm, while the other two first watch but later join in. Ruth makes a figure out of her banana peel and the others are engaged in playing with and commenting on the figure. Again, small artefacts such as banana peels (and lip balm) are creatively made into resources in the children's play, even though usually not allowed to play with. Children at other tables are told not to play with the peels by the teachers, but these four children are not. As mentioned, to engage in secondary adjustment and be able to play with things that they are not supposed to, the children have to know how to negotiate the rules (Evaldsson & Karlsson, 2020). This peer group is well aware of how to manage this, for instance by not disturbing other children or being too noisy.

Later, the children sit in silence for a while but soon start planning upcoming play activities again. Anna invites Ruth to make her a nice hairstyle when they are allowed off the bus and she agrees to that. After a few moments, all four children start to play with each other's hair. Ruth, who sits next to Sarah, plays with her hair and Anna, who sits next to Kim, plays with his. Sarah has her head in Ruth's lap and Kim has his in Anna's. Ruth and Anna use their fingers to comb, fondle and ruffle up the others' hair over and over. While occupied with the hair of the others in their laps, Ruth and Anna keep looking

over at each other and the two mirror each other's way of combing and ruffling up the others' hair. The two children lying in their laps look as though they enjoy being combed and touched.

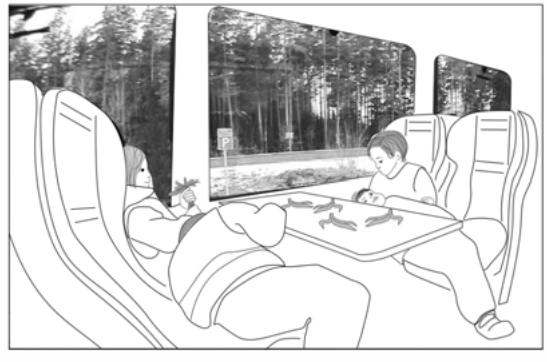


Figure 3, combing hair

After about five minutes of this hair-play, Kim sits up and leans across the table to invite Ruth to another bodily play. He challenges her to start pressing hands, as they did earlier. They continue doing this until the teachers have collected all banana peels and it is time to disembark.

In a creative use of diverse artefacts such as fruit peel and lip balm as well as their bodies and hair, the children engage in a range of recurrent play activities (cf. Corsaro, 2018; Evaldsson, 2009). The children within the mobile preschool practice often engage in collective corporal and intimate play. The physical design of the bus and where the children are seated is an important part of the composition of the children's collective interaction and embodied play (cf. Massey, 2005; Nansen et al., 2015). Leaning over the table in order to boop on another's nose or press hands is easily done (when not wearing a safety belt), but combing someone else's hair is easier on the person sitting next to you. However, the way in which Anna and Ruth look at and mirror each other's combing and touching shows how they position themselves as playing together (Evaldsson, 2020).

Creative play with peers on the bus

Inspired by Ann-Carita Evaldsson's research on children's creative play and participation in everyday preschool routines, the focus of this paper has been on the recurrent routine of children sitting in their seats in the preschool bus. The mobile preschool children are familiar with the time-spatial organisation of the day and the opportunities to play more freely and in different constellations after they have disembarked from the bus. As Evaldsson has described

so well (Evaldsson & Corsaro, 1998; Evaldsson, 2009; Evaldsson & Karlsson, 2020), children know that getting access to play and interactional space is a serious and complex interaction that includes demanding situations and has to be protected. In our ethnographic fieldwork, we often noticed how the children on the bus are creative in preparing for upcoming outdoor play. Children seated in different parts of the bus make room to arrange to play together later, and children who sit together start playing already on the bus and continue to do so once outside. Anna inviting Ruth to play with her hair when they get off the bus, and already on the bus starting a hair-play together with her and the two others, can be seen as examples of this. Additionally, whom you sit next to on the bus is important for possibilities and limitations for rest and 'dwelling in motion' (Urry, 2009) as well as for interactional space and play opportunities. However, the analysis shows how the children collectively interact through talk, bodies, gestures and movement as well as materialities (e.g., bus seats, sounds from loudspeakers, clothes and small artefacts they have 'smuggled in') when creating space for play within the cultural routine of sitting on the bus. The results demonstrate that 'sitting and waiting on the bus' by no means is a passive phenomenon. Rather, the children are actively involved in a range of creative collective play activities such as bodily play, physical competitions, singing and dancing.

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Uninvited diners in children's kitchen play: Embodiment and materiality of territorial takeovers

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Introduction

Play can be joyful, and it can also be serious, constituting a ground for children's everyday social organization, including peer group constructing and reconstructing social order in moment-by-moment interactions (Goodwin, 2006; Evaldsson & Karlsson, 2020). Learning how to build and sustain play, how to establish peer relations and alliances, and how to handle disputes and conflicts constitute an important part of accomplishing local social order. Both play and conflict are characteristic features of peer group cultures (Corsaro, 2023) and are part of children's everyday life both in families and in institutional contexts. Recent studies on children's peer interactions have highlighted the importance of verbal, bodily, and material resources in the organization of social interaction and in children's social worlds (e.g., Kyratzis, 2025; Nasi, 2025; Xu & Evaldsson, 2025). Research has shown that among interactional meaning-making resources children use to negotiate play activities, escalate or de-escalate disputes and conflicts, language constitutes but one resources. Bodily actions and materiality similarly contributing to the meaningfulness of children's social actions (Goodwin, 2006). While peer group conflicts can be viewed as productive for children's social and moral development, avoiding conflicts can also be a strategy to protect a play event.

The present study analyses the interactional dynamics of a potential play conflict in the peer group at a preschool in Sweden. The chapter involves a "single case analysis" of a play episode (Sacks, 1984; Schegloff, 1987) when two four-years old boys play together and a group of six-years old girls interfere in their play, take over the play space, material objects, and appropriate the play frame. Building on Goffman's (1971), notion of "territorial disputes" we examine verbal and embodied interactional methods and spatio-material resources that the girls use when taking over the boys' ongoing play, and the boys' actions for avoiding conflict escalation. The analytical framework of the study is informed by ethnomethodological work on social action focusing particular on participants' methodical ways of accomplishing and making sense of social activities. We are inspired by Ann-Carita Evaldsson's and other researchers' work on the social worlds of children's peer groups (Evaldsson, 2005; Goodwin, 2006; Kyratzis, 2025).

Children's play: access to play, inclusion, alignment, disputes and conflicts

Children's play is an intricate activity that is associated with complex micro-politics of the peer group. In his ethnographic studies of children's play, Corsaro (2003) showed that children spend much effort to protect their play from other children, and that close peer relations are supported and protected by children refusing others' attempts to join their ongoing activities. Hence, the protection of *interactive space* is related to the fragility of peer interaction and the possibilities of disruption in most preschool settings (Corsaro, 2023). When children initiate the entry procedure with a straight-forward strategy 'can I be with' routine (one that is frequently advocated by educators), they believe their chances of entry as fairly good (Cromdal, 2001). However, when the 'can I be with' routine is used in later phases of ongoing activity these bids are often refused.

While play activities are emergent and involve a great deal of improvisation, they are also characterized by a whole lot of common resources that contribute to constituting the social and performative fabric of play. In social pretend play, children need to share a co-constructed interactional framework that refers to both the pretend world (alternate reality) and to the real context (actual reality) (Butler, 2008; Sidnell, 2011). They also need to establish shared "contextualization cues" (Gumperz, 1982) that signal when they are within the pretend play frame, i.e. in frame, or in the real context, i.e. out of frame. Such cues are highly varied. For instance, bilingual children can use their different languages as a contextualization cue to signal when they are *in* versus *out* of frame (Guldal, 1997; Kyratzis, 2014). Björk-Willén (2012; 2021) shows that children's use of different tense markers can serve as a contextualization cue. Use of past tense can be consistently exploited by children to display the factual past event status, signaling to the co-players that this matter that cannot be altered. In contrast, the use of present and future tense is utilized to make bids for upcoming events.

In addition to talk, gestures, bodily positions and movement, material as well as imaginary objects are used to configure both nearness and distance in children's interaction and relationships during pretend play activity (Björk-Willén, 2012). The use of space and material objects constitutes relevant resources in children's organization of play scenarios, as well as in play access, and in their strategies to protect their play from others' territorial intrusions. The ownership of play objects, especially in institutional settings, can be negotiable and temporary, and distribution of toys constitutes a major cause for play conflicts. Usually, ownership rights related to the initial possession of an object, although they can be contested and re-negotiated (Holm Kvist, 2018; Cekaite & Burdelski, 2021). The link between play, object 'ownership', and play space, including the strategic use of space, is demonstrated in a study on siblings' 'sabotage' and play disputes. As noted (Zotevska, Cekaite &

Evaldsson, 2021, p. 139), "[s]patial distance or proximity, approaching or distancing and looking away from the other, can calibrate effective conflictual exclusion or highlight friendship (non-conflictual and harmonious) relations". Siblings in play conflict situations, when having 'lost' the desirable play object, retaliated by configuring 'deceptive' bodies, that is, non-threatening bodily displays. The 'loser' of the play object retaliated (although the conflict had seemingly fizzled out) through sabotage moves that targeted the children's object of mutual desire. "This required a skillful embodied performance and concealment of the upcoming destruction" (Zotevska et al., 2021, p. 141) achieved by configuring non-threatening body posture and using this kind of embodied behavior to gain access to the opponent's play space. The siblings' territorial intrusion and territorial offense (Goffman, 1971) were less detectable before they launched an 'attack' on the sibling's play object.

Children's establishment of shared play spaces are highly relevant for the social organization of the peer group. Goffman's work on the "the ritual and territorial elements in human encounters" (1971, p. 49), and his view that personal space is constituted through emergent bodily and territorial arrangements are productive for achieving a deeper understanding of children's peer cultures and their everyday activities (cf., Evaldsson & Karlsson, 2020). Shared spaces for play can be established through territorial arrangements that include children themselves, and a range of material resources, e.g., play huts, toys, imagined play spaces and many others (cf., Cobb-More, 2007; Bateman & Butler 2014; Zotevska et al., 2021). Such shared territorial arrangements accomplished through joint activities can also experience "territorial offenses" and "intrusions"—embodied practices of mobility when an individual or a group position themselves in the space of the others' ongoing activities (Goffman, 1971, p. 49). Territorial offenses may lead to conflicts and disputes among children, both in families and in institutional educational settings.

In conflict situations, social organization is instantiated through participant constellations, where 'numbers matter'. Studies show that children often establish local coalitions, e.g., "three-against-one" (Goodwin, 2006), "two-against-one" (Svahn & Evaldsson, 2011) that work to both include and to exclude peers and organize power hierarchies. Moreover, alliances and social hierarchies among children, and especially in age-integrated peer groups, can be clearly related to different age groups, where younger children can be excluded or assigned less desirable positions in play (Goodwin, 2006). In preschoolers' social world the categorization of age is of central importance; age is a differentiating principle that is crucial for the maintenance of the local social order of the peer group (Häll, 2022).

Previous research has pointed out several gender differences in children's dispute strategies, suggesting, for instance, that (middle class) girls mitigated utterances in conflict situations, while boys attempted to escalate conflicts. However, ethnographic studies have shown that girls act in a similarly competitive manner (Evaldsson & Karlsson, 2020). Goodwin (2003) found that

girls utilized a range of multiple semiotic fields, including talk, gestures, and objects, during oppositional talk in spontaneous play. They made extensive use of oppositional markers expressed through different intonation contours, accounts, demonstrations, and body positions. In all, embodied actions, movements and body positionings vis-à-vis each other are also important in the social organization of peer group; they can indicate relational alignment between friends or exclusion from the group (Goodwin, 2006; Svahn & Evaldsson, 2011). It is therefore important to take into account bodily and socio-material arrangements—that is, how children are positioned bodily vis-à-vis each other, play objects, and space (or 'play territory')—when analyzing children's social activities and their relational work.

Method

The present data are drawn from a video study of preschoolers' everyday interaction and talk during so-called free play periods (Swedish: 'fri lek') in a Swedish preschool setting that aims to acquire a deeper understanding of children's language use and socialization at preschool[2]. The theoretical framework is influenced by ethnomethodological work on social actions, which means that the main focus is on the participants' methods of accomplishing and making sense of social activities (Garfinkel, 1967). The current findings are derived from a single case analysis (Schegloff, 1987) of a pretend play episode between two boys and five girls. Single case analyses rely on a process where particular sequences of interaction are 'noticed' by the analyst (Francis & Hester, 2004, p. 25) and come to be of analytical interest.

Analysis

The play trajectory involves two sections: initially, we will show how two boys organize and sustain their joint play in a 'kitchen corner' by using verbal and material means within a collaboratively established play space; the second section discusses the transformation of the same play trajectory, instigated by a territorial intrusion and take-over by a group of six-year-old girls. We will show how the girls utilize territorial arrangements, body positionings and materiality, and an appropriate verbal play frame to stage spontaneously emerging "territorial offenses" (Goffman, 1971, p. 49) and to take over the boys' play.

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Collaborative play in a kitchen corner

In the first section two boys, Erik and Brian (both four-years-old) are playing in a room equipped with small kitchen furnishing, play dinnerware and kitchen utensils. Further into the room there are big windows with long transparent curtains. There is some noise from other children seeping in from adjacent rooms. Erik pretends that he is preparing a pancake dinner while Brian is sitting at a table. The researcher sits on a chair nearby, recording, and sometimes taking part in the boys' conversation. The boys' pretend play evolves spontaneously, without a prearranged agenda or explicit discussion of play roles, however, as often in pretend play situations, play moves follow implicitly shared rules and procedures (Evaldsson & Corsaro, 1998; Danby & Baker, 2000; Bateman & Butler, 2014). Their pretend reality is interactionally created through talk, movements and transformative manipulation of objects (Sawyer, 1997). The boys' reliance on the emergent but also recognizable conventions of pretend play makes the interaction flow smoothly.

When the excerpt begins, Erik has set the table with plates, glasses and a jug for a pretend smoothie. The table is set for four: Brian and his small robot, Erik and his small plastic figure. The researcher is also offered a pancake, which she pretends to eat with gusto. The boys do not take much notice of the researcher's presence, and she just seems to be a part of their play without an active role.

Excerpt 1

1	Erik:	här ((pretends to pour smoothie into the robot's
2		glass))
		Here
3	Brian:	tack
		Thanks
4	Erik:	den blå tallriken är din och den gröna är hans
		The blue plate is yours and the green is his
5		(the robot's) jag ska hämta en pannkaka till
		I will get another pancake
6		((walks to the kitchen counter and picks up a
7		bowl)) här lägger du i en pannkaka till honom
		Here you put the pancake for him
8		((points at the green plate)) för du har redan en
		because you already have
9		pannkaka i din ((gives the bowl to Brian))
		one in yours.
10	Brian:	((pretends to empty the bowl with the pancake onto
11		the plate while making a splash sound))
12	Erik:	så ((takes the bowl from Brian and walks to the
		that's it

13		kitchen counter and then turns back)) min är grön
		mine is green
14		((the plate)) jag ska sitta här hans ((the
		I will sit here his
15		figure's plate)) är blå
		is blue.
16	Brian:	han ((the figure)) har inte fått nåt glas
		he hasn't got a glass
17	Erik:	nä då måste jag gå och hämta han kan få välling
		No I have to go and get it he can get gruel.
18	Brian:	mm
19	Erik:	det kan din med få
		Yours can also get that
20	Brian:	nä han är vuxen
		No he is a grown up
21	Erik:	jag vet vad han ska får ni ska få bestick också
		I know what he will get you will also get cutlery.

After preparing the meal and setting the table, Erik serves food consisting of smoothie and pancakes (lines 1-2). For their pretend play to work, Erik is defining and managing objects—plates, food, and their toy figures. This interaction work builds mutual understanding (Coob-Moore et al., 2009). Notable is that the dining participants are not only the two boys, but also their play toys. For instance, when serving food Erik describes the color of the plates, indicating who—boys and their toys—sits where, and instructs Brian who will receive the pancake he has picked up from the kitchen (lines 4-9). The boys give considerable attention to their play in their talk, where they use mainly present but also future tense: "The blue plate **is** yours and the green **is** his" (line 4); I **will get** another pancake" (line 5); Here you **put** the pancake for him (line 7); because you already **have** one in yours (lines 8-9); "Mine **is** green, I **will sit** here, his **is** blue" (lines 13-15) and so on, which states that they are out of the pretend play frame.

In doing so, they enact the play scenario (Lodge, 1979), project future actions, and collaboratively negotiate the play trajectory. The use of present and future tenses indicates that there are possibilities to make proposals about what the upcoming events should be, and to make bids for specific actions (Björk-Willén, 2012; 2021). This is apparent in line 20, in the boys' out of frame talk, when Brian argues that his robot does not need gruel because the robot is a grown up. Here we also can see that pretend material objects, including food, are used as indexical membership categorization devices (Butler, 2008), where eating gruel is associated with being a child, in contrast to being an adult—a grown-up—participant (using cutlery), here the toy figure of a robot.

After a while, the boys' mealtime play becomes as livelier, and Brian pretends to quarrel with his robot at the table. Erik is standing in front of the kitchen counter when a six-year-old girl enters the room.

Excerpt 2

1	Erik:	((stops in front of the kitchen counter and
2		looks towards girl 1 who enters the room))
3	Girl 1:	vad gör ni
		What are you doing?
4	Erik:	[(x)
5	Re-	[vi äter pannkakor
	searcher:	We're eating pancakes.
6	Girl 1:	oh får jag smaka ((screeching voice))
		Oh may I taste?
7		[((sits at the table, pretends to eat rapidly))
8		Vad goa pannkakor det var ((runs out of the
		What delicious pancakes those were.
9		room))
10	Brian:	[((is standing on the other side of the table,
11		holding a chair in front of his face))
12	Girl 2:	((runs into the kitchen playroom, sits at the
13		table, pretends to eat)) Va goa ((runs out))
		Delicious!
14	Brian:	((puts down the chair, stands still on the
15		opposite side of the table))
16	Erik:	((stands still in front of the kitchen coun-
17		ter, anxious facial expression))
18	Girl 3:	((runs to the table, "takes a bite"))
19		Va goa ((turns back and runs out))
		Delicious!
20	Girl 4:	((runs to the table and then out))
21	Erik &	((standing immobile, quietly, serious facial
22	Brian:	expressions, watching the girls' running into
23		and play in the kitchen play space))
24	Girl 2:	((runs in, stops in front of the table, pre-
25		tends to drink, then runs out)) de va saft de
		It was juice it
26		var flädersaft där borta kom allihop
		was elderflower juice over there. Come here everyone

The first girl who enters the room immediately asks "what are you doing" (line 3) and Erik answers something inaudible in an overlap with the researcher's response "we are eating pancakes" (line 5). The researcher's reply provides

information about the play activity and could be seen to provide a go-ahead for the girl's participation in play. Girl 1 sits down at the table and pretends to eat (line 7). She does so although the boys have not invited her or given her permission to take part in the play. She quickly "eats" and then leaves the room (lines 8-9). During her uninvited and unsanctioned play move, her intrusion into the boys' play, Erik remains standing at the kitchen counter while Brian stands on the other side of the table, holding up a chair in front of his face, as if to protect himself (lines 10-11). The boys stand still, silently watching the girls. Then three more girls run quickly – they rush into the room one after each other - and pretend to eat from the set table that was prepared by the boys (lines 12-13, 18-19, & 20) and immediately rush out again. In line 24 Girl 2 alone comes back to the kitchen play corner and the boys' play set. While she appropriates the main play frame, she also changes the play scenario to some extent: she pretends that there is elderflower juice on the table and invites the other girls to join her by calling "come here everyone" (lines 25-26).

Excerpt 3

```
1   Girl 2, 3,  [((‘storm’ into the room, run to the table,
2   & 4:        pretend to eat and drink in a high tempo, all
3               around the table))
4   Erik:       [((moves to the window, hides behind the cur-
5               tains from where he observes the girls))
6   Girl 3:     (xx) ((uses screeching voice, then runs out))
7   Girl 1:     ((enters the room))
8   Girl 4:     ((gaze at the researcher, moves outside then
9               re-enters))
10  Girl 5:     ((re-enters the room immediately after Girl
11              4))
12  Girl 4:     ((a quick glance at the researcher))
13  Brian:      [((stands still behind the curtains, observ-
14              ing girls))
15  Girl 2:     va go mat de va ((turns around, looks at the
                The food tasted so good!
16              researcher))
17  Girl 5:     mm ((grabs Erik’s plastic toy figure that lays
18              on the table))
19  Brian:      det är Eriks (the toy figure) ((takes a step
                It is Erik’s
20              towards the table)) det där är Eriks.
                                              It is Erik’s.
21  Girl 5:     Vems
                Whose?
22  Brian:      den ((points at the plastic toy figure in girl
```

		This
23		5 hands))
24	Girls 1-4:	((leave the room quietly))
25	Erik:	[((looking out from behind the curtain))
26	Girl 5:	[((puts the figure on the table, leaves the
27		room))
28	Erik:	((emerges from behind the curtain, looks
29		around))
30	Brian:	((gives him the plastic toy figure)
31	Erik:	Tack ((looks at the table)) nu har vi ingen
		Thank you. we don't have more food.
32		mat längre

Now, upon the request to come in, several girls enter the room together, as a group—and take over the table and play space. They achieve a powerful territorial intrusion, as they act collaboratively as a group of five and they are also older and physically larger than the two boys.

When Girls 1-4 enter the room, Erik engages in clear conflict avoidance moves—he walks away from the main play territory and objects; he moves to the window and hides behind the curtains, observing the girls (lines 4-5). Brian who stands on the opposite side of the table backs off and leaves the play territory. None of the girls take any notice of the boys; they do not even glance at them, sustaining 'the girls' only' participation framework. Only one of the girls—girl 4—directs several glances to the researcher, the adult who is a co-present observer (lines 8-9 &12).

The children's use of temporal markers—present vs. past tense—are interesting and informative. In Excerpt 1 the boys use present and future tenses as a contextualization cue (Gumpertz, 1982), which signals that they are outside the pretend play frame, still collaboratively negotiating and developing their play. Unlike the boys, the girls in Excerpt 2 mostly use past tense: "What delicious pancakes those **were**" (lines 8-9), "It **was** juice", "it **was** elderflower…" (lines 25-26). The use of past tense signals that children, from that very moment, are part of a pretend world (Strömqvist, 1984). As demonstrated in several interactional studies on pretend play, the use of past tense is a way of displaying the factual status of past events; past tense emphasizes the definite character of the play moves. Co-players hear that these moves cannot be altered (Björk-Willén, 2012, 2021). We suggest that alignment in the girls' embodied participant framework (Goffman, 1981) in the factual character of their play moves gives the girls' group a possibility to sustain a closely-knit unit that excludes the boys. The girls powerfully keep them outside the play frame and accomplish the exclusion not only by adhering to but also changing the boys' play script, and by 'taking over'—by invading the play space and utilizing the boys' play objects (see also Karlsson & Nasi, 2023).

The girls' play frame breaks when Girl 5 grabs Erik's plastic figure, i.e., play character- participant (lines 17-18, see Ex.1, lines 14-16). Brian steps forward and tells her that it is Erik's, defending Erik's ownership, thus producing a conflictual move (lines 19-20). Temporary play toy ownership is important in preschool settings, where the child who has first claimed the toy is its lawful owner (see Cobb-More et al., 2007; Cekaite & Burdelski, 2021). Girl 5 orients to this rule and asks "whose" (line 21), and Brian points at the figure in her hand. None of the other girls make any comments. Instead, they leave the room quietly, finishing their territorial intrusion. Girl 5 puts the toy figure on the table and follows the group (lines 26-27). It is only when the girls have left the kitchen play space that Erik re-emerges from his hiding place behind the curtain. Brian immediately gives him back this toy figure (line 30). Erik thanks him, looks at the table and notes that there is no food left, immediately re-orienting to the play scenario.

In sum, despite the advantage that the girls' group has by forming their own participation framework, and by excluding the boys', the boys are able to reclaim their play. Brian's defense of Erik's play property (lines 19-20 & 22-23) shows that he finally dares to disrupt the girls' dominance (girl power) even though they are both older and form a larger group alliance. Like a hero Brian steps forward to save Erik's toy figure from the invaders, who immediately abandon the play territory.

Concluding observations

In this play trajectory study, the girls take over the boys' play through territorial intrusions and by using their toys (e.g., Goffman, 1971; Karlsson & Nasi, 2023). The girls are not invited or granted access to the boys' play space, nor do they ask for access. Rather, in their group actions, appropriation of the play plot, objects and play materiality, they take inspiration from the boys' play but also transform it. In doing so, they exclude the play originators themselves. Interestingly, the girls' encroachment on the boys' play territory and their physical use of the boys' play objects do not lead to a physical confrontation. There is no verbal conflict or dispute on the surface, and for a long time there are no protests or other conflictual actions from the boys, who silently and with serious faces follow the girls' actions. It can be suggested that age differences and differences in numbers—the girls are two years older, and they are many, compared to the two younger—four-year-old boys, are relevant for the successful and smooth territorial takeover and can support the boys' avoidance of the conflict. Perhaps the presence of the researcher contributed to the avoidance of conflict between the children. While previous studies have emphasized "the collaborative nature of children's protection of interactional space" (Evaldsson & Karlsson, 2020; Corsaro, 2003), our analysis has revealed that territorial intrusions and obtrusive play entry without asking for acceptance or permission are also effectively achieved in collaboration.

Appendix 1

[ ]	square brackets mark the start and end of overlapping speech
	word underlining indicates emphasis
WORD	capitals mark speech that is audibly louder than surrounding speech
° °	degree signs surround talk in quieter speech (sotto voce)
(2)	pauses measured in seconds
(.)	micro-pause
(( ))	investigator's comments within double parentheses
:	prolongation of preceding vowel
↓ ↑	falling or rising intonation
> <	more rapid than surrounding speech
< >	slower than surrounding speech
=	immediate 'latching' of successive talk
( )	uncertain interpretation within parentheses
(x) (xx)	inaudible word or words
svenska	talk in Swedish
English	English translations

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The transformative, shifting and multilayered nature of young children's situated play

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Introduction

This paper presents, analyses and discusses, utilising empirical examples, a selection of methodological and theoretical insights from Ann-Carita Evaldsson's long academic career. The adoption of *a micro-ethnographic, multimodal and situated approach*[3] to children's peer play, games and interactions provide insights into the collaborative, transformative, multilayered and often socially shifting (ambiguous) nature of peer play (see Evaldsson & Corsaro, 1998; Evaldsson, 2021; Goodwin, 2006; Sawyer, 1997). This analytical framework also addresses how simple notions and dichotomies regarding children's play (see Aronsson, 2023; Evaldsson, 2009, for overviews) as free, joyous and outside ordinary experience do not hold when studying play interactions in situ: 'in contrast to the popular belief that games are divorced from everyday experience', there is a 'continuation between games and ordinary experience' (Goodwin, 1985, p. 135). This means that children learn cultural techniques and about membership categorisations while playing games; thus, 'children may in fact discover how social order works through game participation' (e.g. Sacks, 1980). So, it is useful to study *how* children organise their play participation in actual social situations (rather than *what* they play or studying children´s reflections around their play participation in retrospect), as this organisation in situ can highlight a) interactional and social dynamics and b) the diverse sociocultural meanings of children's play activities from the children´s own perspectives.

A brief note on a theoretical background: The transformative character of play (frames):

Building on this line of research touched upon above, of which Ann-Carita is a leading scholar, one can consider the transformative, creative and collaborative character of children's situated play performances. The seminal work by Goffman (1974) and Bateson (1972) can function as a theoretical background for understanding the transformative power of play, and the complex and often demanding work children must do to maintain playful framings of a

[3] This approach is rooted in and extends the work of Erving Goffman, Charles and Marjorie Goodwin, William Corsaro, Harvey Sacks, Helen Schwartzmann and others.

situation. According to these scholars, humans (and animals) frame activities which can define what is going on in a situation and function as a reference point of how to understand the utterances and embodied actions done. This stems from Bateson´s (1972) observations of monkeys 'play-fighting' at a zoo and where the animals 'knew', through sending out metamessages 'this is play', that they were not in a 'real fight'. However, playful framing of actions and activities can be ambiguous and unpredictable and is often re-negotiated on a turn-by-turn basis (Goodwin, 1996; Gordon, 2008). As noted by Bateson (1972, p. 188), play frames are not clear cut: 'metacommunicative signals' which frame actions as playful, are in a way paradoxical because they simultaneously require both serious and non-serious interpretation –and where children can play with and collectively address the contradictory meanings and incongruities (cf. Corsaro, 2018). This relates to what is further noticed by Bateson (1972, p. 183) how 'human verbal communication can operate and always does operate at many contrasting levels of abstraction', such as within signalling play frames where 'the playful nip de-notes the bite, but does not denote that which would be denoted by the bite' (p. 189).

Building on the work by Bateson, Goffman´s notion on frames and related concepts (such as re-keying) can help us 'gain a deeper understanding of the interactional flow, shifts and transformations' (Cekaite, 2025, p. 34) of our everyday activities, where any activity can involve multiple transformations and meanings (e.g. Goffman, 1974). It means that definitions of situations (as play or serious) can be shifting and involve different layers or be combined for various interactional purposes. For example, Cekaite (2025) showed how adults in preschool environments can introduce an 'overlaying' playful frame of actions (done through embodied acts of touch of tickling and 'flying') to pursue the interaction with children, but which is combined with a framing of the ongoing instrumental activity so that its progression is furthered (managing transitions between activities).

These theoretical (and methodological) insights relate to the empirical examples of children's situated play presented below, which can exemplify the varied layers of verbal, embodied and affective (re-)transformations of conduct and objects performed by children within activities. It includes both serious and playful levels of interaction, and where language (and other resources) can be used for quick redefinitions of a situation (e.g. Gordon, 2008), including the managing and production of various stances towards each other's actions. The next section presents a summary of prior research related to children's play and relationship building, with emphasis given to the work of Evaldsson and colleagues; such scholarship provides a background for the empirical examples that follow.

Background research

The negotiation of what, how and with whom to play: Processes of social inclusion/exclusion

Ann-Carita Evaldsson has, through multiple studies, demonstrated many aspects of peer play in a variety of educational contexts, including how children generate knowledge of the wider culture through play and how play can alongside joy, creativity, language learning, social co-operation and solidarity also become a site for power differentiation, challenges, tensions and exclusions (Evaldsson, 2021; Evaldsson & Aarsand, 2022; Evaldsson & Tellgren, 2009). For example, Evaldsson and Tellgren (2009) showed how young girls in preschool socially organise play participation and form small play groups in which they exploit the power of language, play roles and rules in a process of strengthening peer relations and mark exclusive play spaces while indexing status differentiations. Other studies have similarly shown how children in play invoke and use their understandings of social categories and associated predicates along with directives to control others, indexing play hierarchies without overt confrontations (e.g. Evaldsson & Karlsson, 2020). Social processes of *exclusion* and status differentiation are collectively accomplished by children and do not always involve shifting of play frame. For example, a study by Evaldsson and Aarsand (2022) showed how a peer group of boys initially framed a table tennis game as a playful warrior duel: through mapping the oppositional categories of the players, two boys were able to create a framework of two-against-one, allowing them to overtake and dominate the physical play space initially inherited by the targeted third party. In this process, the material artefacts of the racquets functioned as symbolic 'weapons', creating a pretend play frame that justified competitive and degrading actions and cast the third child as an outsider in the boys' peer culture. This can also relate to the contractionary framing in play which is demonstrated in a recent study by Andrén and Cekaite (2021) among a group of preschool children who during a mealtime initiate a joint play activity (a girl pulling and catching another girl's cutleries) in which they had to re-negotiate emotional and social tensions between playful and serious teasing/dominance (see also Lerner & Zimmerman, 2003). The children restored the playfulness and fun of their play through smiles and laughter in response to one girl signaling mild opposition (verbal oppositions, whining voice, serious facial displays), which was due to the perceived antagonism of one party as dominating and mocking.

Recent research has also examined the *social processes of inclusion,* which can include joint activities and social recruitment practices of others to joint activities. From an early age, children actively manage their peer participation frameworks, and they develop a repertoire of various linguistic and non-verbal resources to solicit peers' attention and initiate mutual engagement around a shared focus in play, which can involve processes that can be stretched out in

time, unfolding over the course of the interaction (Burdelski & Cekaite, 2022; Fantasia, Moncalli & Bello, 2024; Nasi & Karlsson, 2026). As demonstrated in this research, the effectiveness of these attempts often relies on the maxims of being 'interesting' and 'persistent' (Cathcart-Strong, 1986). Recently, such interactional research has brought to the fore the local socio-material environment and its role in children's practices of inclusive acts towards peers, often involving a recognition and use of (real and imagined) objects and the spatial environment (e.g. Karlsson & Nasi, 2026). Thus, this field has expanded—from a primary focus on children's practices related to gaining access or protecting play spaces and exclusion—to include the multimodal assemblages of actions related to children's recruitment of others in shared play.

Girls' morality and relationships in peer groups

Another strand of Ann-Carita Evaldsson's research has examined how children in school environments, especially preadolescent girls from low-income and multiethnic backgrounds, negotiate social and moral norms of conduct and accomplish the local social organisation of their peer group structure over time. Evaldsson (2007; 2021) emphasised the use of ethnographic knowledge gained through longitudinal fieldwork to understand children's relational groupings and language practices over time (see also Goodwin, 2006). This is clearly demonstrated in another study by Evaldsson and Svahn (2011), who followed the (social) school careers of a triad of girls over a longer period to show how rather subtle features of interactions can be consequential for how children renegotiate and restructure their relationships from a triad to a dyad. In a similar vein, studies of preschoolers have shown how children can create dyadic affiliations and form relative positions in small interacting groups of three, demonstrating how such relationships can be established within play and games, but also renegotiated and shift over a rather short period of time (Karlsson, 2025; Karlsson & Nasi, 2023).

Evaldsson's work, alongside that of Marjorie Goodwin (1996; 2006), has also challenged stereotypical notions regarding girls' and boys' games, relationships and morality. Evaldsson (2004; 2007) has shown how children, as they talk and physically interact while playing games or assessing each's relational behaviour in the peer group, are *doing* gender and morality. To deepen this examination, she has often used Sacks' (1995) work on members' understandings of social categories (see Nasi, On social categories, this volume); for example Evaldsson (2007) demonstrated how preadolescent girls ascribe morally bound features to the characteristics of one another as 'good or bad friends', which are consequential for one girl being labelled 'friendless'. Evaldsson (2004) also, analysing how girls and boys (fourth to sixth graders) played the game foursquare, showed how girls engaged in extended arguments and negotiated rules on a turn-by-turn basis: the girls oriented to different forms of moral orders depending on the participants, thereby shifting away

from a 'morality of rights' and a 'morality of responsibility' to a 'morality of play', whereby they manipulated and outmanoeuvred the boys' participation and competencies (see also Evaldsson, 2021; Goodwin 2006). So, studying children's situated play can challenge simple notions of gender dichotomies in morality and competencies, such as 'girls as co-operative' and 'boys as competitive', along with essentialised notions that boys' games are more complex than girls' (for an overview, see Evaldsson, 2009; Goodwin, 2006).

The many layers of young children's transformative and situated play: Three empirical examples

Example 1: Preschool girls managing moral orders and peer relationships in the midst of board game interactions

The first example is collected from a situation in preschool involving two girls (Nelly and Vera, aged 5) who are engaged in playing a memory-based board game; a bystander, Julia (aged 5), is watching and sometimes commenting on the girls' play. Relational experiences outside the game and adult-like rules influence and become part of negotiations of the game rules. According to the children's preschool teachers, Nelly and Vera had been friends for some time, but Nelly had recently started to play with others, and the relationship between the two girls seemed to be changing, which can relate to the re-negotiation of the game rules below. Thus, ethnographic knowledge of children's pre-existing relationships can shed light on the local sequence. Before the excerpt begins, the children had oriented to different forms of moral orders; while the game is about winning for Vera (a more common justice- and competitive-based moral order), Nelly orients to the idea that the players should have an equal number of pairs (a socio-moral order of reciprocity). These different stances result in repeated arguments about what is 'fair' as part of the formation of a 'vernacular legal system' (Goodwin, 2017, p. 90).

As Excerpt 1 begins, Vera, who is having the most success in the game, gets another pair (line 1), which results in Nelly indicating that she wants to quit the game (line 2).

Excerpt 1

01	**VERA**	**+(2.0) +$Ye:ss$**
	vera	+lifts cards, opens mouth +receives a pair
02	**NELLY**	**.hhh de är inte ku[l ( ) [jag e inte me:***
		.hhh it´s no fu[n ( ) [I´m not in=
	nelly	*grabs some cards and drops them on the table
03	**JULIA**	**+[heja Nelly**
		[come on Nelly
	vera	+lifts a card
04	**JULIA**	**jag hejar bara på [di:g**
		I only support [yo::u
05	**VERA**	**[+men så gö:r man inte Nelly?**
		[but you don´t d:o that Nelly?
	vera	+turns back a card, shakes her head
06	**NELLY**	**men du (måste) det är faktiskt inte kul**
		but you (must) it is actually not fun
07	**VERA**	**jag ve:t att du kom- ja men annars får du (0.2) två av mig↑**
		I kno:w that you wil-yea but otherwise you can have two from
08		**(1.0)**
09	**VERA**	**+HÄR↑**
		HERE↑
	vera	+holds up two pairs
10		***(2.0)**
	nelly	*looks at the cards Vera is handing to her
11	**NELLY**	***visst ( )**
		sure ( )
		*turns two cards, turns them back
12	**VERA**	**+får du dom av mig (.) #1 här↑ ta dom**
		you may have them from me here take them
	vera	+put the cards in front of Nelly
	#Fig1	
13	**NELLY**	**Visst, såna hade jag ju**
		Sure I had a couple of those

Adapted from Karlsson, Hjörne and Evaldsson, 2016.

In line 2 Nelly drops her cards on the table, sighs loudly and says, 'it's no fun I am not in', demonstrating her negative emotions and intent to leave the game. This mobilises support from Julia, who starts to cheer Nelly on (lines 3–4). Simultaneously, Vera corrects Nelly (and indirectly Julia) in a moral manner, as demonstrated by her use of an adult-like tone of voice with a deeper register, by saying, 'but you can't do that, Nelly' (line 5). On a meta-communicative level, this signals a 'contest of prior play moves and coordinat[ion of] future ones during out-of-play frames' (Reynolds, 2010, p. 468). Vera here draws upon and gives voice to an institutional rule: 'you can't not finish the game just because you don't think it's fun'.

After Nelly once again states that the game is no fun (line 6), Vera shifts her strategy and begins instead to support Nelly's participation, engaging in a kind of encouraging relational work ('I know that you wi—') before she verbally offers Nelly two of her pairs (line 7). This attempt to encourage Nelly to stay in the game temporally abandons Vera's chosen moral order (producing a winner) and personal approach to the game's rules. Nelly seems to treat the offer as serious by accepting it: 'Sure, I had a couple of those [cards]' (line 13). This shift by Vera may have been catalysed by her social agenda at the time: to avoid a dispute with Nelly and to stay friends. In this way, the two girls manage to continue playing and to follow the institutional rule while also organizing their social relationship, thus showing how their relationships outside the game frame can influence game-specific negotiations (Goodwin, 1985).

The following excerpts (2a, 2b and 3) provide additional examples of the collaborative, creative, transformative and (sometimes) ambiguous nature of children's *play(ful)* performances. In general, play and playfulness have most often been associated with humour and amusement among children who are spontaneously engaging in make-believe play, playful teasing and clowning. However, play is not always so clear cut, and children's playfulness and mutual sense of joyfulness and humour can easily evolve into and be layered with more fearful and aggressive actions, such as playful-serious teasing or threats, (mild) opposition, mocking and ridicule (see Aarsand & Evaldsson, 2021; Andrén & Cekaite, 2017; for toddler's interactions, see Lerner & Zimmerman, 2003).

Example 2: The ambiguous framing of play: Negotiating relationships in and through interactions with play objects

The second example is taken from a situation in which two preschool-aged boys (Otto and Eric, 5 years old) have played in the same area for some time. They have alternated between playing with each other and playing separately with different objects. Related ethnographic fieldwork clarifies that Eric and Otto have a relatively stable friendship relationship: they play quite often together and are seldom involved in sustained conflict. As the excerpt begins,

Eric performs a first play action, saying ‘here was a knight who guarded here’ (line 1) to recruit Otto´s attention and where he use of the past tense, which is often used to initiate play and can signal that one is already within the play frame (Sawyer, 1997). At the same time, Björk-Willén (2012) demonstrates also how past tense can be a powerful device to establish who the decision-maker is within upcoming play. In the following Excerpt 2a, we shall see how these actions from Eric displays a multilayered and ambiguous framing of the activity as shared play.

Excerpt 2a

1	**ERIC**	**HÄR↑ va +en RI↑-dda-re som y↑a-ktade här*+**
		HERE was A KNI-ght who gua-rded here
	eric	>>comes walking, carries an action figure *sits down, places object in front of building
	otto	+moves gz twd E-->+ lowers gz
2		**(*+2.5)**
	eric	+looks at object-->
	otto	* looks at object-->
3	**ERIC**	**se ↑upp *för den här ri-↑ddaren* bakom *#2 dö-rren**
		watch out for this kni-ght here behind the door
	eric	*…points twds door–„„*touches door*
	fig#2	
4	**OTTO**	**+*~HÄ::R~+ #3 ***
		HE::RE
	otto	+puts dinosaur in front of knight, rotates on it, side to side-->
	eric	*sits up, *sits down, monitors Otto´s play actions—>
	fig#3	
5	**ERIC**	**Xxx (klubban) ***
		(xx)(the club)
	eric	*rises
6	**OTTO**	**jag slog med mina taggiga+**
		I hit with my spiky
	otto	+leans fwd, taps on spikes
	eric	-->*sits down, monitors Otto´s play actions-->

7	**ERIC**	**~nä:↑~**
		no:
8	**OTTO**	**+dom här**
		these ones
	Otto	+taps on spikes
9	**OTTO**	**+EH*[EH EH**
	otto	+rotates dinosaur, 'hits' against the knight-->
	eric	*places brick on building, moves gz twds dinosaur-->
10	**ERIC**	**[DU ~F↑Å:R INTE~+**
		/YOU MA:Y NOT
	otto	-->+stops actions with dinosaur
11		**+(2.0)* #4**
	eric	*puts another Duplo brick on building
	otto	+withdraws body
	fig#4	

Adapted from Karlsson and Nasi, 2023.

Eric places an action figure in front of the Duplo building he has constructed (also known as 'the castle'; naming not included in the transcript), and he announces to Otto that the knight will guard in front of the castle (line 1; Fig 3). Thereby he ties a category-bound activity/predicate to the knight (i.e. guarding the building), which makes relevant and connects the knight and castle categories (Sacks, 1995). As shown, Otto immediately bodily orients towards Eric and examines the arrangement of objects (lines 1–2) as Eric then points to the knight while giving a warning that one should 'watch out for it' (line 3), using present tense, which is often used to signal something negotiable in the unfolding of upcoming play events (e.g. Björk-Willén, 2012). However, as noted by Sacks (1995), there is an ambiguity related to warnings: they can imply 'alternative possibilities' and be heard as a 'challenge' because their linguistic forms are often virtually indistinguishable (p. 586). Thus, Eric's action can be interpreted as a (play) *challenge* (i.e. an invitation to a pretend fight between relational categories of 'defender' and 'challenger') or as a *warning* to 'keep out' of the play space/territory, including through the introduction of objects. These varying interpretations also have categorical implications; according to the first, Otto an equal co-player, while according to the second, he is not. Otto orients to the warning as a play challenge, so he places his object in front of Eric's knight, animating 'hitting' actions towards the knight as a response to a potential challenge in a shared play frame (lines 4, 6 and 8–9; Fig 3). Eric closely monitors Otto's actions with his dinosaur and the intensification of more (playfully) aggressive actions against Eric's play object (lines 6–10). Finally, Eric directs Otto to stop, loudly saying, *'YOU MAY NOT'* (line 10), thereby signalling his authority and his territorial rights regarding objects. At

this point, Otto is not oriented to being an equal or affiliated co-player, and the play frame is clearly broken, so he bodily withdraws (line 11; Fig 4).

The next Excerpt 2b exemplifies how (categorial) transformations of both conversational and non-conversational objects 'are not accomplished for their own sake' but on 'particular occasions for specific practical purposes' (Hester & Hester, 2012, p. 568), which relates to the construction of a shared play frame. The action figure previously categorised as a 'knight' that protected the castle is (multimodally) re-categorised (Burdelski & Fukuda, 2019) to become 'a friend', which is predicated with being 'nice' (Excerpt 2b, line 12). This action with an object has both categorial implications for the unfolding play and, one can argue, on the level of the children's re-structuring of their affiliative relationships within the situation (line 13; Fig 5).

Excerpt 2b

12	**ERIC**	**DEN HÄR↑ DEN *HÄR↑ KOMPISEN va snäll**
		THIS THIS FRIEND was nice
	eric	*takes action figure and turns it twds O-->
	otto	>>crashes bricks and jumps with object-->
13	**ERIC**	**HEJ↑+ #5 KOMPIS (.) du få:r komma in*+**
		HI FRIEND you ma:y enter
	otto	-->+places obj in front of action figure, holds it-->
	fig#5	
14		**(*1.0+)**
	eric	-->*moves on obj, opens door with obj
	otto	-->+lifts on obj-->
15	**OTTO**	**+*jag är SÅ: stor**
		I am THA:T big
	otto	+moves obj twds opening of door-->
	eric	*looks at and monitors Otto´s actions with his object-->
16	**OTTO**	**får jag sova här↑ istället +då får jag komma in ↑här+**
		I have to sleep here instead then I may enter here
	otto	-->+moves obj twds top of building +places it
17		**+↑a:hh**
	otto	+makes obj to fall down
18	**ERIC**	**nej ~där kan man ramla~+**
		no there you may fall down
	otto	+moves to the other side of the Duplo building-->
19	**OTTO**	**Där?+**
		There?
	otto	+Places dinosaur within the castle
20	**ERIC**	**Ja:↑**
		Ye:s

Eric first requests Otto's attention to the re-categorising of his play object, placing it in front of Otto's dinosaur (lines 12–13), which makes Otto immediately halt his competing activity. As Eric greets Otto's object (beginning of line 13), Otto puts his dinosaur in front of Eric's object, making the two face each other in a relationship pairing of friend–friend (Sacks, 1995). Thus, Otto views Eric's announcement in relation to his object as an invitation to share play, and Otto can then approach the castle with his dinosaur (lines 14–15), All these actions are actively monitored by Eric, who is managing the play space (and frame). After Otto has simulated the object falling from the roof, Eric comments that he 'no, there you may fall down' and where Eric supports Otto´s actions with his object within space (lines 18, 20). Thereby, Eric is implying both that he cares for Otto's play object and performs affiliative stances towards his playmate

Through these quickly performed, multimodal and sequential formatted actions with objects, which is accompanied with softer tones of voices and emotional displays, the two children display a reciprocally affiliative stance towards each other. Thus, the re-categorisations and actions with objects in Excerpt 2b also relate, one can argue, to a more playful mode and frames of interactions, shifting from aggression to a more co-operative sharing of emotions. This can be contrasted with the more disaffiliating actions and breaking of frame in Excerpt 2a. Overall, such actions and renegotiations of activities can further children's mutual and co-operative play and sharing of play experiences, interactions and emotions, which can mirror and affect how they construct their friendships over time (Corsaro, 2018).

Example 3: The transformative and shifting character of peer play

Evaldsson (2021) and Corsaro (2018) emphasise children's recognition of the transformative power of play (frames) as a central element of the collective and innovative features of their peer culture. Excerpt 3 demonstrates how an object (both material and linguistic) can be selected and transformed into a 'plaything' (Goffman, 1974, pp. 43–44) and how playful framings and transformations of activities can include both serious and non-serious interactional work and framings which are re-negotiated on a turn by turn basis, along with affiliative and disaffiliative stances towards others' actions. In the excerpt, two boys (John and Ralph, aged 5) are sitting at a table inside the preschool and drawing together. This activity has alternated between playful challenges and playful-serious mocking/ridicule and has been socially restored multiple times, moving from mild oppositions towards more co-operative actions and congruent affective stances (cf. Andrén and Cekaite, 2017). This relates to how children, in order to sustain an activity as playful and joyful for both parties, must renegotiate the situation to avoid one party dominating the other (Goffman, 1974). As Excerpt 3 begins, the boys have transformed the situation

into a game-like challenge that consists of pulling and grabbing a can of pens that was previously used in the drawing activity.

Excerpt 3

1	**RALPH**	**+*$Ta dom?$ ***
		Take them!
	ralph	+Puts can of pens in front of J, gz>J-->
	john	*holds pens in both hands *moves gz>can of pens, slightly moves left hand towards can
2	**RALPH**	**+Ofh***
		Ofh
	ralph	+quickly moves back can
3		**+*(1.0)*+ #6**
	ralph	+moves can> J-----+quickly moves it away, some pens fall out
	john	*Slowly moves gz>can *tries to reach for the pens with left hand
	Fig#6	
4	**JOHN**	***oh oh Ha HA [HI**
	john	*Looks >pens on table, Puts hand in front of mouth
5	**RALPH**	**[$Oho::$ #7**
	Fig#7	
6	**JOHN**	**Hihihihi**
7	**RALPH**	**+$Det var <u>du</u> som gjorde så +du fick [också hjälpa till John$**
		It was you who did like that so you [also had to help John
	ralph	+points with finger, touches pens in can +gzs J, nods
8	**JOHN**	***[Ha ha ha**
	john	*gz>R, smiles-->
9	**RALPH**	**För du gjorde så puttade (din hand) så +*alla gick ut [så:**
		Because you did like pushed (your hand) so all went like [that
	ralph	+Points towards and touches pens +takes some pens and demonstrates in 'slow motion' how they fell out
	john	---->*widens smile----->
10	**JOHN**	**[he he he**
11	**RALPH**	**+så du får också hjälpa till**
		so you also have to help
		+reduces smile
12	**JOHN**	**Men mitt hus är inte färdigt än**
		But my house is not finished yet
13	**JOHN**	**+*Måste rita: moboosh +*HA HI HA=**
		Have to draw moboosh HA HI HA= mediation
	john	*Continues to draw *moves gz J -->
	ralph	+gzs> J, smiles +Steps down from chair
14	**RALPH**	**=Ha ha ha(.)$mobooshS**
15	**JOHN**	**+Ha ha**
	ralph	+Bends down, Picks up pens from the floor
16	**JOHN**	***$MobooshS↑=**
	john	*Slightly rotates body, moves gz towards R

17	RALPH	=UH HA↑ HA↑-
18	JOHN	He he hi hi ~Mo-boosh~↑ *
	john	*puts back pen in can, gz>can-->
19	RALPH	*+<HA HA- [HA-+
	John	*gz>R-->
	ralph	+walks towards table, picks up pen from floor
20	JOHN	[He he he
21	JOHN	$Mo-boosh$
22	RALPH	+AH: #8 HA: HA:
	ralph	+walks back towards table +wrinkles face-->
	Fig#8	

At the beginning of the excerpt, Ralph, with a slight smile on his face, produces an embodied action with an object: a playful challenge to reach for the can (line 1). At the same time, John monitor Ralph's actions, beginning to put up his left hand, thus orienting to the game challenge (line 1), as Ralph quickly moves them back (line 2). When Ralph repeats his actions (line 3), John slowly moves his gaze towards the can, bodily signalling that he is about to take them. As John tries to reach for the materials with his left hand, Ralph quickly moves it away, which makes some of the pens fall out (line 3, Fig 6). This results in upgraded affective stances from both parties towards the event: John puts his hand in front of his mouth and laughs in a high-pitched voice while Ralph says 'Ohoo' with a smile on his face (lines 4-5). Thus, at this point in in the interaction, the boys orient to the event as fun and where spilled pens can transgress order and create chaos, which are recurring elements in situations in which children share laughter and joy (cf. Strid & Cekaite, 2021).

However, the framing of an activity as playful and fun can be seen an ongoing achievement that is open to renegotiation, and the next lines in the transcript follow a stepwise transition from a playful frame to more serious opposition from Ralph. In line 7, still with a smile on his face, Ralph says that it was John who made the pens fall out, arguing that John should help gather them. John responds with more laughter and does not seem to mark Ralph's turn as a serious request to help him to pick them up (line 8). Ralph next begins to frame the situation as more serious, as indicated by his fading smile, shifting his tone of voice while he verbally identifies John as the one who caused the pens to fall out (line 9). To strengthen his account, Ralph bodily demonstrates the pens falling out, but it only produces more laughter from John, stemming from Ralph´s replay of the (funny) accident (e.g. Jefferson et al., 1987; see lines 9-10). However, John subsequently orients to the frame shift being performed by Ralph, and with a more serious tone of voice, John says he cannot help because he has not finished his house (line 12).

As the playful frame and affiliative encounter has now been temporarily breached, John can be seen trying to reconnect with Ralph, through the re-framing of the situation of serious arguments to a playful and non-serious one: when repeating his prior utterance, he replaces the projected linguistic object 'house' with a nonsense word (i.e. 'Mooboosh'), which illustrates how any (social) object can be transformed into a 'plaything' (Goffman, 1974, p. 43). John turns his gaze towards Ralph and laughs in an unnatural pitch, inviting Ralph to affiliate with laughter. Initially, Ralph responds with laughter and repeats the nonsense word, displaying appreciation of the joke (line 14). However, after John repeats the nonsense word several times, each time following it with upgraded affective stance of laughter, Ralph orients towards shifting the frame, thereby 'reshaping the speech event, or constructing distance from the tone of the activity' (Goodwin, 1996, p. 71). This is clearly demonstrated when Ralph produces outstretched, marked laugh tokens reminiscent of 'fake laughter' that is laughter that is non-natural and forced rather than spontaneous (e.g. Haakana, 2012; see line 20; Fig 7). Ralph's actions can be seen to have an overlay of non-seriousness, but an underlay of frame shift to a (playful) serious mocking laughter, which makes the playful activity fade out. These actions from Ralph may be due to his viewing of Johns's repetitions and laughter as exaggerated but may also be indicative of a reorientation to John's prior conduct as non-co-operative and non-friendly.

Conclusion

This paper has attempted to show, based upon insights from Ann-Carita Evaldsson's academic work, how a *micro-ethnographic, multimodal interactional and situated approach* to children's play and interactions can be used to investigate the collaborative, transformative, and often socially shifting (ambiguous) nature of peer play. The three examples included in this study illustrate the mutual, demanding and responsive work children must perform to maintain a play frame, as well as how frames and shared activities can be multilayered, unpredictable and shifting in nature. Children's creativity and social skills here come to the fore when they, in rapid and close collaboration, coordinate their contributions.

The examples show the close connection between (imaginary) play (with objects within frame) and children's negotiations of friendships (both inside and outside frame). As is noted by Schwartzmann (1978), children's participation during play (and games) relies on two intersecting levels of identity, the fictive characters/players of the play frame/game and being a friend in the peer group, with different social agendas. As shown in Excerpt 1, to maintain affiliative relationships and through the taking of the perspective of others, one girl mitigated her view regarding what was fair or not, according to her take on the rules, to make her friend stay in the game. In Excerpts 2a and 2b, by multimodally ascribing new meanings to objects, the framing of a situation

was shifted from serious opposition to a joint activity within a shared play frame, which can enable children to display affiliation and closeness both inside and outside of a play frame. In the last example, Excerpt 3, it is shown how the bodily handling of play-relevant materials in a drawing activity can transformed to initiate a playful game challenge and where the transgression of order initially results in the amusement and fun for both parties. However, it is also shown how it successively becomes a source for breaking the play frame. It can relate to how exaggerated playful actions and upgraded affect displays towards a situation can easily evolve into more serious arguments and non-affiliative relationships that are here based upon opposing the other's conduct as non-cooperative.

Overall, the examples exemplify how play and game activities (often centred around object use) can oscillate between co-operation/playfulness and mild conflicts and non-affiliating turns, overall functioning as a 'training ground for sociality' (Lerner & Zimmerman, 2003, p. 442). Similarly, being expressed by Evaldsson (2021, p. 71): such activities are central to how children 'actively construct their social worlds and their place within it'. This methodological and theoretical perspective presented in this text thus enables to study the empirical subtleties related to how children construct play interactions and relationships on a turn-by-turn level, and how affect, embodiment and objects can be configured in an improvised, shifting and collaborative manner while children interact and have fun with peers (cf. Corsaro, 2018; Sawyer, 1997). These observations can also challenge the simple notions and dichotomies that have historically been connected to children's play (cf. Aronsson, 2023), such as phantasy play being less complex than games with rules, girl's vs boy's competencies in games/play, play and seriousness, children's worlds as separate from adult worlds and more.

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Embodied performance in gameplay narratives

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Introduction

Children's peer cultures have been at the center of Ann-Carita's research for more than three decades. Taking children's activities seriously, she has deepened our understanding of children's social and cultural worlds in a number of studies that have received wide international recognition. Situated at the intersection of educational sciences, linguistic anthropology, and child(hood) studies, her research underlines the importance of combining interaction analytic approaches with ethnography to fully understand children's worlds. Ann-Carita's attention to the details of social interaction and how they contribute to social and moral order underlines that children are not a mystic tribe with their own norms and rituals outside society, nor are they all through nice, cute, and innocent (cf. James, Jenks and Prout, 1998). Rather, she has shown how children's peer cultures are interwoven with the adult world, dealing with issues that are seen, experienced, and discussed in society at large. This includes activities such as telling stories about their experiences, creating and adjusting rules when playing games as well as negotiating what it means to be Swedish or Kurdish, boy or girl. Studies concern different sides of children's lives such as negotiations and establishments of social hierarchies, derogation and bullying (e.g., Evaldsson, 2009), but also how friendship is co-produced through sharing competence, experiences, and narratives (e.g., Andréasson & Evaldsson, 2023; Evaldsson & Abreu Fernandes, 2019; Evaldsson & Melander Bowden, 2025). Through the study of children's peer-cultures, Ann-Carita has also challenged taken-for-granted ideas about gender dichotomies in games and play, such as girls being cooperative and boys being competitive. With a primary interest in children's peer cultures, she has demonstrated how children's everyday lives are embedded in various institutional practices such as preschool, school and afterschool programs, and how these are consequential for the accomplishment of the activities in peer groups within the institutional frames.

Peer cultures can be described as shared norms, values, and practices that children co-create, negotiate and use to navigate within their social groups (e.g., Evaldsson, 2004; 2005; Evaldsson & Corsaro, 1998). These practices may be challenged, negotiated, and changed, and they include the establishment of social hierarchies (Evaldsson, 2004; Evaldsson & Aarsand, 2023), identities (e.g., Evaldsson, 2004) and knowledge relations (Melander, 2012a). Research on children's peer cultures highlights how these social worlds are

collectively organized by the children themselves (cf. Corsaro, 2009). This means that the analytical attention is directed toward participants' use of various interactional resources through which identities, social categories, and boundaries are achieved in social interaction. Evaldsson's work on children's peer cultures has shown how children tease, employ derogatory categorizations, mock, and use other language practices to exclude peers and establish social hierarchies through their use of categories, intonation, physical objects and embodied actions (Evaldsson, 2024; Evaldsson & Aarsand, 2024; Evaldsson & Melander Bowden, 2022; Evaldsson & Svahn, 2012; 2016). However, her research also shows how peers co-operate to solve problems and challenges that they are facing (Evaldsson & Melander Bowden, 2024; Danby, Evaldsson, Melander Bowden & Aarsand, 2019).

Our chapter is inspired by Ann-Carita's work on the social and multimodal organization of play and games in peer groups. We direct attention to a 'metagame activity' (Khaila et al., 2021), in this case peer talk about game progress, with a particular interest in how such tellings are produced and used to position oneself epistemically as someone who knows (or not) in peer relations.

Everyday narratives about games and gaming

Talk about digital games and gaming are part of children's peer-cultures (e.g., Aarsand, 2018; Khaila et al., 2021; Melander Bowden, 2024). Taking various forms, it can be stories where children claim themselves as excellent players or how gaming is handled in the light of moral panic (Aarsand, 2012), it can be narratives that are used to organize "digital" games on the playground (Aarsand, 2010), as well as talk about rules and rule breaking behaviour (e.g., Aarsand & Melander Bowden, 2024; Evaldsson & Melander Bowden, 2025). Most children in the Western world either play digital games themselves, know someone who does, or are in some other way familiar with the phenomenon. Talk and discussions about games and gaming can today, albeit to varying degrees, be considered a part of children's everyday lives (e.g., Dezuanni, 2018; Dezuanni, O'Mara & Beavis, 2015; Melander Bowden, 2024, Wernholm & Vigmo, 2015, Wernholm, 2018).

In focus for our analyses are children's everyday tellings about game play in the peer group. Such conversational narratives of personal experiences are interactionally constructed accounts that constitute "a vernacular, interactional forum for ordering, explaining, and otherwise taking a position on experience" (Ochs & Capps, 2001, p. 57). Studies of children's peer cultures show that narratives constitute significant parts of a large variety of activities such as gossiping and bullying (e.g. Evaldsson, 2002; 2021; Evaldsson & Svahn, 2012) as well as playing and gaming (e.g., Aarsand, 2024). By focusing on a teller's verbal as well as embodied resources, Evaldsson and Abreu Fernandes (2019) show how a child at a very young age can engage in

collaborative procedures with her mother to initiate and design a storytelling performance. The verbal and embodied animations, including prosodic actions, gestures, affect displays, sound effects, etc. contribute to creating stories of high tellability (cf. Ochs & Capps, 2001).

Telling stories involves stance taking and social positioning displayed through both linguistic and embodied actions. It is interactional as well as relational and involves positioning and alignment toward co-participants, objects, and activities (e.g., Goodwin, 2007). Evaldsson (2024) argues that "embodied displays of affect and affective alignments, cut across various modalities including not only talk, gesture, the face, posture and prosody but also the material environment" (p. 64). Along such lines, Goodwin (2007) explores how storytellers reconfigure actions through multimodal performances—drawing on gestures, embodied animations, prosody, facial expressions, and playful language to shift between serious and imaginative frames. In addition, we approach children's peer groups as epistemic ecologies (Goodwin, 2013; Melander, 2012a), in which the children dynamically position themselves vis-à-vis with each other and the activity in progress. This adds a focus on the peer group as a crucial site for knowledge sharing about, in this case, online games.

Exploring children's digital literacy practices

In 2015-2018, we conducted a video ethnographic study together with Ann-Carita, exploring children's digital literacy practices (MAW 2014:0057). In focus for the project was the communicative and multimodal competencies that children develop and how different places and everyday contexts, such as schools, after schools and homes, become an integrated part of children's digital literacy practices. We conducted fieldwork in two Swedish elementary schools with different catchment areas and with varying access to digital technologies in school. The data in this chapter are drawn from fieldwork in one of the schools, a grade 4 with children aged approximately 10 years, over a period of four months. Most of the children came from white middle-class families.

The analyses draw on recordings of the everyday interactions of loosely formed peer groups of boys that were avid gamers. Some played more than others, rarely together, but regardless they often talked about their gaming activities during the school day, updating each other on what was happening in their game worlds (see also Melander Bowden, 2024). For this chapter we have selected two examples to explore the dramaturgical and rhetorical resources that the boys use in their narrative engagements, in particular how embodied performances and reenactments are drawn on as crucial resources in game play narratives (cf. Evaldsson & Abreu Fernandes, 2019). The first part of the analysis focuses on the boys' orientations to game characters, and their artful ways of reproducing these characters' moves and attacks. Next, we

explore how the boys talk about and make visible to each other in-game constructions that they have built.

Enactments and embodied performances of game character moves

Our first extract demonstrates how everyday conversations about games recurrently are initiated, relying on a high degree of common ground between the children. Adam and Alex are two classmates who frequently spend time together in school. One of the recurrent topics of their talk concerns games, in this case the game *Shadow fight*. When Extract 1 begins, the boys have just entered the classroom after their recess. They look warm after playing outside, and Adam's cheeks are rosy. While waiting for the lesson to start, they sit down at a table by the window, opposite each other (fig.1.1). The talk about the game is initiated by a question about progress and success, as Adam asks Alex how the defeat of Wasp is going (line 1).

Shadow fight 160310:10.07.12-10.07.44

1 ADAM: hur går de me #besegrandet av Wasp.
how's the defeat of Wasp going.
fig #fig.1.1



fig.1.1

2 ALEX: ja har inte besegrat henne än.
I haven't defeated her yet.
3 ADAM: har du fått de där vapnet som man kan besegra henne me.
have you gotten that weapon that you can defeat her with.
4 ALEX: vicket?
which?
5 ADAM: de där va:pnet (.) som:-
that wea:pon (.) tha:t-
6 (1.0)
7 ALEX: >du menar< moon sabres.
>you mean< moon sabres.
8 ADAM: nej. som man: kunde:: besegra henne me.
no. that you: cou::ld defeat her with.
9 ALEX: maga:ri ya:ri.
10 ADAM: ja,
yes,
11 (0.5)
12 ALEX: >ja de har ja,< men de känns lite som att (.) de: j-s-
>yes I have,< but it feels a bit like (.) i:t j-s-
13 de ha- de slåss på exakt samma sti:l (.) som hennes va:pen.
it ha- it fights in exactly the same sty:le (.) as her wea:pon.
14 bara sva:gare så. (.) °°°de e faktiskt ganska- lättare me
only wea:ker so. (.) °°°it's actually quite- easier with
15 moo:n sabres.°°°
moo:n sabres.°°°
16 *+(1.0)+(3.0)**
adam *shifts gaze to look out the window**looks at Alex-->>
alex +nodding+

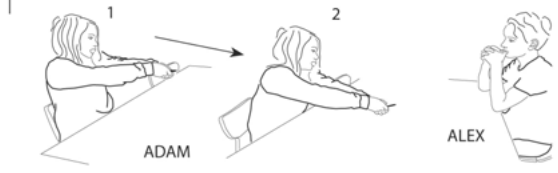
The design of the question "how's the defeat of Wasp going" displays the boys' shared knowledge about the games that they are playing and evidences their habits of taking an interest in and informing each other about their progress in the games. In fact, a question requesting a *telling* about recent developments in peers' game play represents a typical way of opening a game conversation in the studied peer group (Melander Bowden, 2024). In this case, Alex responds that he has not yet defeated Wasp, whereupon Adam initiates a line of inquiry about the reasons. Rather than to assume that Alex lacks the required skills to defeat the demon, Adam asks Alex about his weapons, "have you gotten that weapon that you can defeat her with." (line 3). The emphasis on "can" makes the weapon relevant as a necessary item, and Adam thereby displays knowledge about the game and that there is a weapon that can be used to defeat the demon in question. However, Alex does not immediately recognize which weapon Adam is referring to and requests clarification "which?" (line 4). This repair initiates an inserted sequence that establishes the identity of the weapon (lines 4-10) before moving on to answer the question about possession. Adam hesitates as he initiates an answer, "that wea:pon (.) tha:t-" (line 5). The stretched production, micro-pause, and abandonment of the turn indicate a word search. After a 1 second silence, Alex suggests ">you mean< moon sabres.", thereby contributing an item to the search (cf. Goodwin & Goodwin, 1986). In response, Adam however rejects the suggestion with a decided "no." and repeats that he is searching for the weapon that could defeat Wasp (line 8). Hence, he simultaneously claims to know that Moon sabre is not a weapon that is strong enough to defeat Wasp. Alex comes up with a second suggestion "maga:ri ya:ri" (line 9) that Adam confirms as the weapon he was searching for and the inserted sequence comes to a completion.

After a brief silence, Alex reconnects to Adam's question in line 3 and produces a positive answer (">yes I have<") but then embarks on an evaluative elaboration on the qualities of the weapons, claiming expert knowledge and drawing upon his experience of the weapons in question. The account contains a negative assessment of Magari yari as a weapon that "fights in exactly the same style (.) as her weapon. only wea:ker so." (lines 13-14) or in other words, a weapon that may encounter difficulties in fights with Wasp. Instead, Alex returns to Moon sabre and claims independent knowledge based on experiences of attempting to defeat the demon with a whispering that "it's actually quite- easier with moo:n sabres" (although the claimed easiness has in fact not yet made it possible to defeat Wasp).

Next, Adam moves on to ask Alex questions about different attacks. The ensuing interaction involves a series of narrative enactments and embodied quotes as the boys establish shared understanding about the attacks.

Shadow fight 160310:10.07.44-10.08.10

17 ADAM: kan du göra den där (.) framåtattacken (me)
can you do that (.) forward attack (with)



Adam enacts a forward attack, pushing forward over the table with a pencil as weapon, while Alex watches

18 ALEX: menar du tschou tschou tschoutschoutschou
do you mean tschou tschou tschoutschoutschou

Alex enacts an attack, demonstrating his understanding of what Adam refers to



19 ADAM: nej ja menar den här- (>den här attacken<)
no I mean this- (>this attack<)

20 när man hoppar upp på väggen. när Wasp gör de.
when you jump up at the wall. when Wasp does that.

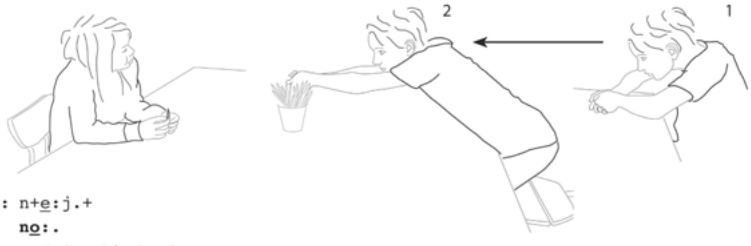


Adam re-enacts the forward attack

21 ALEX: så här (.) tschu[::.
like this (.) tschu::.

Alex enacts a different, quicker, attack

22 ADAM: [ja,
yes,



23 ALEX: n+e:j.+
no:.
+shakes his head+

24 ADAM: e de bara hon som kan göra den.
is it only she who can do it.

25 ALEX: ja, (.) de e en sån här specialgrej som (.) demonerna kan.
yes, (.) it's like this special thing that (.) the demons can do.

26 ja tror inte man kan de bara för att man har hennes va:pen.
I don't think you can do it just because you have her wea:pons.

27 (1.2)

When the extract begins, Adam inquires whether Alex can perform a specific attack that he verbally refers to as a "forward attack" (line 17). The verbal description is accompanied by an enactment as Adam stretches his arms

forward, holding a pencil like a metaphorical sword. This time Alex responds by checking his understanding "do you mean" as he vividly enacts an attack swinging his left arm in different angles and circles as he makes swooshing sounds (line 18). Adam however rejects the proposed attack and clarifies that he is referring to a different attack "no I mean this- (>this attack<) when you jump up at the wall." As he describes the jumping on the wall, he recycles the same gesture as before, with his arms held straight in front of him in a probing movement (line 20). He also adds an increment highlighting the demon in question "when Wasp does that.", underlining that he is asking about one of Wasp's attacks (and not some other demon). Alex picks up Adam's embodied gesture re-enacting the very same movement. He holds his arms straight in front of him, hands clasped together, demonstrating an attack parallel to the table as he produces a sound "tschu::." (line 21). In overlap with the demonstration, Adam acknowledges that this was the attack that he referred to with a "yes,". However, contrary to the demonstration of the attack that could suggest otherwise, Alex responds to Adam's question in line 23 with a minimal but determined "no:." as he shakes his head, in all witnessing his inability to perform the attack. The production of the negative response is highly contrastive to the engaged embodied enactments through its much less emotionally charged affective stance that takes on a serious tone. Adam continues by requesting more information and asks, "is it only she who can do it", in other words treating Alex's enactment as a knowledge demonstration that opens the possibility that something else than knowing how to perform the attack is at stake. He also displays his knowledge of the game and its players, by suggesting that this might be a Wasp attack. This assumption is confirmed by Alex who first acknowledges with a "yes," (line 29), and then moves on to explain that the attack is restricted to demons, that is not linked to the weapons, and that an ordinary player can thus not perform.

With the various requests about Alex's progress in the game, a knowledge asymmetry between the boys emerges where Alex is positioned as the more experienced *Shadow fight* player. Adam displays some knowledge of the attacks but orients to Alex as a source of knowledge about the details of the attacks and with an interest in his skill level. Alex claims expert knowledge by not only displaying knowledge about the various weapons and their attacks, but also by taking an independent evaluative stance on the quality of the weapons. The enactments and embodied performances of characters' in-game movements work to display knowledge and to establish shared understanding. In addition, the orchestration of the dramatizations with sound effects and exaggerated movements displays the boys' enjoyment and their collaborative explorations of the game and its characters.

Embodied performance of a construction through collective imagination

Another core part of the boys' talk about game play in the peer group were tellings about the constructions that they were building in *Minecraft* (for a more elaborate analysis, see Melander Bowden, 2024). To do this, the boys largely relied on the use of gestures and embodied actions to establish what Kinalzik and Heller (2020) call *joint imagined spaces* through which constructions from virtual spaces were brought into the boys' collective imagination. When we enter the interaction in Extract 3, Alex has provided an introductory description of his construction (not analyzed here) which is followed by an extended narrative about how it has been designed to defend oneself against monsters and more concretely how one steers a piston automat that Alex has constructed. The analysis will focus on the resources used by Alex to describe how an intruder walks in a corridor and how one, upon discovery of the intruder, can pull a lever so that the piston moves and catches those who walk in the corridor.

Minecraft 160417:11.23.50-11.24.07

1 ALEX: alltså >kolla.< (.) de:- de: e: här (.) e k#orridoren längst ner.
like >look.< (.) i:t- it is: here (.) uh the corridor at the bottom.
fig. #2c.1



fig. 2c.1

2 ADAM: a[:.]
yeah:.
3 ALEX: [ma]n gå:r här. >kolla<# tytyty (.) å typ h#ä:r e kolven.
you wa:lk here. >look< tytyty (.) an' like he:re is the piston.
fig. #2c.2 #2c.3


fig. 2c.2


fig. 2c.3

4 om man e precis där då. så e u-u-u å så kan man- e-e sp#a:ken
if you're exactly there then. so uh u-u-u an' so one can- uh-uh the le:ver
fig. #2c.4


fig. 2c.4

5 typ hä:r uppe. (.) på nästa vå:ning. så dra#r man där.# tschu.
like up he:re. (.) on the next floo:r. so you pull there. tschu.
fig. #2c.5 #2c.6



fig. 2c.5 fig. 2c.6

6 så puttas den #ne:r. å håller fast en# så ba- dom si#tter fa#st där.
an' then it's pushed do:wn. and holds one so ju- they get stuck there.
fig. #2c.7 #2c.8 #2c.9
7 då kan man ta-
then you can ta-



fig. 2c.7 fig. 2c.8 fig. 2c.9

The utterance "like >look.<" in line 1 prepares the co-participants that something is about to happen and initiates a sequence that describes how the monster-catching mechanism works. The attention-seeking "look" reorients the hearers from a mainly auditive modality to something that one should visually attend to. Alex lifts his hands, places them in front of him on the table and prepares to give life to the construction with the tabletop as a stage. He continues by transferring himself and his audience to another place: "it is: here (.) the corridor at the bottom". The deictic reference ("here") requests the participants' embodied co-orientation towards an imagined space (Kinalzik & Heller, 2020; cf. Goodwin, 2007a). The design of the corridor is visualized in front of them by Alex's moving hands and pointing fingers on the table back and forth (fig. 2c.1). He thereby establishes the foundation and extension of the construction in space as a reference point. Alex transfers the audience to a virtual place by, in Heller's (2019, p. 171) words, executing the transition in an observable and recognizable manner. Adam shows that he is listening by confirming the joint imagined space with a "yeah:". Now the narrative is transformed to detail an activity taking place inside the building. The telling is initiated by a verbal description "you wa:lk here" followed by a directive to ">look<" that is probably oriented to the fact that the others are not visibly paying attention to what Alex is doing but continue eating. At the same time, the lexical "look" refers to shared seeing (cf. Goodwin, 2018, p. 300). Alex continues to illustrate how someone moves through the corridor, with his right hand shaped as a character that moves jerkily through the imagined corridor and with the left hand as a distant reference point (fig.2c.2). The movement is accompanied by a metaphorical vocal sound "tytyty" that marks the figure's steps (cf. Keevallik, 2010). When the right hand has reached the left, a new verbal description follows detailing what the story recipients should imagine: "an' like he:re is the piston" (line 3). The indexical "here" is clarified using an embodied gesture as Alex points with his left finger toward a specific place (fig.2c.3). The telling continues by Alex illustrating a lever (fig.2c.4) "like up

he:re. (.) on the next floo:r." (line 34) that one can pull (fig.2c.5) so that a piston moves downwards, where the speed and force in the hand movement toward the table is emphasized with a sound effect "tschu" (fig.2c.6), so that the character moving through the corridor is caught (fig.2c.7). Alex changes perspective from the constructed building to an enactment of how to control the piston. The telling comes to a close as Alex enacts the character-monster being caught by wiggling his body as if unsuccessfully attempting to free himself (fig.2c.8-9).

Through verbal descriptions and gestural depictions, Alex elicits the imagined construction so that the audience can create a virtual image (Kinalzik & Heller, 2020, p. 31) of it. Demonstrative pronouns such as "here" are used to refer to imagined rather than material objects. Alex's verbal descriptions and embodied enactments create a shared frame of reference to talk about the building.

Minecraft 160417:11.23.50-11.24.26

37 ADAM: e de som en ◊>glasgolv< dä:r nere.#
is it like a >glass floor< dow:n there.
◊pointing movement-->
fig #2d.1





38 ALEX: ne:j. de ◊e bara två kolvar. [men d*om e] kli:#bbiga så dom
no:. it's just two pistons. but they are stick:y so they
adam ->◊
nils *enacting moving pistons-->
fig. #2d.2 fig. 2d.2

fig. 2d.1



39 ADAM: [men-]
but-

40 ALEX: håller £fa:st en.£=
keep you £stu:ck.£
41 ADAM: =men hur ka#n [man ↑s]#e: *(.) när spindeln >kommer<.
but how can one ↑see: (.) when the spider >comes<.
nils -->* fig. 2d.3
bild #2d.3 #2d.4
JONAS: [↑ö.]
↑uh.



42 (1.2)
43 ALEX: ö: för den gå:r +på insidan+ i så fa:ll. (.)
uh: 'coz it wa:lks on the inside in that ca:se. (.)
+walks w. fingers through corridor+ fig. 2d.4
44 för att (.) ja:.
'coz' (.) yeah:.
45 JONAS:>hörni.<=
>hey.<
46 ALEX: =så då: kan man dö av ↑svä:lt. [>eller så kan]man< fånga=
so the:n one can die of star↑va:tion. >or you can< catch
47 JONAS: [hö:rni,]
he:y,



48 ALEX: =en spindel till da:n så att den blir vä:nlig. så kan man ri:da på den.
a spider for the da:y so it becomes ki:nd. so that you can ri:de it.

The description of the construction is followed by a request for clarification produced by Adam (line 37). The design of the question refers to the collaboratively imagined, while displaying Adam's understanding of the construction so far: "is it like a >glass floor< do:wn there.". The indexing "there" is linked to an imagined floor through a sweeping pointing gesture (fig.2d.1) that refers to the corridor that Alex has visualized on the table (cf. Fig.2c.1). The utterance requests more information to understand the construction of the building while simultaneously checking his understanding (see Murphy, 2005, for an interesting comparison with how architects at the drawing table collaboratively imagine buildings and their functions). Alex initially responds with a clear "no:." and proceeds to clarify the construction of the pistons (lines 38, 40). It might be that he hears "piston" instead of "floor" (*kolv-golv* in Swedish). With "but how can one see: when the spider >comes<" Adam shows that Alex did not answer his question and reformulates while emphasizing "see:" with a heightened tone of voice, that again highlights the seeing as central. Alex hesitates before answering with an initial hesitation marker "uh:" followed by "'coz it wa:lks on the inside in that ca:se". It is difficult to reproduce in writing how the utterance is produced, but it conveys an impression of uncertainty, compared to the surrounding talk where Alex has a more confident voice. He also continues with something partly different. He describes what can happen when what was talked about as monsters in the beginning and now has been specified as a spider by Adam (line 41), gets caught by the sticky pistons (lines 43-48).

After Alex's description of how the pistons work and while Adam and Alex talk to each other, something interesting happens. In parallel, Nils enacts the movements of the pistons; how they are pulled apart and then pushed together (fig.2d.2-4). The enactment is not accompanied by talk but is fitted to Alex's telling and probes how the pistons work through an embodied gestural comment. Albeit in verbal silence, Nils thus actively participates in the unfolding development of the narrative (cf. Goodwin, 1986).

Alex's narrative about the construction establishes him as a skilled gamer with a capacity for creative solutions in the Minecraft world. He can design advanced constructions and also finds a way of tricking some of the monsters that otherwise pose a threat to the players. The other boys' engagement in the narrative demonstrates the game world as a shared experience and the talk about games as valuable settings for knowledge sharing and learning. The children also orient to the playful dimensions of the game. In fact, the children ascribe considerable value to the game's ludic dimensions, and a systematic analysis of their engagement—including the competencies and skills cultivated through gameplay—must attend to the specific interactional practices through which this engagement is accomplished and to the role these practices play in constituting locally recognized criteria for what counts as a competent gamer.

Discussion

Storytelling constitutes a central interactional practice within children's peer culture. In this chapter, we examined how everyday narratives about games and gaming are co-constructed and performed in peer interaction. In the cases analyzed, these narratives draw on shared knowledge and interactional histories of specific games, in which game events and characters are enacted through embodied demonstrations embedded within tellings. For the boys in our data, games are a serious matter. The narrative performances incorporate embodied actions, animations, and deictic references, all of which enhance the tellability of the co-produced stories. These embodied actions not only enrich the narrative with vivid and engaging details but also functions as a demonstration and visualization of in-game actions—such as how characters move or how one kills a monster—and of the physical environments they inhabit, forming what Kinalzik and Heller (2020) describe as *joint imagined spaces*. Moreover, the performance of narratives draws participants into a shared imaginative space, which not only enables an understanding of the story but also constitutes being a part of it. Within this participation framework, the narratives function as dramatizations of events that are treated as noteworthy, spectacular, or otherwise normatively relevant for competent gamers. The children's enactments therefore do not merely reproduce elements of the game world; they also function as displays of epistemic access and, perhaps more importantly, epistemic primacy, through which the participants negotiate and sustain social and epistemic hierarchies.

Peer culture is (re)produced through a range of social practices and activities, among which storytelling constitutes a central means through which common ground is negotiated and established, and where activities, knowledge, and social positions are sanctioned and approved. The everyday narratives about gaming examined here, show not only which activities matter within this peer culture but also how storytelling itself becomes an epistemic field in which social positions, knowledge claims, and rights to evaluate or instruct are interactionally negotiated. This resonates with Evaldsson's research on play and games, which highlights these activities as collaborative social practices encompassing processes of inclusion and exclusion, bullying, teasing, and the negotiation of gender and ethnic identities, here supplemented by a focus on knowledge, epistemic stances and expertise in embodied narrative performances.

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Performing a spontaneous fairy story through bilingual English-Fairy talk

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Beginning on a personal note

When embarking on my own personal academic journey exploring children's social worlds through conversation analysis (CA) and membership categorisation analysis (MCA), Ann-Carita's research provided essential guidance and inspiration. Whilst engaging with Ann-Carita's work in these early years, I did not imagine that one day I would meet her in person and be welcomed by her into the world of early childhood and CA so warmly. As the years have flown by, I have fond memories of talks with Ann-Carita about a whole range of issues—from academic debates in early childhood CA to more personal family experiences. I have learnt so much from you, Ann-Carita, not only on how to carefully engage with video data of children's peer play and write findings up in ways which highlight children's social competencies, but also about important life issues such as how to catch the train from inner-city Brussels to Brugge during the IPrA conference 2023! Ann-Carita's writing style and careful unpacking of children's competencies is timeless and consistently offers a beautiful balance of academic prowess and accessibility. Her work will always be an essential resource for all those studying children's social worlds. It is truly humbling that such a pioneering women academic can also be such a caring and welcoming friend. I continue to learn from you, Ann-Carita and hope to continue the thoughtful and collegial approach to research you have forged.

Children's spontaneous fairy play as an embodied bilingual performance

Ann-Carita's careful study of children's social interactions with their peers has been an inspiration to many over the years. Within this impressive catalogue of work, Ann-Carita provides unique insight into such issues as play performances in games (Evaldsson, 2009) where children actively make peer culture and wider world issues visible during the co-production of play and games (Evaldsson & Corsaro, 1998). Micro dramas (Evaldsson, 2021) draw attention to children's meaning making and careful negotiation in the orderly process of pretend play endeavours (Evaldsson, 2004), both of which are specifically significant issues that are explored here when looking closely at the

fairy play of children in a New Zealand early childhood centre. Ann-Carita's expertise in demonstrating how children's social organisation encompasses their social category work through employing membership categorisation analysis (MCA)—the less visible side of CA—(e.g. Evaldsson, 2005; 2014), adding a contextual layer of analysis and insight into children's worlds.

The following piece is inspired by Ann-Carita's catalogue of work that sets the context for researchers to look more closely at children's use of more than one language in interaction, and specifically in their play with peers, to consider their use of play-spaces for social organisation purposes. It also draws on her recent IPrA 2023 panel on heteroglossia and translanguaging with Amy Kyratzis (currently being organised into a Special Issue for Discourse Studies) and related publication (Evaldsson, 2025). The following writing and analysis specifically builds on Ann-Carita's article—Evaldsson and Abreu Fernandes (2019)—which explores embodied bilingual storytelling, where I will explore children's use of improvised 'Fairy language' to assert embodied performance in storytelling practices. Guided by Ann-Carita's writings, the analysis of the Fairy talk data prompts the following questions that will be returned to in the discussion:

1) Can spontaneously 'made-up' talk officially be recognised as a language?
2) Could the children's talk here be recognised as 'bilingual' if one of the linguistic codes used is *not officially* recognised as a language?

These two questions relate more specifically to Ann-Carita's most recent study of heteroglossia and language creativity (Evaldsson, 2025, p. 961) where the analytic discussions 'highlight multilingual children's playful juxtaposition of diverse voices, styles and ways of speaking'. Here we can certainly relate the children's use of improvised Fairy talk to the language creativity that Ann-Carita discusses, particularly when considering semiotic resources that are intertwined with the talk. These issues will be explored further throughout this contribution.

In her afore mentioned co-authored article with Abreu Fernandes, Ann-Carita focuses on the co-production of retelling lived experiences through embodied means between a child and her mother. The findings offer insight into how the mother becomes co-teller with the child, using multi-modal semiotic resources including code-switching between languages to fully engage with the telling. The rich analysis brings to the fore key issues that are now picked up as demonstrably relevant in the interaction presented and analysed here between three children—Huda aged four years, and Breya and Emma aged three years. The interaction here shows how the children perform fairy play, where acknowledgement of Ann-Carita's work is visible through orientation to and exploration of how:

1) the current research looks beyond the white-middle class storytelling with adults, as Huda and Breya (the children who improvise 'Fairy language) are of Māori Pasifika heritage
2) the interaction demonstrates 'embodied animations, reenactments and affect displays, including prosodic actions and exaggerations, dramatizations, laughter, sound effects, exploitations of language form and code-switching' (Evaldsson & Abreu Fernandes, 2019, p. 36), visible as 'micro-dramas' (Evaldsson, 2021)
3) the children keep co-players interested in engaging with the fairy story performance through contingent multimodal means (Evaldsson, 2021), where the children's embodied ways of telling 'emotionally compelling' stories captivate the audience (Evaldsson & Abreu Fernandes, 2019, p. 40).
4) footing is demonstrated as 'young children in certain cultural settings from an early age appropriate the linguistic, interactional and social competencies to perform a tellable story' (Ibid, p. 40).
5) participants invoke membership categories in the unfolding interaction, to provide richness and deeper exploration of a collaboratively achieved telling, demonstrating full engagement with Sacks' wider work on membership categorisation analysis (MCA) (Evaldsson, 2005; 2014).
6) social organisation practices are managed around the Fairy talk – those who engage in it (Huda and Breya) and those who question the diverse creative improvised Fairy talk (Emma) (Evaldsson, 2025)

These issues will be explored as a members' interest—made significant by the participants themselves in their peer play together, where their fairy play makes a storyline clearly visible through multimodal means such as using 'Fairy language' to communicate with each other along with specific prosody that marks out character performance (Bateman, 2016) and transformation of everyday environmental objects into fairy related artifacts (e.g. a stick into a fairy wand). These impromptu multimodal actions are entwined in systematic and orderly ways to orally formulate fairy characters and play out a storyline about familiar fictional (fairy) characters (Evaldsson, 2021).

Prior to this exploration, details regarding the participating children and their setting will now be given, to add important context to the unfolding interaction subsequently explored.

Method: Data, setting and participants

The following excerpts are transcribed and analysed as part of a larger storytelling project that spanned three years, following 12 case study children for their last two years in early childhood settings to their first year in primary schools. The excerpts included here involve three girls—Huda and Emma who

are four years old and Breya who is one of the case study children and is three years old. The video recording included here is the first one-hour recording of Brayer and her everyday social interactions with her peers. Even though the children are a year apart in age, Brayer and Huda often play together at the early childhood centre and are known for their shared love of stories and imaginary play. They have often been observed playing various characters together, but this is the first time that their Fairy talk has been observed and recorded (although this does not mean that they have not used it before out of adult gaze).

The children are playing in the vast garden space of the early childhood setting. Huda (HUD) and Breya (BRE) have been walking together, carrying long sticks that they refer to as 'wands'. They have used the 'wands' to magic themselves from feeling cold to warm, and to magic wings on each other so that they can fly. Whilst not explicitly labelling their play as 'fairy' play, it would seem that the observable elements of the play such as using wands to change status (sticks—wands; being cold-warm; no wings—wings) certainly perform a story of fairy characters. After several minutes, Huda and Breya walk towards another girl, Emma (EMM) and begin a more formal mapping of their play, giving specific characters to each child, collaboratively constructing membership to what Butler (2008; Butler & Weatherall, 2006) reported as 'fairy play' in prior New Zealand children's play. The players make observably relevant the colour of their clothes in this role negotiation—Huda is wearing a dark pink (almost red) jumper and trousers; Emma is wearing a purple jumper and trousers; Breya is wearing a blue jumper and trousers. The following role negotiation shows parallels with Evaldsson and Abreu Fernandes' (2019) 'footing', marked as important to the participants within the process of their telling.

Excerpt 1: Footing as central to participation in the fairy story

```
01 EMM:     I wanna be a fa::iry:.
02 HUD:     O::ka::¿ okay and ↑I'm the mu::m.
03          (0.8)
04 HUD:     wh- >↓±and she's the sister↓< what can y↑o::u be.
                  ±points to BRE---------
05 EMM:     I could- I could be the gree::n fairy?
06 BRE:     ↑and I'll be the [li- ba:be-
07 HUD:                      [no I'm the pink. I'm the pink.
             §And she:'s the blu:e.
             §points to BRE who is wearing blue
08 EMM:     no ±that's actually re:::d.
               ±lifts her stick to point to HUD top
09 HUD:     and I'm the pi::nk.
10 EMM:     no that's actually re:::d.
```

```
11 HUD:     no. I'm the red fairy. And what have- colour
12          t-shirt do you go::t?
13          (1.8) ((EMM looks down at her clothes))
14 HUD:     pu::rple. §on top§.
                     §points stick at EMM's top
15          and ±she's got blue.
                ±points stick at BRE top
16          okay guys¿ follow me::¿
```

Evaldsson and Abreu Fernandes (2019, p. 36) draw on Goffman's (1981) 'footing' to point out that when negotiating participation in storytelling activities 'footings [are] central for the tellability of a story'. As a preface to subsequent play, this initial footing around story characters works map the participation of each child through their orientation to the environmental resources to hand, marking each player as a specific member of the group of fairies. From the beginning of the fairy play here, similarities to Ann-Carita's work is visible regarding

> how the laminated structure of actions and participation frameworks relevant to the dialogical organization of a young child's spontaneous telling…involve co-participants as reflexive actors…who mutually monitor one another's actions. (p. 38)

Play entry has to be negotiated, and specific roles mapped and agreed upon before the play activity can begin. Here, Emma's initial request to join the play (line 01) was accepted by Huda with a clear assertion that Huda is 'the mum' (line 02) and Breya is 'the sister (line 04). Emma is then invited to provide a choice of character (line 04) where—if performed as contingently relevant—would align to the membership category of 'family member' as already mapped by Huda in her assertion of 'mum' and sister' characters. However, there is a slight pause, followed by Emma suggesting that she 'could be the green fairy' (line 05), suggesting a different category set of 'colours' with which to map out play character membership. In the next turn, Huda builds on the mapping of fairy characters by performing a laminated action on Emma's notion of colour, in a 'meaningful, locally relevant action' (C. Goodwin, 2007, p. 45 cited in Evaldsson and Abreu Fernandes, 2019, p. 37), as she orients to their clothing colours as a way of establishing social order through 'dialogical sense-making' (Evaldsson & Abreu Fernandes, 2019, p. 37). Emma, still not quite aligning with Huda suggestions, argues that Huda's clothing is 'actually red' (line 08—reiterated line 10 when not taken up). Huda subsequently changes her identity from 'pink fairy' to 'red fairy' as a response to this, demonstrating the collaborative negotiation Ann-Carita has alluded to in her prior research (e.g. Evaldsson, 2004; 2009; 2021).

Once all roles are decided, Huda closes this mapping negotiation sequence of the interaction with 'okay' and physically moves the play along through the player directive 'follow me' (line 16) and leads the two 'fairies' to another part of the garden with large shrubs growing bright flowers. They begin picking the flowers, casting a spell on the flowers to make them 'magical'. This collective action and negotiation of roles During this next part of the play, they remain in characters of two sister fairies (Emma and Breya) with Huda being the 'mum fairy'.

Extract 2: Initiating 'Fairy language'

In what follows, we see lamination in the pretence taken to another level, initially by Huda as she shifts from English to an unrecognisable language that might be described through the nature of the play as 'Fairy language'. This shift in footing through code switching—in the words of (Evaldsson & Fernandes, 2019, p. 38)—can perhaps mark a shift from 'narratives as dialogical sense-making (low tellability) to narratives as performance (high tellability)' as we see a shift from mapping play characters to entering the realm of performing the fairy story proper.

```
16 HUD:      §↑LOO:::::K.
             §points to a flower on the ground
17           (1.9) ((HUD picks up flower. EMM and BRE gather
             around))
18 HUD: →    This is the ±bellim obstru::ctid.
                         ±shows picked up flower to EMM
19           I got it.
20           (2.5) ((they search on floor))
21 HUD: →    ±he:nno visfavmo::r.
             ±points to another flower on the ground
22 EMM:      what did you sa:y?
23           (4.7) ((EMM and HUD look at each other))
24 HUD:      look he::re¿ see there's a flo::wer. There's a
25           flo::wer down here.
```

Huda orients to the flower by making it an object of joint attention within the social group, as she shouts an emphasised directive to 'look' (line 16), steering their line of vision through pointing as she speaks. Further semiotic resources are then employed, as Huda picks the flower up and offers the first instance of a language other than English, through a noun phrase whilst simultaneously 'showing' the flower to her peers (line 18). This initial 'code switching' to a language other than English when referring to the flower '**bellim obstru::ctid**' (line 18) could perhaps be observable as the Latin term for the flower, but more likely in the sequence of talk and performativity of 'fairy

play' it is 'Fairy language' for flower. Huda's 'heightened dramatic rendering' (Evaldsson & Abreu Fernandes, 2019, p. 44) through code switching, prosody and embodied performance create a collaborative involvement in looking for further flowers as the children subsequently search on the ground for several seconds (line 20).

Huda then employs further 'Fairy language' (line 21) as she again couples this talk with a pointing action to another flower on the ground. Although the flower has previously been named as '**bellim obstru::ctid**' (line 18) it is now referred to through a syntactically different term '**he:nno vis-favmo::r.**' (line 21), giving a mismatch in consistency of terms in this non-English labelling associated with the flower. Huda's introduction to the new language is then oriented to as other initiated repair by Emma—followed by a 4.7 second silence signifying the problematic issue further, as the children exchange gaze. Responding to the flagging of trouble, As Ann-Carita states, such examples of children's diverse language use demonstrate their social organisation resources and 'is a key component in children's emergent performativity and peer group sociality' (Evaldsson, 2025, p. 979). Huda's next utterance returns to the use of English when referring to the 'flower' (lines 24-5). However, this is not the end of the use of this new language, where it is subsequently returned to by both Huda and then also Breya in the next sequence of action in Extract 3.

Extract 3: 'Fairy language' as a collaborative performance of a fairy story

In the following interaction, we see Breya recruiting the pre-established category 'fairy mum' as she elicits Huda's attention (line 26), with Huda responding in character, once again in the new language (lines 27-8). Breya then aligns with Huda's language form, as she too adapts her utterances to this improvised language (lines 31 & 33). As such, we see what Ann-Carita observed as the 'organization of language and culture, of stance and footing, and how telling a story provides a powerful means for children to reenact and animate their own and others' actions' (Evaldsson & Abreu Fernandes, 2019, p. 37).

```
26 BRE:     m↑a::::m. [§can you hold my wand ple::se¿
                      §holds 'wand' towards HUD - uses 'baby
           voice'
27 HUD:               [m↑e::::h.
28          da::wnyo ka::n won [won s↑a:n yumoo::r.
29 EMM:                        [can you get us more flowers:.
30 HUD:     no: no::.

Lines omitted where BRE and EMM have a dispute about who's wand
is the biggest - who is oldest and then who has collected the
```

most flowers. BRE then walks away to pick more flowers, then walks toward HUD using 'Fairy talk' and waving her wand

```
31 BRE:     lis::core shtimi.
32          (3.2)
33          ↑lis::core shtimi. STE:simite. STE::. ±Corestimi.
                                                  ±walks away
            from HUD
34 HUD:     moo:skus moo:skus. §can you say moo:skus moo:skus
                               §walks to EMM – gaze to EMM
35 EMM:     <°moo:skus moo:skus¿°>
36 HUD:     yeah £moo:skus moo:skus.£
37 EMM:     <°moo:s kus moo:s kus¿°>
38 HUD:     can't you know some different languages about
39          (this)? Ah: ±bee up there..
                        ±holds flowers up to mark bee location
40 EMM:     yes I know: a bee::::.
41 HUD:     §sister a bee up there look up.
            §moves BRE head upwards so eyeline aligns with bee
42          see a bee's slo::w. it flewed away now sisters so
43          you don't have to worry about it anymore.
44 EMM:     §Ar well you can ↑stop calling us sisters you- you
            §walks toward HUD and BRE
45          could start calling us our na::::mes::. Aye.
46 BRE:     ±reree::t. ollesteem gleeshleeem? .hhh (.)
            ±walks slowly away from EMM and HUD
47          oshtellesheek koyshtemee.
```

Breya's initial term of address towards Huda here (line 26) demonstrates a participation framework that is co-constructed around specific roles, positioning Huda as fairy mum to Breya. Breya's performance of the fairy character is touched off by Huda as she provides a contingently relevant response, demonstrating her alignment to Breya and the performance of the fairy story through her linguistic footing. Emma, however, uses English for her turn, calling for more flowers, to which Huda gives an exaggerated dispreferred response 'no no' (line 30). This leads to Breya and Emma having a slight dispute over various issues, before Breya—again—aligns with Huda's fairy play as a linguistic performance through her subsequent turns. By engaging in the spontaneous improvised 'Fairy language' both Huda and Breya can be seen as 'engaging in language alternations as an integral part in the co-production of a bilingual storytelling performance' (Evaldsson & Abreu Fernandes, 2019, p. 42).

As Emma has so far resisted engaging in Fairy language, Huda now explicitly recruits her participation, initially formulating 'moo:skus

moo:skus' then asking Emma to repeat them (line 34). Emma does give a preferred response here, as she copies Huda's Fairy language, albeit very quietly and slowly, demonstrating some hesitation. At this point, Huda offers a question concerning Emma's knowledge of languages (line 38-39) but quickly becomes distracted by a bee. What is interesting here is that Huda's initial orientation to the bee is firmly placed in the present reality of their location, and then in the next turn the real-life bee is subsequently adapted into the play (lines 41-43), to 'perform interesting, laminated actions through assembling semiotic resources that extend far beyond the structures of talk' (Evaldsson & Abreu Fernandes, 2019, p. 38).

Huda's utterances here demonstrate her change in footing into fairy character through her reference to Breya as 'sister' (line 41) and collectively to Emma and Breya 'sisters' (line 42) as she performs a protective mum role, reassuring them that they 'don't have to worry anymore' (line 43). This performance of the fairy storyline is immediately contested by Emma though in her next turn where she requests Huda to use their names (line 45), marking a suggestion to abandon the current playframe that is being performed. However, Breya continues to perform as fairy character, demonstrated by her further use of Fairy language (lines 46-7), making demonstrable her alignment with Huda and willingness to continue in the fairy playframe. Breya further marks her dis-alignment with Emma, as she physically moves away from her. As Breya and Huda align with their category bound activity of engaging in a specific language together, and Emma does not, Fairy language might be seen as a resource for that is employed to exclude and include specific members of the fairy play. As such, direct alignment with Ann-Carita's heteroglossia work can be made, where children can be observed using standard monolingual talk (here Emma) and also diverse language use (here Huda and Breya) mapping social organisation in improvised ways.

Some concluding thoughts and questions

Guided by the work of Ann-Carita (e.g. Evaldsson, 2004; 2005; 2009; 2021) and specifically her co-authored work (Evaldsson & Abreu Fernandes, 2019), this writing has attempted to demonstrate the breadth of impact Ann-Carita's work has, globally and in an ever-changing world. Reusing Ann-Carita's analytical words and extending these to the data explored in this piece, further consideration can be given to how, 'launching and designing a highly tellable bilingual story requires an attentive and affectionate co-participant that reflexively orients to semiotic modalities that extend beyond the stream of speech' (Evaldsson & Abreu Fernandes, 2019, p. 60). The extension I would like to make is by way of recognising the children's spontaneous and improvised 'Fairy language' as a point for further consideration, which does raise the following questions:

1) Can a spontaneously 'made-up' language officially be recognised as a language?
2) Could the children's talk here be recognised as 'bilingual' if one of the linguistic codes used is *not* officially recognised as a language

We can summarise that the code-switching evident in the data presented here is 'doing something' to the interaction—perhaps linking more closely with Ann-Carita's earlier work on children's exclusions and inclusions of interlocutors in peer groups (Evaldsson, 2005). One thing we do know is—if a specific feature of interaction is made demonstrably important for the participants themselves, then it is analytically of interest to researchers. My interest in children's 'Fairy language' here will be further enlightened by Ann-Carita's work in her forthcoming co-edited (with another inspirational pioneer of early childhood CA research—Prof Amy Kyratzis) Special Issue of Discourse Studies exploring 'Children's language creativity, emergent performativity and heteroglossia in multilingual settings'. I look forward to engaging further with your future work, Ann-Carita!

I would like to end this piece by thanking Ann-Carita for her inspirational contributions to the world of ECEC CA. Prompting researchers to fully engage with children's social organisation practices in ways which draw out their competencies is one legacy that Ann-Carita will certainly inspire in others. Furthermore, digging deeper into explorations of children's language choice, code switching, translanguaging and heteroglossia, Ann-Carita's work offers exceptional insight into children's cultures that is rarely afforded. As with all great scholars, Ann-Carita's work raises additional questions that will extend her work into further global contexts and uncertain futures in a world that continues to frame children as less-than adults.

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“Let’s read!”: Multilingual practices and the interactional organization of peer literacy

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Introduction

Over the last few decades, Ann-Carita Evaldsson’s work on peer interaction, play, and multimodal analysis has deepened our understanding of how children and adolescents use multiple languages, styles, and embodied conduct to construct identities and constitute social relationships in interaction. A central insight emerging from this work is that children’s multilingual practices are not merely reflections of broader sociolinguistic contexts but are interactionally organized accomplishments through which participants take stances, negotiate participation, and socialize one another. One way to honor and build upon Evaldsson’s legacy is to revisit key contributions from her research and show how they can illuminate new empirical material. In their introduction to a special issue on multilingual peer socialization, Evaldsson and her colleagues argue that children are “adept at socializing one another to and through heteroglossic discourse practices” (Kyratzis, Reynolds & Evaldsson, 2010, p. 468). While heteroglossia has often been theorized at a broad sociocultural level (e.g., Bakhtin, 1981), Evaldsson’s work—together with that of her collaborators—has consistently demonstrated how such diversity becomes visible in situated interaction, particularly in peer contexts. Drawing on the framework of language socialization (e.g., Ochs & Schieffelin, 1984), this research has extended early emphasis on adult-child interaction to detailed analyses of peer interaction in mundane and institutional settings (e.g., Evaldsson, 2005). Crucially, children’s peer interactions are sites not only of social reproduction but also of transformation, or what Corsaro (1992) terms “interpretive reproduction” (see also Evaldsson & Corsaro, 1998). In classroom settings, children may be exposed to bilingual practices that employ two languages within a turn or across speakers. In teacher-fronted lessons, however, these practices are often limited to translation (Burdelski, 2025), thereby sustaining a monolingual “medium of interaction” (Gafaranga & Torras, 2002). In contrast, peer interaction—particularly during transitional moments, those in-between activities, or in “backstage” spaces (Goffman, 1981) within classrooms and on playgrounds—affords more dynamic and flexible forms of language alternation (e.g., Jørgensen, 2008; Xu & Evaldsson, 2025; see Rampton, 1995 on “crossing”). In these contexts, children creatively draw on their multilingual repertoires to display stances, perform identities, and align with or resist

others' perspectives (e.g., Anatoli & Cekaite, 2025; Aronsson, 1998; Cekaite & Aronsson, 2004; Evaldsson, 2005; Kyratzis, 2025; Paugh, 2012). Such practices may be playful, but they can also be subversive, particularly when they challenge institutional norms, such as those that privilege one language at a time, thereby constraining children's access to their full communicative repertoires (Burdelski, 2025). Importantly, these practices are inherently multimodal, involving not only talk but also gaze, gesture, bodily positioning, and touch. They can also involve interaction mediated by material objects, such as technological devices (Evaldsson, 2025) and reading materials (Johnson, 2017). As Evaldsson and Svahn (2017) have demonstrated, children's meaning-making, including their affective stances and moral positions, is richly layered and laminated across semiotic resources.

This paper examines classroom interaction surrounding a peer-initiated and peer-managed literacy activity among boys at an international school in Japan. Focusing on a naturally occurring literacy event, the study asks: 1) How do the children use bilingual and embodied practices in organizing the activity? 2) How do co-participants respond to these practices? 3) How do these interactional practices contribute to the processes of language socialization?

Background

Peer socialization and heteroglossia

It has long been observed that children are not mere recipients of adult socialization but active participants who shape, transform, and create norms, knowledge, and practices through everyday interactions. Over the past couple decades, researchers have built on the framework of language socialization (e.g., Ochs & Schieffelin, 1984)—as a flexible and dynamic paradigm involving socialization to *use* language and socialization *through* language—to explore how children socialize one another to shared relationships and norms, as well as to interactional and cultural competence in peer interaction (e.g., M. H. Goodwin, 2006; Goodwin & Kyratzis, 2011; Kyratzis, 2004). An important figure in this expansion is Ann-Carita Evaldsson, whose work has demonstrated how children align with, negotiate, and subvert institutional norms and moral order through diverse activities such as peer disputes, play, and assessments (e.g., Andréasson & Evaldsson, 2023; Evaldsson, 2005, 2007; Evaldsson & Svahn, 2017; Reynolds, 2007). Evaldsson's studies have highlighted that children not only display interactional and sociocultural competence but also selectively and agentively shape their social worlds.

Central to peer interaction is the concept of heteroglossia (Bakhtin, 1981). Bailey (2007) describes heteroglossia as the coexistence of multiple voices or language varieties within a single utterance or interaction, often reflecting different social positions, ideologies, and stances. Heteroglossia may include aligning with or resisting peers, reframing activities, invoking third-party

voices, and transgressing normative order (Aronsson, 1998; M. H. Goodwin, 1990; Paugh, 2005). It often includes not only multilingual resources but also multimodal resources, including gestures, gaze, and material objects. Evaldsson's research—often in collaboration with colleagues across Europe, North America, and Japan—has demonstrated ways in which children socialize each other to and through heteroglossic practices (e.g., Anatoli & Cekaite, 2025; Burdelski, 2025; Nasi, 2025). Such practices are often most visible in peer-organized activities, which provide interactional spaces relatively free from adult surveillance and the constraints of institutional—and often monolingual—norms. In such settings, children creatively draw upon their communicative repertoires—switching between languages or dialects, stylizing voices, playfully mocking rules, and the like—to constitute social relationships. These moments not only reflect but also produce the local social order.

Children's peer literacy in classrooms

An important site of peer interaction is within literacy activities. While literacy has traditionally been treated in educational policy and pedagogy as an individual cognitive skill—something to be carried out and processed alone—postmodernist approaches view literacy as socially embedded and culturally organized (see Street, 1984). An interactional approach grounded in ethnomethodology and conversation analysis (EMCA) goes a step further by exploring literacy as an interactionally situated and embodied activity (e.g., Church, 2010; Cohrssen et al., 2015; Heller & Rohlfing, 2017; Tainio & Slotte, 2017; Takada & Kawashima, 2019). While much of this work has focused on teacher-led instruction and adult-guided literacy events, an emerging strand highlights the importance of peer-organized literacy activities, especially reading (e.g., Kyratzis, 2014, 2017; Sterponi, 2007; see also Melander, 2012, on writing). Johnson (2017), for example, examined peer reading among English-speaking kindergartners (ages 5 to 6), showing how the children drew on multimodal resources—such as aloud recitation, facial expression, gesture, and gaze—to manage turn-taking, assist one another, and negotiate roles during collaborative reading. In particular, Johnson explored sequences where a peer-initiated correction on another's reading aloud of a word or phrase, leading to self or other-correction. Such peer-initiated correction was occasioned by displayed troubles in reading—indicated by restarts, pauses, self-correction, and the like. Her work foregrounds how peer reading becomes a site for building reader identities, epistemic authority, and affective affiliation. Kyratzis (2014, 2017) has pursued this line of inquiry in relation to bilingual peer interaction. Kyratzis (2014), for example, examined how two bilingual Spanish English-speaking children in a preschool engaged in "pretend" literacy practices over time. This included using a reading voice to structure participation, ask questions to invite the listener to display understanding—thereby re-enacting reader and listener roles inherent to teacher-led literacy activities in

educational settings. Over time, children shifted from using exclusively Spanish to employing both Spanish and English for various purposes, such as to label illustrations (e.g., *El* monkey 'The monkey' [referring to Curious George]) and ask comprehension questions. Although the young readers were not actually reading text, Kyratzis's analysis illustrates how children "do reading" by adopting situationally relevant roles, constructing reading as a joint activity, and mobilizing bilingual and other verbal and embodied resources—such as stylized intonation, pointing, and gaze—for various practical purposes, such as organizing turn-taking and aligning affectively.

Together, studies of peer interaction in reading activities make visible the interactional complexity of children's literacy practices and how reading becomes a locus for social organization, learning, and identity construction. The present study builds on this work by examining how children in a classroom at an international school in Japan engage in a peer-initiated and peer-managed reading activity, using multilingual and embodied practices to produce social actions and stances. The analysis shows how peer-led literacy events can become key sites for exploring children's participation frameworks, socialization practices, and creative negotiation of interactional, relational, and institutional norms.

Methodology

This study draws upon audiovisual recordings of naturally occurring interaction in a first-grade classroom (children aged 7) at an international school in Japan. All children spoke Japanese as their L1 and were generally more proficient—some exceedingly so—in Japanese than English. The data were collected during the first two months of an ongoing project, which coincided with the final two months of the school year (May and June 2024), totalling approximately 8 hours of recording. Following ethical guidelines, approval was granted from the author's university, where the project was initiated (reference number: Kenron A-1, The University of Osaka). Written consent was obtained from parents, teachers, and the principal, including permission to use the data and modified images for educational and research purposes. Children were verbally informed about the general aim of the study: to observe how they interact in the classroom and on the school grounds.

This paper focuses on a "single-case analysis" (Sacks, 1992; see also Nishizaka, 2024) of spontaneous peer-managed reading. In ethnomethodology—and Conversation Analysis (see C. Goodwin, 1979; Schegloff, 1987)—single cases have been viewed as valuable for demonstrating recurring structural features of interaction, which is the goal of the present analysis in relation to a literacy activity. The classroom had a reading corner, furnished with a small sofa and a shelf containing both Japanese and English books, which provided material and social "affordances" (Gibson, 1977) for such activities to emerge during transitional moments between scheduled events—here,

following lunch and before going outside to play. This activity was initiated by a boy (JK), who said in English, "Let's read!". Then four classmates followed him to the reading corner, where they formed an "ecological huddle" (Goffman, 1964: 64), or a socially constructed spatial area where participants demonstrate through their talk and embodied conduct that they are mutually oriented toward each other and to a shared focus of attention (Streeck, Goodwin & LeBaron, 2011). During the activity, a sixth boy attempted to gain entry to the reading activity but was unsuccessful (not shown), resulting in the activity being carried out from start to finish by the original five boys.

The analysis draws on methods from EMCA and multimodal interaction analysis. Transcription conventions are adapted from Jefferson (1984) for verbal interaction and Mondada (2018) for embodied and spatial features. In the excerpts, the first line represents the original utterance (italics for Japanese and regular font for English). The second line offers an idiomatic English translation or an English word-by-word gloss (in bold), based on which option more clearly conveys the original meaning (see Appendix for interlinear gloss abbreviations). All participant names are pseudonyms.

Heteroglossia, language alternation, and embodied practices in a peer-organized literacy activity

The focal case, Excerpt 1, is drawn from an extended peer-organized reading event that spans nine minutes; the excerpt begins at 03:45, or about one-third of the way into the activity, and continues for several minutes beyond this excerpt. Before the excerpt, Boy-3 had picked up a Japanese book titled *Japanese Myths*, which contained written text along with subdued illustrations of monsters, ghosts, goblins, and other mythological beings, and then invited nearby peers to read together. These images become the focus of imaginative engagement, arguments, and collaborative sense-making in Japanese and English. For instance, one such creature is referred to below as "Pakkuriman," and another is (mis)identified as a "cockroach".

The excerpt is divided into three parts, each illustrating key multilingual and multimodal practices deployed by the children across this emergent, peer-managed activity:

(i) characterizing and assessing visual illustrations (Ex. 1-a);
(ii) managing participation in the activity (Ex. 1-b); and
(iii) repairing and correcting aloud reading of written text (Ex. 1-c).

While (i) and (iii) are oriented toward the forward progression of the reading activity, focusing on sense-making and literacy, (ii) marks a temporary halt in this progression, as participants deal with issues of participation in the activity.

In Excerpt 1-a, the Japanese book has just been opened to two new pages containing various fantastical figures, captions, and explanatory narratives. In line 2, Boy-1 initiates a "noticing action" (Haddington et al., 2022) by pointing to a small, ghost-like white figure (see Figures 1-1 and 1-2), and characterizes it in Japanese (line 2: *woo pakkuriman da* 'Wow, it's Pakkuriman'—the name of a fictional character).

Excerpt 1-a "Pakkuriman"

```
01    b5     turns page
02    B1     |woo |pa#kkuriman da.
                wow  pakkuriman   COP
                     |LH index finger point to small white object on page
      b5     |RH finger point to black object on page
                     |withdraw point
      fig              #1-1/1-2
```

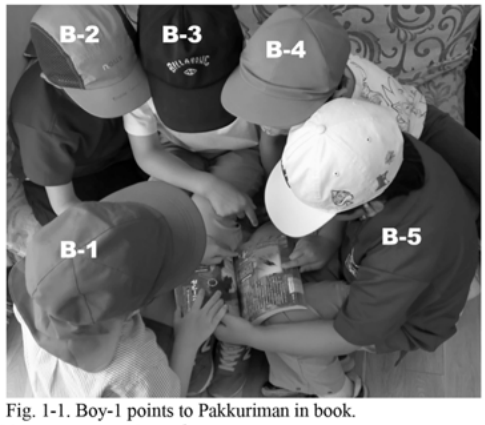


Fig. 1-1. Boy-1 points to Pakkuriman in book.



Fig. 1-2. Close-up of 1-1.

```
03    B?     |cough
      B1     |h|hhh  |
      B5       |no no|
04    B5     no |he's |ka
                        Co(ckroach)
      B2         |RH  on top of Boy-1's LH,
                         |swipes B1's RH off page
05           (0.6)
06    B5     ano |gokiburi ga.
              that  cockroach  SUB
                   |RH spread out on page-->
```

In response to Boy-1's noticing (line 2), Boy-5 produces a disaffiliative action in English (line 3: "No, no, no") and redirects attention to an illustration on the opposite page ("He's co-. *ano gokiburi ga*" 'He's ka. That cockroach is'). This utterance includes a code alternation from English to Japanese. More specifically, he begins in English ("He's co-"), then switches to Japanese by saying *ano gokiburi ga* 'um, cockroach'. This turn suggests that the first sound "co-," pronounced /ka/, which is cut off, was an attempt to produce the English word cockroach, but was replaced with the Japanese word *gokiburi* 'cockroach'—in other words, a self-initiated self-repair (Schegloff et al., 1977).

This moment can be understood as a heteroglossic practice in which language alternation is mobilized to accomplish multiple actions. Through the sequential organization of the turn, Boy-5 uses English to initiate a competing assessment, while the shift into Japanese resolves a word-search and secures a label for the referent. Heteroglossia here is not merely a matter of language choice, but an interactional resource for contestation, repair, and stance-taking. Through these linguistic and embodied resources—including a reduplicated interjection ("no no no"), language alternation, and pointing—B-5 competes with B-1 for the group's attention to an alternative illustration on the open pages of the book. This laminated configuration of talk, gesture, and material orientation exemplifies how heteroglossic practices are embedded within embodied participation frameworks in peer interaction (Evaldsson, 2005).

"We cannot see that": Managing participation in peer literacy

Another central practice in this peer reading activity is the management of embodied participation (e.g., C. Goodwin & M. H. Goodwin, 2023). This management can momentarily suspend the progression of the activity to deal with issues related to the entry of new participants, control of the book and its orientation, decisions about when to turn the page, and physical access to the book through hand placement. These issues are frequently accomplished through multilingual and embodied means, making participation management a key site for the enactment of heteroglossic practices in peer interaction.

In Excerpt 1-b, which immediately follows 1-a, placement of hands becomes a central focus of attention when one boy's (Boy-5) hand obscures a key illustration. Here, while multiple children have their hands on the edges of the book (allowing shared visibility), Boy-5 places his hand in the middle of one of the pages, covering up the illustration he has just referred to as *gokiburi* 'cockroach' (Figure 1-3).

Excerpt 1-b “We cannot see that”

07 b5 >>#*RH spread out on page-->*

fig #1-3



Fig. 1-3. Boy-5’s RH covers part of page.

08 B2 we |#can|#not see| that.

|#*RH on top of B5’s RH*

fig #1-4



Fig. 1-4. Boy-2’s RH touches Boy-5’s RH.

b2 |#*gaze up to camera/research*

b5 |*takes RH away*

--> |*looks up*

09 B5 |( )|

|takes hand away/looks down

10 (0.3)

11 B5 yes, she's |*gokiburi*.

cockroach

|RH points to page

12 (0.4)

13 B2 |he is so |fasto.

|takes LH away

b1 *|LH on page*

In response to Boy-5's covering of the illustration, Boy-2 code-switches to English (line 8: "We cannot see that"). Although phrased as a declarative, the utterance serves as a directive (e.g., Ervin-Tripp, 1976), implicitly conveying to Boy-5 to remove his hand from the image. His use of the inclusive pronoun "we" frames it as a collective concern, reinforcing the shared nature of this activity. From a heteroglossic perspective, the choice of English here can be seen as an interactional resource for managing participation within a multilingual peer group, temporarily prioritizing a shared code to resolve a local coordination problem. Importantly, the directive is multimodal: Boy-2 lightly touches Boy-5's hand while issuing the directive to guide the removal of his hand (Figure 1-4). Boy-5 immediately complies, and the interactional problem is resolved.

Before leaving this participation management-related exchange, it is useful to briefly detail how the joint reading activity is resumed. Once visual access to the image is restored (at line 9), Boy-5 produces an utterance in English and Japanese about the image by characterizing it again (line 11: "she's *gokiburi*"). Rather than moving on, he re-engages the group with the same referent. Boy-2 affiliates with an English assessment (line 13: "he is so *fasto*")—stylizing the word "fast" by adding an epenthetic vowel /o/. Such moments of stylization—regardless of their source—exemplify how children build, transform, and negotiate stances and actions.

Sequentially, these consecutive turns by different speakers represent a "format tying" (M. H. Goodwin, 1990), built around the copular construction "She/he is X."

Boy-5: **she's** *gokiburi*.
Boy-2: **he is** so fast.

Despite differences in language choice and reference, action continuity is maintained through heteroglossic coordination across turns, allowing the

children to move smoothly from participation management back to shared sense-making in the reading activity.

"No, shadow people": Correction and repair in peer literacy

A final set of practices in literacy activities involves peer-initiated repair and correction in relation to written text (e.g., Johnson, 2017), highlighting emerging forms of instructional scaffolding and epistemic negotiation. While the book's text is written in Japanese, both Japanese and English are recruited to address breakdowns in fluency, making repair a key site for heteroglossic coordination in peer literacy interaction.

In Excerpt 1-c, immediately following from 1-b, the group is focusing on a caption written in katakana: シャードーピープ (pronounced *shaadoo piipuru* 'shadow people'). The comparatively large, stylized print of the caption is accessible even to these early readers, though the surrounding narrative explanations—written in a combination of kanji, hiragana, and katakana—require a higher level of reading ability and were not attended to during this activity.

Excerpt 1-c "Shadow People"

```
22    B5    |shii        |:::#::|ji (0.3)
            |RH finger swipe |hover    |point/touch
      fig                      #1-5,1-6
```

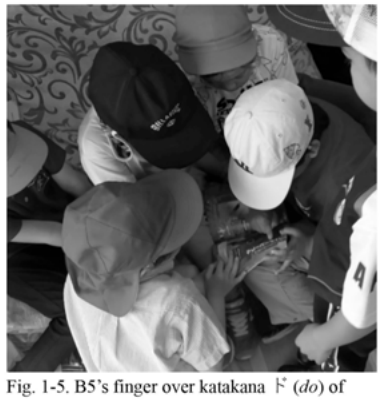


Fig. 1-5. B5's finger over katakana ド (*do*) of シャードー*shaadoo*.



Fig. 1-6. Close-up of 4-5.

```
23    B4    SHAADOO.
            shadow
24    B5    shadoo                |(0.3)   |#pii|(0.2)|(0.2)|#pu
            shadow                          peop(le)
            |RH finger traces シャードー |RH finger at ピー                |RH finger at プ
      fig                                  |#1-7/1-8
```



Fig. 1-7. B5's finger over katakana ピ (*pi*) of *piipuru*.



Fig. 1-8. Close up of Fig. 4-8.

25 B2 |no *sha*|#*doo*

shadow

|#*RH finger-->*

piipuru.

people

RH finger traces ピープル (piipuru) and continues beyond the word to bottom of page

fig #1-9,1-10



Fig. 1-9. B-2's finger toward ピープル *(piipuru)* B5 finger at ピー*(pi)*.

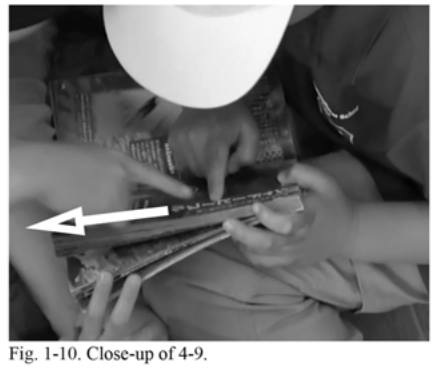


Fig. 1-10. Close-up of 4-9.

26 (1.2)

27 B1 <*shadoo piipuru*.>

shadow people

28 b3 *turns page*

In line 22, Boy-5 initiates reading of the caption by pointing to the first mora シャ (*sha*) and says *shi::::* (シ::::), stretching the vowel. He then skips over the following small *ya* (ャ), which is supposed to be combined with the preceding character *shi* (シ) to produce a single mora *sha*, and continues to the

next character ド (*do*), which he misreads as ジ (*ji*) (Figures 1-5 and 1-6). Following this misreading, a 0.3 second pause emerges, creating a space for peer assistance.

In response to this pause, B-4 interrupts by producing an exposed correction (Jefferson, 1987), clearly articulating "SHAADOO" to model the correct reading of the first part of the caption. This corrective move can be understood as a heteroglossic practice in which a peer temporarily adopts an institutionalized, teacher-like voice, drawing on recognizable pedagogical prosody (e.g., Cekaite & Aronsson, 2004). B-5 indicates receipt of the correction (line 24: *shadoo*) and continues reading, though further displays disfluency during the reading of *piipuru* 'people'. As he produces pauses while reading this word (ピー [0.2] [0.2] プ, *pii* [0.2] [0.2] *pu*; see Figures 1-7 and 1-8), another child (Boy-2) responds with "No" and reads the full caption "*shaadoo piipuru*." Here, the English rejection marker "No" serves as a heteroglossic resource for initiating correction, while the modelling of the Japanese reading addresses the literacy task itself. During this turn, Boy-2 uses a tracing gesture (C. Goodwin, 2007), moving his index finger along the vertical text (Figures 1-9 and 1-10), further laminating talk, gesture, and text in the repair sequence. This other-initiated repair treats Boy-5 as needing assistance (Kendrick & Drew, 2016), thereby positioning participants asymmetrically in terms of epistemic status and authority. Although B-5 remains silent, another boy (Boy-1) reads the entire caption aloud again and turns the page, bringing the episode to a close and re-orienting the group to the forward progression of the reading activity. Across this sequence, heteroglossia is enacted through the coordinated use of English and Japanese for correction, modelling, and participation management, allowing children to resolve trouble in reading while maintaining the peer-organized nature of the activity.

Such peer repair and correction sequences highlight how heteroglossic practices (e.g., English rejection markers, Japanese modelling of written text, and stylized pedagogical voices) are mobilized to support emergent reading. Children momentarily take on the situated roles of "tutor" and "tutee", offering guidance while reproducing and transforming recognizable correction practices. In Evaldsson's (2005) terms, the peer group becomes a site for socialization in which institutional voices are stylized and reworked through interaction, providing both affective and instructional scaffolding.

Discussion and conclusion

This study has explored how children in a first-grade classroom at an international school in Japan collaboratively organized a spontaneous, shared reading activity, using bilingual, multimodal, and heteroglossic resources to jointly construct an affective and socially meaningful literacy event within a transitional space (i.e., following lunch and before going outside to play). Rather than focusing on bilingualism as an individual trait or code-switching as a

display of personal competence, the analysis foregrounds literacy as an inherently social process—one accomplished through the coordinated deployment of bodies, gaze, voices, and material objects. As Evaldsson's (2005, 2025) work on multilingual peer interaction has repeatedly shown, such peer practices are not ancillary to formal education, even when they occur outside planned lessons or teacher-fronted activities. Instead, they are intricately woven into children's learning to participate, align, and produce contingently relevant meaning, often beyond the institutional panopticon of teacher surveillance and the monolingual norms governing classroom discourse, as in the present school's "English-only" policy.

Across the activity, the children's shifting language use—fluidly alternating between English and Japanese, reading aloud written Japanese text, and stylizing speech—constituted heteroglossia as an interactional accomplishment rather than a static linguistic condition. These practices indexed stance, organized participation, and built alignments, resonating with prior research on peer heteroglossia and identity work (Anatoli & Cekaite, 2025; Evaldsson, 2025; Kyratzis, 2004; M. H. Goodwin, 2006). Importantly, heteroglossia was enacted within an emergent ecology of shared reading in which participation was continuously negotiated. Through characterizing illustrations, managing access to the book, and correcting one another's reading, children actively socialized one another into and through heteroglossic discourse practices (Kyratzis, Reynolds & Evaldsson, 2010), including linguistic repertoires and affective stance (M. H. Goodwin, Cekaite & C. Goodwin, 2012), and epistemic positions (Heritage, 2012). In doing so, they enacted locally relevant roles and membership categories, such as "reader," "corrector", and "supporter," while building shared understandings about how to *do* literacy together.

Central to this process was embodied organization (Goodwin & Goodwin, 2023). Children's pointing, page-turning, hand placement, gaze, interpersonal touch, and gesture worked in tandem with talk to sustain joint attention and organize contributions, whether oriented toward advancing the activity or suspending it to address issues of participation. The laminated multimodal practices highlight the embodied and emergent nature of literacy, a view supported by Evaldsson and her colleagues' work on bodily coordination in social interaction. More broadly, this peer-managed literacy activity highlights the analytic value of spontaneous, child-organized interaction as a key site for both learning and identity formation, which are foundational to children's social worlds (cf. Nasi, 2025).

The analysis further demonstrates how heteroglossic practices are implicated in the negotiation of stance and authority within the peer group. Corrections, directives, and negotiations over who speaks, reads, or controls the book reflect children's ongoing work to position themselves and others in relation to knowledge and authority as a moral concern (Stivers, Mondada, & Steensig, 2011; see also Nasi, 2022). Peer corrections serve not only as instructional scaffolding but also as identity work, revealing implicit norms around

competence, inclusion, and participation (Johnson, 2017). At the same time, literacy activities can become sites of *exclusion*, as children form tight spatial and interactional clusters (Goffman, 1981) that make entry by additional participants difficult.

Finally, the children's heteroglossic language practices subtly challenge institutional norms that promote one language at a time. While English was privileged in the school's formal curriculum, children's multilingual improvisations resisted and transformed these constraints, opening up space for alternative language practices and identities. These moments of linguistic creativity—playful, affective, and relational—demonstrate how children navigate and reshape institutional norms in agentive and sometimes subversive ways. In this respect, the findings affirm the value of a multimodal and multilingual EMCA approach to children's social interactions while honouring Ann-Carita Evaldsson's legacy by showing how children co-construct knowledge, communicative repertoires, and moral orders in and through everyday peer interaction.

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Social voices and knowledge displays: Children orchestrating participation in the literacy corner

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Introduction

Drawing on language socialization theory, multi-modal conversation analysis, and Membership Categorization Analysis (Goodwin, 2018; Ochs & Schieffelin, 2011; Sacks, 1992), Ann-Carita Evaldsson has made extensive contributions to sociolinguists' and educators' understanding of how children socialize one another to moral orientations in a variety of arenas, including to language norms in classrooms and schools (e.g., Cekaite & Evaldsson, 2019; Evaldsson, 2005, 2007; Evaldsson & Cekaite, 2010; Evaldsson & Kyratzis, 2025). She closely examines the skill of children in creating sequential environments in which multiparty consensus is created in ratifying particular actions as positive or negative category bound activities. For example, she illustrates how immigrant children at primary schools in Sweden "consolidate a collective critical view of not-knowing correct Swedish" (Evaldsson & Cekaite, 2010, p. 587) through upgrades, laughter, recycles, repetitions, corrective practices, parodic imitations and metalinguistic statements, while at other moments orienting to polylingual practices as indexing peer competence and interethnic peer group belonging (Evaldsson, 2025; Blommaert & Rampton, 2011).

In my work with Ann-Carita, we have applied Bakhtin's construct of heteroglossia (Bakhtin, 1981) to children's interactions (Evaldsson & Kyratzis, 2025; Kyratzis, Evaldsson & Reynolds, 2010). Bakhtin argued that the novel draws its expressive strength from the dialogic positioning of different social voices, thereby playing out tensions that exist in societies between pressures pushing language towards unification around a national or standard language, and those pushing it towards heteroglossia and a diversity of social-ideological languages, each carrying its own socio-historical associations**.** By choosing to take on particular social roles in pretend plays, and enacting them in particular ways, children reflect these tensions and power relations in the larger social world, and in so doing, also have the power to *change* those associations (Minks, 2013; Paugh, 2012; Kyratzis, Reynolds, & Evaldsson, 2010). However, children also have more local purposes for drawing on social voices. They do so in the context of organizing *participation* (Goodwin & Goodwin, 2004), how they become *aligned* (Goffman, 1981) to their talk and

one another in the local interaction. They emulate powerful adult roles, privileged to speak with high-status control act forms—for example, mothers portrayed as speaking with bald directives (Goodwin, 1990)—in order to achieve their own local power in the peer group. In this paper, I examine how children's play with various authoritative voices, *teacher talk* and *reading voice*, serves as a resource to them in organizing participation among their peers, namely through the epistemic authority they afford the child in teacher or reader role in the interaction. I then discuss the implications of children's heteroglossia in play for their literacy and language development.

Research background

Conversation analysis looks to participants' practices in the moment-to-moment interaction to reveal social identities and meanings that are important to the participants themselves, rather than looking to the analyst's categories (Sacks, Schegloff & Jefferson, 1974). One phenomenon that participants regularly orient to in interaction is one another's knowledge states (Goodwin, 1981; Heritage & Raymond, 2005). Charles Goodwin has argued that participants' relative (K+/K) knowledge states are publicly exhibited and monitored by co-participants, as they are consequential for how the co-participants design their utterances in interaction (1981).Claims made about the relative knowledge states of participants may be ratified or not by co-participants in subsequent turns of the interaction (Sacks, Schegloff & Jefferson, 1974; C. Goodwin, 1981; M.H. Goodwin, 1990).

Participants' relative knowledge states are also regularly contested in interaction. Heritage and Raymond (2005) argue that when a speaker makes a particular kind of speech act in first position, for example, describing a state of affairs (i.e., through a declarative) that the co-participant does not know, or assuming the right to evaluate a state of affairs (i.e., through an assessment), this proposes for the speaker a position of epistemic primacy or *epistemic authority*. The co-participant can then engage in systematic practices to either ratify or "resist any claim to epistemic authority that may be indexed by the first speaker" (Heritage & Raymond, 2005, p. 15).

Several studies have shown how children contest one another's claims to knowledge, using public exhibitions of instructing, reading, knowing classroom rules, and knowing numbers in Japanese to do so (Goodwin, 1990; Johnson, 2018; Kyratzis, 2018; Martin & Evaldsson, 2012; Melander, 2012). In this paper, I examine how Spanish-English bilingual children at a bilingual preschool in Southern California draw on social voices carrying epistemic authority in pretend play, to orchestrate shifts in the participation structure among them. In particular, the children draw on the social voices of teacher talk or *subteaching*, whereby they position themselves as teachers and exploit a series of teacher-like strategies to control the interaction among them. *Subteaching*, as described by Tholander & Aronsson (2003), includes strategies

like instructing, evaluating and disciplining peers. In subteaching, children reproduce discursive practices that characterize typical classroom interaction as they position themselves relative to their co-participants in the interaction.

Children in the present data also utilize *reading voice*, a register characterized by staccato rhythm simulating the action of reading text off a page (Gumperz & Cook-Gumperz, 1978; Kyratzis, 2018). I show how children use these social voices to contest their relative knowledge states and gain control of the interaction. I then examine the implications of this type of natural heteroglossia in children's talk for their literacy development and their development of language ideologies.

Method

Setting of the study

The data for this study were collected at a bilingual Spanish-English Head Start preschool in Southern California. For the majority of families served by the preschool, Spanish was the language spoken in the home. The bilingual Head Start preschool was preparing children for English-only public school education in California under Proposition 227. Passed in 1998, Proposition 227 ended bilingual education in most public California elementary schools until Proposition 58 replaced it in 2016. Following Head Start policy, teachers would incorporate children's home language and use Spanish-English bilingual practice throughout the year. However, in preparation for kindergarten, they would also increasingly use English language resources for literacy activities as the school year progressed, thereby orienting to English as the official language of literacy and school. Consequently, although there were influences promoting heteroglossia and multilingualism in the classroom language practice, there were also influences promoting English dominance (Bakhtin, 1981).

Data collection, participants, and analytic approach

Children were between three to five years old. Data were collected through a video-ethnography conducted in a classroom of the preschool over two years in the early 2010s. Children were observed and videotaped in their friendship groups in naturally occurring interactions during free play and centers time, a time when children interacted with peers at centers set up for different activities (e.g., literacy corner, writing table, house area). The classroom was visited once a week.

The focus of the overall study was on the types of social identities children explored and their use of Spanish, English, and bilingual Spanish-English practice in their peer pretend plays.

Two excerpts drawn from a longer episode of pretend play in which four-year-old children were teaching and reading to one another in the literacy corner are analyzed in this chapter. Multimodal conversation analysis (Goodwin, 2018) was used as the analytic approach to capture how children assemble diverse resources—prosodic, embodied, multilingual, multivocal, etc.—in representing different social roles and registers in their play. All names used in this report are pseudonyms to protect participant confidentiality.

Analysis

Two excerpts drawn from a longer episode of pretend play, in which children were attempting to teach and read to one another in the literacy corner, illustrate how the children draw on social voices carrying epistemic authority to orchestrate participation. It should be noted that, as these data are of preschoolers, rather than reading in the sense of decoding the written text on the page, the children are exhibiting an *emergent* form of literacy practice, one of reciting story text out loud while looking at storybook pages and using a staccato rhythm that simulates the action of reading text off a page. Cook-Gumperz and Gumperz (1978) have referred to this social voice as *reading voice*.

Before the start of the first excerpt, Nico had chosen a book about a cat and read it in Spanish to Luna in this way, turning the pages and describing the pictures, for example saying "Y mira que pasó con el gato. Sacó la lengua y 'meow'" (*And look what happened with the cat; It took out its tongue and meow.*) Luna had aligned as someone being read to and asked him questions about the book. After a few pages, Nico announced that the book was finished ("Y ya se acabó"), and left the literacy corner to get a notebook to write in about the book, while Luna sat waiting for him to return. Excerpt 1 begins as Nico returns to the literacy corner. Seeing him come back, Luna announces "Yo te voy a leer este libro! Siéntate aquí" (line 1). Her announcement and directive constitute forms of teacher talk. They initiate a communicative project by which she will read to Nico, who will be in the role of her "student". A *communicative project* is an activity proposed by one or more participants to solve a problem or task; the concept represents a dialogic approach that focuses on how the participants collaborate, or don't collaborate, on the project over sequentially unfolding interaction (Linell, 1998; Goodwin & Cekaite, 2018). At the same time, Nico grabs a different book from the basket of books in the literacy area, saying "Look it, hey, hey!" (line 2), thereby initiating a competing communicative project whereby he will read to *her*. As he says this, two girls, Debby and a second girl, sit down in the two chairs across from Luna, where Nico had been sitting before. Nico takes issue with this and complains that the girls have taken his "spot". Luna continues enacting teacher voicing or "subteaching" (Tholander and Aronsson, 2003) to

attempt to get the children to attend to her reading. She initiates an I-R-E sequence (Mehan, 1979). The excerpt will also show how Nico resists her attempts by not answering her I-R-E sequence initiation in the way she projects as appropriate and attempts to get his seat back so that he can read *his* book to Luna.

Excerpt 1

1	Luna	Yo te voy a leer este libro! Siéntate aquí. Les voy a leer este- ((as Nico returns, Luna holds up book then leans forward with it))
		I am going to read you this book. Sit here, I'm going to read you this …
2	Nico	Look it, hey, hey! ((Nico grabs book from book Wall, Luna Laughs; two girls sit down in chairs Across from Luna))
3	Luna	Les voy a leer una hisotira que se llama 'el gatito Va a la escuela'. Quién va pa'la escuela? ((Raises Her hand indicating procedure for requesting Permission to speak; uses staccato for title))
		I'm going to read you a story that is called 'The Kitty goes to school'. Who goes to the school?
4	Girls	Yo! ((the two girls raise their hands))
		Me!
5	Luna	Los gatitos van a la escuela.
		The kitties go to the school.
6	Nico	Yo voy a la escuela. Somebody else en mi spot. ((Returns from book wall, sees the girls are in his chair))
7	Debby	No, no, no. ((Debby, one of the girls in Nico's chair, points to mic as Nico backs into it. A boy momentarily enters literacy area, points at something across room, and leaves area)).
8	Nico	Where's my spo:t? Where's my spo:t?
9	Girls	((Get up from Nico's chair; leave literacy area))
10	Luna	Look-it. Debby. Debby. Okay. ((waves book after the departing girls.))
11	Nico	Dónde es mi spo:t?
		Where's my spot?
12	Luna	Aquí, siéntate. ((Points to the chair as Nico moves towards basket of books))
		There, sit.

In line 1, seeing Nico return from getting a notebook to write his story in, Luna enacts teacher voicing by proposing to read to him and by directing him

to sit down (line 1). There is an embodied component to her enactment of the teacher: she holds the book up and faced outward towards the "student" and leans forward. Before sitting down across from her, Nico goes to the book shelf perpendicular to the chairs in the literacy corner to retrieve a different book, saying "Look it, hey, hey!" (line 2). In line 3, after two girls sit down in the chair across from Luna that Nico had previously occupied, Luna continues her teacher voicing by instructing the children on the title of the book. She uses reading voice to read the title out loud, "El gatito va a la escuela" saying this very deliberately, syllable by syllable in a staccato rhythm, conveying that she is decoding words one-by-one off the cover of the book and doing so with a high degree of confidence in the knowledge she is imparting. She then in line 3 asks the first part of an I-R-E (Initiation-Response-Evaluation) sequence (Mehan, 1979), a comprehension check question which, in English, translates to *Who goes to the school?*

The I-R-E sequence is a distinctive genre of teacher talk which creates an epistemic hierarchy. It does so by projecting the teacher as being a more knowing (K+) participant and as having the right to ask others to display *their* knowledge to her (C. Goodwin, 1981; Heritage & Raymond, 2005; M.H. Goodwin, 1990). Luna also raises her hand, modeling an appropriate action for requesting permission for a turn to speak. Concomitantly, the "students" (the two girls and Nico) are positioned as less knowing (K-) (Goodwin, 1981), being placed in the position of having to demonstrate that they are able to answer the question. In line 4, the two girls in the excerpt fully ratify the right of the teacher to demand a knowledge display from them by mirroring Luna's embodied action of raising their hands and calling out a proposed answer, "Yo!" (*Me*!).

The instructional sequence continues in line 5 as Luna evaluates and corrects the two girls, saying that, in the book she is preparing to read to them, the gat<u>i</u>tos (the *kitties*, emphasis on the second syllable), rather than the children, go to the school. As noted by M.H. Goodwin (1990, p. 100), instruction such as this establishes an asymmetrical relationship among participants, with the child in teacher role projecting the right to give her students information (by reading to them), pose known-answer questions to them, and evaluate their responses, in these ways projecting herself as a knowing participant (K+), while projecting her peers as less knowing (K-).

Notably, Nico does not ratify the epistemic hierarchy projected by Luna. In line 6, he insists that *he*, rather than the kitties, go to the school, answering "Yo voy a la escuela", giving a more confident, elaborated response than the girls did and defying teacher Luna's projection of greater knowledge. This is not the text-based answer that Luna was seeking. In the same turn, he also derails her communicative project of reading and asking comprehension-check questions about her book, by initiating a new project of reclaiming the seat the two girls are now occupying ("Somebody else en mi spot"). The term "spot" in the classroom's everyday practice is used to refer to the designated

spot on the rug where each child sits to participate in whole group Circle activities (e.g., group read-alouds by the teacher). Although the two girls are occupying the *chair* across from Luna that Nico had formerly occupied, rather than a spot on the rug, it is notable that Nico invokes this genre of school to reclaim his space and oppose Luna's projection of greater knowledge. He still wants to participate in reading, but perhaps not *her* reading.

Finally, after further complaints from Nico about the loss of his seat (line 8), the girls leave the literacy area (line 9). Luna calls after them to no avail (line 10). Nico complains about his seat being taken once more (line 11), and Luna directs him to sit down in the now freed-up chair (line 12). The episode continues in Excerpt 2.

Excerpt 2

1	Nico	Let's say everybody deir letters! ((Getting book from basket))
2	Nico	Letters de places. one-two-three-four. ((Nico sits in chair and starts to read out from the book in staccato as George arrives on scene and sits in chair w/Nico))
		Letters about places. one-two-three-four.
3	Luna	[Quién (.5) va a la escuela.] Quién va- Who go to the school?
		Who- go to the school? Who go-
4	Nico	[==One-two-three-four.] Cross the floor. ((staccato, holding book as if reading from it))
5	Geor	We're already in school. Look-it. This is our school.

In line 1 of Excerpt 2, possibly to derail the communicative project of Luna reading to him, a next action which his sitting down across from her would have projected, instead of actually sitting down, he walks over to the book basket, grabs his own book from it and announces in line 1, "Let's say everybody their letters!". As he does finally sit down in the chair, he starts to read out loud from that book, "Letters de places. one-two-three-four" (line 2). He uses a distinctive staccato rhythm, which Cook-Gumperz and Gumperz (1978) refer to as *reading voice*. At the same time, a new boy, George, enters the literacy area and sits down in the chair next to Nico. It is notable that even though Luna had been instructing and questioning Nico and the two girls about her book in Spanish, and earlier in the episode, Nico had read a book to Luna in Spanish, he has now shifted to English for reading his book out loud. This code-switch may go toward creating an oppositional move to Luna's in the previous turn (Cromdal & Aronsson, 2000) and derailing the communicative project of Luna reading to *him*.

Seeing that she has lost control of the reading, that an English-dominant boy, George, is now in the literacy corner with Nico, and that Nico is reading out loud in English, in line 3, Luna attempts to reinstate her previous project of reading aloud to Nico by initiating another I-R-E sequence, testing Nico's comprehension of her book. She starts off in Spanish, but in light of the now English-language medium of the reading activity in the literacy corner, in line 3, she shifts to English mid-utterance for her I-R-E initiation, "Quién (.5) va a la escuela. Quién va- Who go to the school?" I-R-E initiations, as stated earlier, depict the speaker as knowing and the addressee(s) as less knowing.

Nico and George resist Luna's I-R-E initiation, which, if ratified, would position her as having the right to question their knowledge of something; this would project their knowledge states as less knowing (K-) relative to hers (Heritage & Raymond, 2005; Goodwin, 1990). Nico is not even listening to Luna; he starts reading from his own book in overlap with Luna's I-R-E initiation (line 4). George, for his part, refuses to provide an answer consistent with the story-line of the book Luna is reading from. Similar to what Nico had answered in Excerpt 1, George answers that the children themselves, rather than the protagonist of Luna's book, which is a cat, goes to school. He says, "we're already in school" (line 5). From then on, although the episode continues for several turns, the boys continue to resist Luna's efforts to read aloud to them.

Although Luna has made several attempts—using I-R-E initiations, corrections, reading voice, and a code-switch to English—she has not been successful in getting Nico and George to orient to her project of reading the book aloud about the cat going to school. The boys orient instead to their own book-reading activity. Nico has used several strategies—refusals to provide "correct", text-based responses to Luna's I-R-E questions, reading voice, and a code-switch to English (line 1 of Excerpt 2)—as well as complaints about the girls sitting in his chair (Excerpt 1)—to derail Luna's communicative project (Goodwin & Cekaite, 2018; Linell, 1998) of controlling the reading and reading aloud to him.

Conclusions

These excerpts of talk in the literacy corner illustrate how children draw on diverse social voices and genres—teacher talk in the form of I-R-E comprehension checks and evaluations of responses to them, as well as reading voice—to either assert epistemic authority and depict themselves as knowing (Luna), or to resist their peers' attempts at depicting *them* as less knowing (Nico). They also use shifts in social voices and named languages to align or not align with their peers' reading projects. Nico read to Luna before Excerpt 1 began, but when she tried to read to *him* in Excerpt 1, attempts to get his seat back to read to *her*, then uses reading voice to frame a reading project distinct from Luna's in Excerpt 2. He also uses shifts to English. Luna used a directive,

reading voice and an I-R-E-initiation to frame a reading project of her own in Excerpt 1, but when she couldn't get Nico and George to align as her students by Excerpt 2, shifted to English to frame her I-R-E questions. The different social voices the children use are "semiotic assemblages" of diverse multimodal resources (Pennycook, 2024). These include prosody, embodiment, (e.g., the arrangement of their bodies sitting across from one another that the literacy corner affords; holding the book up and faced out to the child being read to, or looking down at the book in their laps and turning the pages), gestures (Luna's leaning forward in Excerpt 1), and resources from different named languages. Children artfully and fluidly make use of all of the diverse multimodal resources at their disposal (Li, 2018) to shift moment-to-moment into reading voice and teacher talk and construct knowing (K+) identities for themselves as readers and teachers.

Centers time in the preschool is a time when children fluidly move in and out of the literacy corner, and to command control of the interaction, children can draw on a range of resources for managing *participation*, that is, how they become aligned to their talk and one another in the interaction (Goodwin & Goodwin, 2004). Children can draw on genres of teacher talk—reading, instructing, posing comprehension questions to peers and evaluating their responses—as means of constructing themselves as knowing participants (K+), while constructing their peers as less knowing (K-) (C. Goodwin, 1981; M.H. Goodwin, 1990).

Children's natural heteroglossia and social positioning work with peers in classrooms, as seen in these examples of children's pretend play, can be incorporated in classroom literacy activities and leveraged to provide a building block for children's reading and writing development in schools (Dyson, 2005; Johnson, 2017; Kyratzis, 2017). Children learn a great deal about what reading is, including its embodied aspects, from such play. By turning the pages of a book while orally dictating story content and using reading voice, they learn that reading involves tracking and decoding the written symbols on the pages and coordinating the sequential progression of the orally dictated story with the progression of the symbols, even before they can actually carry out the decoding of the symbols. They also learn how to pose and answer I-R-E questions assessing one another's comprehension of story text. When children are given space to read aloud to one another, they read, not because they have to learn a skill important for school, but in the course of pursuing fun, meaningful activities with peers and participating in the peer social life of the classroom. This kind of "third space" activity, where school discourse meets peer discourse, enables children to experience feelings of competence in the classroom and can be transformative of their learning of emergent literacy skills (Gutiérrez et al., 1999).

Children's heteroglossia has another implication. Through choosing to emulate particular roles and enacting them in particular ways, children's pretend play reflects power relations in the larger social world (Minks, 2013). Children

also have potential to influence these indexical associations. Through associating authoritative discourses of school like reading, instructing, posing comprehension-check questions and evaluating peers' responses to them with Spanish, as Nico and Luna did when they were reading together before Example 1 began, and as Luna continues to do up to the point where she is outnumbered by the boys in Excerpt 2, the children maintain positive identities for speakers of minoritized languages like their heritage language, Spanish, (Paugh, 2005, p. 79; Evaldsson & Kyratzis, 2025; Kyratzis, 2018; Mortimer, 2016). Through the inclusion of Spanish and bilingual teacher-led read-alouds as part of the curriculum in this bilingual classroom, Spanish remains a relevant resource for children to draw upon for managing participation during peer book-reading.

As the work of Ann-Carita has shown us, excerpts like these illustrate how children create their own social worlds. They do so through drawing on diverse cultural resources—here, reading and teacher voicing and heteroglossia—as affordances for participation, learning a great deal about literacy and language in the process.

Appendix: Transcription conventions

:	: prolonged syllable
[ ]	: demarcates overlapping utterances
(.)	: micropause, i.e. shorter than (0.5)
(2s)	: pause length in seconds
(word)	: unclear utterance
(x)	: undecipherable syllable
((gaze))	: transcriber's commentary
=	: latching between utterances
↑	: heightened pitch
↓	: lowered pitch
(h)	: laughter token
?	: rising intonation
.	: falling terminal intonation
,	: continuing intonation
°word	: pronounced quietly
WORD	: all caps indicates loud speech
_	: underscore indicates stressed syllable
English	: translation into English from Spanish, in the second line

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Animating stories: Multimodal and heteroglossic participation in a Heritage Language classroom

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Introduction

Ann-Carita Evaldsson's research has significantly advanced our understanding of children's language practices as dynamic and socially situated sites of meaning-making, identity formation, and socialization (Cekaite & Evaldsson, 2019; Evaldsson & Cekaite, 2010; Kyratzis, Reynolds, & Evaldsson, 2010). Drawing on Ethnomethodology Conversation Analysis (Filipi & Markee, 2018) and multimodal interaction analysis (Goodwin & Cekaite, 2018), her work examines how children participate in and make sense of everyday interactions, language use, and identity formation within diverse settings, primarily schools and preschools in Sweden (see Burdelski & Evaldsson, 2019; Evaldsson & Cekaite, 2010). Furthermore, a multimodal interaction approach allows her to focus on how affect and emotions as situated practices configured through linguistic, embodied, and material resources (cf. Evaldsson & Melander Bowden, 2024). In these contexts, language is not simply a medium of communication but also a resource for positioning, alignment, and moral reasoning.

A central contribution of Evaldsson's scholarship is her recognition of storytelling and play as dialogic and affectively charged activity where children exercise creativity, stance-taking and agency (Burdelski & Evaldsson, 2019; Cekaite & Evaldsson, 2019; Evaldsson & Cekaite, 2010; Evaldsson & Abreu Fernandes, 2019). Her analysis draws attention to the ways in which participants mobilize a range of multimodal and multilingual resources (e.g. gesture, gaze, prosody and code-switching) to engage with both peers and the teacher. These resources allow children to position themselves in relation to institutional norms and peer cultures. Through such practice, children are not passive recipients of socialization but are active agents (Cekaite & Evaldsson, 2019). They engage in "interpretive reproduction" (Corsaro, 1992), appropriating communicative and cultural resources from the adult world while taking various stances -- including playfully transforming or actively resisting these resources (Kyratzis, Reynolds & Evaldsson, 2010).

In multilingual peer groups, such practices often involve playful heteroglossic engagement, where children draw on and differentiate among multiple codes and registers – a practice that allows them to explore and play with

language forms and their social meanings. For instance, Cekaite and Evaldsson (2017) show how young Swedish-Kurdish immigrant children engage in multilingual play with peers where they creatively experiment with features of the heritage language. In another study, Burdelski and Evaldsson (2019), in their editorial introduction to the special issue of research on children and social interaction, highlight how young children's tellings across a variety of languages, settings, and societies constitute a ubiquitous mode of interaction. The special issue addresses young children's telling is a crucial area for interaction research as its collaborative, multimodal nature and call for further research using Conversation Analysis to better understand the interactional dynamics of children's telling. Similarly, in a video-ethnographic study on Russian–Swedish bilingual storytelling, Evaldsson and Abreu Fernandes (2019) illustrate how a young child's spontaneous embodied performances and shifts in footing allow her to animate characters, align with story events, and reconfigure participation frameworks. Together, these studies support the view of children as creative social actors who participate in storytelling not just linguistically, but also interactionally and emotionally.

Data and analysis

Inspired by Evaldsson's research on children's social participation with peers and adults in institutional settings, this short paper explores how a teacher's multimodal storytelling practices support young Chinese—Swedish bilingual children's creative engagement and heritage language learning in a private classroom setting. The study focuses on two interrelated aspects of Evaldsson's work:

1) The central role of storytelling and multimodal practices in children's meaning-making, and
2) The importance of positioning children as creative agents who actively shape storytelling through embodied stance, shifts in footing, and multilingual resources.

In addition, the analysis draws on Bakhtin's (1981) concept of heteroglossia, as taken up in Evaldsson's work (Evaldsson & Cekaite, 2019; Kyratzis, Reynolds, & Evaldsson, 2010; Xu & Evaldsson, 2025), to explore how multiple social voices, language ideologies, and moral positions are negotiated within classroom storytelling. By examining how the teacher initiates the story, responds to children's contribution, and how the children draw on embodied resources, code-switching and stance-taking to participate in the telling, this short paper will show the layered, socially situated nature of heritage language learning. These practices reflect the children's engagement with diverse social worlds, and their ability to draw from those worlds to shape interaction in the classroom.

All seven young children (3-5 years old) in the selected excerpts are of Chinese heritage and are born in Sweden. Notably, children's heritage language is varied significantly based on their family language policy and practices, while they are all expected to maintain and develop proficiency in Chinese as a heritage language.

The data comes from a weekly 90-min language session at a weekend language school, where children participate in various activities designed to foster Chinese language use. The selected excerpts are from a storytelling activity in which the teacher dramatizes a conflict from a picture book called *Pip and Posy and the Super Scooter.* In the story, Posy takes Pip's scooter without asking. The pedagogical theme of the class is "emotions" with the aim of supporting children to express emotional states in Chinese.

In the first excerpt (*Excerpt 1. Pip is angry*), the teacher introduces the background of the story (line 1), establishing an interactive participation framework (Goodwin, 2007) through her embodied and spatial orientation. It invites the children into the storytelling space as active participants and engage in the heritage language learning. As the teacher narrates Posy's behaviour, she outstretches her left arm with spread fingers (see *fig.grab*) and then closes it into a fist while withdrawing her arm (line 2). These coherent moves animate Posy's action of grab and inviting embodied attention to Posy's action. The teacher's gestures not only visualize the story but function as multimodal resources that shape the participation framework, directing children's affective and moral orientation to the story.

Excerpt 1. Pip is angry

01 Teacher Posy #$ta meiyou wen Pip ↓shuo $kebu keyi jie wo?
Posy #$he did not ask Pip ↓saying. can (you) lend it to me?
$left hand reaching further with fingers spread open
#fig. grab



fig. grab

02 Teacher $ta MASHANG jiu ba huabanche na zou le.
$he RIGHT AWAY took the scooter
$closes fingers into a fist and draws back the left arm

03 Teacher $na zou yihou, ta kaishi ↑zenmeyang?
$after taking it, ↑what did he start to do?
$points to the page

04 Zoe $sheng qi
$angry

05 Theo $crosses both arms over chest
#fig.angry



fig.angry

06 Teacher $> ta na-< dui. shei shengqi le?
$> ta took-< yes. who is angry?
$left hand points at the page

Following this embodied enactment, the teacher invites the children to engage with an open-ended question that allows children to interpretate (line 3). Zoe responds immediately in the heritage language (line 4), verbally capturing the character's emotional state. At the same time, Theo performs a bodily stance of alignment—crossing his arms over his chest and pouting (see *fig. angry*). While Zoe provides the linguistic formulation, Theo contributes through embodied performance. Together, they position themselves affectively within the unfolding narrative event (Evaldsson & Cekaite, 2010). Even though Zoe's and Theo's answers do not directly answer Teacher's question, they accurately describe Pip's emotional state, achieving the pedagogical goal of the classroom activity.

As shown, children's participation is both agentive and socially meaningful, reflecting their understanding of the story and moral stance towards this conflict. The teacher then confirms children's contribution and continues to extend this affective framing in line 6. Taken together, this excerpt shows how the teacher creates spaces for children to take up stances that are emotional, linguistic, and moral at once in the multimodal storytelling activity. Children's

participation here aligns with Evaldsson's insight that children are not passive learners; they are agentive and affectively engaged participants who participate in morally meaningful ways within a shared interactional space.

The following excerpt (*Excerpt 2. You have to ask first*) picks up from the affective-moral frame established in the previous interaction. I will now focus on how another child, Ellen, further contributes to the narrative by affectively aligning and expanding the moral discourse to display her interpretive and moral agency (line 8).

Excerpt 2. You have to ask first

07 Teacher $Pip shengqi le. $weishenme ta shengqi?
$Pip is angry. $why is he angry?
$left hand holding the book and left hand point the book
$right hand resting on her waist

08 Ellen **MAN +måsta fråga först**
YOU +have to ask first
+Teacher gaze to Ellen

09 Teacher $henhao #$Ellen
$very good #$Ellen
$left hand pointing to Ellen--#$thumb up
#fig. thumbs up



fig. thumbs up

10 Teacher $yinwei $Posy meiyou wen Pip
$because $Posy didn't ask Pip
$left hand point at the book $twist the lips

11 Teacher $Posy yinggai yao xian wen Pip
$Posy should have asked Pip first
$spread the left hand

12 Teacher >**Man måsta fråga först**<
>you have to ask first<

13 Teacher $ta jiu meiyou wen, jiu qizoule
$she didn't ask and rode away
$right hand point the picture in the book

14 Teacher $↓humm Posy hen shengqi
$↓humm Posy is angry
$ hands on her hips and **pout**
#fig. pout


fig.pout

In response to the teacher's follow-up question (line 7), Ellen, who has limited proficiency in Chinese uses an assertive intonation to explain in Swedish *"Man måste fråga först"* ("You have to ask first") (line 8). Ellen's code-switching into Swedish here shifts footing (cf. Goffman, 1981) that reconfigures the participation framework. Her utterance moves from story interpretation to moral evaluation which is likely internalized from outside the classroom. Despite breaking the classroom's implicit monolingual norm (cf. Jaspers, 2024), Ellen receives both verbal and embodied positive feedback from the teacher (line 9). Affirming Ellen's response, the teacher revoices the moral claim in Chinese in line 10 and 11, transforming Ellen's Swedish contribution into a heritage language learning opportunity. This scaffolding reflects the teacher's orientation to a translanguaging space (Li, 2011), where children's full linguistic repertoires are treated as pedagogical assets and resources.

The moral stance "You have to ask first" is repeated in Swedish (line 12) by the teacher who then also reformulates in Chinese (line 13). This repetition and revoicing are commonly used in classroom by children and teachers to enhance children's classroom participation and sustain their engagement (cf. Cekaite & Evaldsson, 2017). In line 14, the teacher once again revoices Zoe's and Theo's affective stance from Excerpt 1 with embodied cues (see *fig. pout*). Through this dialogical recycling, the moral stance moves from an individual child's response to a collectively shared evaluative stance. This pedagogical strategy sustains engagement and supports language development through repetition, reinforcement, and alignment.

This second excerpt illustrates how heteroglossic participation formed by diverse voices, languages and norms could be used as interactional resources for collaborative meaning-making. The teacher plays an active and responsive role in shaping the storytelling interaction and fostering children's participation. She builds on Ellen's code-switching through embodied cues, multilingual revoicing, and repetition. The teacher recontextualizes it as an heteroglossic contribution and transform it into a morally and linguistically rich moment to the whole class. Together with Zoe's and Theo's affective stance in the first excerpt, Ellen's moral claim in the second excerpt shows how children are positioned and position themselves not just as learners but also socially situated agents who shape the trajectory of classroom storytelling.

Concluding discussion

These two excerpts have illustrated how young multilingual children and their teacher co-construct storytelling as a space for emotional, moral and linguistic engagement. Through embodied resources, stance-taking, code-switching, and revoicing, the children engage with the narrative in ways that are emotionally attached, linguistically creative, and socially meaningful. The teacher's multimodal scaffolding and flexible response to children's

contributions foster an interactive participation framework (Goodwin, 2007) where both affective alignment and moral reasoning are collaboratively negotiated.

These moments align closely with Evaldsson's findings on the narrative and multimodal practices in children's interactional learning, and on the importance of recognizing children as creative and agentive participants who actively shape meaning through embodied stance, shifts in footings, and language use. As shown in the analysis, storytelling emerges as a dialogic space where young learners co-construct emotional understandings, cultural knowledge and social norms within and across languages. This short study affirms Evaldsson's enduring insight that children's everyday interactions are rich sites of cultural production, social negotiation, and linguistic development. Hopefully the analysis will contribute to Evaldsson's legacy by showing how young multilingual children creatively shape the moral and linguistic trajectories of classroom narratives.

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Stylizations and classroom performance: Taboos, staging and the co-creation of jokes

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Introduction

In institutional contexts, e.g. secondary schools, 'having a laff' (Willis, 1981) is an important way of passing time, and of positioning and repositioning oneself in relation to classmates and teachers. This often involves multiparty participation by two or more dueling parties and one or more onlookers. Multiparty performances, as parts of play fighting, teasing and verbal duels are recurring features of peer group interaction in school and school-yard contexts (Evaldsson, 2005; Evaldsson & Cekaite, 2010; Jonsson, 2018; cf. Goodwin & Kyratzis, 2012).

This chapter presents sequential analyses of joking in an upper secondary school setting, as a part of conversations during classroom time. It draws on a collection of episodes of classroom joking, audio recorded during peer group conversations, as parts of an ethnography of classroom interaction in a vocational school. Detailed analyses reveal a number of ways in which the participants—male students during group work—engaged in joking in relation to partly tabooed areas (stereotyping sexuality target languages and ethnicity), and more specifically how they enacted voices of other parties (present or absent) as parts of mutual entertainment.

Voicing the Other can be understood as a form of *stylization*, that is a performance in which the speaker adopts a recognizable voice (Coupland, 2007) or put differently, where the speaker presents "an artistic image of another's language" (Bakhtin, 1981, p. 362). Stylizations enable speakers to engage with "stereotyped personas and genres" and "well-known identity repertoires" (Coupland, 2007, p. 154). Ben Rampton (2009, p. 149) characterizes stylizations as interactional moments where participants produce "specially marked and often exaggerated representations of languages, dialects and styles that fall outside their usual repertoire (at least as perceived in the given context)."

Stylizations can be seen as parts of an actor's repertoire for *accentuating* changing stances in a drama (Stanislavskij, 1997), or as ways of *animating* talk (Aronsson & Ågren, 2022; Goffman, 1978). Some prior work on the micro dramas of everyday life includes analyses of such exaggerated or parodic imitations of another speaker's style (Evaldsson & Cekaite, 2010; Evaldsson & Svahn, 2017; Jonsson, 2018; Wiksten, Jonsson & Franzén, 2025; Åhlund & Aronsson, 2015). Code switching between two languages can be deployed

as another way of animating talk (Cromdal & Aronsson, 2000; Evaldsson & Cekaite, 2010; Xu & Evaldsson, 2025; Åhlund & Aronsson, 2015). Overall, the analyses of this chapter concern dramaturgical aspects of *staging* jokes, through linked actions: such as first jokes—second jokes; laughter—more laughter; laughter—unlaughter (Billig, 2005). In line with work on dramaturgical aspects of everyday life (cf., Goffman, 1959, 1971), target episodes have been analyzed in terms of how participants jointly co-create micro dramas and humor in social life in their ways of talking back—as in their 'pisstaking' (Lund & Lundström, 2021)—and in other ways of talking to each other and about each other. A related dramaturgical aspect is participants' ways of *staging* dramas (Evaldsson, 2005; Evaldsson & Svahn, 2017).

In our contribution, stylization is deployed as a concept to explore how participants speak in the voices of others, in ways that create animated performances, particularly when stylizations contain entertainment and humor. The humor embedded in such stylizations relies on the recognizability of the voices being imitated. Nik Coupland (2007) emphasizes the importance of an audience in stylizations—whether present or imagined—in shaping the meaning of what is spoken. Humor in stylized performances often disrupts conventional discursive norms, where the stylized voices or stereotypes articulated within these playful contexts may gain legitimacy due to the ludic nature of the interaction.

More specifically, stylizations are analyzed as components of joking practices. The analyses document the participants' methods for relating to cultural stereotypes through their joking—foregrounding what is laughable and what is not laughable—and their ways of building jokes and affective stances, aligning or dis-aligning with co-participants. Drawing on tabooed areas of language, such as swearing, is one way of aligning with peers (Jonsson, 2018). In line with Boxer and Cortés-Conde (1997), we would expect mock duels and playful bantering to involve elements of both bonding and biting.

Our focus is thus on the local packaging and unpackaging (Jefferson, 1985) of jokes and how this is in turn related to changing affects and alliances. But, neither laughter, nor smiling, giggling or second jokes are to be seen as solid proofs of whether something is to be seen as laughable. And—whether joking is to be seen as biting or bonding—is also to be discussed as constituent parts of everyday interaction.

Data and method

In line with the seminal work of Gail Jefferson (1985), our method is oriented to social interactional aspects of the packaging of jokes. Joking practices are analyzed *in situ*, and more specifically as part of joking practices between classmates in an upper secondary school context.

The data are taken from a classroom ethnography of social interaction between students and between students and their teacher, drawing on audio

recordings and fieldnotes from three upper secondary school programs (for more information on the fieldwork, see Jonsson, 2018). The analyses draw on classroom talk between peers, in this case male students (aged 16-17) during their first year of a vocational program, a Building and Construction Program. The present conversations took place in a small group format during one classroom period, a language lesson as part of a classroom task, where students responded to classroom material on 'foul language and swear words'. Their task was to read and respond to a collection of articles about multilingual complexity and hybridity in relation to "foul language", featuring material by the comedian and linguist Fredrik Lindström (2000) on Swedish as "baddest language" and on Rinkeby Swedish, a contemporary urban vernacular that invokes ethnic otherness in urban Stockholm contexts (Jonsson, 2018; Jonsson, Franzén & Milani, 2020; Milani & Jonsson, 2012).

In this paper, our analyses focus on dramaturgical aspects of everyday interaction in multiparty settings, analyzing affiliative and disaffiliative moves between two or more participants (Goffman, 1959; 1971; 1978; cf. Åhlund & Aronsson, 2015; Xu & Evaldsson, 2025). The transcripts primarily feature three co-participants (Gorgis, Mohamed[4], Christian) seated around a number of small tables, forming a group, with other classmates seated nearby. Apart from Swedish, Gorgis speaks Syrian, Mohamed speaks Urdu, and Christian speaks Spanish. The recordings started when Rickard (first author) just had seated himself, next to Gorgis and Mohamed, placing his record player on one of their desks. It can be noted that this conversation primarily unfolded between Gorgis and Mohamed.

Code switching is marked through italics when students move from Swedish to another language. Deviations from Rinkeby Swedish are marked, but talk in Rinkeby Swedish *is not* marked, as it was the students' regular (unmarked) way of speaking (cf. Appendix A Transcription Conventions).

Mobilizing and staging a dramatic persona

Impersonating a film star

Our transcripts of classroom talk illuminate how the classroom can be deployed as a location for staging a dramatic persona. In line with prior work on classroom joking, pupils tend to co-construe both the joking as such and their responses to joking (Tholander & Aronsson, 2002). During the selected classroom period of the episode of this paper, Gorgi reveals that it is his wish to be a film star.

[4] Muhammad, also spelled Muhammed, Muhamad, Mohammed, Mahammad, Maxammed, Mehemmed, Mohamad or Mohamed (deployed in this paper) is an Arabic given male name meaning 'praiseworthy'. It is one of the most popular names in the world, by 2014, it was estimated to have been given to 150 million men and boys. (Wikipedia, Dec. 2025).

Ex. 1a

1	Gorgis:	Hey I wanna be a film star jao (.) hehe
2	Christian:	Okay where are we? (*referring to classroom task*)
3	Gorgis:	You know what an awesome film star I would be: man?
4	Rickard:	What did'ya say?
5	Gorgis:	film star
6	Christian:	in soccer (.) you'd be filming in football? hehehe
7	Gorgis:	Nope a filmstar for real
8	Christian:	There we go (*browsing through the text*)
9	Mohamed:	*Abo*
10	Gorgis:	YOU A:RE SUCH A BORE MAN! hehehe::: no hold
11		on filmstar I think so bro (.) yeah actor (.)
12		look I would have been AWESOME!

The classroom task is to discuss language use, but Gorgis introduces a presentation of a private dream (bragging about becoming a filmstar). Twice during this initial phase, Gorgis introduces this dream, or his plan for becoming a "filmstar", as in 'Hey I wanna be a film star jao (.) hehe ' (line 1).[5] On both occasions, Christian immediately (ensuing turn) tries to re-direct him—and the group—to the classroom task at hand. First, Christian tries to steer back their discussion from future glamor to the classroom task (Okay where are we?', line 2). But Gorgis does not respond to Christian's attempt to get back to the assigned classroom topic, instead he upgrades his personal dream, replicating what an awesome (Sw: *grym*) filmstar he would become (line 3). Christian then responds with a teasing joke: "Would you be filming in football?" (line 6). This joke repositions the term "film star" in a negative context, suggesting someone who "films" in football—pretending to be fouled to gain an unfair advantage. In doing so, it transforms Gorgi's aspirations of becoming a successful film star into a joke about a cheater—someone with low status who is ultimately deplorable. Apparently, he delivers a somewhat disaffiliative joke, and Gorgi does not respond with laughter.

Moreover, he can be seen to spoil Gorgis' classroom performance, when adding "There we go", thereby returning to the text of the classroom task (line 8). Christian's somewhat resistant stance taking is commented on when Gorgis loudly exclaims "YOU A:RE SUCH A BORE MAN! hehehe:::!", rounding off his complaint with laughter (line 10). In any case, Christians fails to engage Gorgis in their classroom task, when Gorgis anew insists on talking

[5] The term 'jao' is a term for 'friend' or 'dude', emblematic for so called Rinkeby Swedish, including gender neutral bonding.

about his personal dream (of becoming an actor), adding that he would have done it brilliantly (lines 11-12).

Impersonating ethnic others

Gorgis continues to discuss his potential future as a successful film star. With the help of stylizations, he begins to compare his own ability to imitate voices with that of Mohamed and Christian, who apparently lack his talent.

Ex. 1b

```
13   Gorgis:    It would work for me sure? but for you? (point-
14              ing at M) no- (stylizing a nazal indian voice:)
15              "Kopitakolli (.) oh curry curry"(.) (.)you get
16              it? and he (points at C,and stylizes in a dark
17              voice) <"oh lu lu lu lu::"> hehe
18   Mohamed    Shut up and study you moron!
```

Gorgis proclaims that this (his plans of becoming a filmstar) might not be something for everyone, at least not for Mohamed or Christian (lines 13-17), and as part of this argumentation, he first enacts Mohamed with a stylized nazal, stereotypically Indian voice, and then demonstrating laughingly to the group that Christian is indeed ”oh lu lu lu lu lu::”.

During this episode, Gorgis apparently impersonates first Mohamed and then Christian, talking in hybrid versions of different types of multilingual speakers, that can be seen as parodies or caricatures of these two classmates. Georgakopoulou (2007, p. 132) notes that humor in stylizations often draws on the recognizability of the imitated voices. By stylizing the voices of others, participants are able to playfully engage with familiar stereotypes, to evoke laughter.

However, Mohamed reacts with unlaughter (Billig, 2005) to Gorgis stylizations, saying “Shut up and study you moron!” (line 18). Mohamed’s unlaughter does disciplinary work, oriented to get Gorgis to concentrate on the school task through not laughing at Gorgis’ stylized classroom performance. Tom, their teacher, seems to notice an upcoming conflict, intervening with a critical comment on their listening (or not listening) to classroom information.

Ex. 2a

```
1    Teacher    (speaking from other end of the classroom)
2    TOM:       Could you listen and talk at the same time?
3               That's a good capacity
4    Gorgis:    My mates they say that I've one brain here
5               (.) for listening (.) one brain he:re (.) for
6
```

7		chatting (.) one brain here (.) for persuading (.) and one brain here for chilling out!
8	Mohamed:	But in any case he's brain dead!
9	Gorgis,	[(*laughing softly*)
10	Rickard:	[(*laughing softly*)
11	Mohamed:	°totally brain dead°
12	Gorgis:	hehe $ and you're bro:wn (.)hehe pakistanian$
13		[hehehe
14	Mohamed:	[hehe
15	Christian	and you're yellow
16	Gorgis:	and you're white
17	Mohamed:	He can never shut up! Hehe

At this point, Tom, the teacher, apparently tries to call the students to order, asking somewhat ironically whether they are able to listen *and* talk at the same time. Gorgis then improvises, claiming jokingly that he in fact has several brains, one for listening, one for talking, one for persuasion and another one for relaxing (lines 4-7). Notably, one of his many brains is for persuasion (line 6). For Gorgis, persuasive, rhetorical or dramaturgical aspects of the brain(s) are as important for him as 'listening', 'talking' or 'relaxing', the role of his other brains. Mohamed then orients to Gorgis' boastful joking about his many "brains", casting Gorgis as a third person ("But in any case he is brain dead", line 8). Mohamed's joke can be seen as a second joke (in relation to Gorgis' joke about having several brains). When categorizing Gorgis as 'brain dead', Mohamed can be seen to engage in *disciplinary humor* (Billig, 2005; Franzén & Aronsson, 2013). In any case, the audience's laughing uptake in a chorus format (lines 9-10) can be seen as another validation of the joke as a 'laughable'. On another note, it can also be noted that—that Mohamed refers to Gorgis as 'he'—and not as a second person 'you'—when retorting jokingly that "But in any case he's brain dead". Thereby, he indirectly can be seen to underline Gorgis' role as performer.

Encouraged by their laughter, Mohamed upgrades his joke by claiming that Gorgis is "totally braindead" (*så hjärndöd*), but he packages his upgrading in a *sotto voce* delivery (line 11). Gorgis first laughs in response, and then switches to racist joking, he laughingly bites back as it were, calling Mohamed 'a brown Pakistani' which leads to mutual laughter between the two of them. Another classmate claims that Mohamed is yellow, but this is met by one more second joke from Gorgis, who retorts that the speaker is white (*vit*, line 16), pronouncing white in a manner that leaves no doubt about the inferiority of whiteness. In his uptake to Mohamed's joking about brain death, Gorgis thus engages in a number of jokes about color, addressing Mohamed as a brown paki etc, engaging in some kind of taboo humor (cf. Franzén, Jonsson & Sjöblom, 2021).

Jokes about ethnicity and race are potentially more sensitive (compared to the "brainy" jokes and stylizations above). However, in this episode, humor also does the work of bonding. Mohamed follows up on Gorgis's claim that he is brown with a giggle (line 14). Christian, who has been listening to the others for some time, now interjects that Mohamed is yellow (line 15), but Christian is immediately countered by Gorgis with a comment about his own whiteness (line 16). This jointly constructed humor on a taboo topic—where Gorgis, Christian and Mohamed seem able to joke about race without the local mood turning sour and while maintaining laughter—jointly forming friendly alliances around and across the classroom tables.

Mohamed is a third party in staging this teasing performance, but he anew assumes the role of Gorgis' sidekick, commenting about his (Gorgis') 'joking 'he can never shut up! hehe', line 17), again casting Gorgis as a third person ('he', not 'you'), positioning him as something of a 'star' as it were (who just cannot stop performing).

Taboo sex talk and the impersonation of ethnic others

A little later, during the same lesson, Gorgis switches to another laughable, to taboo sex (how Mohamed's grandma has carried out with his grandpa, lines 15-19, below).

Ex. 2b

18	Gorgis:	This one it's also like that (3.0) eh hey did
19		you find all that about your granny? Check
20		this out!
21	Mohamed:	you're a moron (.) hehe
22	Gorgis:	your granny- your granny (*reading*) just not
23		to imagine that your granny has fucked with
24		your granpa
25	Mohamed:	eh shut up (.) shut up (.) hehehe
26	Kille	"very good curry"! (*in stylized Indian Eng-*
27		*lish*)
28	Gorgis	HAHAHAHAHA
29	Mohamed:	Imagine your mum (.) your dad
30	Gorgis	"*OBLIGA OBLI*!"(*in stylized Indian English*)
31		hahaha
32	Mohamed:	your mum your dad

Gorgis starts out by enacting a concerned and helpful teacher, asking Mohamed whether he can locate the text about his grandparents. Mohamed protests ("du är en idiot" you're an idiot) but his protest is followed by laughter,

so his namecalling of Mohamed as 'idiot' is *bracketed* as it were (Goffman, 1974; 1981), produced as offside talk.

After this introduction, Gorgis initially reads out loud in a serious voice about "your grandma- your grandma", switching back to a collusive stance, asking Mohamed whether he has thought about the fact that his grandma and grandpa have fucked (lines 22-24). Mohamed responds "eh shut up- shut up (.) he he" and this leads to token appreciation in stylized Indian English, from another classmate, "very good curry". The classmate's stylization can be seen an uptake to a prior stylization on Gorgis' part (*"Kopitakolli (.) oh curry curry"*, Ex.1b). In any case, it generates appreciation in the form of loud laughter from Gorgis "HA HA HA HA HA" (line 28).

Mohamed then recycles Gorgis' grand-mother joke, turning it against Gorgis "Imagine your mum (.) your dad" (line 29. As a part of his overall classroom performance, Gorgis then shows off with some more stylized Indian English, playing along with his two classmates, rounding off his comments with laughter "ha ha ha". Doing the part of someone who is unperturbed, amused rather than offended by potentially offensive peer group jokes (Drew, 1987). Notably, Gorgis' "ha ha"-laughter (both here and previously), has a somewhat ironic quality. As in other duels in social interactional settings, "ha ha" is apparently deployed to index something of an ironic distance. In sum, we can see how taboo breaking can bring joint laughter, in the tabooed jokes about race (Excerpt 2a). In this example (2b), Gorgis picks up another highly tabooed theme for his jokes—talking about grandparents' sex lives. This topic continues as a spontaneous co-construed language lesson in the next excerpt:

Ex. 2c

33	Gorgis:	hehe bro imagine this (.)$ his granpa has put
34		his yarak in his granny's amcik so BA::H $
35		(*several co-participants laugh*)
36	Mohamed:	Hey- hey what's cock (Sw:*kuk*) or how do you
37		say cock?
38	Gorgis:	*Yarak*
39	Mohamed:	*Yarak*
40	Gorgis:	in Turkish
41	Mohamed:	Listen what's "arack" then?
42	Gorgis:	*"Arack?"*
43	Mohamed	Mhm
44	Gorgis:	*"Arack" does not exist (.) it's "amcik" (.)*
45		*yarak (.) then khota in Syrian*
46	Mohamed:	What's ass?
47	Gorgis:	*kıç*

48	Mohamed:	*kıç*
49	Gorgis	*kıço*
50	Mohamed:	kıço
51	Gorgis:	Mhm

In this part of their conversation, it can be noted that Gorgis first addresses Mohamed as 'bro' brother, that is, in a second person format (line 33). Yet, he swiftly switches to a third person format, staging a joke about how '*his'* (Mohamed's) grandpa and grandma are making out (lines 33-34). This 3-personizing of his classmate is one of many ways in which Gorgis is staging a joking *performance*, through orienting to—or co-creating a classroom audience—when building up a shared joke for the entire group (Mohamed as well as other classmates), and not only for Mohamed, who is thereby indirectly positioned as his sidekick, rather than as his primary or sole addressee.

As pointed out, the conversation primarily takes place between two students Gorgis and Mohamed. Yet, they recurrently refer to each other in the third person (e.g., Gorgis, on lines 33 and 34; see also Mohamed Ex 2a, line 14). Thereby, the two boys of this joking duel can be seen to orient to a broader audience, to classmates and other co-present parties. Once again, breaking a taboo—explicitly discussing Mohamed's grandparents' sex life—generates a lot of laughter (cf. Franzén, Jonsson & Sjöblom, 2021). Gorgis uses a playful tone when making his point, which is followed by loud laughter from overhearing classmates (line 35).

However, at this point in the conversation, Mohamed who does not speak Turkish is trying to capture more precisely what Gorgis is saying and asks for how to refer to intimate body parts in Turkish. At this point, the conversation gradually turns into a language lesson on intimate body parts, a type of word search that is normally not part of official classroom talk. Notably though, in this specific case, it is a conversation that is quite in line with the classroom task. But it actually expands its focus on language to a multilingual context.

Impersonating a rapper, a gangster rap and Gorgis' stage aspirations

Until now, Gorgis has invoked his future as a filmstar and the speaker of many language varieties (Ex.1) and how he can outperform his classmates, since he "has several brains" (Ex.2). He then moves on to perform as a rapper.

Ex. 3a

1	Mohamed:	(*reading out loud*) "the word cock could mean
2		(.)rooster or cukoo (.) how come"(3.0) as I
3		said page-
4	Gorgis:	"Rooster or cu::ckoo fucking you e::h! Moth-
5		erfucker! This is cupas and blö:t (.)gunshots
6		dö: and hu:rt (.) and (*five click sounds,*

```
7                 mimicking pistol shots) kallen i din bal-
8                 lens(.) puts up a mag there (.)" (rapping)
9
10  Mohamed:      (reading) the word cunt xxx
11  Gorgis:       bullet proof vest and a bmw rolling by: (.)
12                fattest BMW-we-w: e::h hehe jalla (.) I swear
13                I could become a rapper too jao! (.) bro (.)
14                man! (.)M-M-M- Mohamed (.) Mohamed [hehehe
15
16  Mohamed:      [hehehe
17  TOM:          (approaching)
18  Gorgis:       (quickly shifting to classroom task) Body
19                parts
20  TOM:          Then you read this!
21  Gorgis:       Yes
22  TOM:          and then you read (3.0) this
```

On lines 1-2, Mohamed is orienting to a classroom register, of reading aloud in the mode of a well-adjusted student. But through switching to another mode, speaking in a staccato rhythm, and rhyming through hybrid language forms ("cupas and *blö:t*," "*dö* and hurt"), lines 5-6; inserting random Swedish words or word forms into raps in English. In his lyrics, Gorgis moves into another register, a rap register (lines 4-9, playing with language, and inserting words ("*blöt*" and "*dö"*) that seem to have no literal meaning beyond serving the purpose of completing the rhyme in the rap lyrics, while other words refer to a gangster life (gunshot, mag [magazine of pistol]), mimicking pistol shots).

Gorgis' rap lyrics are informed by Rinkeby Swedish and local youth language registers. For instance, Gorgis addresses Mohamed as '*bror*' (bro) or '*mannen*' (a personal address form, in the form of a loan word from 'man'; here literally 'the man', that is in a definitive form)[6].

This episode draws on a number of register shifts, between rap registers (lines 4-9 ,11-14) and classroom registers (like reading aloud, lines 1-3, 10, 18) and between a monolingual register (here: teacher) and multilingual registers (Gorgis).

A rap register is also invoked in the next extract when Gorgis calls out 'Slim Shady', the name of Eminem Slim Shady, a well-known rap artist.

[6] In Swedish spoken language, the gender of nouns is a complicated affair, where male, female and neuter forms and endings cannot be explained in terms of any simple rules. For instance, the definite form of Swedish words for words like 'bottom' (arse, fart) can be accomplished through various endings: -en, -n, -t ; as in *röv-en, rumpa-n, ända-n, stjärt-en, arsle-t, bak-en, prutt-en* (cf. classroom tasks, drawing on the linguist and entertainer Lindström, 2012)

Ex.3b

24	Gorgis:	Okay (.) *slim shady* (.) *Eminem Slim Shady*
25		(rap artist)!
26	Tom:	Ten minutes
27	Gorgis	*Shit ten minutes remaining* till *the time* (.)
28		M::M::M::
29	Mohamed:	Do we finish by two o'clock?
30	Gorgis:	(*producing an outstretched sucking sound*)
31		hehe asså bror $ you know, I can become it
32		ALL JAO (.)I can become a RAPPER (.) I can
33		become a beatboxer (.) I can become e:h film-
34		star (.) e::h $
35	Mohamed:	(xxx *brief interlude with another student*)
36	Gorgis:	(*shifting to a loud opera mode in mock Span-*
37		*ish*) LA LA LA (.) POR QUE:::: MA:RIA:::::
38		hahahaha (.) haha (*sings opera*) ESTA NO-
39		CHE::::
40	Mohamed:	Shut up!
41	Gorgis:	Di da di da di da:: (*singing*)
42	Mohamed	$Just imagine a whole day with him at work!$
43		hehe

Gorgis calls out the name of Eminem Slim Shady as if embarking on a novel performance (line 24). But Tom then calls the classroom into order, reminding the group that there are just ten minutes left of class time. Gorgis hearably orients to Tom's directive, switching into English and integrating this call for time into his lyric performance "Shit ten minutes remaining *till* the time (.) M::M::M::" (line 27).

This brief lyric involves a creative mix of registers. Gorgis switches from classroom Swedish to English, starting out with a mild swear word 'shit' before repeating the time limit 'ten minutes' confirming that he is indeed on board, well aware that time is soon out. But he then wraps up his confirmation with a lyrical fragment, in the form of a rhythmically repeated "M::M::M::" (line 28)[7] and moves into an opera aria register, showing his skills, not only as a rapper, but also as an opera singer to be. Moreover, he happily calls out that he could become "EVERYTHING JAO!" ("rapper, beat boxer, film star", lines 30-34). However, Mohamed tries to move him back to classroom order. But he still speaks about Gorgis with some awe, complaining laughingly: "Just imagine a whole day with him at work! hehe" (line 42) At this point, as on other occasions, what might be seen as a critical *or* biting comment (Boxer & Cortés-Conde, 1997) has to be understood in its sequential location. The very

[7]On another note, Gorgis can here be seen to make sounds of speeding things up, stylizing or mimicking a racing engine as it were ("M::M::M::").

same comment could be a way of voicing admiration *or* criticism (as in the ambiguity of *disciplinary humor* (cf., Billig, 2005; Franzén & Aronsson, 2015; Franzén & Jonsson, 2024).

Concluding discussion

In line with Georgakopoulou (2007), we have demonstrated how stylizations are used for entertainment and how they recurrently contain humor. Gorgis deploys stylizations to simultaneously envision and embody various desirable roles that he believes he can achieve. He presents himself as a film star, a successful rapper, or as an opera singer. Thus, while a stylization is often examined as a way to adopt another voice in interaction, we have seen how Gorgis uses it to highlight potential prestigious positions that he (either jokingly or perhaps seriously) aspires to, suggesting his potential success in various artistic professions. Thus, Gorgis' stylizations of different voices serve as explorations and demonstrations of his skills, related to various possible future identities for himself, ranging from a successful actor to a rapper. While making these indirect and direct claims about a successful future career—his jocular auditions of public roles—he incorporates humor and laughter, embracing the role of entertaining his peers. Through his joking mode, his aspirations are left open to interpretation—whether they are genuinely serious or merely playful. At the same time, there is recurring teasing banter in the interaction, as when Gorgis boasts about his many talents, while Mohamed, in particular, objects and brings him down to earth, calling him 'an idiot' and 'brain dead', and jokingly suggesting that Gorgis' only chance of becoming a film star would be as someone "filming", e.g. by acting as a cheater in soccer.

Gorgis himself creates an atmosphere of entertainment through his laughing performances and joking boastfulness about glamorous future roles. In line with our dramaturgical analyses, Mohamed can also be seen as part of the staging of Gorgis' performances. First, Mohamed recurrently acts as something of a side-kick in that he plays along with or laughs at Gorgis' jokes. Moreover, he comments on them as something laughable, as when he talks to the audience (classmates and researcher) about Gorgis and his skills. And as a sidekick, he recurrently talks about Gorgis in the third person, putting him on stage as it were, rather than merely talking to him or with him. When acting as Gorgis' side-kick, he can be seen to be part of the staging of classroom entertainment. Along with classmates and other over-hearers, Mohamed is recurrently, not only part of Gorgis' audience, but also of the overall audience design of joking intermezzos in the classroom, providing cues about when to orient to classroom tasks and when to orient to (other) laughables.

Appendix A. Transcription key to our dramaturgical analyses

hehe	laughter particles (e.g.: hehe, haha, hoho)
<u>kolla</u>	emphatic talk (underlined)
ko:lla	after extended sound
°kolla°	more silent
KOLLA	louder voice
$ kolla $	dollar signs for smiley voice
”kolla”	talk in “other” voice
?	question intonation
!	exclamatory intonation
>kolla<	quicker tempo
<kolla>	slower tempo
(.)	micropause
[	onset of overlapping talk
ko- kolla	cut off sign (for aborted talk)
till *the time*	italics for shift to another language than Swedish
(*giggles*)	stage descriptions, transcriber comments about nonverbal or nonvocal action in italics and parenthesis (cf., Osborne, 1957),

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Narcissism or Masquerade? Selfies as visual communication in Vocational Education classrooms

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Introduction: I'm out here a thousand miles from my home

In the immensely popular podcast *Poddagogen*, we meet researchers in the vast research field of education who have recently completed their PhD dissertations on topics we believe deserve a bit more attention. In the extensive work of producing new episodes, we read many doctoral dissertations, and it is striking how often researchers describe their time as a PhD student using various metaphors in the introduction of their work. Everything from the writing being a rollercoaster to their collaboration with their supervisors being like a boxing fight. However, the most common metaphor is that time is described as a journey—a winding journey with many adventures, obstacles, and leaps.

Our (Kontio's & Lundmark's) time as Ann-Carita's PhD students ended with us defending our dissertations more or less around the exact same time. The journey began for both of us with a mental and physical relocation, several miles away from our respective homes, away from what we were familiar with. Physically, this meant travelling intermittently to Uppsala University, an hour's journey north of Stockholm, but the incomparably greatest journey was the one we underwent mentally, and for both of us, Ann-Carita was the guiding North Star, the bright lighthouse towards which we could steer our unsteady ships.

We are forever thankful, Captain Evaldsson, it has been a pleasure to have travelled with you, to have you as our academic guide, in the same manner as Bob Dylan once had his guide. When he arrived in New York in the early 1960s, hitchhiking from Minnesota to New York, he immediately started to look for his great idol, Woody Guthrie. Guthrie, one of the most significant folk music singer-songwriter and composers had been one of Bob's guiding stars, a role model to whom he looked up to. It turned out that as Bob arrived in the big city, Guthrie had developed Huntington's disease and was hospitalized at Greystone Park. Dylan would make several trips to visit and befriend his great hero, even writing a song to him, *Song to Woody*, that he has sung live in concerts throughout his long career. The song starts by calling out for Guthrie's attention ("hey hey, Woody Guthrie, I wrote you a song") before describing the world that Guthrie's songs often inhabit, acknowledging the friends Guthrie met and inspired along the way, and the song then ends as the

singer concludes that he will never likely get to the heights of his hero, but that he wishes to be able to say that he too, one day, will have a journey to look back upon.

So, we have decided to build this chapter for you in the same way, and we start the story of this chapter in the spirit of Bob Dylan's legacy; hey, hey Ann-Carita, we wrote you a chapter.

Hey, hey Ann-Carita, we wrote you a chapter

About a funny old world, that's a-coming along. In 2022, Internetstiftelsen reported Instagram as the most popular platform among Swedes, with Snapchat emerging as the preferred choice for Swedish teenagers (Statens Medieråd, 2023, p. 49). Despite this widespread use, discourse analytic examinations of actual Snapchat usage among Swedish youth remain limited (Sandin, 2021). This study addresses this gap by delving into the interactional dynamics of selfies produced on Snapchat by Swedish teenagers within a vocational school context. Through the integration of video recordings capturing classroom activities and screen-recorded smartphone interactions, we aim to unravel the nuanced facets of this visual communication medium. In vocational education, visual representations play a key role in shaping technological literacy and professional identity (Larsson, Fälton & Stolpe, 2024), making selfies a particularly interesting phenomenon to study in this context.

The evolution of selfies:

Since the introduction of built-in cameras in mobile phones after 1999, the ability to capture images on the move has revolutionized visual communication (Van Dijck, 2007). However, early mobile phone cameras were characterized by low image quality, limited editing capabilities, and challenges in sharing images due to high costs and slow upload/download speeds.

Thus, the invention of smartphones equipped with front-facing cameras and the proliferation of social media platforms like Instagram and Snapchat significantly transformed the practice of selfies (Rettberg, 2014). These technological advancements not only improved image quality but also introduced features such as filters and editing tools, enabling users to curate their self-images meticulously. This shift facilitated a new form of visual communication where individuals express their identities, emotions, and social affiliations instantly and widely (Peraica, 2017).

Selfies as representational and social tools:

The cultural perception of selfies has also evolved. Initially heavily criticized but now recognized as a legitimate form of self-expression and identity construction. Selfies serve as a means for individuals to engage with their social circles, participate in cultural trends, and assert their presence in digital spaces.

The integration of selfies into daily life underscores their role in contemporary visual culture, reflecting broader societal shifts towards visuality and self-representation (Peraica, 2017; Rettberg, 2014). Selfies serve as a means for individuals to test their appearances and expressions in relation to their own and others' gaze. Moreover, gender and age play pivotal roles in shaping selfies, influencing visual codes through looks, gestures, mimicry, and text overlays or filters. It is essential to note that selfies are not exclusive to youth; they have become ubiquitous in various social contexts worldwide, as evidenced by phenomena like "Selfies at funerals" and global headlines highlighting their widespread normalization.

The selfie craze: A mass phenomenon:

Indiana Cybersecurity Hub underscores the magnitude of the selfie phenomenon, revealing that over 92 million selfies were generated daily in the Western world (ICH, 21.7 2024). The survey, conducted among individuals aged 18 and above, demonstrated that nearly half of the population engaged in selfie-taking. Motivations ranged from commemorating special occasions to documenting personal style choices and enhancing self-esteem. Markedly, image filters were commonly employed to modify features such as skin tone, eye color, eye size, lips, and body shape.

The influence of celebrity culture on the selfie trend is evident, with notable figures like Amir Ashoor, Justin Bieber, Neymar, Nicki Minaj, Rihanna, and Billie Eilish actively participating in selfie-sharing practices via social media platforms.

Here's to Helen and Karin, and Anna, too, and to all the good people who travelled with you.

Exploring identity and knowledge through peer interaction:

In Helen Melander Bowden's (2012) study, the construction of knowledge and learning through interaction within a peer group is explored. The article highlights how individuals develop and negotiate their epistemic identities through conversation and bodily actions, which is central to understanding how young people use media such as selfies to navigate and create meaning in their social contexts. Helen's work provides valuable insights into the dynamics that may be behind young people's use of visual media as a tool for identity construction, which relates to the interactional aspects of selfies that we discuss here.

The concept of impression management, as introduced by Goffman (1990) and applied by Evaldsson (2009), further deepens our understanding of these identity performances within peer groups. Impression management refers to the ways individuals consciously or unconsciously control how they are perceived by others, particularly in social settings. Evaldsson (2009), in her study of girls' play and peer culture, illustrates how children strategically present themselves to fit into group norms and expectations, in another study made in

a vocational education setting, Evaldsson describes how girls in auto mechanic education adapt their identities to navigate through a masculine setting (Kontio & Evaldsson, 2015). In the context of selfies and visual interaction, this perspective helps explain how youth curate images of themselves to align with peer norms, assert social status, or negotiate belonging.

Building on Melander Bowden's (2012) exploration of knowledge construction and identity negotiation within peer interactions, Susan Danby's research offers further insights into how children actively participate in constructing knowledge and identities through peer interactions. Theobald and Danby (2017) examine how children co-construct knowledge in everyday interactions, emphasizing the collaborative nature of learning processes.

The work of Susan Danby and several other colleagues also delve into the dynamics of peer conflict and its role in social learning, showing how these interactions are crucial for understanding how children learn to manage social interactions and construct their social relations (cf. Danby & Theobald, 2012; Evaldsson & Svahn, 2017; Goodwin, 1990). Danby et al. (2018) have also examined how children engage in digital gameplay across various settings in Australia, Norway, and Sweden. The research highlights how children utilize multimodal resources, such as language, gestures, and digital tools, to collaboratively solve problems, share knowledge, and construct shared understandings during gameplay.

These studies collectively underscore the importance of peer interactions in the development of children's identities and knowledge construction. The findings also resonate with the themes of identity formation and knowledge negotiation discussed in our study. They also provide valuable perspectives on how children use social interactions to navigate their social environments, which is pertinent to understanding the role of visual media, like selfies, in contemporary youth culture.

Visual culture and childhood:

Visual culture, as described by Anna Sparrman (2006), encompasses all facets of visual perception, extending beyond photography to encompass every aspect involving sight. Sparrman asserts that vision is not solely a physical function but is profoundly influenced by historical and cultural contexts, intertwined with power dynamics. Similarly, in vocational education, visual representations are integral to shaping students' technological literacy and professional self-perception (Larsson, Fälton & Stolpe, 2024), underscoring the role of selfies as both a representational and identity-forming tool. This perspective encourages us to examine how childhood and youth are perceived through various types of images, as well as how children learn to visualize themselves.

In line with this, Karin Aronsson (2022) is another researcher whose work has been highly influential in the field of visual culture, particularly in relation to how children and young people use visual media, including images, to

express themselves, construct identities, and engage in social interactions. Other scholars have also emphasized the importance of visual practices in educational contexts, where students utilize digital technologies to share knowledge, reflect on personal experiences, and form social bonds with peers (Stenliden & Nissen, 2022). These themes are also closely connected to explorations further developed in our edited volumes on didactical dilemmas both in digital settings and in children and youth leisure time activities (Lundmark & Kontio, 2022; Lundmark & Kontio, 2024). However, these visual expressions, such as selfies, do not merely serve as tools for self-presentation but are also deeply intertwined with learning processes. Through images, young people communicate not only their individual identities but also negotiate their social roles within peer groups (Aronsson, 2022). This process, mediated by digital platforms like Instagram and Snapchat, enables students to construct knowledge collectively while simultaneously shaping their self-perceptions and social relationships. In this way, visual communication plays a pivotal role in both personal and social learning environments, where the boundaries between learning, identity construction, and peer interaction are fluid and dynamic.

Impression management in selfies:

Building upon Larsen and Sandbye's (2013) assertion that photos function as material and social objects shaping identity and social relationships, we adopt Goffman's (1990) framework of impression management to scrutinize the self-presentation processes embedded within the images and interactions captured in our data. This approach illuminates the role of situated identities and the construction of self-representations within the realm of visual communication.

In "The Selfie (and Ussie) as Identity in the Classroom", Jennifer Kienzle (2017) delves into the phenomenon of selfies and ussies (group selfies) within the context of educational environments. Kienzle explores how these visual self-representations have become integral tools for students to construct and express their identities in the classroom setting. The article delves into the motivations behind taking selfies, such as self-presentation, self-expression, and social interaction. Kienzle also examines the influence of peer culture, societal norms, and technological affordances on students' selfie practices. The study sheds light on the multifaceted role of selfies as a means of communication, identity formation, and social engagement in the educational context. Ultimately, Kienzle's work highlights the need for educators to acknowledge and understand the significance of selfies in contemporary student experiences and consider how they can be leveraged positively within educational settings.

Jeya Amantha Kumar, Paula Alexandra Silva, Sharifah Osman, and Brandford Bervell (2023) explore the concept of "selfie defamiliarization" in

educational settings. The study investigates how the act of taking selfies in a classroom context can lead to a novel perspective on familiar classroom experiences. The authors examine how the use of selfies can potentially disrupt and transform conventional classroom dynamics, offering new insights into student engagement, participation, and social interaction.

The research employs a mixed-methods approach, combining surveys and interviews with students to gain a comprehensive understanding of their experiences with taking selfies in class. The findings reveal that taking selfies in the classroom can serve as a form of creative expression, allowing students to view their learning environment from a different vantage point. Additionally, the study identifies potential benefits, such as enhanced engagement, improved self-awareness, and strengthened social connections among students.

Furthermore, the authors emphasize the need for educators to recognize the potential educational value of selfie defamiliarization and consider how it can be integrated into pedagogical practices. By incorporating selfies into the learning process, educators have the opportunity to tap into students' creativity, self-reflection, and sense of belonging within the classroom community. Overall, the study sheds light on the transformative potential of selfies as a tool for reimagining and enriching the educational experience.

Method and setting

Our data were collected within vocational programs at an upper secondary school. In total, the project generated 75 hours of video recordings, focusing specifically on students' use of mobile phones in vocational education settings (Connected Classrooms, VR/UVK Ref. No. 2015-01044). This study is also part of a broader effort to explore pedagogical challenges and opportunities within vocational education (Kontio & Lundmark, 2021). During data collection, two researchers were typically present in the classroom: one operated one or two digital video cameras, while the other concentrated on recording the selected student's mobile phone activity. The student's phone was mirrored and recorded directly onto our computer, enabling us to observe in real-time exactly what the student was doing on their device. This constituted a significant technical advancement. Whereas previous attempts had relied on filming over students' shoulders to capture screen activity, we were now able to monitor their usage from a distance with much greater accuracy.

At the time of data collection, a government proposal was under consideration to introduce a general ban on mobile phones in Swedish upper secondary schools. The final decision, however, was left to the discretion of each school's leadership in consultation with the teaching staff. Research did not offer strong or unambiguous support for such a ban. On the contrary, Anita Grigic Magnusson argued in her dissertation that a mobile phone ban is not the right course of action. She contended that mobile phones form part of the school's learning infrastructure, both students and teachers make use of

students' private devices, and that classrooms have even, according to teachers in her study, become noticeably calmer since mobile phones were introduced (Grigic Magnusson, 2022).

Shortly after our data collection concluded, the government moved from proposal to implementation, deciding to ban mobile phones in schools starting August 1, 2022. In online forums frequented by teachers and parents, it has been reported that this decision has led some students to bring two phones to school: one that they dutifully hand in at the beginning of class, and another they use covertly.

Figure 1 (below) illustrates the structure of our data. The image is divided into three panels. The left panel shows the focal student filmed from behind. In this particular example, a class council meeting is taking place, a context that often presents an ideal opportunity for students to take out their phones, as much of the information shared by the teacher is not directly relevant to them. Consequently, students often listen only half-attentively while scrolling through their phones. A small microphone, roughly the size of half a pencil, is also visible on the student's desk, capturing anything the student might say.

In the top right panel, we see the same student filmed from the front. If we look closely, we can observe that the focal student has just lifted her gaze from the phone to check whether the teacher is sharing anything of interest, but a second later, her attention returns to the screen. Finally, in the bottom right panel, we see the student's phone screen. At this moment, she is scrolling through her Instagram feed, which features a mix of celebrity posts, advertisements, hearts and likes, and messages from friends.

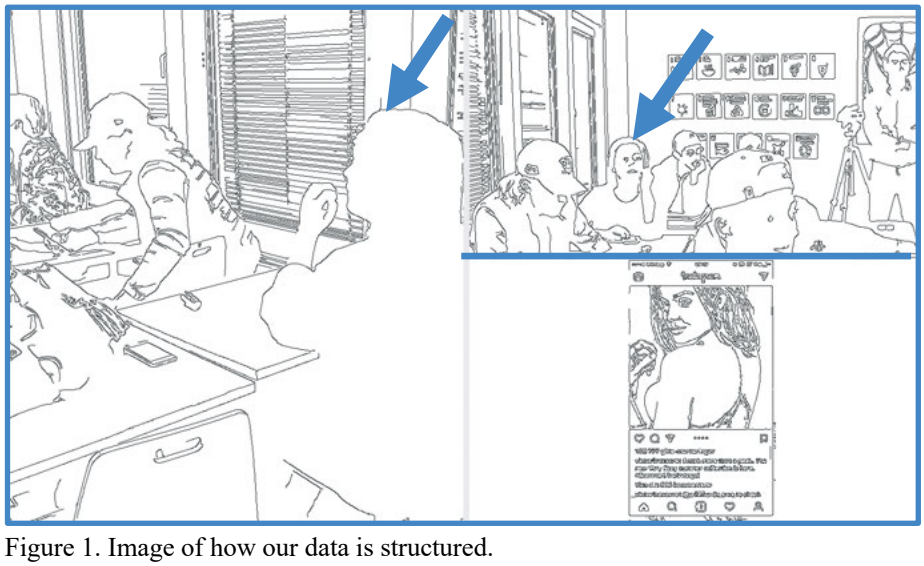


Figure 1. Image of how our data is structured.

In this study, we have chosen to focus on a specific aspect of students' mobile phone use, namely, the act of taking photos of themselves in various contexts and for different purposes. From the collected data, we compile and analyze a collection of self-portraits. Overall, it is evident that the Snapchat app plays a significant role in driving selfie production among students.

Snapchat features a function where, for example, Anna can send a photo to Emma, and if Emma responds with her own photo within 24 hours, they have "one day." If this exchange is repeated the following day, they reach "two days," and so on. When Anna and Emma maintain a snapstreak for, for instance, 650 consecutive days, there is a certain pressure on both to keep the streak going. If Emma fails to respond, the streak resets to zero, and, of course, she does not want to be the one in their relationship who breaks the unbroken streak.

In addition, Emma might have 170 friends in the app whom she needs to interact with daily through photo exchanges, which students in our study report as a source of stress. Various strategies are used to manage this pressure: some students respond to every notification, ping, or vibration by immediately lifting their phones to take a photo, while others wait for a brief pause in the lesson to respond to several messages at once.

Our interviews also reveal stories related to this stress. One student, for example, described planning a vacation abroad and being uncertain whether the hotel would have wireless internet access. As a result, she left her phone with a friend back home who was tasked with taking photos and responding to incoming messages on her behalf, so that she would not lose her snapstreak days.

We now turn our attention to the students and their classrooms. During instruction, we observe that our focal students can take up to 30 selfies during a single lesson. These may include multiple images sent to the same person, as well as images sent to different recipients. Our study includes data from both traditionally female-dominated vocational programs (such as the hairdressing program) and male-dominated programs (such as the building and construction program), and clear differences emerge in how students use their mobile phones.

Kontio and Asplund (2019), for example, note that students in the hairdressing program tend to use their phones individually to a much greater extent, while students in the building and construction program use their phones in a more collective manner, for instance, by inviting peers to view something entertaining on their screen. Kontio and Asplund suggest that while these differences cannot be solely attributed to the students' gender identities (i.e., identifying as girls or boys), they more clearly reflect the nature of the respective vocational programs. Hairdressers are expected to become self-reliant individuals, capable of building a personal portfolio of skills and marketing their services independently. In contrast, students preparing for work on

construction sites are expected to communicate and collaborate with others on the team, including electricians and plumbers.

Another striking difference that emerges from our data appears when we focus on the self-portraits students take using their phones. In the following example, students from the building and construction program have initiated a group project. Anyone who has participated in school group work may recognize the familiar dynamic: some students contribute significantly, while others do very little more than go along, commonly referred to as *social loafing* (Ingham, Levinger, Graves & Peckham, 1974). In this case, the students have brainstormed ideas about what the cities of the future might look like, drawing on a short film on architecture that they viewed together. The project has now entered the presentation phase, during which the students are preparing a poster. This task has been delegated to one of the group members, the most artistically inclined, while the remaining four engage with their mobile phones.

Then, something occurred that surprised us as researchers: the students began exchanging phones with one another. Initially, one student (B) took another student's (A) phone. Student A requested the return of his device, but the request was denied. Instead, student B proposed that they swap phones.



1. A) Now, I want my phone back
2. B) Chill
3. A) Can I have yours then?
4. B) Yeah-h (2) see, we'll swap a little
5. (1) there's nothing fun there
6. A) What is your password then
7. B) Zeros

When Student A's request to have his phone returned is denied, Student A responds by taking Student B's phone and asking for his password to unlock it. "Zeros," B replies, after which the two participants begin to interact with and through each other's phones. In the illustration (above), we see the artistically inclined student on the far left completing the group assignment by drawing an elegant poster, while the student on the right (B) takes self-portraits using A's phone (visible in the mirrored screen in the lower right corner).

What surprised us as researchers about this interaction was how distinctly it differed from what we had observed in the hairdressing program. The hairdressing students also brought mobile phones to the classroom. 98% of Swedish upper secondary students own a mobile phone, but the prospective hairdressers used them in markedly different ways. In the aforementioned study comparing the two student groups, we found that the hairdressing students used their own phones with a strong sense of personal integrity, almost as a shield to protect themselves from others, often physically leaning away from their classmates (Kontio & Asplund, 2019). Here, in contrast, we see the boys taking and using each other's phones, something we would likely never have seen among the girls, and even producing selfies of themselves and posting them to each other's social media feeds (which we certainly would not have seen among the hairdressing students).

By definition, adolescents' social media feeds are social environments, and within these spaces, young people must navigate and manage how they are perceived by others, what Goffman (1990) refers to as *impression management*. At first glance, one might interpret the boys' behavior as a sign that they have given up on, or simply do not care about, how they are perceived on social media, since they allow their peers to post images freely in their personal feeds. However, after observing and studying these students over an extended period of time, we came to a different conclusion: teamwork and trust appear to hold greater value for them, and the selfies aid them in creating strong social bonds (Stenliden & Nissen, 2022). Allowing someone to produce and publish selfies in one's feed signals an understanding of what it means to be a team player who trusts their peers to act in good faith.

One of the hairdressing teachers recounted an incident that had taken place during a party outside of school, where many of the students had been present. The event led to conflicts that the teachers later had to address. One student had consumed too much alcohol and fallen asleep. Another girl took the sleeping student's phone and posted images of her, intoxicated and asleep, on her social media. Once discovered, the incident escalated into a serious conflict that eventually spilled over into the school's hairdressing salon. Hypothetically, had this occurred among the boys in the building and construction program, the outcome might have been different, potentially even yielding *social capital* or "points."

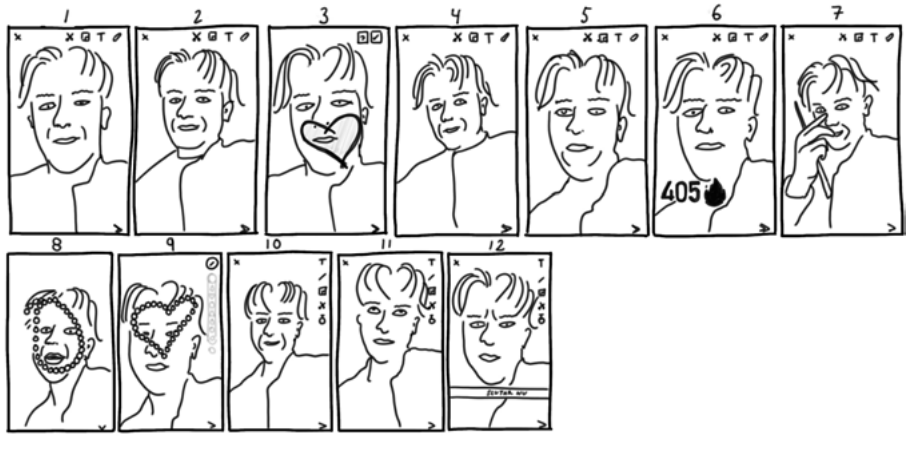
By examining selfies and visual interaction, *impression management* provides a lens through which we can better understand how young people curate

images of themselves in order to align with friendship norms and negotiate membership within both peer and professional cultures.

Selfie trajectory → A Masquerade

In the concluding image below, we are offered a glimpse into a student's selfie-related interaction during lesson time. In this particular example, a boy spends a significant portion of the class, during which students are expected to watch a film together, engaged instead in producing and sending images of himself to his girlfriend.

For ethical reasons, we are limited in what we can say about the incoming messages, as the girlfriend on the other end has not provided consent to be included as a research subject. However, we can examine the images produced by the student in the classroom. During the 16 minutes and 30 seconds in which the film on urban planning is projected onto the classroom wall, the student sends twelve self-portraits.



The twelve images are compiled above, each numbered from one to twelve. In brief, the first image is taken from a slightly low angle, and the student displays a fairly neutral facial expression. In the second image, he stretches and adjusts his hairstyle. In the third, he has used a drawing tool to add a red heart that partially covers the lower part of his face. In image four, he moves slightly away from the camera; in the fifth, he leans forward, pouting his lips so that his chewing gum is visible. In the sixth image, he has added the number "405" alongside a flame icon, together symbolizing the 405 consecutive days of snapstreaks he has maintained with his girlfriend (see earlier discussion in this chapter).

In the seventh image, he raises his hand toward his face, placing one finger on his lips and another near his eye. The eighth image is decorated with

emojis, smiling faces with heart-shaped eyes, forming a circle around his smiling face. In the ninth image, he does the same but arranges the emojis into the shape of a heart. In the tenth image, he again leans away from the camera, followed by an eleventh in which he looks up toward the ceiling. In the final image, he has added the caption "I am quitting now", signalling that the lesson, and thus his undisturbed opportunity to send messages, has come to an end.

Taken together, these twelve images may initially appear randomly produced. However, prior research on how interaction is organized can provide a deeper understanding of what is taking place. Evaldsson's (2009) studies on how small children negotiate their identities and positions within peer groups highlight the importance of self-presentation and self-expression in social interaction. In managing one's own self-presentation in and through smartphones, the selfies seem to be crucial (Kienzle, 2017).

In the example above, we observe the boy experimenting with different expressions of self, through varied roles, positions, bodily formations, and facial expressions, not only to reinforce his message (his affection for his girlfriend), but also to communicate a curated image of himself: who does he want his girlfriend to perceive him as?

Much of the research and media discourse surrounding mobile phone use tends to emphasize body image pressures and negative mental health outcomes among young people. Here, we wish to nuance that narrative and suggest that what is happening in this example may, in fact, echo behaviors familiar to earlier generations (such as those of us born in the early 1980s). As children, we dressed up in costumes and lip-synced in front of the mirror. Standing before the mirror, we explored different ways of expressing ourselves. What would it mean if I pouted? How would others see me if I leaned back, looked up at the ceiling, or positioned my chewing gum between my lips? Is it less of an expression of narcissism and more of a digital kind of masquerade?

Or, as Bob Dylan remarked during his Halloween 1964 concert at New York's Philharmonic Hall: *"It's just Halloween, I have my Bob Dylan mask on."*

Results

This study provides crucial insights into the broader digital youth culture, particularly illuminating the image-centric nature of young people's lives facilitated by smartphone usage. It delves deep into the practical application of image use, emphasizing its occurrence within institutional contexts.

Contrary to prevailing notions associating youth selfie-taking with narcissism and potential mental health issues (Sorokowski et al., 2015; Anderson, 2017), this research demonstrates a nuanced understanding. By delineating the timing and manner in which image production and consumption take place, the study distinguishes between various user actions: self-presentation, self-

representation, and masquerade. This empowers youths, affording them agency in managing their self-image within a visually oriented social landscape.

Furthermore, the study highlights how the utilization of smartphone cameras and images mirrors distinct aspects of vocational classroom cultures, aligning with previous research findings (Carlsson, 2025; Nyström, 2012). Notably, the counter-establishment culture observed in vocational education settings sharply contrasts with data from upper secondary schools geared towards further studies, which is something that we think needs to be studied further.

Conclusion: The very last thing that we'd want to do

Finally, our work underscores the need for educators to recognize and understand the significance of the selfie in contemporary students' lived experiences and to consider how this practice might be harnessed in productive ways within educational settings. This conclusion aligns with what we interpret as both the ambition and legacy of Ann-Carita's work: that by cultivating a deeper understanding of the lived realities of children and young people, through close and detailed study, we create the conditions for teachers and other adults to develop their practices in collaboration with the children themselves. In these footsteps we can only follow; these paths have been laid by Ann-Carita and those who have walked beside her and after her. And when the time comes for us to close our own books, the very last thing that we want to do:

Is to say, "We've been hitting some hard travelling too"

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Breaking the fourth wall – Children's social uses of the camera in video ethnographic research

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The authors of this chapter are both former colleagues and doctoral students of Ann-Carita. We were under her supervision, with great enthusiasm, socialized into and developed a broad interest in studying the everyday lives of children and youth—particularly with a focus on capturing their local social interactions, identity work, and moral negotiations within various cultural practices. Being supervised by Ann-Carita naturally involved ongoing theoretical and methodological discussion about concepts such as language socialization processes and children's interactional practices, as well as the importance of (video)ethnography in capturing children's relational work *in situ*. But it also meant countless other conversations—cinema being a recurring and important one. It is difficult to summarize the influence Ann-Carita has had on both our research careers, but as a way to express our appreciation for all the time and knowledge she has shared with us over the years, we offer this contribution—combining a concept from cinema with interactional approaches on children's peer interaction. In doing so, we hope to shed light on how the camera lens can play a meaningful role in how young people express their agency in ethnographic research, as they share their concerns with an outside audience.

Introduction

In ethnographic research, video recordings are commonly used for capturing children's everyday life in various contexts (see, e.g. M. H. Goodwin, 1990; Corsaro, 1993; Evaldsson, 2005; Melander Bowden, 2024). A particular advantage of this approach is that the camera allows the researcher to capture the fine-grained details of children's social encounters *in situ*. As argued by Corsaro (1982, p. 145), video recordings enable the researcher to focus on the identification of substantive content in the data at one point in the analysis, and later attempt to specify how interactants use and organize these features as the interactive events unfold. Through the use of the camera, scholars have come to demonstrate how children in peer interaction use not only talk but also other modalities—such as gaze, gestures, and artifacts—to for instance transform knowledge in classroom learning activities (Melander, 2012), collectively solve problems during digital gameplay (Danby, Evaldsson, Melander & Aarsand, 2018; Evaldsson & Melander Bowden, 2024) or to

negotiate moral codes among friends in the schoolyard (Evaldsson, 2007; Evaldsson & Svahn, 2017). These studies, alongside others within the genre, illustrate a range of contexts and purposes for which video recordings are employed to analyze children's interaction.

It is important to note that video recordings are not merely used to capture isolated social events among children. Rather, by recording how children construct and manage social interactions with peers, scholars employ video recordings in relation to broader aims—regardless of whether the focus is on children's relational talk (Evaldsson, 2007) or play activities (Corsaro, 1993). That is to explore how children, as social actors, use various interactional modes to interpret their ongoing social worlds and make sense of central issues in their lives (M. H. Goodwin, 1990; Corsaro, 1993; Evaldsson, 2007). However, capturing interactional details is not necessarily sufficient in itself. Rather, we argue, in line with, for instance, Evaldsson (2021, p. 305), that such analysis will be complemented best with ethnographic knowledge in order to explicate and discuss the participants' sense-making processes. And also, as Derry et al. (2010) argue, for selecting and analyzing video recorded episodes as part of a wider narrative of how children interact in particular contexts and cultures.

Although the many affordances of using video recordings in ethnographic research are well known, they are most often discussed in methodological terms and from the researcher's perspective. Such discussions tend to include practical and ethical challenges, such as the difficulty of getting gatekeepers to engage in video ethnography, the risks of disrupting activities and/or persons, or how the potential power asymmetry between researcher and participants will risk influencing their ability to set boundaries in moments where they wish to no longer partake. These issues are, of course, important, especially in the way they underscore that consent is an ongoing, negotiated process, and highlight the fundamental relational nature of ethnographic research. However, we like to argue that few studies tend to move beyond the researcher's perspective, by also exploring in more detail how the camera actually influences the participant's ongoing interactions during ethnographic fieldwork. In fact, we would go so far as to say that such instances, where the participants explicitly interact with the camera, more likely pose a threat to the fundamental scientific principle of capturing participants' cultures and actions in their natural environment, and as such are treated as unusable data. In this article, we therefore deliberately and with a genuine curiosity take on the quest of exploring how the camera, in particular situations, may also afford children with agency, as they use it for their own local social purposes within the context of peer interaction.

Analytic approach and data

This chapter incorporates data from two separate video ethnographic studies conducted by the authors as part of their respective PhD projects. Although these studies were carried out twelve years apart, they share several common features. For instance, they were both focused on the same age group (11–12) and explored similar themes related to the social and moral orders of childhood through the lens of children's everyday interactions in school. The first dataset was collected in a fifth-grade class during the 2007-2008 school year. This fieldwork examined children's participation in morally charged peer group dynamics, such as social exclusion, gossiping, disputes and disagreements, and explored fine grained details of activities that generated issues related to *school bullying* (see Svahn, 2012). The second dataset was collected in 2019-2020 in two fifth-grade classes. This more recent fieldwork explored how middle school children organized peer relationships through various forms of *relational talk* (Evaldsson, 2007), including teasing, gossiping and storytelling. Particular attention was paid to how these interactions contributed to the negotiation of friendship, cross-gender relationships and romantic interests in the context of everyday school life (see Andréasson, 2023).

To analytically approach the specific fieldwork moments during these two studies when children acknowledged the camera in an explicit way, we use the concept of *breaking the fourth wall* (BTFW) as a main figure. Originally rooted in theatre and film, BTFW refers to the metaphorical barrier that separates performers from the audience—an invisible "wall" through which viewers observe the fictional world on stage or screen. Breaking this wall occurs when characters cease to pretend that the audience or camera does not exist and instead address them directly (Brown, 2022). In film, such moments can serve many entertaining and narrative purposes. For instance, actors might explain their thoughts and actions, disclose unknown information, or appeal for the audience's sympathy. To our knowledge, however, the concept of BTFW has not been widely applied to analyze the relational dynamics that unfold when participants in real life settings orient to and interact with the camera. In undertaking such a venture, we will draw on an ethnomethodological interactional approach, focusing on children's interaction with the camera during ethnographic fieldwork as a situated activity. Specifically, we will examine peer interaction as co-constructed events, and put emphasis on what the children do or accomplish as they engage with an "unpresent audience" through sequences of actions (cf. M. H. Goodwin, 1990). The children's orientation to and playful engagement with the camera will thus be analyzed as meaningful forms of action—achieved through talk, embodied actions, and the use of artifacts (C. Goodwin, 2000)—as they organize activities that involve creating humorous media content, disclosing peer misconduct, giving directions to the ethnographer, and more.

In the analysis, we will closely examine the children's shifting forms of participation across interactional sequences (C. Goodwin & M. H. Goodwin, 2004), and explore their collaborative organization of events in which they in their own unique ways, break the fourth wall. Our approach will, to some extent, also draw on Goffman's (1981) concept of footing, which concerns participants' alignment and how shifting interactional frames and modes are handled in social encounters. Following Goffman (1981), we understand footings as dynamic configurations that enable participants to continuously reposition themselves in various ways in relation to ongoing conversational topics, activities and/or coparticipants. Importantly, however, we do not see shifts in footing as simply a replacing of frame, but rather as a continuous process where several frames can be held in suspension, in a way that enable participants to move in and out of them. This interactional work indicates changes in how participants align with themselves and others (Goffman, 1981, p. 127f), potentially altering social roles, interpersonal relations and the organization of ongoing tasks and activities. In some of our empirical examples the concept of footing is also used for exploring how the children use animation to stage different characters within their interaction. As Goffman (1981, p. 144f) illustrates, animation involves an animator who (re)enacts an event and its central characters through performed or reported activities, speech, and/or situations, by use of various animation cues—such as exaggerated or mimicked voices. These cues serve as key resources for dramatizing events and commenting on unfolding actions and characters (M. H. Goodwin, 1993, p. 111).

Analysis

In the following analyses, we examine three central themes to illustrate how children utilize the camera for various locally situated purposes: (i) as a distinct artifact of play, through which they stage media content for an imagined external audience (ii) as a tool for guiding the researcher during the course of fieldwork, and (iii) as a means of addressing moral transgression among peers. The selected episodes in each section have been chosen for their narrative richness and expressive power (Derry et al., 2010).

First, the analysis demonstrates how children employ a range of interactional resources to "break the fourth wall", thereby inviting an outside audience into their everyday school life (e.g. through direct address, gestural cues, and performative acts). Second, it shows that such moments of fourth-wall-breaking, recurrent throughout the broader video-ethnographic corpus, serve as strategic resources for pursuing social goals, including the creation of shared fun and the negotiation of peer-related moral concerns. Third, and more broadly, the analysis also sheds light on how the presence of the camera shapes children's ongoing interactions during ethnographic fieldwork. It highlights the agency that the children exercise as they appropriate the camera for their

own social aims, using it as a tool to navigate and construct their peer culture within the context of everyday school interactions.

I: Using the camera to play around with various media content

In this first section, we present two examples with a focus on how children orient to and interact with the camera for creating media content for an outside audience. The analysis demonstrates how the camera becomes an artifact of play as children use humorous performances to invite the audience behind the scenes, while managing both boring situations as well as more emotionally and morally charged situations, such as conflicts among peers in school.

Managing school boredom through a humorous weather report

In this first example, the two classmates Ann and Sarah have been working in a smaller group room while their classmates are studying in the classroom next door. A camera is placed in the room on a tripod for capturing the peers' ongoing talk, and the researcher has left the room. The presence of the camera leads to the girls on and off breaking the fourth wall by addressing the camera for various purposes, rather than doing actual schoolwork.

Excerpt 1: Are you presenting the weather?

1	Sarah	**moves the table and turns the chair towards Ann and the camera**
2	Sarah	nu är det bättre now that's better
3	Sarah	**gazes into the camera and smiles, then gazes at Ann**
4	Ann	**smiles, gazes into the camera and at Sarah**
5	Sarah	okej (.) + [de e ganska fult ute vem vill gå u:t? ingen vill bli blöt okay (.) it's rather ugly out who wants to go out? No one wants to get wet *+looks out on the schoolyard through the windo*



6	Ann	[**looks out the window**
7	Sarah	+de e ganska mycket is och [som eh slaski::t +å it's rather a lot of ice and [that is slushI:: and *+gazes at Ann and then looks out the window +smiles laughingly*



8	Ann	[heh skaru +p- presentera vädret? hehe- are you p-presenting the weather? *+smiles*
9	Sarah	yea:h
10	Sarah	**gazes out the window*

As shown, Sarah starts orienting to an outside audience by adjusting her physical position while gazing into the camera. Her embodied actions combined with her talk "now that's better" and "okay" (1-3, 5) frame the activity as an innated report for an outside audience. Particularly, the use of the word "okay" take the form of an action cue that invites the audience to now take part in what she is about to tell. Ann aligns with the initiated activity by also smiling and gazing into the camera (4). Sarah then continues by looking out the window, while posing a rhetorical question, "it's rather ugly out who wants to go out?". The rhetorical question format "who wants…." combined with the description of it being "ugly" outside, can be seen as a scripted (typical) event description (Edwards, 1994) of what to do and expect from people when it is not so appealing weather. Thus, Sarah displays her footing (Goffman, 1981) by constructing assumptions about herself and other children's behavior. Namely, that when it is "icy" and "slushy" (7), they do not like to go outdoors.

Now, Ann starts giggling and smiling, signalling that Sarah's account is somewhat humorous (8). Importantly, her following question "are-u p- presenting the weather?" (8) also signals that the activity of presenting the rather gloomy weather is an odd activity to be doing; yet humorous as it perhaps is not the most spectacular information to present to an outside audience. Sarah aligns with Ann and reinforces that the ongoing activity is both odd and funny through the use of a laughing smile (7), while confirming that she is actually presenting the weather (9).

Heightening ongoing drama through an animated crime report

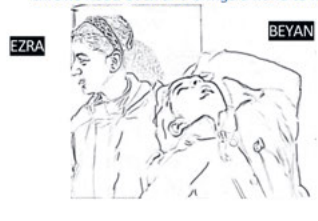
In this sequence, six friends—Emine, Beyan, Ezra, Yaasmin, Lana and Salina—are gathered outside the school canteen. Moments earlier, Emine had attempted to apologize to Emilia for using a derogatory term towards her, but the apology was met with silence as Emilia looked at her phone and walked away. Visibly unsettled, Emine begins venting to the group. At this point, Ezra and Beyan suddenly step away from the group, addressing the camera directly.

Excerpt 2: My name is Hasse Larsson

1	Beyan	a: vi gör e yeah let's do it
2	Ezra	+hello (.) hasse larsson- hallå (.) hasse larsson- *+pretends to be holding a microphone and looks into the camera*



3	Beyan	**pushes Ezra away and starts laughing**
4		(0.6)
5	Ezra	+vi står här vid aspåskolan (.) nåt allvarligt har hänt dada we're standing here at aspen river school (.) something serious [has happened dada *+steps in front of Beyan*
6	Beyan	mitt namn är Beyan ja blev rånad +men nu lever ja (.) tack gode gud (.) +hahahaha my name is Beyan I was robbed but now I'm alive (.) thank you dear god (.) hahahaha *+throws head back and brings a hand to her head*



7		(1.2)
8	Beyan	ja ba skoja I'm just kidding
9		(0.8)
10	Beyan	**returns to where the group is standing**
11	Ezra	**approaches the camera**
12		(1.2)
13	Ezra	hallå (.) hh. mitt namn e hashe larsson (.) vi står här vi asp+åskolan hello (.) hh. my name is hashe larsson we're standing at aspen river school *+steps out of view*

The shift in activity is initiated by Beyan's declaration: "yeah let's do it" (1). The lack of contextualization cues (Gumperz, 1982) suggests a familiar, perhaps recurring practice between the two girls, and this shared understanding is reinforced by Ezra, who promptly steps into the role of a television reporter, introducing herself as "Hasse Larsson" (2)[8]. A shift in footing is here evident as her vocal tone becomes serious and composed, her body mimics holding a microphone, and she looks directly into the camera, marking a transformation from drama-related gossip to performative roleplay aimed at an imagined audience beyond the camera lens.

Beyan's ensuing playful push and laughter (3) align with this shift while also introducing a competitive dynamic, positioning her as a rival for the leading role. However, Ezra, seemingly unfazed, stays in character as she now starts providing details in the form of their current location, "the aspen river school", and also alludes to the nature of an incident as "something serious has happened" (5); her tone and script closely mirroring that of a conventional crime news broadcast. Beyan then again attempts to assert herself within the performance, now as a victim, labelling the fictitious crime, a robbery, and amplifying the dramatic tone, thanking God for her survival while striking an exaggerated pose (6). Her theatrical expression contrasts sharply with Ezra's composed tone, introducing a new performative layer that once again shifts the mode of the activity. While Ezra seems amused, she does not engage with the new narrative, instead turning away, signalling a temporary disengagement. As Beyan then exits the scene with a disclaimer, "I'm just kidding" (8), Ezra immediately resumes her role as crime reporter, returning to the previous activity frame.

Both these examples, while fundamentally different in some ways, also share several features. In each, the children transform the camera into an artifact of play, using humor and performance to engage an imagined audience. In the first example, humor invites the audience into the dull routine of school life (caused by bad weather), while also helping manage that dullness through playful interaction with the camera. In the second, humor helps manage emotionally and morally complex issues, such as peer conflict, via an animated crime report. Creating media content for an outside audience, where humor plays a central role, can thus be seen as an affective practice for handling everyday school life and peer relationships (cf. Franzén & Jonsson, 2024).

The analysis highlights the children's agency and creativity as they draw on popular culture to manage peer interactions. The use of the character "Hasse Larson" a well-known TV crime reporter, illustrates how enacting familiar figures can serve both as entertainment and as a means to defuse tension

[8] This is most likely a mislabeled reference to Hasse Aro, the host of the well-known television show *Efterlyst*. The show began airing on Swedish television in the 1990s in collaboration with the Swedish Police Authority and focuses on soliciting information from the public about ongoing crimes. Hasse Aro was the host from 1991 to 2014.

from previous conflicts. The children use various interactional resources, such as gestures, direct address and vocal shifts, to transform real school situations into fictional, performative play. While both examples emphasize humor and a breaking of the fourth wall, they also show that the children treat the camera not as an intrusive presence but as a playful tool. This is essentially clear in the second example when Beyan competes with Ezra for the lead role, shifting into a victim character to remain central in the performance. Here, the camera becomes a resource for pure play.

II: Using the camera to direct the researcher's focus and actions

In this section, we will move on to how children use the camera to direct the ethnographer during ongoing fieldwork. In the analysis, we will show how the camera becomes a resource for communicating with the researcher while evaluating particular peers in school. As such, the presence of the camera becomes a tool for guiding the researcher's focus during fieldwork and for giving the researcher a deeper understanding of problematic behaviors among peers.

Guiding the researcher to explore abnormal behavior among boys

When we enter Excerpt 3, the classmates Sarah and Ann have been addressing the camera, highlighting that boys in their class gaze at the girls' bodies in school. As part of this discussion, Sarah orients to the camera and tells the ethnographer to pay attention to the boys' problematic behavior (see line 1).

Excerpt 3: You have to admonish them

1 Sarah +dom där småkillarna i vår klass asså säj till dom
those little boys in our class you have to admonish them
+ *smiles and gazes into the camera*



2 Ann +dom har spårat dom har spårat +ja
they've gotten out of hand they've gotten out of hand yeah
+*gazes into the camera* +*smiles*

3	Sarah	+när dom är ute i k- va hettere (.) eh i grupprummet Eli= when they are out in the c- what's it called (.) eh in the group room Eli Anders = +*leans into the camera*
4		(0.2)
5	Sarah	=dom där killarna gå↑lyssna på dom för att dom pratar ba om tjejer å hur snygga= Anders those guys go↑ listen to themcause they only talk about girls and how good looking
6		(0.2)
7	Sarah	= dom ä och grejer fan äckliga uhlä +äckelpäckel (.) hehehe they are and stuff damn disgusting yuck creepy creeps (.) hehehe +*grimacing*



As shown, Sarah and Ann break the fourth wall by revealing to the ethnographer that the "little boys" in their class participate in a type of behavior that has gone "out of hand" (1-2). Therefore, they ask the ethnographer to correct their behavior (1). Simultaneously, the girls signal that they find their request and upcoming disclosure somewhat humorous as both of them smile and gazes into the camera (1-2). Though it is important to note that the girls do not display that the boys' behavior is funny. It is rather likely that they find it amusing to tattle on the boys and potentially put them on the spot.

In line 4-5 Sarah then uses a generalized categorization in which she pairs a gendered category with a specific activity (Stokoe, 2010, p. 65) to explain the issue at hand; which in this case concerns that little boys "only" talk about "girls and their "looks". This type of behavior is then evaluated as abnormal as Sarah categorizes the boys as "childish" (in terms of being "little"), but also "disgusting" and "creepy" (7). Her grimacing facial expression also reinforces that the particular boys' behavior is deviant and bothersome (7). Consequently, the episode demonstrates how the camera becomes a resource for the girls to display their shared footing while having fun as they tattle and construct generalized assumptions about particular boys. But it also shows how the camera becomes a resource for guiding the ethnographer to "go" and "listen" to the boys—and perhaps correct their problematic behavior.

Giving direction on the filming

Emine, Ezra and Beyan have been walking around the schoolyard engaged in conversation, and they are now coming to a stop a short distance from where a group of students are playing soccer. At this moment, Emine abruptly makes a disparaging comment about one of the girls, Evelina, who is among those out there on the soccer field.

Excerpt 4: Can you film that girl?

1	Emine	Kolla på Evelina +jag hatar +henne +så jävla mycket Check out Evelina I hate her so fucking much
2.	Ezra	+*turns around to look in the direction of the soccer field*
3.	Beyan	+*looks in the direction of the soccer field*



4.	Ezra	shit vilka kläder shit her clothes
5	Beyan	**laughs**
6.	Emine	+hörru (.) kan du filma den där tjejen när hon kör fotboll? hey you (.) can you film that girl while she's playing soccer? +*moves towards the camera smiling*
7	Ezra	hon som står- the one standing-
8.	Emine	hon i vitt the one in white
9.		**camera sweeps over the soccer field**
10.	Emine	ja kolla yeah look
11.	Ezra	**laughs**
12	Emine	HEJ FEMMOR KOLLA HIT (.) SEXOR MENAR JAG HEY FIFTH GRADERS LOOK THIS WAY (.) I MEAN SIXTH GRADERS
13		(5.0)
14.	Emine	HEJ SEXOR KOLLA HEY SIXTH GRADERS LOOK
15		**camera turns back to the girls**



16	Emine	**smiles big**

Emine's expression of dislike for Evelina, stating she "hates her", in combination with her direct prompt: "check out Evelina" (1), effectively redirects her friends' attention to the soccer field. In an aligning move, Ezra quickly joins in the negative commentary by criticizing Evelina's clothing: "shit her clothes" (4), prompting laughter from Beyan. These responses indicate a change in footing by the rapid formation of a new shared activity, the negative evaluation of a disliked peer in her absence. Noticing her success in engaging the group, Emine then smiles and subtly moves closer to the camera, excitedly asking the ethnographer to film Evelina. Ezra supports the request by identifying Evelina's location: "the one standing-" (7), with Emine adding "the one in white" (8).

As the ethnographer appears to comply, panning the camera across the soccer field (though without focusing on any specific individual) Emine

enthusiastically highlights the moment: “yeah look” (10), eliciting a laugh from Ezra (11). She then raises her voice to draw the attention of the students in the field, seemingly trying to make them aware of being filmed (12-14). Her broad smile as the camera returns to her underscores her satisfaction in successfully directing the filming in line with the group’s activity.

Both this and the previous example illustrate how the participating children in the two field studies occasionally assumed a more active role in the research process, deliberately attempting to influence the ethnographer’s actions and interpretations. As we have demonstrated, this involved not only pointing out and elaborating on issues they presumed the ethnographer might be unaware of, but also taking a greater initiative in the data collection process by directing the focus of the camera. In both instances, the camera is interacted with in a more deliberate and agentive manner, as the children treat it as a tool for capturing what they perceive to be the “real picture”. In the first example, this is evident in the girls’ efforts to provide behind-the-scenes guidance by directing the ethnographer’s attention toward scenarios they consider relevant for the research focus. By sharing details of inappropriate behavior and attributing them to specific boys, the girls also inform the ethnographer of ongoing activities that are not widely known and could otherwise be overlooked in the exploration of the children’s peer cultures. In the second example, the girl’s attempt to take control over the filming process assigns a different kind of significance to the camera lens. While they, similar to in the previous example, orient to the camera as a metaphorical flash that can illuminate particular aspects of peer culture, it is simultaneously employed as a tool to amplify the thrill of engaging in norm-breaking behavior. Here, the idea of filming a peer from a distance serves as a way to test the boundaries of collective moral order through ridicule. In doing so, the girls not only perform acts of social transgression but also demonstrate their awareness of the research agenda, engaging with its focus on socially inappropriate interactions.

III Using the camera to approach moral transgressions

In this final section, we analyze how the camera during fieldwork—both as a technical device and as a social instrument—can contribute to the creation of local norms and, at times, implicit moral codes of conduct. In our case, these emergent norms were often tied to perceived entitlements regarding when and during which activities it was acceptable to be filmed. Additionally, notions of fairness played a significant role as some children felt they received disproportionately little or no time in front of the camera, which occasionally gave rise to tensions. Such perceptions sometimes led to competitive dynamics, with certain children actively attempting to assert control over the camera’s focus and direction, confronting certain peer behavior that they saw as a breach of moral conduct.

Confronting norm-breaking behavior while competing for the limelight

The following example takes place during recess, when the three friends—Natalie, Paula and Linnéa—are spending time in the stairwell. Natalie and Paula, both enrolled in figure skating classes, are practicing pirouettes and decide to attempt a synchronized pirouette for the camera. As Linnéa, who is also taking figure skating classes, is at a less advanced level, she chooses not to participate. Instead, she observes the practice from the sidelines.

Excerpt 5:1: I can also do it

1	Linnéa	men ni gör fortfarande samma takt ju:::: but you're still doin it the same pace
2	Natalie	just de +vi gör i slo- vi gör I slowmotion samtidigt +<e:::tt två:::: > right let's do it in slo- let's do it in slow motion at the same time <o:::ne two::::> *+moves back to the corner* *+performs a slower pirouette*



3	Paula	+tre three *+lands her pirouette a micro second after Natalie's and starts laughing*
4		(2.0)
5	Salina	**passes the camera and moves to stand by the window**
6		(4.4)
7	Lana	**enters the door and takes a few dance steps in front of the camera before standing by the wall**
8	Natalie	**perform another pirouette**
9	Paula	**perform another pirouette**
10	Natalie	de va inte så bra +va that was no good right *+looks first at Paula and then Linnéa smiling*
11	Lana	+jag kan också I can also do i *+performs a jump in front of the camera before standing by the window*



12	Salina	+vi::i:: i::: *+performs a one-legged jump with her hands in the air*
13	Paula	**makes a pirouette and starts laughing**
14	Natalie	men Paula +vi gör så här but Paula we'll do it like this *+turns Paula around and lifts her up*

Following their first synchronized attempt, Linnéa offers feedback, noting that their execution remains too fast (1). In response, Natalie suggests performing the next pirouette in slow motion, upon which she and Paula proceed with this task, counting aloud to synchronize their movements (2-3). At this moment, their classmate Salina enters the stairwell, followed by her friend Lana. While Salina quietly moves past the camera and takes a position by the window, Lana steps into view, performs a few dance steps, then moves off-frame to stand by the wall.

Natalie and Paula appear largely undisturbed by the newcomers and continue practicing. However, as Natalie turns to discuss their latest attempt with Paula and Linnéa, Lana reenters the frame, performs a jump, and declares playfully: "I can also do it" (11). This teasing remark marks the first direct engagement by the newcomers with the ongoing figure skating activity, which is then followed up by Salina, who joins in with a small balletic jump, her arms raised over her head in an imitation of a classical ballet pose.

Despite these interjections, Natalie and Paula remain focused, seemingly indifferent to the disruptions. However, the dynamic shifts with the arrival of another student, Omid. Unlike other students, who pass through quickly, Omid stops to speak with Salina and Lana, inadvertently blocking the camera's view of Natalie and Paula. This elicits an immediate and forceful reaction from Natalie.

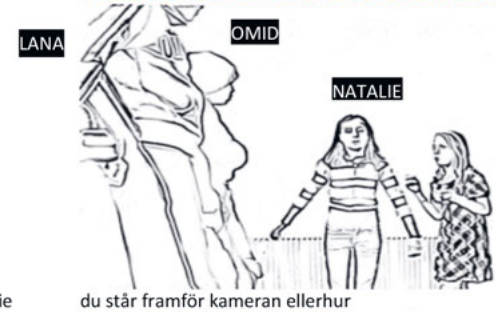
Excerpt 5: 2 You're standing right in front of the camera

14	Natalie	ursäkta + du kan flytta ditt feta ä:::s för du står rakt +framför kameran excuse me you can move your fat ass cause you're standing right in front of the camera *+pushes Omid to the side* *+point to the camera*



15	Lana	nä:: [låt honom va no:: leave him alone
16	Omid	[**lifts his leg pretending to knee Natalie**
17		(0.8)
18	Omid	+nä jag vill vara här no I want to be here *+lowers his leg*
19	Lana	ja: vi får vara här yea:h we're allowed to be here
20	Natalie	nä no

21 Omid +vad tänker du göra?
what you gonna do about it?
+*moves over to stand next to Lana and Salina and crosses his arms*



22 Natalie du står framför kameran ellerhur
you're standing in front of the camera aren't you
23 Omid och?
so?

Without hesitation, Natalie approaches Omid, initially addressing him with what appears to be a polite "excuse me" (14). However, this quickly escalates into a more emotionally charged confrontation as she tells him to: "move your fat ass", accompanied by a physical push and a demonstrative gesture towards the camera, asserting that he is in the way. This shift in footing, from polite address to verbal insult and physical action, marks a clear escalation in her response. Unlike the earlier, playful interruptions by Lana and Salina, Omid's presence is treated as a direct interference with the ongoing figure skating activity, a clear transgression. The incident significantly alters the previously playful atmosphere, drawing attention to the camera and its significance as more than a peripheral object. Natalie's reaction underscores the camera's importance, positioning it as something to be protected.

The seriousness of Natalie's actions is reflected in the heightened emotional responses from the other children. Omid initially responds physically, raising a leg in a mock fighting stance (16), before verbally asserting his emotional investment by stating he "wants to be there" (18). Lana immediately steps in to defend him, firmly instructing Natalie to "leave him alone" (15), and supporting her position with an appeal to shared entitlement to the public space of the stairwell (19). When Natalie rejects this claim with a direct "no" (20) Omid challenges her authority with a provocative question: "what you gonna to do about it?" (21). Interestingly, although Natalie initiated the confrontation, she now refrains from matching Omid's emotional tone. Instead she adopts a more reasoned stance, returning to the core issue of him blocking the camera (22). This move frames her actions as justified, appealing to presumed shared understanding that access to the camera—and by extension, the ability to participate in the figure skating activity—is a legitimate right that Omid should recognize and respect.

While this situation may not represent an equally overt example of breaking the fourth wall, given the absence of direct address to an outside audience, it nevertheless offers valuable insight into the children's awareness of, and

orientation toward the camera and its social uses, as well as its perceived relevance for specific activities. Indeed, certain activities appeared to be highly contingent on the camera's presence, to the extent that their meaning or coherence would be compromised in its absence. In this sense, the figure skating practice is not entirely meaningful in and of itself, but rather gains significance through the imagined presence of an audience of the girl's performative actions. From this perspective, Omid's physical positioning—although initially unrelated to the girls' activity—is treated as a genuine disruption to their interaction, and becomes a catalyst for negotiating the issue of entitlement on multiple levels. A particular noteworthy dimension of this is how the basic entitlement to occupy and move freely within the school's public spaces is brought into tension with the more implicit entitlement to be recorded and "seen". Viewed from a broader ethnographic perspective, and with knowledge of the children's local social hierarchies, it is also interesting how Natalie, who did not possess the same social standing as Omid, and certainly not Salina and Lana, who were among the most popular, asserts herself so decisively in opposing what she sees as Omid's inappropriate behavior. This further highlights the social significance attributed to the camera and how being filmed, for some children, conferred a form of status, thus serving as a legitimate basis for challenging existing social structures. In other words, the camera, in this context, not only documented but also enabled forms of resistance and agency, inspiring some children to use confrontational means that might not otherwise have been available to them.

Concluding discussion

Building on the fundamental ethnographic principle of capturing participants' naturally occurring social interactions, many ethnographers have reflected on and discussed the implications of their presence in children's everyday lives from a general perspective (see e.g. Jonsson, 2007; Eder & Corsaro, 1999; Lundström, 2020). In this chapter, however, we have aimed to take this reflection a step further by conducting a more direct analysis of children's innovative uses of the camera and how it fulfils local social purposes. In doing so, we challenge the notion that the camera constitutes merely an intrusive presence in their ongoing lives.

By combining Goffman's micro-sociological framework with the cinematic concept of *breaking the fourth wall,* we have tried to demonstrate how children not only orient themselves to the camera, but also use it strategically to co-organize their participation while positioning themselves in relation to various audiences. This includes, for example, staging performative acts that express alignments or disalignments with both present and non-present parties (cf. M. H. Goodwin, 2007). Rather than dismissing such data as "unnatural" or analytically irrelevant, we argue that children's interaction with the camera can and should be analyzed in its own right, and that this approach offers

valuable insight into children's social concerns within their peer cultures. Moreover, we have adopted a broader ethnographic perspective to illuminate children's sense-making processes and cultures-in-action (cf. Evaldsson, 2007, 2021). This has involved exploring, for instance, how the camera serves as a tool for challenging existing social hierarchies (Excerpt 5), as well as a platform for engaging with central issues in their lives that align with the focus of the fieldwork. Notably, we have shown how participating children use the camera to explicitly guide the researcher's attention, actions and focus by raising topics of clear scientific interest (see Excerpt 3-4). Viewed from this perspective, the children's direct and indirect communication with the researcher offers important insight into their understanding of the research process, as interpreted through their own local circumstances.

In sum, this explorative study contributes to a more nuanced understanding of how children's direct interaction with the camera in ethnographic research affords them agency on multiple levels. This includes the capacity to influence ongoing social dynamics, activities and relationships, as well as the opportunity to share their in-depth knowledge and perspectives on issues central to the constitution of social life in school settings.

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Tracing the accomplishment of disabilities identities: The case of a student on the autism spectrum

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Introduction

Identity construction and transformation in the context of special education and inclusive schooling have been of long-standing interest to Ann-Carita. Together with colleagues, she has published a series of papers showing how children with special needs are co-constructed as students of different types, such as active and compliant, or resisting teachers' authority and categorization. Evaldsson and Svahn (2019) trace a transformation in the identity of a girl with ADHD from that of an 'unwilling' participant to that of an 'active and interested' student in classroom lessons; it is shown how the child's growing agency is fostered by the teacher's emotional and relational scaffolding to support her engagement und active participation (255). Evaldsson and Melander (2017) reveal how a student with ADHD resists the teachers' categorization as in special need for help and thus gains more agency in the classroom over time. Evaldsson (2014) and Hjörne and Evaldsson (2015) disclose how references to biomedical diagnostic criteria invoke specific disability identities that at the same time mark behavior as norm-deviant and inappropriate. Identity work may also come into play in peer interactions when repeated embodied derogatory stances—such as labelling a boy with learning disabilities as 'coward', 'rule-breaker and 'idiot'—lead to the categorization of the boy as an outsider. By positioning themselves contrastively as 'real warrior boys', the others simultaneously establish and reaffirm shared understandings about masculinity (Evaldsson & Aarsand, 2023).

Methodologically, two features stand out in Ann-Carita's work on situated and institutional identity formation: the use of Membership Categorization Analysis (Sacks, 1972, 1989; Hester & Eglin, 1997) and of sequential and multimodal analysis of interaction (Goodwin, 2017; Mondada, 2018). In Ann-Carita's work, identity accomplishment and attribution are always to be found in all embodied resources available to participants—language, the body, and the environment (see also Burdelski & Fukuda 2019; Mondada, 2021; Rossi & Stivers, 2020). We would like to follow up on this rich line of Ann-Caritas' research and build on it in the following way: On the basis of a case analysis, our short paper aims to exemplify how teaching staff accomplish specific "disability identities" (Renshaw et al., 2014) of children on the autism spectrum

by invoking membership categories through talk and bodily behavior. Previous research on membership categories in educational institutions has predominantly focused on how educators categorize students through explicit categories or category attributes, for example in referral meetings (Hester, 1991), or in communication books exchanged between parents and teachers (Renshaw, 2014; Hjörne & Evaldsson, 2020), or test situations (Maynard, 2005). In this paper, we examine how social categories become visible through the actions performed by educators and students, drawing on the notion of "category-sensitive actions" (Rossi & Stivers, 2020). Unlike the term *category-bound activity*, this notion enables us to focus on specific moves within a sequence (rather than larger activities) and to include actions that are not strictly bound to a particular category but are rather "governed by social norms tied to membership in social categories" (ibid., p. 50).

Capturing the tacit processes through which social categories are invoked requires the analyst to "demonstrate the operational relevance of a given membership category when this is not explicitly articulated" (ibid., p. 53). Rossi and Stivers suggest that membership categories can be tacitly invoked at the levels of action design, action ascription, and the rights and constraints to perform certain actions. Our analysis focuses primarily on *action design*, that is, how participants choose among alternative practices and resources when performing a certain type of action (e.g., issuing a request or a directive to establish attention) and how, through this design, they reflexively evoke membership in a given category (e.g., 'child-like', 'disabled'). In addition, we examine the accomplishment of intercorporeal participation frameworks (Goodwin & Cekaite, 2013), i.e., publicly visible configurations of bodies for (inter)action and cooperation in particular activities, as a level at which membership categories operate. We argue that the concept of *participation framework* is closely linked to the concept of *action*: participation frameworks are established through participants' coordinated actions and at the same time provide an interpretative frame for further action. Therefore, they display how the participants interpret the situation, including their category-sensitive expectations about the co-participants.

In our paper, we analyze a situation in which a child diagnosed with autism, Matteo, does not engage in the task that was assigned to all students in a classroom. Two adults, the German language teacher and a learning support assistant, establish what we will call a *third-party secured participation framework* and employ indirect and mitigated requests, as well as audible and tactile signals such as drumming on the table and frequent touch, to establish mutual attention, while simultaneously categorizing the child in particular ways. Both requests and touch, especially in their combination, can be regarded as category-sensitive actions in the classroom: typically, adults—especially teachers and parents—have the right to request something from students, to touch them to solicit attention (Bergnehr & Cekaite, 2018; Heinonen et al., 2020; Heller, 2023) or even to guide them manually to organize their co-presence and

accessibility as participants (Kern, 2018). Importantly, the form and use of requests and touch vary according to students' age: Bergnehr and Cekaite (2018) observe a decrease in adult-initiated touch and suggest that this decline reflects widespread expectations in Western cultures that children should be fostered to become competent and self-reliant social actors. Thus, the choice of a particular touch practice can become a resource for categorizing children in terms of 'age-appropriate competence', 'half-membership' (Forrester, 2010), or—as we would like to demonstrate—'disability'.

In the following section, we provide background on inclusive education in Germany and on autism, before presenting our data and analytical approach. We then examine the participation framework and the design of actions used to reinvolve the child in an activity that was assigned to all children in the classroom. Our discussion highlights how action design is oriented to the category of having 'child-like abilities' and being 'in need of special attention' while at the same time giving rise to an interactional trajectory in which this categorization is confirmed and reified.

Background: Inclusive education in Germany

Since the UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities became legally binding in Germany in 2009, students with special needs have the right to be taught in mainstream schools. This legal entitlement has presented the German school system, which is traditionally highly segregated, with a number of problems. In most federal states, separation begins after the 4th school year, with two or three types of school to choose from. The *Gymnasium* (grammar school) leads to A-level graduation exclusively which grants access to higher education such as universities, whereas comprehensive schools additionally lead to O-level or high school diploma equivalents, thereby preparing for vocational training as well. In addition, there are still special education schools which traditionally accommodate children with special needs, claiming that they can provide better individual support for the children (Sturm, 2025). Disability identity is thus institutionally highly relevant as it opens the way to additional resources (e.g., learning support assistants, special education teachers) for the classroom. In this particular context, and for the purpose at hand, the different disability identities are derived from the medical model, which means that they are primarily viewed as deficient, pathological, and deviating from the norm (cf. Renshaw et al., 2014).

Autism

Biomedical approaches regard autism as a neurological condition affecting communicative and interactive behavior (DCM-5; American Psychiatric Association, 2013). Persons on the autism spectrum are said to exhibit uncommon communicative behaviors, such as formulaic speech ("echolalia"),

repetitive bodily and/or verbal behavior, or atypical use of eye gaze or prosody. Because the interpretation of a behavior as 'uncommon' or 'atypical' reflects a non-autistic perspective, we use quotation marks to highlight the perspectival nature of the term. While 'uncommon' behavior may affect interactions with others in several ways (Wiklund, 2016; Kilpiä et al., 2023), in this paper, we focus particularly on how teachers and assistants interact with a student on the autism spectrum when the student is working on a course assignment. Our aim is to show how the teacher together with the student's learning support assistant establishes the student's identity through actions and practices that invoke specific membership categories (Burdelski & Fukuda, 2019; Rossi & Stivers, 2020; Mondada, 2021).

Data and methods

The case presented below stems from on a collection of 60 hours of video recordings featuring classroom interactions in German secondary schools involving 10 autistic children. The recorded lessons include plenary sessions as well as group and individual work across two subject areas—German language lessons and STEM—in grades 5 to 8, along with an additional 12 hours of peer interactions. Three cameras were used during filming to capture (1) the teacher, (2) the focal child together with their peers, and (3) a full-room view. The multimodal transcriptions were conducted using modified versions of (Mondada, 2018) and the GAT 2.0 system (Selting et al., 2011).

For the case study and analysis, an extract from a Year 6 lesson was selected, in which a teacher (the 'regular' German language teacher) and the autistic boy's assistant turn to him in order to encourage his engagement in the task that had been previously assigned to all students and which the children were asked to complete individually. The extract was then carefully transcribed with stills inserted to facilitate multimodal analysis. Afterwards, an analysis inspired by ethnomethodological conversation analysis (EMCA) and Membership Categorization Analysis (MCA) was conducted, drawing on the notions of category-sensitive actions, action design, and participation frameworks (see above).

Analysis

Similar to Hjörne and Evaldsson (2020), categories such as 'autistic boy' or 'child with special needs' are rarely used explicitly in classroom interaction represented in our video corpus. Instead, category work often occurs incidentally and becomes evident, for instance, in participants' expectations regarding their co-participants' assumed competence to perform tasks assigned to them, or interactional demands the student is deemed capable of managing (Heller & Kern, 2021).

In the extract examined here, category work becomes visible in the design of actions, that is, in the ways actions are constructed and display orientation to particular membership categories. A teacher and an assistant design attention-soliciting actions in ways characteristic of interactions with individuals requiring special support for participation. They do so, first, by creating an intercorporeal participation framework (Goodwin & Cekaite, 2013) that reinforces and secures a dyadic F-formation (Kendon, 1990) through the presence of a third party positioned behind the student, prompting him to engage with the interlocutor in front of him. Second, they engage in concerted actions involving summonses, indirect requests, frequent touch, and rhythmic drumming on the table. From a Membership Categorization perspective, the design of these actions is reminiscent of interactions with *small children*, thereby evoking the latent category of someone unable to adhere to common-sense rules of attention and classroom engagement, and, at the same time, with restricted rights concerning their own body (Goffman, 1963, p. 40; Kern, 2018).

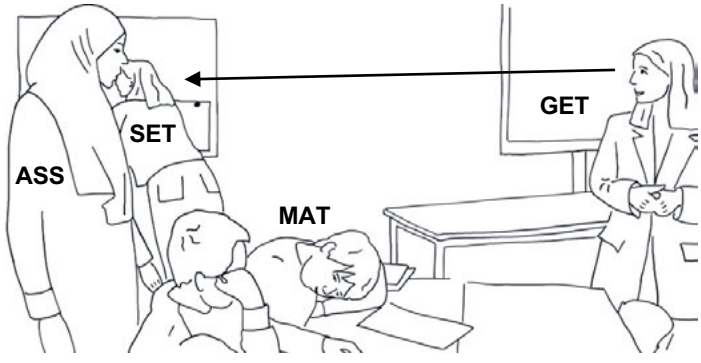
We trace how implicit categorization unfolds sequentially, ultimately culminating in an overt, albeit silent, embodied comment that conveys the professionals' categorization of the child as having 'child-like abilities' and not 'being able or willing to engage' in interaction without strong support. We further demonstrate that the student resists the age-inappropriate action design and the categorization associated with it. From the professionals' perspective, however, this resistance is itself treated as behavior indicative of 'not being able or willing to engage'. In this way, their actions lead to a behavior on the side of the child they then interpret as confirming and reinforcing their categorization.

The extract is taken from a German lesson in an inclusive sixth-grade class comprising several students with diagnosed special needs. The students are working on poetic devices for making comparisons using a poem by the German writer Heinz Erhardt. They have just begun an individual work phase, during which they are to complete a worksheet. Matteo (MAT), the student with a diagnosis of autism, has had his head on his desk for some time, including during the preceding whole-class discussion. Three professionals are present, a German language teacher (GET), a special educational teacher (SET), and an assistant (ASS).

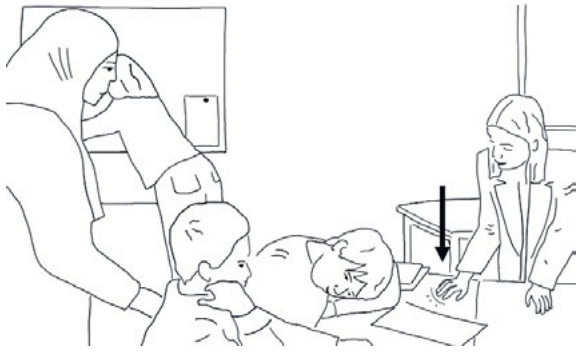
Ges2_6d_Deu_241203_LK-t1 #0:31:03.0#

```
001    SET-vb    oKAY;
                 all right
002              ich stell den timer mal auf FÜNFzehn minuten,
                 I set the timer for fifteen minutes
003              dann schaun wir mal wie weit du geKOMmen bi:st,
                 and then we'll see how much you've achieved
004              | (0.1)  | 0.1)  |  (0.2)  |
       SET-mo    |sets the timer, searches material-----------|
       MAT-po    -upper body lies on table-------------------->>
```

ASS-po |walks tow. MAT, comes to stand behind him----|
ASS-gz |at GET--|at MAT----------------------------->
GET-mo |walks tow. MAT, stops in front of table |
GET-gz |at ASS--|at SET--|at ASS--|at ASS------------>

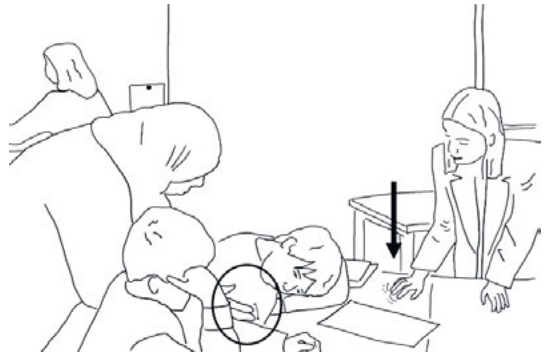


005 ASS-vb |**matTEO;** |
ASS-po |leans tow. MAT--|
GET-po |leans tow. MAT--|
GET-ge |drums on table-->

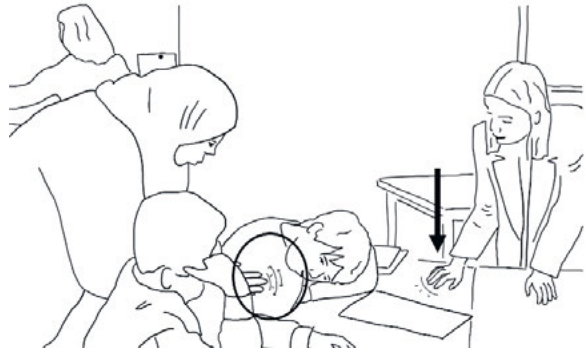


006 ASS-vb |GUCK mal; |
look
ASS-tc |taps MAT's shoulder 2x |
GET-ge |drums on table---------->
MAT-po ------------------------->

007 ASS-vb |frau KRUMM ist da; | (0.2)
miss krumm is here
ASS-tc |pats MAT's elbow 2x-|
GET-ge |drums on table------|
MAT-po ---------------------->



008 ASS-vb |**matTEO; (.)**
ASS-tc |pats MAT's elbow----------|
GET-ge |drums two fingers alternately on table----->
MAT-po ---------->



009 ASS-vb |**matTEO;**
ASS-tc |pats MAT's elbow|
GET-ge ----------|
MAT-po ----------|shakes off ASS' hand

010 | (0.5) | (0.1) | (0.3)
ASS-gz |at GET, points head tow. MAT|down---|at GET--|
ASS-po |leans back against windowsill----------|
GET-po |stays at table---------->
GET-gz |tow. SET---------->
MAT-po ---------->



011 GET-vb |<<p> willst DU | [oder soll ich;>]
do you want or should I
GET-ge |points at MAT--|
GET-gz |at SET---------|

012 SET-vb [MACH ich]gleich;=
I'll do that in a moment
SET-gz |at GET---------|



013 SET-vb |=JA, |
okay
SET-mo walks to other table->
GET-ge |nods |
ASS-po |leans back |

When the special education teacher initiates the individual work phase by setting the timer (001–004), Matteo does not respond. He remains with his upper body resting on the desk, eyes open, staring into space. This bodily posture resembles what Goffman (1963, p. 69) describes as an "away", through which individuals signal an "inward emigration from the gathering" and indicate that they are not available for engagement. Matteo's relaxed posture appears less an expression of distress than an attempt to take a break from the numerous audio-visual stimuli present in the classroom. In everyday interactions, including classroom settings, however, such bodily displays of disengagement might become subject to strict situational regulations (Goffman, 1963, p. 107).

Both the assistant and the German teacher respond to Matteo's display of disengagement: The assistant positions herself behind him, observing the German language teacher, who likewise approaches Matteo but stops in front of his desk in order to check visually whether the special education teacher is available (004). This checking glance toward the special education teacher expresses the expectation that she is primarily responsible for the child in this situation. Indeed, one of the reasons why the special education teacher is in this classroom is because of Matteo. At the same time, this ascription of responsibility reflects the German teacher's orientation towards Matteo as a student requiring special—not 'regular'—pedagogical expertise. Since the

special education teacher is otherwise occupied, the German teacher moves closer to Matteo's desk.

While the German language teacher comes to stand vis-à-vis Matteo, creating a spatial arrangement in which face-to-face interaction can occur, the assistant remains in her position behind the child (004). An intercorporeal participation framework emerges (Goodwin & Cekaite, 2013, p. 129) not designed to enable smooth multiparty interaction, but rather to reinforce and secure a dyadic interaction between the German teacher and Matteo through the assistant's prompts. The adults' positionings in front and behind the student thus expands their opportunities for potential action and monitoring: Both adults have visual access to each other as well as to Matteo, whereas Matteo, from his reclined position, cannot see them—especially not the assistant standing behind him. Moreover, the adults' standing positions prevent them from establishing a shared interactional space with Matteo (Ciolek & Kendon, 1980) and rule out interaction at eye level. By attending to Matteo as a team of two, the adults enact an expectation of participation and communication difficulties on the student's part, which are to be addressed through concerted action. In this way, an implicit categorization of Matteo as 'being not able or willing to engage in interaction (and with the task at hand) in age-appropriate ways' and 'needing special attention' is evoked.

Subsequently, the German language teacher leans forward (005) while rhythmically tapping her fingers on the table. This soft drumming could be heard as an audible request to establish mutual attention. She does not, however, address Matteo verbally, so the signal she uses to attract his attention remains weak, and possibly ambiguous to him. The teacher's actions suggest both her uncertainty about Matteo's willingness to participate, and her hesitation to take responsibility for supporting him.

In parallel, the assistant leans over Matteo from behind and quietly calls his name (005). She produces an embodied directive with *look* (006), laminated with light taps on Matteo's upper arm while leaning over him from behind. Immediately thereafter, she verbalizes a *noticing* (Schegloff, 2007, p. 219) regarding the teacher's presence (007). The design of this attention-soliciting move further contributes to the latent categorization at play: *Look, X is here* constitutes an exclamative format typically employed in interactions with young children to express surprise (Anna & Pfeiffer, 2021) and to establish joint attention to something or someone in the environment—in this case, the German language teacher. Here, the exclamative format functions as an indirect request aimed at channeling Matteo toward interaction with the German language teacher. Unlike directives, which tell the recipient to do something and demand accelerated fulfilment (e.g*., you have to look + name or now wake up*, cf. Heller, 2023), requests ask the recipient to do something and are thus constructed as contingent on the latter's ability or willingness to comply (cf. Craven & Potter, 2010). Designing the action as an indirect request and formulating it as a noticing of a person whose presence Matteo is already aware

of again evokes the category of 'not being able or willing to interact in age-appropriate ways'.

The childlike or infantilizing action design is equally reflected in the nature and frequency of touch. After first tapping Matteo's upper arm—an energetic and directive form of touch also referred to as "control touch" (Cekaite, 2016; Heinonen et al., 2020; Heller, 2023), the assistant turns to softly patting his elbow. Two further embodied summonses by the assistant (008 and 009) are again designed as packages that combine language and touch—this time, the touch is a slow, cautious pat on his elbow. At no point is Matteo explicitly or unequivocally expected—or entrusted—to establish attention on his own; instead many resources are mobilized to facilitate his access to interaction. At the same time, Matteo's bodily conduct is not overtly framed as a norm violation which one might expect in the classroom. In turn, this dispenses him from the kind of accountability (Garfinkel, 1967) normally applied to participants in interaction, and especially from students in classrooms (Cekaite, 2012). Throughout this time, the German language teacher maintains the soft drumming on the table from her front position, without, however, projecting a meaningful object or activity Matteo could orient to. Matteo remains in his position but upon the third patting, shrugs off the assistant's hand with a shoulder movement (009). Rather than admonishing him, the assistant withdraws from the interaction and, by adjusting her posture and gaze, constitutes a participation framework that excludes Matteo and involves only herself and the German language teacher.

Once this is established, the assistant looks at the German language teacher, lips pressed together, briefly lowering her head in Matteo's direction. In this way, she produces an embodied, wordless commentary on Matteo. Even though its meaning cannot be reconstructed, the withdrawal from interaction with Matteo and the embodied commentary *about* him (while he is present) suggest that his behavior is interpreted as 'noticeable' or maybe even 'irritating'. In this sense, it can be understood as *recognitional work* in Hester's (1991) terms: it displays the participants' interpretation of the situation, "of their being respondents to an independent or objective set of problems within the school" (ibid., p. 461), and functions as a normalizing device for extraordinary events (Jefferson, 2004).

The embodied commentary goes unnoticed by the German teacher, as she, too, has already withdrawn from the interaction with Matteo and turns her gaze to the special education teacher. With her alternative question "do you want, or should I" (011) she attempts to recruit the special education teacher to take responsibility for resolving the issue, the contrast between *want* and *should* signaling that the task properly belongs to the special education teacher. Again, the negotiation of responsibility conveys the German language teacher's orientation toward Matteo as a student requiring special—not 'regular pedagogical expertise. The special education teacher agrees, and the two

other adults depart, thereby bringing their interaction with (and about) Matteo to a close.

Through the whole exchange between the two adults, Matteo's head remains on the table. At no point does he respond positively to their tentative attempts to persuade him to get to the task at hand. While at the beginning, Matteo possibly assumes his posture for a short break from the noisy classroom, a shift in stance can be detected when he repeatedly ignores the German language teacher's attempt to get his attention and finally shakes off the assistant's hand. By resisting both adults' attempts to get him to engage in classroom work, he retains control over his body and his actions, thereby maintaining his agency.

In sum, the adults' intervention does not change the status quo: Matteo remains with his head on the table, thus publicly disengaged from classroom activity. The *third-party secured dyadic framework* and the childlike design of actions reflect an understanding of his identity as someone who is 'not being able or willing to engage'. This perception is likely to be shaped by his diagnosis known to the teachers, and points to a particular disability identity—namely an autistic one. Matteo responded to these attempts to solicit his attention with continuous resistance. The professionals however treat his resistance as another indicator and confirmation of childlike behavior, as manifested in the assistant's embodied commentary. In this way, their concerted actions "contribute[s] to establishing and maintaining disability identities" (Hjörne & Evaldsson, 2020, p. 399).

Discussion

This paper has examined some of the practices and resources mobilized by teachers and assistants in designing actions in category-sensitive ways and in constructing a specific disability identity of a student diagnosed on the autism spectrum. Drawing on the notion of *category-sensitive action* (Rossi & Stivers, 2020), we investigated the multimodal establishment and configuration of intercorporeal participation frameworks and the category-sensitive design of attention-seeking actions within these frameworks, thereby following Ann-Carita's proposal to combine multimodal interaction analysis with membership categorization analysis (MCA). The focus was on a situation in which a student diagnosed with autism does not engage in the assigned classroom task but displays continuous embodied disengagement instead. In an attempt to solicit his attention and engage in the task, a teacher and the child's assistant created a participation framework which we described as a *third-party reinforced dyadic framework*. Within this framework, teacher and assistant design actions to seek attention for which they use packages of embodied resources, especially language and touch, but also tapping. The specific design of these actions, and in particular the frequency and types of touches evoke not only the membership category of someone who is 'not able or willing to engage in

interaction' but also that of a 'small child'. In this sense, the assistant's soft pats present publicly visible transgressions into Matteo's 'personal territory of the self' (Goffman, 1971) and thus establish his status as a member who has no full autonomy over his own body (Kern, 2018)—a feature associated with the category of 'child' (Goffman, 1963, p. 84). Additionally, the teacher's negotiation with the special education teacher also contributes to Matteo's assignment to the membership category 'child': Talking about someone who is present (and very possibly listening) is usually reserved for persons who are not considered full members (Goffman 1959, p. 152).[9] It should be noted though that Matteo's ongoing resistance to the teacher's and assistant's coordinated attempts, reaching its climax when he shakes off the assistant's hand, is an important expression of his agency.

In sum, throughout the sequence, and on several layers of the interaction, Matteo is approached as someone who needs special treatment, and, as such, special encouragement to engage in interaction and in classroom tasks, thus evoking a particular disability identity. When the intervention does not succeed, the German language teacher withdraws from the interaction and delegates responsibility to the special education teacher while the assistant produces an embodied commentary during her withdrawal. Both actions could be seen as normalizing practices in dealing with situations in which the autistic student is visibly disengaged in classroom activity. At the same time, they illustrate in an exemplary manner the everyday problems of inclusive classrooms in German mainstream schools in which teachers often hand over responsibility for students with special needs to the special education teachers, and cooperation between the various actors in the classroom is often difficult (Neumann & Lütje-Klose, 2021).

Arguably, the teachers' specific ways of dealing with the student's temporarily displayed disengagement can be traced back to the 'medical model' of autism which views autistic children as interactionally incompetent and in extra need of attention especially when communication is concerned. The teacher and assistant seem to act on this implicit knowledge when they make a concerted effort to gain his attention. And while the teacher's and assistant's attempts are not interactively successful, they serve to maintain the institutionally relevant disability category of a 'student unable or unwilling to engage in interaction' and thus construct Matteo as different from the other students in the classroom. The student's 'childification' (as we would like to call it)[10] might provide a face-saving way of dealing with his temporary visible disengagement. In this way, the intertwinement of both membership categories invoked in this sequence—i.e. that of a disabled student with interactional

[9] Goffman (1959, p. 152) states in this respect "(…) there are other standard categories of persons who are sometimes treated in their presence as if they were not there; the very young, the very old, and the sick are common examples."

[10] We have opted for the term 'childification' instead of 'infantilization' because we wanted to avoid the negative connotation of the latter.

problems and that of a young child—are highly functional to the professionals. At the same time, they reproduce what Hjörne and Evaldsson (2020, p. 397) describe as "categories [being] part of an 'institutional machinery' (Mehan et al., 1986, p. 164) through which schools simultaneously (re)produce knowledge and coordinate its daily practices". The membership categorizations as outlined by this case study might thus provide a solution for a constantly recurring practical problem for teachers in inclusive school settings. At the same time, Matteo's ongoing resistance shows how such membership categorizations can be dealt with and locally overcome on the student's side.

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The importance of others in identity construction

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Introduction

> The self, as that which can be an object to itself, is essentially a social structure, and it arises in social experience. After a self has arisen, it in a certain sense provides for itself its social experiences, and so we can conceive of an absolutely solitary self. But it is impossible to conceive of a self arising outside of social experience
>
> - Mead 1934, 140

In this essay, I aim to discuss how identity is constructed and transformed in interaction with others. In doing so I will focus on how a medical-psychiatric diagnosis can become part of someone's identity in different ways. I will discuss mainly two of Ann-Carita Evaldsson's works on this subject: Evaldsson and Svahn (2019) and Hjörne and Evaldsson (2015). Similar to my own research, both papers deal with special educational school settings, in which not only the students' perspective on their own diagnosis becomes relevant to identity formation but also the teachers', parents', and peers' perspective.

Among the most common psychiatric diagnoses that the Swedish schools need to address are *Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder* (ADHD) and *Autism Spectrum Disorder* (ASD). As I started my PhD journey, with Ann-Carita as my main supervisor, it was important to me that my research made clear that a psychiatric diagnosis does not, in and of itself, determine negative expectations or restrict a student's possibilities for action and self-understanding. Throughout my research, the two papers that I have chosen to discuss in this chapter have served as clear examples of how the implications of a psychiatric diagnosis can shift depending on how it is used in interaction and that the identity of a student is flexible, negotiable and can be more or less shaped by the medical-psychiatric diagnosis.

This essay serves as a contribution to Ann-Caritas festschrift, and is a way for me to highlight a theme that has been of mutual interest in hers and my own research: how identity is constructed in interaction with particular focus on how the use of diagnostic labels influence identity processes. In the following sections I will describe and discuss the two papers which I think show the importance of studying identity processes as an interactive phenomenon in educational research.

A girl with ADHD as "an agentive learner"

The paper by Evaldsson and Svahn (2019) is situated in a special support school in Sweden. This paper focuses on a girl with ADHD, Mariam, who, throughout the school year, goes from being an "unwilling student" to becoming an "agentive learner". Using an ethnographic framework, Evaldsson and Svahn describe how this identity transition is accomplished through the everyday interactions between the student and the education staff. Throughout the school year, the teachers' actions and communications with Mariam aim at amplifying her competences and positioning her as able to learn. In her interactions with the teacher, Mariam gradually confirms herself as able and thus co-construct her identity as an agentive learner. By the end of the school year, Mariam is understood by her teacher as well as by herself as someone who has the competences and abilities to handle school, both intellectually and emotionally. This paper is an important example of how teachers and students work together to construct an identity that is useful for the learning process. In this case, the fact that Mariam has an ADHD diagnosis does not seem to become too central to how the student is understood by the teachers nor by herself.

In identity construction, categories such as psychiatric diagnoses can become central to how individuals understand themselves. This is not necessarily a bad thing but can be risky if a diagnosis becomes an element that confirms inabilities and insecurities. The trajectory illustrated by Evaldsson and Svahn (2019) is a clear example of how the competences of the education professionals allow the student to identify with useful categories such as "collaborative student" and "agentive learner" rather than overfocusing on difficulties and limitations. Furthermore, the paper demonstrates how individuals (children and young people in particular) can resist, negotiate, and at times confirm the roles assigned to them, as well as how much these roles should define who they are. In the study by Evaldsson and Svahn, we see how Mariam actively co-constructs her identity in interaction with the teachers. Initially, Mariam resists the "learner" identity through both her embodied actions and verbal expressions. However, as the school year progresses, she gradually shifts towards acting as emotionally competent and capable of planning and carrying out school-related tasks.

Identity, or how you see yourself, also incorporates how others see you. Furthermore, identity is not only an abstract idea of yourself but it also influences the choices you make and what you believe is possible for you to achieve. This makes identity an important aspect to consider in learning processes. The work by Evaldsson and Svahn is an example of a recurring theme in Ann-Carita's work, namely the reciprocity in the construction of identity and educational trajectories. The paper illustrates how the education professionals can make an important impact on how young students see themselves and, as a consequence, on the types of choices and actions that are available for them in their learning process. It also highlights the importance of having

educational professionals who challenge limiting beliefs that students might have on themselves as well as confirming useful identities such as being a competent and agentive learner. Perhaps even more importantly, the research by Evaldsson and Svahn exemplifies the focus in Ann-Carita's work on how children's agency and voices matter greatly in shaping their identity and their educational trajectories and thus also the importance of including their voices in research.

A girl with ADHD as "the ADHD girl"

In Hjörne and Evaldsson (2015), the authors show how the ADHD diagnosis of a young student, Annika, is solidified and becomes a central category in the student's identity. In this paper the data are drawn from the communication books that passed between the parents and teachers, and from ethnographic work during a period of one school year. During the beginning of the year, Annika is configured as capable of handling her school life, but by the end of the year she is constructed as disabled and as a "typical ADHD girl". The analysis in the paper shows how in the communication between teachers and parents as well as in interactions with her classmates and with the teachers, Annika's behaviours are more and more understood through the medical-psychiatric diagnostic category of ADHD. For example, the parents explain and legitimise certain troublesome behaviours as symptoms of her disorder, and from the teachers' side, Annikas behaviours become increasingly seen as a consequence of not having taken her medication and in this way orient toward ADHD as the disorder that causes the troublesome behaviours.

Drawing on Sacks (1992), Hjörne and Evaldsson show how Annikas ADHD diagnosis turns into a social label that others (and also she herself) use to define her in a significant way. In comparison to Mariams trajectory thus, the diagnostic label ADHD becomes a central element to who Annika is, for herself and for others. A psychiatric diagnosis could be a central element to how a person understands oneself without becoming a restraining element. In Annikas school life however, ADHD becomes an element that reinforces problematic behaviours and Annika seeing herself as someone problematic. Considering if and how opportunities are given to Annika to see herself as capable, competent, and having friendships, interactions that centre around her being problematic and negatively different likely limit rather than enrichen her sense of self.

The importance of studying identity in education

Both Evaldsson and Svahn (2019) and Hjörne and Evaldsson (2015) explore special educational contexts and in both studies the student in focus has an ADHD diagnosis. However, the students' identities, and the significance that the diagnosis acquires, differ. In Evaldsson and Svahn (2019) the interactions between the student and the teacher confirm the student as competent and an agentive learner. In this case, the ADHD diagnosis does not seem to acquire a

central role. In Hjörne and Evaldsson (2015) on the other hand, the ADHD diagnosis ends up having a central role in the sense that it explains and confirms problematic behaviours as residing inside the student.

Placement of students in separate special educational contexts is a contested question, and it seems reasonable that separation of students favours perceptions of being different and not belonging. The two studies I have been discussing are interesting in relation to this question because they show two very different identity processes both occurring in special educational contexts. In Evaldsson and Svahn (2019) the young student Mariam is approached by her teacher, and more and more by herself, beyond the diagnostic category and more in relation to categories of competences that have to do with the educational context—such as "co-operative student" and "agentive learner". Differently, in Hjörne and Evaldsson (2015), the diagnostic category becomes a central element in how Annika is identified and how her actions are interpreted. Even though it seems adequate to think that placement in a special context favours some kind of identification as being different from those who are in the mainstream, regular context, these two studies show that the education professionals can have a great impact on how the students' understand themselves and how capable they believe themselves to be- in school and perhaps also in the life that will take place after they finish school.

Research into how identities are constructed through interaction within school environments highlights the significance of the self-understandings of the students in how they navigate their schoolwork. To believe in oneself as competent, and to have this identity confirmed by teachers, is a crucial part of the learning process. My reason for choosing to research how the diagnosis autism spectrum disorder influences the interactions between students, parents and education professionals in special educational settings is rooted in the understanding that diagnostic labels inevitably contribute to shape how the students view themselves and how they are seen by others. In theory, a diagnosis need not carry a defining or restrictive role within the school context. It can be approached in ways that open new opportunities for students, or conversely, it can impose unnecessary limitations. This is the reason why interactional research about identity, labels and education matters, because it helps us better understand the processes that either keep doors open for students to learn and believe in themselves, or risk closing them. Ann-Carita's works are clear examples of how the difference happens in interaction between the children, their peers and the adults surrounding them.

Identity construction and young people's voices

The above two papers were chosen as illustrations of how identity and its relation to diagnostic labels are co-constructed in interaction. This point is also illustrated in various ways in other works by Evaldsson and her colleagues (for example Evaldsson, 2014; Evaldsson and Melander, 2017; Evaldsson and

Velasquez, 2012; Tassinari Rogalin, Magnússon, Evaldsson, 2025). I think all these works illustrate a few key points to the theoretical assumptions that I use in my research: Identity is always constructed in interaction; a diagnostic label does not in itself imply that identity will revolve around the diagnostic label. In school, interactions might generate the diagnosis as a main element of the student and other interactions might place other characteristics or categories as more central to how the students are understood (as "an agentive learner" for example). If a diagnosis becomes central to a student's identity, this does not entail something necessarily "negative". It can become something limiting if a focus on the diagnosis implies that inabilities are confirmed where they do not need to be confirmed (for example someone understanding themselves as "unable to have friends").

For me, the mentioned works exemplify the active role individuals play in supporting and sustaining each other. Be it a teacher and a student in compulsory school, or a PhD student and her supervisor. Although the example with Annika is more "negative" than the one with Mariam, both of them show the ability we have to encourage each other, the power that teachers have to form their students and also the students' capabilities to engage actively in understanding themselves. While Annika somewhat takes on the negative idea of herself, she also does her best to stand up for herself and display her discomfort in the special class she is placed in. Returning to the citation from Mead (1934) at the beginning of this text: the self arises through social experiences. Ann-Carita's scholarship has shown us how this process unfolds in daily interactions and how young students' perspectives are in constant transformation, in relation to their peers and the adults surrounding them.

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On social categories in peer interaction

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Prologue

A boy is ridiculed with a high pitch mocking voice. A girl is insulted with reference to her alleged sexual behavior. A boy is marginalized because of his lack of language proficiency. How can we analyze and describe the underlying common-sense knowledge that substantiates these rather mundane events in the school context?

The question of members' everyday understanding and management of their social life-world has been a central issue in ethnomethodology, starting from Sacks' notorious interest in the common-sense knowledge that members routinely deploy to interpret and predict others' behavior (Sacks, 1992). This broad interest can be more closely specified around members' deployment of *categories* and their associated predicates and attributes: individuals daily reconstruct and make sense of social action by displaying, ascribing, and negotiating membership to specific social categories ('women', 'bank clerks', 'Chinese people' and so on). Even though Sacks' insights gave way to a relevant milieu of studies (e.g., Jayyusi, 1984), until the early 2000s this stream of research remained rather peripheral within ethnomethodologically-oriented studies, which mainly revolved around Conversation Analysis (CA). Lately, a renewed interest in members' understanding and local use of social categories resulted in numerous studies on the topic, often under the common frame of Membership Categorization Analysis (MCA; Hester & Eglin, 1997; Stokoe, 2012; Housley & Fitzgerald, 2015; see also the studies in Antaki & Widdicombe, 1998). These studies share a concern with the empirical examination of members' orientation to social categories in interaction, focusing on the verbal, embodied, and material resources that people contingently deploy to construct themselves (or others) as members of a certain category (e.g., category bound to ethnicity, Whitehead, 2009, or gender, Stokoe, 2003).

Social categories in childhood and adolescence

This renewed interest was also sustained by studies on the common-sense knowledge and peer sociality of *children and adolescents*. Within this specific research domain, Ann-Carita Evaldsson's work was seminal in making children's and adolescents' understanding of social categories a viable topic of study in CA-oriented analyses (e.g., 2002, 2005, 2007). Evaldsson, together with other like-minded scholars, started focusing on the sequentiality and social relevance of children's and adolescents' orientation to social categories,

analyzing the daily re-construction of social identities and relationships in the peer group. These studies illustrated how the mobilization of membership categories in specific contexts of social action allowed children to negotiate and dispute their (mis)alignments to one another: in and through directives, assessments, teasing, storytelling, and other practices, children and adolescents resorted to both adult and peer-constructed social categories to re-negotiate their social selves and the overall order of the peer group (see Kyratzis and Goodwin, 2017 for an overview). These local uses of social categories were observed both in pretend play and in mundane interactions.

As regards *pretend play*, children were shown to resort to hierarchically ordered social roles (e.g., doctor-nurse-patient, mother-father-child, teacher-student) to sustain locally-constructed play frames. Notably, these social roles were often associated with category-bound ways of speaking, activities and rights. For instance, children enacted privileged and high-status roles (doctors, parents) through direct and unmitigated forms of requests, whereas they enacted lower status roles (patients, younger siblings) through more polite and indirect forms of request (Andersen, 1990; Cobb-Moore, 2012). In addition to category-bound ways of speaking, children invoked specific roles and social categories to assert the right to specific social actions, objects, or spaces. For example, children were shown to invoke the social category 'nurses' to claim the right to use a toy syringe ("I'm the nurse and the nurses getta do shots, remember?", Sheldon, 1997, p. 235). As evident from the latter example, when children assert membership to specific categories they are not simply 'playing' with characters, but negotiating real-life asymmetries—for instance, asymmetries in the access to specific materials or in processes of decision-making that influence the unfolding of everyday life in the peer group (Goodwin, 2006; Butler & Weatherall, 2006; Bateman, 2022; Davidson, 2022).

Apart from pretend play, children and adolescents might organize their *mundane interactions* with reference to social categories that are relevant within a specific context of social practice. Bound to each of these categories is a set of attributes and norms, which might be mobilized to interpret and assess other peers' behavior. For instance, boys might be negatively evaluated for not fulfilling the normative expectations associated with a certain idea of masculinity within the peer group culture (Evaldsson, 2021). These normative expectations also regard the overall morality of the peer group (i.e., the set of appropriate and inappropriate ways of behaving with peers). For example, adolescents have been shown to sanction another peer for calling on adults for help (ascribing her to the despised category of 'snitches'; Evaldsson & Svahn, 2012) and primary school children were recorded targeting a classmate for not telling the truth (ascribing him to the category of 'liars'; Nasi, 2024, p. 109f). On other occasions, children and adolescents make relevant social categories that are bound to ethnicity, mocking other peers for their (lack of) language proficiency (Evaldsson, 2005; Evaldsson & Cekaite, 2010), or recurrently blaming peers who are perceived as belonging to a racialized out-group category (e.g., Moroccan immigrants in Spain; García-Sánchez, 2014). These

ethnically-defined social categories are not only evoked in negative ways. For instance, adolescents have been shown to actively display their migratory background, claiming membership to an 'alien' social group and thereby indexing their hybrid identities (Corona et al., 2013). It is worth noting that these social categories might be bound to narratives and debates in the broader socio-cultural community (e.g., gender or ethnicity), but they might also be quite specific to a small community of practice. For instance, studies in the school context have shown how children orient to categories of competence and proficiency, negotiating their local identities and peer relationships on the basis of the local management of knowledge (e.g., who is 'the most knowledgeable student'? Melander, 2012; Morek, 2015).

An empirical illustration

These lengthy reflections are best discussed with a concrete example. Let's consider a stretch of peer interaction from Evaldsson's research, first published in the journal *Research on Language and Social Interaction* (Evaldsson, 2007). Three girls, aged between 11 and 12, are interacting in a primary school in Sweden, negotiating the rights and responsibilities that are associated with 'being a good friend' in the peer group. A girl, Jackie, accuses her classmates Leena of untoward behavior ('taking advantage of another girl'), prompting her to justify her actions and defend her membership to the category of the 'good friends'.

Excerpt

9	Jacky	å ↑Leena när du e- vi e me henne då
10		utnyttjar hon Zaida o e me henne. ↑å då
11		e hon inte längre me henne bara när vi har grupper (.)
12		↑när ni två e sams då kommer ni ba så här (.)
13		"o hon gjorde de o hon gjorde de" bara för att ni vill att vi ska va-
		And ↑Leena when you are- we are with her, then
		she takes advantage of Zaida and is with her. And then
		she's not with her any more only when it's group work (.)
		↑when you two are together then you two come like this (.)
		"she did this and she did that" only because you want us to-

((lines not shown))

26	Leena	[↑JA:: utnyttjar inte Zaida=
		[↑ I:: do not take advantage of Zaida=
27	Jacky	=Ni vill att vi ska va på nåns sida men vi e inte på nåns
28		sida vi e [på varandras sida
		= You two want us to be on somebody's side, but we are not on
		anybody's side [we are on one another's side
29	Leena	[↑NÄ:: ja utnyttjar inte nån för egentligen när ja kommer
30		på morgonen så säger ja till Zaida "kom Zaida"

31		eller hur? Inte sant?
		[↑NO:: I do not take advantage of anyone cause
		actually when I arrive in the morning I say to Zaida
		"come Zaida!" don't I? right?
32	Zaida	°ja°
		Yeah
33	Leena	Ja där ser ni! ja utnyttjar inte henne
34		ja utnyttjar inte
		Yeah there you are! I don't take advantage of her
		I don't take advantage of her

Adapted from Evaldsson 2007, pp. 387-389

Jacky publicly accuses Leena of taking advantage of another group member, ascribing her to the negative category of the 'bad friends'. Her extended turn and the management of the personal pronouns (Leena's third person reference 'she', contrasted with the in-group pronoun 'we'; lines 9 to 13) contribute to excluding Leena from the ratified participants and single her out for criticism. Leena emphatically counters this public accusation: through a pitch leap, a shift in pronoun, and a negation, the girl resists the negative category-bound activity of "tak[ing] advantage of Zaida" (line 26). In addition to the negation of the problematic conduct, which is repeated four times in rapid succession, Leena draws attention to her ordinary routine (*when I arrive in the morning I say to Zaida "come Zaida"*, line 30) and calls Zaida as a witness of her narrative (*don't I? right?,* line 31). This mobilization of Zaida, the girl allegedly taken advantage of, is instrumental in underpinning Leena's defense in front of the other girls. Zaida confirms Leena's narrative (line 32), providing her with a powerful argument to restore her moral status and social identity: through her repeated denials and Zaida's confirmation, Leena is able to position herself as fulfilling the category-bound obligations of a 'good friend' as a responsible and caring person who "performs routine friend-like activities" (Evaldsson, 2007, p. 390). Through the analysis of this and other excerpts, Evaldsson convincingly showed how the girls resorted to morally-laden categories ('good friend' vs 'bad friend') to negotiate their social selves and the network of alliances and antagonisms that crisscrosses the peer group. The significance of these analytical insights was *theoretical* and *methodological* at the same time.

In relation to theories of young people's sociality and mundane knowledge, the article showed the relevance of the nexus of broader discourses, ideologies, culturally-shaped categories, norms and expectations that play a role in everyday praxis. In order to provide significant accounts of children's and adolescents' sociality—accounts that are close to their own *emic* perspective and understanding—, this broader network of semiotic systems and diachronic features must be somehow considered: everyday practice in the peer group cannot be fully understood with a restricted focus on the contingent and

observable features of children's mutual engagement. In fact, a constant oscillation between local actions and broader systems (i.e., between the local and 'dislocal' nature of social interaction; Cooren, 2010) can provide a holistic understanding of children and adolescents' mundane reasoning and everyday experience of their life-world. For instance, the social categories that are relevant within a specific peer community, or the diachronic relationships between classmates, shape and constrain everyday practice without being necessarily topicalized or displayed by participants (on the topic, see Levinson, 2005). It is worth noting that this attention to broader systems should not lead us astray from the 'concreteness' and relevance of what children and adolescents actually do in their peer interactions. Thus, a *moderate holism* (Linell, 2009) is probably a balanced theoretical posture when approaching young people's mundane sociality: the broader discourses and ideologies that 'haunt' mundane activities are taken into account as long as they can be somehow grounded in concrete sequences of local actions and reactions.

This theoretical stance is bound to a methodological posture that allows the analyst to take into account these various non-local, non-immediately-visible entities that young people rely on to manage and make sense of mundane activities. As convincingly shown in Evaldsson's article, this posture combines the *micro-analysis of video recorded social interaction* with an *ethnographic perspective.* As regards the video recordings, the article illustrated how the details of children's mutual engagement made the difference in the daily reconstruction of their peer cultures and relationships (e.g., details such as words, pauses, intonation, gestures). The analysis of what young people precisely say and do is paramount to highlight how specific semiotic resources are contingently deployed to pursue a certain social aim. Despite its heuristic significance, this focus on the observable details of social interaction has some limits. For instance, the relevance of specific social categories in the girls' relational talk could not be considered without an ethnographic knowledge of the social categories that are routinely used and 'current' within that specific peer group. The analysis of membership categories, together with the category-bound activities and characteristics that are "habitually and conventionally associated" with them, necessarily relies on a certain knowledge of the broader sociocultural context in which they are locally mobilized and invoked (Evaldsson, 2021, p. 305). This knowledge can be acquired through a period of ethnographic fieldwork, i.e., a prolonged period of on-site observation that is instrumental in familiarizing with the social organization, developmental and relational trajectories, sociocultural norms and routines, and interpretative strategies of a specific social group (see Duranti, 1997 on ethnographic methods). The combination of this ethnographic knowledge and the detailed analysis of local inter-actions can provide empirically grounded analyses of peer sociality and cultures, constructing scientific knowledge that is close to children's and adolescents' emic understanding of their own life-worlds (Evaldsson, 2005).

Epilogue

So, let's go back to the examples that introduced this essay. If you are somehow in contact with children's and adolescents' everyday activities, you might be faced with a boy being ridiculed with a high-pitch voice (Evaldsson, 2002), with a girl being insulted for her alleged sexual behavior (Evaldsson, 2021), or with a boy being marginalized because of his lack of language proficiency (Evaldsson, 2005). These episodes can be best understood with reference to the peer culture and common-sense knowledge that underpin and substantiate young people's mutual engagement: the (negative) assessment of specific peers and the overall co-construction of social identities and relationships usually revolves around culturally shaped social categories. Notably, while these categories might be evoked to construct affiliative relationships and a cohesive peer group culture, they are at times mobilized to marginalize other peers and negatively assess their conduct. For instance, multiple children might publicly and repeatedly belittle a classmate for his/her inability to meet specific standards and expectations, leading to the solidification of a problematic social identity. In turn, these hetero-imposed ascriptions to a negative social category (e.g., 'sluts', 'liars', 'snitches', 'bad friends') might hinder a child's ability to construct meaningful social relationships in the peer group, possibly jeopardizing the possibility to participate in everyday activities and to qualify for membership in the peer culture. Considering these potential risks for social exclusion and their disproportionate impact on young people with limited interactional skills or impairments, it is important to be able to grasp and address the social significance of peer social categories—both as a scientific researcher and as an educational professional. An increased understanding of young people's category work can provide us with interpretative keys to monitor and possibly re-address trajectories of peer inclusion and exclusion. Ann-Carita Evaldsson's work provides us with a window into children's and adolescents' peer cultures and own understanding of social relationships—let's use this knowledge to further our scientific and professional understanding of their social worlds and co-construct educational environments in which the possibility to re-address and question a negative category ascription is always granted.

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Morality and accountability in directive trajectories: Notes from US and two Mayan contexts

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Ann-Carita Evaldsson has been pioneering in her integration of ethnography with conversation analysis and ethnomethodology in analyzing moral behavior in everyday life. Evaldsson and Corsaro (1998, p. 397) examine how in displaying intimacy, cooperation and compliance, as well as individuality, children display an orientation towards values of the Swedish afterschool program. Evaldsson and Karlsson (2022) have investigated how childhood educators socialize children into accountability and compassion while maintaining a democratic ethos in everyday preschool practices. This aligns with Aukrust (2004), who found that in general Swedish values and cultural patterns are associated with "mitigated collectivism", involving both orientation toward and appreciation of solidarity and the uniqueness of the individual.

To further explore the socialization of moral behavior, we examine the trajectories of directive-response sequences (Goodwin & Cekaite, 2018) in families across three cultures—middle class urban Los Angeles families (as part of the Center for Everyday Lives of Families at UCLA), urban Mayan Mexican families studied by Hilario Chi Canul, and rural Mayan Mexican families studied by Lourdes de León. We examine trajectories of talk to see how family members make meaning together, not only through the way that they produce talk for others to respond to, but also through their uptake to what others are saying.

Through our analysis of the way in which families orchestrate their participation to get others to do something (Goodwin & Cekaite, 2018) we provide our empirical approach to studying moral behavior. By participation we mean "forms of involvement which are collaboratively attended to by speakers and hearers in co-occurring action (Goodwin & Goodwin, 2004, p. 222.) By focusing on trajectories of directive/response sequences we can examine the practices through which child and parent(s) or grandparent(s) construct local identities for one another, either as parties who are accountable to one another for their actions or dismissive of them.

Ervin-Tripp, investigating directives and structures of control, defined directives as including "offers, requests, orders, prohibitions, and other verbal

moves that solicit goods or attempt to effect changes in the activities of others" (1984, p. 116). A speaker with high esteem has the right to receive verbal deference from others and can make control moves boldly without offering deference to those lower in esteem (1984, p. 118). The accounts that the speaker provides may appeal to justifications related to the requirements of the current activity or can be arbitrary, based on speaker's desires. Accounts according to Hasan (1992) can either appeal to rational explanations or be accounts that include threats, bribes, appeal to authority or tradition. In response to a directive, next moves may comply or reject the proposal. A recipient can flatly refuse, offer an account, or ignore a directive. Next moves by children can show deference to the parent issuing the directive, through moves that attempt to carry it out, or alternatively may show lack of respect through openly defying the directive. Alternative trajectories will be explored in three cultures which offer contrasting forms of deference and demeanor.

The effectiveness of a directive trajectory in the US depends on the establishment of joint attention with the child. Distractions such as TV must be turned off. Participants need to be physically positioned vis-a-vis one another to display a common framework of orientation. Participants can either closely align their bodies and their talk to the task at hand or demonstrate lack of alignment, disengagement, or protest through the ways they position their bodies and sequence talk. In some Los Angeles families, parents were consistent in their child rearing practices. When summoning her daughters to get ready for an outing, Mother (family A) provided an account for a next course of action (the children's clothes had been ironed), turned off the tv, and provided bald imperative directives when trying to get daughters mobilized for an outing: "Go:. Brush tee:th, Get dre:ssed, Come on guys." In response children got up to brush their teeth.

However, when parents fail to establish a shared framework for mutual orientation or do not provide clear expectations about obligations, they may encounter considerable difficulty in achieving compliance from children. A directive might then need to be recycled multiple times and produced with increased volume to enhance the seriousness of the directive in response to open defiance. In Family B when Mom summoned her son from a distance to take the dishes from the table to the sink, her son responded with a flat refusal in a raised voice: "I'M ***NOT*** DOING IT." Eventually the child was physically escorted to the table and positioned next to the dirty dishes. When he subsequently ran off, ignoring his responsibilities, his mom threatened that his gameboy would be taken away.

Bargaining over the timing of carrying out a directive is frequent in US families. Within Family B when Father told his older son to stop rough housing with his younger brother ("Okay. It's time to mellow it out!"), the son repetitively attempted to bargain with the parent over several utterances about when he would comply. Eventually Father sighed, breathed deeply, and gave up. In another family a mother's directive to her son to take a bath was

repeated twenty-six times, each directive followed by excuses from the child about when he would be willing to comply.

In the urban Mayan families studied by Hilario Chi Canul (2023, 2025) considerably more respect is shown by children vis-à-vis their parents with fewer recycled directives. Though children may not want to comply with a directive, which often takes the form of a bald imperative, they do not openly refuse. For example, when a mother launched a directive formatted with a bald imperative to her son and daughter to go to get Father, in response the two children withdrew their gaze from the mother and looked around, facing away from her, to avoid the responsibility of following through with the directive. Subsequently the siblings looked at each other to see who was going to comply with Mom's directive. The older female child asked the younger to go, but he remained silent. Given the brother's lack of compliance, the sister understood that he did not want to go, and she took responsibility herself for going to talk with Father. Culturally it is the older daughter who is obligated to carry out the mother's directive. The older child has the authority to delegate the younger child as the responsible party; however, if the son does not comply, the daughter has the obligation of carrying out the directive. While urban Mayan families display some features of the US patterns (parents use bald imperatives), the response given by a child is usually not defiance, but rather disattending the parental request.

Open confrontation between parents and children or grandparents and grandchildren was uncommon in the urban Mayan data. Adults provide accounts that lead to compliance. In one case a granddaughter was upset when her grandmother told her to wash her hands; however, she did not defy her grandmother. Instead she responded saying that she had already gone to wash her hands. When grandmother next provided an account stating, "Your hands are dirty," the child immediately agreed to wash her hands. Family members assist one another in executing directive trajectories. On one occasion after a father ordered his daughter to put on her flip flops, grandmother subsequently provided an account: "The floor is cold." When the directive and account failed to secure the child's compliance, Mother warned her daughter that she would get worms in her feet if she did not put on shoes; subsequently, the daughter screamed "NO" and then put on her shoes. Though disagreement occurs at times in interactions with caretakers, for the most part it is uncommon in part because the urban migrant children are socialized to have great respect for their parents and elders, who are viewed as authorities.

Among rural Mayan families de León (2011, 2012) finds fewer directives are issued, because there is an expectation of differentiated contributions from each family member being completed without explicit specification—for example, with regard to caregiving, doing a part of a larger task, etc. Indeed, de León locates among rural Maya a "collaboration ethos" where everybody is expected to take part in a directive trajectory. Children, without being told, help the family by bringing wood for cooking or a female child may make

tortillas. Cooperation occurs within an understanding that the child is allowed to be autonomous and take initiative. De León provides examples that have parallels to the urban Mayan examples of Chi Canul that show noncompliance without open opposition. When two sisters in the flower fields were engaged in trimming dead leaves in the sun, their aunts told them to move to the shade. When the girls remained immobile, silent, and avoided gaze, the aunts recycled their directives providing accounts for why they should move to the shade for handling flowers: the flowers will wilt. In the rural Mayan context, the younger sister told the older sister to comply. Escalations of directives followed from the aunts with raised volume, full address term and a move towards joint attention with them. Though one child did bend her body, beginning to show an orientation towards compliance, what followed next was an escalation with (1) the aunt telling the father, an authority figure, that the child does not listen but stays in the sun, and (2) the father, as ultimate authority figure, providing an indirect threat: "Tell them I'm coming." The directive, performed as what de León views as a "triadic directive", resulted in the girls' compliance.

When children don't want to do things, Mayan rural adults talk indirectly about them: "He/she does not want to help, and he/she is lazy"; or "He goes out all afternoon to play with peers and does not come to help"; "It's good for boys to earn their own money and help with the expenses" (for a ten-year old onwards); "Girls should know how to weave and make tortillas; look how well she wove her piece." These assessments link forms of moral character to a child's actions. Noncompliance provides an opportunity for metacommentary or reflexive commentary on the forms of sociality regarding rights and responsibilities in play. Metacommentary categorizes and assesses current behavior, exposing the child to ways of reflecting on the current situation.

In the US children are directly rather than indirectly critiqued for their misbehavior. A child who had not brushed his teeth correctly was told, "Bein ***la***zy. That's just ***nas***ty." When families establish clear patterns of children's obligations, trajectories may run smoothly. On one occasion a child responded to her mom's directive that it was time to take a bath with the explanation that she'd "had a bath yesterday." In response Mom stated, "It's ***not*** negotiable.=okay?" The child immediately got up from the dining room table to take a bath. In one Japanese-American family in the Los Angeles group, the notion of saving face was highly salient. When a child stalled rather than immediately following her parent's directive to close up her art activity and brush her teeth, Father commented on the behavior of the child: "I don't appreciate this, like, you know, ***stall***ing, ***stall***ing, ***stall***ing all the time." He then posed a question for the child to ask herself as well as a negative evaluation of the child's behavior: "Why is it that- every day has to ***end*** like that, you know? You have to ***push*** people till they get- ***mad*** at you." The parent's character description directly labeled the child's behavior as inappropriate through the way it affected others. By issuing the directive in this way Father produced a

commentary on the child's moral behavior within a frame stating that one should consider others as well as oneself in deciding the course of action to be taken. The child responded not by disagreeing, but rather by displaying shame on her face. One final tactic used by parents to attempt to get compliance from children is to switch the framing of the directive from serious to play: for example, a child reluctant to go to bed was swooped up into the air and danced with to the targeted destination.

Ethnomethodology seeks to provide detailed analyses of the assemblages of practices through which the work of accomplishing local social order is achieved. The impressive suite of Evaldsson's expansive body of work provides guidelines for investigating what notions of moral order are foundational for organizing social life. By exploring how directives are orchestrated across US, and urban and rural Mexican Mayan culture we find different practices for displaying accountability and respect towards one's elders—ranging from open defiance, to silent noncompliance, to cooperative engagement. Practices for escalating the force of a directive occur in all cultures, through raising volume, using threats, full name address terms, and narrowing the spatial orientation between participants. Accounts providing reasons for directives occur across all contexts as well. Among the rural Maya, forms of moral behavior are cultivated by indirectly assessing forms of conduct for social categories of children, while in the US metacommentaries are delivered directly to the child. Noncompliance occurs in all cultures, but open defiance is rare in Mayan cultures. Trajectories of recycled directives appear to be most expansive in the US, especially in families where negotiation is a common practice.

For some time the three of us have been quite astounded by the cultural variation we have witnessed in the directives of the groups we have studied and appreciate the opportunity of this festschrift honoring our colleague Ann-Carita to begin to explore this diversity.

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Repair in an interpreter-mediated asylum interview – an interactional perspective

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Introduction

In many countries, asylum interviews are carried out with interpreter assistance, and an interpreter-mediated interview is a specific form of interaction (Wadensjö, 1992, 1998; Roy, 2000; Bolden, 2000), a bilingual exchange characterised by its non-standard triadic turn-taking order. What interpreters do in interaction necessarily affects both the content and the progression of the exchange. In practice, most of what interpreters say in interaction corresponds as renditions (or translations) to something just said. In this way, an interpreter's turn at talk *implicitly* fulfils a coordinating function, because, to maintain the exchange, participants must wait for the interpreter's regular second turn, i.e., the rendition that discloses what was just said in the other language. Every now and then, interpreters also provide *non-renditions* (Wadensjö, 1998, p. 108), utterances that do not correspond as translations to something just said. For instance, interpreters may ask for repetition or clarification, prompt a speaker to continue, or urge a participant to look in a certain direction. In other words, an interpreter may also coordinate the ongoing exchange *explicitly* (Wadensjö, 1998, pp. 106–109). Importantly, interpreters' translating and coordinating activities do not exclude but rather condition one another.

Moreover, the social order of any asylum interview is characterised by the implicit and explicit presence, mandatory production and occasional use of written texts. In Määttä's (2015) terms, it is a *discourse of reporting*. For instance, the minutes taken down as the interview proceeds constitute an important basis for the decision to be made, for or against granting asylum.

This article sheds light on how, in an interpreter-mediated asylum interview, the participants' possibilities for controlling and repairing shared discourse as the interview unfolds are conditioned. While some studies of interpreting focus exclusively on interpreters, this article explores an interpreter-mediated *encounter* as a *situated activity system* (Goffman, 1961, p. 96), i.e., as a shared communicative event, and treats multilingual interaction primarily as social practice (Evaldsson, 1993; Cekaite & Evaldsson, 2008; Evaldsson et al., 2010).

Approaching repair in interpreter-mediated discourse data

The conversational mechanism of *repair* (Schegloff et al., 1977) was identified and has been extensively explored in monolingual, spontaneous spoken interaction. According to Hutchby and Wooffitt (2008) the everyday communicative phenomenon of repair initiatives and repairing is characterised by the following:

- *Everything* in a conversation can be 'repaired'.
- *As soon as participants in social interaction identify a problem source*, a danger of not being understood in the way they want to be understood – for various reasons – they can initiate a repair.
- Repair is *a resource for securing a shared and common understanding*.
- Repairing is *organized according to preferences* (Schegloff et al., 1977), in the following order:
    1. Self-initiated self-repair—a speaker reformulates something while speaking, keeping the turn at talk.
    2. Other-initiated self-repair—a listener indicates understanding problems and the speaker reformulates.
    3. Self-initiated other-repair—the speaker indicates communicative problems, and a listener assists.
    4. Other-initiated other-repair—a listener suggests how the speaker may want to (re)formulate something just expressed.

Studies on repair in interpreter-mediated interviews are scarce. An article by Straniero Sergio (2012) is a pioneering example, however. He shows how Italian talk show hosts frequently challenge the performing interpreter's position and authority, and that this is done through repair initiatives. In his data, show hosts initiate and perform other-repair by redoing interpreters' translations. In this way they create humorous time-outs from the interview proper—a characteristic feature of the televised talk show as a communicative genre (Straniero Sergio, 1999). In other settings, repair initiatives are reasonably likely to work differently, but little is known about this.

More recent studies on repair in interpreter-mediated interaction are conducted by Hansen (2022) and Svennevig and Hansen (2023). They investigate encounters between medical professionals and patients seated together in the same room, assisted by an interpreter working remotely via video technology. Hansen (2022) demonstrates that interpreters' embodied displays of trouble through the screen can initiate repair, and that the video-mediated environment provides a complex interactional space for participants' perception of these initiatives. Svennevig and Hansen (2023) distinguish two features in repair sequences that are characteristic of settings where interpreting is carried out consecutively. Firstly, the repair initiation may occur unusually late, that

is later than the first possible point to indicate a problem (in monolingual conversations). Secondly, in some cases it may be unclear whether the speaker designs the repair for the interpreter or for the monolingual conversational partner, due to the interpreter's flexible participation status.

Arguably, medical encounters assisted by an interpreter working remotely have a social character that differs from that of asylum interviews assisted by an on-site interpreter. Nevertheless, the findings of Svennevig and Hansen (2023) have been confirmed in a recent study on repair in three interpreter-mediated asylum interviews (Wadensjö, 2026/forthcoming). Looking further into the work of repair in interpreter-mediated interaction, taking one specific interpreter-mediated asylum interview as a case in point, the present study shows examples of participants' self-initiated self-repair, other-initiated self-repair, self-initiated other-repair and other-initiated other-repair, and explores possible effects of these on the progression and content of the encounter. In the concluding paragraph, Table 1 shows how the four types of repairs are distributed between the interview participants. Ultimately, a deeper understanding of this interactive, discursive phenomenon could help improve the education of those handling asylum interviews as professionals—migration officers, public counsels and interpreters.

Data set

The sequences analysed in the paragraph below are drawn from an asylum interview recorded within the research project *Asylum narratives—on co-construction and recontextualization*[11]. This project is based on discourse data documented in naturally occurring interpreter-mediated asylum interviews with the aim of generating knowledge about participants' spoken and written co-construction of asylum narratives, and what this implies for asylum seekers, for their cases, and for those who in various ways handle issues related to asylum – migration officers, public counsels, interpreters, and others. Within this project, conducted by Hanna Sofia Rehnberg (project manager), Zoe Nikolaidou and the present author, encounters related to five asylum cases were observed, audio recorded and transcribed. The project data include asylum interviews carried out in Swedish and another language (Russian, Ukrainian, Turkish, English and Igbo). All or single members of the research team have a reasonable command of these languages, except Igbo. For each case, copies of written documentation in the form of case officers' minutes and submissions from public counsels were collected. Moreover, the team conducted (and recorded) separate post interviews with the asylum-interview participants. The study was approved by the Swedish Ethical Review Authority, and all participants agreed that the research group could use the assembled documentation.

[11] Östersjöstiftelsen (The foundation for Baltic and East European Studies) 3374/3.1.1/2016.

In line with regular research ethics, proper names and other information that could potentially reveal the identity of individuals have been changed.

In Sweden, the language used for asylum interviews is Swedish and asylum interviews are practically always carried out with the assistance of an interpreter. Asylum seekers and case officers may share a common language, but case officers are responsible for conducting the interview and simultaneously taking down the minutes in Swedish, while interpreters are responsible for translating for all participants, i.e., from Swedish into the foreign language and the other way around. Conducting an interview, case officers are expected to take notes continuously without interrupting the asylum seeker's free narrative and, in the next phase, to ask follow-up questions to check for inconsistencies or contradictions in the narrative. In real-life interviews, asylum seekers may find it difficult to provide all their relevant reasons for seeking asylum in a consistent, free-flowing narrative, partly due to the communicative complexity of the interpreter-mediated asylum interview (Maryns, 2006; Pöllabauer, 2023; Wadensjö et al., 2023).

An asylum seeker's first visit to a Migration-Agency office is often only for registration and identification. Normally, a second visit is organised, where reasons for applying for asylum can be presented in detail. This article draws on sequences from such a second visit, recorded in 2018. In the following, sequences where the four types of repair initiatives listed above were found will be explored. The asylum seeker involved in the interview under scrutiny is from Kazakhstan. During the 2.5-hour interview he spoke Russian, his second or rather third language. In the interview, his Russian seemed quite limited, occasionally non-idiomatic, and he tended to stutter. His language choice was partly determined by the lack of interpreters in his first language—Uighur—and partly by his lack of trust in interpreters speaking Kazakh (thinking they might have ties to the Kazakh Police, who, he said, had fabricated charges against him). The interview took place with all participants—a case officer, an asylum seeker, a certified Swedish-Russian interpreter, and a public counsel—seated together in a Migration-Agency office. Present in the room was also the researcher, who audio-recorded and observed the interview. For the analyses presented in this article, talk in Russian and Swedish has been translated into English by the author.

Repair initiatives in a Swedish-Russian asylum interview

Just as in monolingual conversations, participants in interpreter-mediated conversations may self-repair. For various reasons, participants may want to reformulate their words and start anew as it were. Most commonly, the activity signals the speaker's search for a better word or a more precise formulation in the context at hand.

Self-initiated self-repair

Excerpt 1 involves two instances of self-initiated self-repair. The sequence starts 17 minutes into the interview, and the asylum seeker is handing over a document to the case officer, who appears a bit disrupted.

Excerpt 1

1 CAO: mm: va e de. va e de här för handling.
mm: what's that. what kind of document is this.
2 INT: что за документ?
what kind of document is this?
3 ASY: это:: о:::: это о::: обвинительный акт
i::t's the:::: it's the::: the indictment (bill).
4 INT: de e åtalet.
it's the indictment.

As the transcript indicates, the case officer (CAO) asks a question involving a self-initiated self-repair (line 1). In the interpreter's (INT) rendition (line 2), there is no trace of that repair, nor is there in her rendition (line 4) of the self-initiated self-repair in the reply provided by the asylum seeker (ASY) (line 3). Since the interview was not video recorded, we do not know whether the case officer's question (line 1) was accompanied by a pointing gesture from behind the computer, and, if so, whether the others observed it. But her self-repair including *document* (line 1) disambiguates what the question is about and potentially promotes shared understanding. The asylum seeker replies after some word search (line 3). His audible word search, involving prolonged vowels, clearly signals that the speaker is seeking a word or expression. It also becomes a means of keeping the turn at talk. Word search can sometimes also serve as a means of showing eagerness to respond (correctly). As can be seen (lines 2 and 4), the interpreter relays only the 'repaired' bits after both utterances, which arguably simplifies the exchange and potentially also promotes shared understanding.

In everyday monolingual conversations, participants may tend not to take any notice of others' self-initiated self-repairs, but occasionally these can be heard as signs of the speaker's word search, insecurity, orientation towards promoting shared understanding and/or simply as a means of keeping the floor. In an interpreter-mediated encounter, however, monolingual participants are likely not always to sense the existence of an interlocutor's self-initiated self-repair if they have no or very little understanding of the other's language. Understanding both languages, however, interpreters can be expected to notice repair initiatives in the primary parties' discourse.

In a post interview, the interpreter in the interview under scrutiny expressed her commitment to relaying everything said *as* it was said. This, she argued, is what the Migration Authority requires from her as interpreter, without

specifying what this could imply more precisely. In practice, however, her renditions most of the time do not reflect preceding self-initiated self-repairs as these first appear. Rather, her renditions are straightforward and unambiguous, as demonstrated in Excerpt 1 (lines 2 and 4), which indicates that she makes sense of the repaired bits as the base for her renditions, at least in these cases.

To someone listening to the above interpreter-mediated sequence and understanding both the case officer's Swedish and the applicant's Russian, their utterances (lines 1 and 3) may have appeared somewhat vague or uncertain, but in the interpreter's version they do not. Notably, talking straightforwardly rather than hesitantly, interpreters avoid being perceived as insecure—in their capacity as interpreters. At the same time, quick and straightforward renditions can work as a kind of acknowledgement, telling the speakers that they are understood. Moreover, the interpreter simplifies her own task, and simultaneously makes the exchange run smoothly. The same effect can be seen in Excerpt 2, drawn from 35 minutes into the interview. Here, the asylum seeker initiates and performs self-repair when talking about the political party in which his late father used to be engaged.

Excerpt 2

1	ASY:	сейчас я допустим не знаю короче там этот ч-
		now I for instance don't know in short, these this wh-
2		вот, что творится в этой партий сейчас какая
		like, what's happening in this party now what
3		случилась сейчас [я тоже не знаю.
		has happened now [I don't know either.
4	INT:	[informationen kommer från den tiden
		[the information comes from the time
5		som jag kände till, just nu vet jag inte hur
		that I knew about, right now I don't know how
6		det ser ut.
		it looks like.

Excerpt 2 is another example showing that the asylum seeker has some difficulties finding words. The reasons can be multiple. Occasionally, he shows problems with stuttering; in addition, his Russian seems quite limited and non-idiomatic. Also, he may be searching for words to gain time and not lose the floor. It should be kept in mind that, in an interpreter-mediated conversation, the monolingual parties may sometimes lose the turn even when they would have liked to keep it, and without allocating it to the next speaker, i.e., the interpreter. Working consecutively, interpreters take the turn whenever they deem it convenient, doable and necessary in order to be able to follow through with their task of rendering what has been said in the other language.

In this interview, where the applicant's discourse is often fragmented, and therefore not always easy to follow and memorise, the interpreter frequently comes in with a rendition before she is allocated the turn from him (as in Excerpt 2, line 4). Notably, she renders the asylum seeker's preceding utterance in a straightforward way, linking it to her own previous rendition (not shown in Excerpt 2) and leaving out discourse markers like *for instance*, *in short* and *like*, present in the asylum seeker's talk (lines 1 and 2). This reasonably simplifies not just the interpreter's job, but also the progression of interaction. However, the asylum seeker might have lost his train of thought.

Other-initiated self-repair

In some cases, it seems that the interpreter in this interview does try to reflect, in her renditions, instances of the asylum seeker's hesitations and self-repair. Excerpt 3 below shows a candidate case, where she might have been trying to live up to her stated ambition of rendering not just *what* has been said, but also the way it was spoken in the other language. Whether or not this is the case, her first effort is halted when the case officer provides a repair initiative. The sequence starts 24 minutes into the interview, where the asylum seeker mentions that his late father had had a leading position in the party just talked about (in Excerpt 2).

Excerpt 3

```
1 ASY: [e::: и:] мой папа был одним из лидеров e::: он
       [e::: a:nd] my dad was one of the leaders e::: he
2      занимал лидирующий пост (.) в этой партии.
       had a leading position in this party.
3 INT: min far var en utav ledare, ledare i det här partiet,
       my dad was one of leaders, leaders in this party,
4 CAO: =va de farbror?
       =was that uncle?
5 INT: =nä [fa::]:r.
       =no [fa::]:ther.
6 ASY:     [нет] мой папа.
           [no] my dad.
7 INT: =var en ledare i partiet och hade ledars (.)
       =was a leader of the party and had leader's (.)
8      post le- le- ledande [post i partiet
       position le- le- leading [position in the party.
9 CAO:                          [mhm
                                [mhm
```

Excerpt 3 shows how the asylum seeker formulates and immediately reformulates a statement about his late father's role in a political party (lines 1 and 2). The interpreter renders this statement (line 3), and the case worker initiates a repair *was that uncle?* (line 4). In Swedish, *uncle* is 'farbror', a person just talked about in the exchange, and the case officer apparently needs to check whether the uncle was mentioned again. Here, the interpreter instantly

provides what we can call an other-initiated self-repair *no father.* (line 5), emphasising 'father'. This is followed by the asylum seeker saying *no my dad.* (line 6). He knows some basic words in Swedish, like 'far' (father) and 'farbror' (uncle). In other words, they both respond as the person addressed by the officer. Notably, the interpreter does not relay either the case officer's repair initiative (line 4) into Russian, or the asylum seeker's repair (line 6) into Swedish. Instead, the interpreter reclaims her turn to provide a new rendition (lines 7–8) of the asylum seeker's utterance (lines 1–2), excluding only the word *father*, which she (and he) has just repeated (lines 5 and 6). In this way, the interpreter simplifies the interaction order.

The rendition in lines 7 and 8 may seem like an attempt to reflect the asylum seeker's somewhat hesitant way of expressing what his father's role had been in a political party (lines 1 and 2), in line with the interpreter's stated ambition to render talk *as* it is spoken. Nevertheless, from the case officer's point of view, the statement in Swedish (lines 7–8) can be heard (also) as the interpreter's insecure rendition; as involving the interpreter's self-initiated self-repair. The short silence '(.)' (line 7) and the following *position le- leleading position* (line 8) can potentially be recognised as signs of Swedish word search. To the case officer, the ownership of instances of self-repair, if she at all noticed any, may have remained unclear. Nevertheless, the interpreter's repetition (in lines 7–8) of her rendition (in line 3) simplifies matters for the case officer, as they correspond to what she must be listening for—the narrative for the record. In this way, the interpreter secures content for the minutes, and her action, more than anything else, follows the logic of the institutional encounter as a discourse of reporting (Määttä, 2015).

Looking more closely at the case officer's repair initiation *was that uncle?* (line 4), it seemingly functions as it would have functioned in a monolingual conversation. The preceding speaker, the interpreter, provides an other-initiated self-repair: *no father* (line 5). But the interpreter's self-repair is not followed immediately by a third turn from the repair initiator (here, the case officer), confirming shared understanding, something that ordinarily follows in monolingual conversations. Only two turns later, the case officer provides a feedback token (line 9), which could be heard as a sign of shared understanding. However, it can also be heard as the case officer indicating that the relevant piece of information is noted for the minutes (something that later could be observed), and that the turn is free. After a short silence, without any further sign of established mutual and shared understanding, the asylum seeker hesitantly goes on to provide more information about his father.

The first two excerpts illustrate cases of self-initiated self-repair performed by the case officer, and the asylum seeker. Excerpt 3 shows a (potential) instance of self-initiated self-repair performed by the interpreter. Self-initiated self-repair is by far the most frequent type of repair in this interview (see Table 1). Yet, the interpreter's stated ambition to render all talk *as* it is spoken at times complicates participants' identification of repair initiation and repairing.

Excerpt 3 also involves an exceptional—for interpreter-mediated interaction—case of other-initiated self-repair. Both the interpreter and the asylum seeker repair in response to the case officer's initiative, hearing the word 'farbror' (*uncle* in Swedish). The asylum seeker could react immediately, since he recognised this word, and, as it turned out, it was central to his case.

In Excerpt 4, it is the asylum seeker who provides a repair initiative, addressing the interpreter. The interview has been going on for 70 minutes, and the case officer is asking one of her follow-up questions.

Excerpt 4

```
1  CAO: du sa att e::h eh du brukade ha möten med folk om
        you said that e::h eh you used to meet people on
2       Östturkistans självständighet om jag förstod dig
        East Turkestan independence if I understood you
3       rätt, kan du berätta lite mer om det.
        correctly, can you tell a bit more about that.
4  INT: вы также сказали что вы со- вы встречались с
        you also said that you co- you met with
5       людьми, которые были за самостоятельность
        people, who were for independence
6       восточного Туркестана
        of East Turkestan
7  ASY: как как ещё раз, ещё раз повторите.
        what- what- once more, once more repeat.
8  INT: kan du ta det igen?
        could you take that again?
9  ASY: нет чтобы вы ещё раз.
        no that you once more.
10 INT: okej, tolken får tolka sades.
        okay, the interpreter can interpret was said.
11      вы сказали что вы встречались с людьми.
        you said that you met with people.
12 ASY: да
        yes
```

Apparently, the asylum seeker has difficulties following what the interpreter is saying here and requests a repetition (line 7). The interpreter may have understood herself to be addressed (experiencing a repair initiative addressing herself) but nevertheless relays the asylum seeker's repair initiative into Swedish. Hence, its content is immediately made known to the case officer and all the Swedish-speaking participants. The asylum seeker must have thought that the interpreter misinterpreted him and protests, now emphasising that he is addressing the interpreter (line 9), an objection that the interpreter again treats

as an utterance to be relayed into Swedish (line 10) before she starts re-rendering the case officer's follow-up question (line 11). In other words, in this sequence, the interpreter uses her regular second turn at talk not to repair immediately, but to make the case officer aware of the ongoing repairing (lines 7–10), before she goes on relaying another chunk of the follow-up question (line 11). The asylum seeker confirms that he is following (line 12). Subsequently, there is an instance of other-initiated other-repair, as will be shown in Excerpt 6 below, following directly upon the sequence in Excerpt 4 above. Prior to exploring this type of repair, I will first present a short summary of the work of other-initiated self-repair in the interview and then, in the next paragraph, show an example of a self-initiated other-repair.

In the entire encounter, I counted 36 instances of other-initiated self-repair (see Table 1). The case worker 17 times initiates other repair and the previous speaker, the interpreter, feels obliged/selected to produce a self-repair, notably without involving or updating the asylum seeker, that is, treating the initiative as targeting *her* word choice, and not that of the asylum seeker. The case officer confirms shared understanding in eight of these 17 cases after receiving the interpreter's self-repair. Her third turns come in the form of a simple 'mhm', an 'okay', or a repetition of a word or expression (in Swedish) which the case officer had wanted repaired, and the interpreter, in effect speaking for the asylum seeker, had provided.

The asylum seeker in turn initiates the prior speaker to repair five times; in three cases the interpreter repeats the latest word of her preceding rendition or provides a synonym of it. Twice she treats the asylum seeker's repair initiatives as utterances to be relayed into Swedish, as demonstrated in Excerpt 4. In all cases, the asylum seeker eventually provides a third turn, confirming shared—with the interpreter—understanding.

The interpreter 15 times initiates other-repair, 14 times in Russian, hence addressing the asylum seeker, and once in Swedish, addressing the case officer. Notably, third turns, i.e., the initiator's confirmation of shared understanding, are absent in all but three of these cases. This suggests that the interpreter, unsurprisingly, prioritises her obligation to render immediately preceding utterances in another language, before confirming shared understanding. Alternatively, she counts on her renditions being heard as validating shared understanding.

The next paragraph will discuss an instance of self-initiated other-repair, a type of repair that is quite infrequent in this interview (see Table 1).

Self-initiated other-repair

Excerpt 5 below shows an instance of self-initiated other-repair, which is specific to this bilingual setting, because it is triggered by a semantic difference between the two languages spoken. The sequence starts 26 minutes into the

interview, and the asylum seeker tells that he has lost contact with relatives after they were sent to penal camps in China. The interpreter starts rendering.

Excerpt 5

1 INT: uigurerna skickas idag till Kina. och även om det
the Uighurs are sent today to China. And even if it
2 talas om att de skickas för något annat men
is said that they are sent for something else, but
3 egentligen de hamnar i speciella läger och vi idag
actually they end up in special camps and we today
4 kan inte komma i kontakt med dem, inte ens med mina
can't get in touch with them, not even with my
5 бабушка по папиной или маминой стороне?
grandma on dad's or mom's side?
6 ASY: это всё по папиной стороне.
that's all on dad's side.
7 INT: aha, kan inte komma i kontakt med min farmor och släkten
aha, can't get in touch with my grandma and relatives
8 på pappas sida. tolken fråga om det handlade
on dad's side. the interpreter asked if it was
9 om farmor eller mormor (.) och svaret blev pappas sida.
about grandma on father's side or grandma on mother's side(.)and the answer was dad's side.

Excerpt 5 shows an instance of the interpreter initiating a repair (line 5) that she needs the asylum seeker to perform. Hence, she switches to Russian amid rendering his preceding utterance (not shown in Excerpt 5) into Swedish. The subsequent repair (line 6) helps her to determine that the *grandma* just mentioned in Russian refers to a relative on the father's side. Only then can she finish her ongoing rendition in Swedish of the asylum seeker's preceding utterance. Notably, in a conversation between monolinguals, or between interpreter-mediated people speaking languages with similar family terms (like Russian and English), the instance may not have prompted a repair initiative.

Interestingly, the interpreter starts her uptake of the repair by providing a feedback token, what resembles a third turn (*aha,* line 7) confirming that she is 'with' the asylum seeker. Then she continues to render the last bit of his latest utterance into Swedish (lines 7–8) for the case officer and the minutes. Moreover, she informs the case officer about the content of her and the asylum seeker's side exchange (lines 8–9). Overall, this interpreter appears sensitive to the fact that her renditions will end up in the minutes, which is why words must be checked, something she occasionally makes the case officer aware of in this explicit way. Meanwhile, her introducing feedback token (line 7) confirming shared understanding between her and the asylum seeker is somewhat exceptional. In the entire interview, she 15 times prompts someone (almost

exclusively the asylum seeker) to provide a self-repair. Only three times does she provide immediate feedback to signal shared understanding. As a rule, in the place of a third turn is her rendition into the other language. Arguably, a quick and unambiguous rendition may be perceived as confirming shared understanding. It cannot be excluded, however, that the absence of immediately confirming feedback is experienced as lack of shared understanding. This could imply that the asylum seeker is left insecure about how his narrative has landed.

Other-initiated other-repair

The final two excerpts in this section show cases of other-initiated other-repair, revealing potential sources of doubt, but only for speakers of Russian. Excerpt 6 starts right after the end of Excerpt 4 above.

Excerpt 6

13 INT: собирались- встречались с людьми которые боролись за
you gathered- met with people that fought for
14 самостоятельностью восточного Туркестана
the independence of East Turkestan
15 ASY: то что я встречался с людьми и к- к- которые
that that I met with people and th- th- that
16 боялись [e::
feared [e::
17 INT: [боролись.
[fought.
18 ASY: которые боролись.
that fought.

The interpreter goes on relaying (lines 13–14) the case officer's utterance, the framing of her prompt to *tell a bit more* (Excerpt 4: line 3). As shown in Excerpt 6, the asylum seeker's current problem seems to be that he mixes up two resembling verbs in Russian, 'boyalis' (*feared*) and 'borolis' (*fought*) (line 16). The interpreter suggests that he might have selected the first by mistake and hints at the latter (line 17), which seems clear from the context (line 13). In the recording, her suggestion (line 17) sounds more like a statement than a question, hence she is indicating what she anticipates. Eventually, the asylum seeker confirms, reclaiming his turn, repeating his latest word and adding the suggested word 'borolis' (*that fought*) (line 18). The other-initiated other-repair shown in Excerpt 6 is one of three of this type in the entire interview. The interpreter twice corrected the asylum seeker's word choice, and the asylum seeker once corrected the interpreter, an instance shown in Excerpt 7 below. Where the sequence starts, we are 28 minutes into the interview. A small part

of the interpreter's rendition is replaced with three dots in the beginning of line 1.

Excerpt 7

```
1 INT: … och övriga personer som kommer ifrån Östturkmenistan
     … and other people that are coming from East Turkmenistan
2 ASY: Östturk[istan.]
       East Turk[estan.]
3 INT:          [va?] ursäkta,
                [what?] sorry,
4 ASY: Туркестан.
       Turkestan.
5 INT: Östturkistan ska det va, mm,
       East Turkestan it should be, mm,
```

Excerpt 7 shows an instance where the interpreter renders a geographical name in an erroneous way, saying *Turkmenistan* (line 1). The name is central to the applicant's case, and he has in store the Swedish name of the region that he has just mentioned in Russian (before Ex 7), namely *East Turkestan* (line 2), which he immediately offers. The interpreter does not seem to follow directly (line 3) but confirms understanding (in Swedish) when the asylum seeker repeats *Turkestan* in Russian (line 4). Eventually, the correct name in Swedish is provided, for the case officer and the minutes (line 5).

As mentioned above, there were three instances of other-initiated other-repair in this interview (see Table 1), and they involved only the two Russian-speaking participants. None of them acted upon these instances with visible or hearable signs of irritation. Nevertheless, they probably made the interpreter and the asylum seeker mindful of each other's limited language (and factual) knowledge, limitations that the participants understanding only Swedish—the case officer and the public counsel—could hardly have become aware of.

The non-standard work of repair in an interpreted asylum interview

Table 1 below gives an overview of the four different types of repair initiatives found in the interview—their respective frequency and how they were distributed between the participants. The entire interview consists of 1493 transcribed utterances. An utterance is counted quite simply from where a person starts talking until another speaker comes in. Twenty-six (11%) of the case worker's 227 utterances, 131 (22,5%) of the asylum seeker's 581 utterances, and 121 (17,5%) of the interpreter's 685 utterances include self-initiated self-repairs. Proportionally, the asylum seeker most frequently provides self-initiated self-repair, which at least partly can be explained by the fact that he speaks a foreign, to him, language—in a foreign, to him, context. The

relatively high number of self-initiated self-repairs in the interpreter's utterances is predominantly because she searches for words in Swedish, her second language. Moreover, if she was sometimes trying to render the asylum seeker's often vague or non-idiomatic Russian into vague and non-idiomatic Swedish, that might explain some of the instances appearing as her self-initiated self-repairing.

Table 1. The distribution among participants of the four repair types

	utterances	**self-self**	**other-self**	**self-other**	**other-other**
CAO	227	26 (11%)	17	1	-
ASY	581	131 (22.5%)	5	3	1
INT	685	121 (17.5%)	15	4	2
Total	**1493**	**278 (18.5%)**	**37**	**8**	**3**

The examples explored in this article indicate that communicative problems can indeed be detected and solved in interpreter-mediated interaction by way of repair initiatives. Exactly how this works, however, may be difficult and sometimes impossible for participants to follow. Moreover, in an interpreter-mediated asylum interview, to repair everything, in the sense discussed by Hutchby and Wooffitt (2008), is sometimes neither a reachable nor a shared goal. No doubt, primary participants' possibility to control how they are understood—or misunderstood—by their respective counterpart is clearly more limited than in a monolingual conversation.

Excerpts 1 and 2 showed instances of self-initiated self-repair in the primary parties' utterances, which had no counterparts in the interpreter's renditions, despite her stated ambition to render everything said *as* it was said. The asylum seeker's often fragmented and non-idiomatic Russian must have made his utterances difficult at times to follow, to memorise exactly, and to render as they were spoken in the other language. Certainly, the interpreter's difficulty to memorise (or fear of not being able to memorise) occasionally triggered her to take the turn at talk for a rendition before the asylum seeker as the current speaker had allocated it to her, as shown in Excerpt 2.

As the interpreter claimed, she was obliged by the Migration Authority to relay not just everything said, but also in the way it was delivered in the other language. Occasionally, it seems she did make efforts to live up to her stated ambition by including preceding self-initiated self-repair and discourse markers such as 'like' and 'in short' in her renditions, particularly at the beginning of the interview (cf. Wadensjö et al., 2023), but much less as the interview went on. In practice, however, I would venture this ambition is doomed to fail. Spontaneous spoken interaction is by nature loaded with repair initiatives and repair production, and repeating the repairing, even if it is done in another

language, risks highlighting the dismissed bits rather than setting them aside. Excerpt 3 showed a potential such case.

When the case officer initiates a co-interlocutor to repair, this interpreter always responds as the person addressed and volunteers a self-repair, without involving the asylum seeker. The example shown in Excerpt 3, where the asylum seeker also responded as the addressed person, is an exception, basically due to the Russian-speaking applicant's knowledge of the Swedish words for *father* and *uncle*.

The examples in Excerpts 3 and 4 show that, just as in monolingual interaction, someone's repair initiative may be responded to by another at the first possible instance where a problem is indicated, but the specific interpreter-mediated interaction order still complicates shared and mutual understanding. A repair initiative may be designed for the interpreter, and the interpreter may—or may not—treat it as an utterance that should be rendered in the other language. In this interview, only the asylum seeker's other-repair initiatives were treated in this way, as shown in Excerpt 4. The inherently flexible participation status of interpreters allows them to redirect repair initiatives, whoever they are intended for.

The third turn following a response to a repair initiative, typical in monolingual talk and designed to confirm shared understanding, does not necessarily appear in interpreter-mediated interaction. Interpreters, when given or taking the turn, following their professional obligation, are typically focused on rendering what has been said in the other language, rather than on giving immediate feedback to the preceding speaker. This implies that the asylum speaker needs to produce his narrative without receiving the standard type of feedback confirming that the interpreter is following him. People experienced with interpreter assistance may understand the interpreter's very rendering as confirming shared understanding. Arguably, swift and distinct renditions can easily be perceived in this way, while slow and unclear renditions might give the opposite impression. Hence, this interpreter's stated ambition to render the asylum seeker's talk *as* it was spoken, I would argue, is far from unproblematic.

Finally, in this interview, other-initiated other-repair did not seem to constitute a face threat as they have been shown to do in other settings (Stranieri, 2012). Instances of such repairing in this interview revealed certain lack of linguistic and factual knowledge, but information about this was shared only between the Russian-speaking participants.

To conclude, the analyses above point to both similarities and quite substantial differences in the function of repair in monolingual and interpreter-mediated encounters respectively. Another take-home message from this study is that the function of repair initiatives and repairing in asylum interviews, where a spoken asylum narrative is to be taken down in written, indeed deserves further research.

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Can do it myself: Some insights into the history of autodidacticism from Ibn Tufayl to Ivan Illich and Everett Reimer

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Introduction

It was in 1969—an ordinary year in the official calendar, yet one that in my memory seems suspended between the fading certainties of the postwar world and the tremors of a new ideological awakening—that I found myself, a ninth-grade pupil in the Swedish compulsory school system, dimly aware of a movement that would later come to haunt my reflections on learning itself. The national student union, Sveriges Elevråds Centralorganisation (SECO), had launched a campaign against what it called *indoctrination in schools*—a term that at the time struck me as grandiose, almost theatrical, and yet, beneath its rhetoric, seemed to vibrate with something urgent and unspoken.

This campaign had drawn inspiration from Göran Palm's *Indoktrineringen i Sverige* (*Indoctrination in Sweden*, 1968), a book whose arguments, though I only encountered them later, already seemed to ripple through the atmosphere of the classroom like a faint electrical current. Palm maintained that both the media and the pedagogical apparatus—the textbooks, the teacherly tone, the invisible grammar of civic virtue—were infused with an ideology so pervasive it could pass for common sense: the quiet, persuasive logic of bourgeois values, producing subjects who, docile yet self-satisfied, consumed both goods and ideas with equal obedience. Palm's voice was but one among many in the resounding polyphony of the late 1960s, when critique itself was a kind of cultural oxygen, and even the most conformist souls inhaled a trace of rebellion.

The campaign sought, as I came to understand, to reveal how our schoolbooks—those apparently innocent repositories of knowledge—were in fact latticed with imperial and neo-colonial assumptions about the so-called Third World, and how our own society, beneath its democratic veneer, was quietly organized along the stubborn seams of class. It wished, moreover, to expose the grading system not merely as a mechanism of evaluation but as an instrument of ideological selection: a means of identifying those who would carry the torch of the existing order without ever suspecting its light to be anything but daylight.

Of the campaign itself I recall no vivid episodes—no banners or debates that etched themselves indelibly upon my adolescent mind. I must confess

that, at the time, my political consciousness was but a pale shadow of the fervor that animated my friends, who, with a confidence I envied, spoke as if they had already deciphered the world's hidden grammar. I remember standing among them, half-ashamed of my incomprehension, concealing my uncertainty beneath the armor of a too-carefully chosen trench coat, the kind of garment that, in its petit-bourgeois correctness, betrayed precisely the conformity I longed to escape. And yet, though I failed to grasp the full significance of what was being said around me, a single word—*indoctrination*—lodged itself in my thoughts, like a seed whose germination would be deferred for years, awaiting the rain of later experience.

That seed sprouted in the early 1970s, a period that seemed to breathe a different air: the air of counterculture, of experiment, of refusal. Around me, the Beat writers were exalted as saints of independence, their wanderings and defiance presented as antidotes to the stifling embrace of bourgeois propriety. In literature, too, I found figures of resistance: the young men in Hermann Hesse's novels, who first excel within the walls of the academy only to renounce it in pursuit of a more authentic, solitary apprenticeship of the soul—a kind of *avant la lettre* "quit lit," if one may be forgiven the anachronism. By the time I finished upper secondary school in 1973, the idea of university life seemed to me less a promise than a trap; I longed instead to learn through experience itself—to read the world by roaming through remote deserts and mountains in a 4WD or by walking through it, to think with my hands on a paddle, my feet in a mountain stream, my mind nourished by solitude and the slow accumulation of impressions.

It was through such wanderings—geographical, intellectual, and emotional—that I came to ponder what it might mean to learn without a teacher, to educate oneself in the broadest and most ancient sense of that phrase.

The term *autodidacticism*, which I shall use to frame this inquiry, carries a lineage of meanings: from time immemorial, through the medieval mystic who discovers knowledge in isolation to the modern student who distrusts the institution. One of the earliest allegories of such solitary learning is found in the twelfth-century Andalusian philosopher Ibn Tufayl's *Hayy ibn Yaqzān* (*Alive, Son of the Vigilant*), in which a boy, abandoned on a desert island, teaches himself the whole order of nature—a tale whose echoes resurface in Defoe's *Robinson Crusoe*, the Enlightenment's own hymn to self-fashioned understanding. A later resonance, more explicitly political, emerges in the work of Ivan Illich (*Deschooling Society*, 1971) and Everett Reimer (*School is Dead*, 1971), both of whom sought to imagine education freed from its institutional fetters.

The questions I will explore in this inquiry all have to do with the meanings of autodidacticism based on the examples of Ibn Tufayl and Ivan Illich/Everett Reimer: How is the autodidact described? What are the resources and strategies for learning? To what extent is knowledge possible without language? How crucial is social interaction to cognitive and epistemological

development? Before turning to these emblematic cases, it will be necessary to trace, if only in outline, the shifting conceptual terrain of autodidacticism itself—a field in which the desire for intellectual independence is forever shadowed by the memory of the institutions it seeks to transcend.

Meanings of autodidacticism

Learning unfolds across a vast and mutable spectrum—at times bounded by the walls of institutions, at others occurring in the spontaneous solitude of an individual's curiosity; sometimes collective, sometimes private; sometimes compelled by obligation, at other times animated by desire. The value accorded to each form of learning, and to the credentials that testify to it, varies across historical epochs and cultural landscapes, though divergent norms often coexist, uneasily but persistently. In our present era—the so-called "knowledge society"—learning has been institutionalized to an unprecedented degree. Formal education, with its degrees, diplomas, and standardized evaluations, has become both a civic expectation and a moral injunction, aligning itself with political imaginaries of citizenship, productivity, and global competitiveness. Academic credentials thus function not only as proof of knowledge but as symbols of belonging—signs that one has submitted to the sanctioned rites of learning and emerged credentialed, and therefore legible, within the social order.

Yet, alongside this dominant narrative, another ideal has flourished: that of spontaneous, self-chosen learning, detached from the slow machinery of institutions. This ideal finds its most vivid expression in the arts and, more recently, in the mythology of the digital entrepreneur—the self-taught visionary who, disdaining degrees and diplomas, learns instead through experimentation, failure, and passion. Figures such as Michael Faraday and Thomas Edison are famous examples like their contemporaries Steve Jobs, Bill Gates and Elon Musk which are all often invoked as exemplary autodidacts: men whose refusal of formal education becomes itself a mark of genius. In these narratives, learning appears as an adventure of the will, an act of existential self-definition rather than compliance with a prescribed curriculum.

The yearning for autonomy in learning, however, is not confined to the adult innovator or the solitary artist. It appears already in early childhood, in those small but momentous gestures of independence—when a child insists, "I can do it myself!" (Swedish *kan själv*; French *moi tout seul*), pouring milk or fastening a shoe with more resolve than skill. Developmental psychology and pedagogy has long noted these scenes as evidence of what might be called the first dawning of the autodidactic impulse: the desire to act without instruction, to prove one's capability in the eyes of both self and other (Evaldsson & Kyratzis, 2025; Xu & Evaldsson, 2025). Parents and educators, in turn, must perform a delicate balancing act, guiding while yielding, teaching while allowing the child's will to unfold. The "will age," or *trotsåldern*, that stubborn

season of growth, thus foreshadows the lifelong tension between dependence and autonomy that defines every educational relationship.

These ideals of self-determination do not fade with maturity. In higher education, they reappear—transposed into the language of "student-centered learning," "active learning," and "independent study." Paradoxically, however, what was once spontaneous now requires institutional cultivation: autonomy must be taught, guided, assessed. We have reached the curious juncture where independence itself has become a curricular outcome.

The sources from which one learns are as varied as the forms of learning themselves: the immediacy of lived experience, the contemplation of nature, the quiet companionship of libraries and archives, and now, increasingly, the vast digital expanse of online media. The internet, social platforms, and generative AI have amplified the promise of self-directed learning, offering the illusion—sometimes the reality—of infinite access. In this sense, the dream of autodidacticism has never been more widespread, even as it becomes entangled in the very systems of mediation it seeks to transcend.

Autodidacticism, understood broadly as learning that occurs outside or alongside formal instruction, has a long and intricate genealogy, stretching from ancient times, through the early medieval period to the networked present. The term itself coexists with a constellation of related concepts—self-directed learning, self-regulated learning, self-education, unschooling, deschooling—each emphasizing a slightly different facet of intellectual agency. Despite these terminological nuances, they all converge on a shared conviction: that the act of learning possesses an inner momentum, a self-propelling curiosity that resists confinement.

Scholars such as John Biggs and Catherine Tang (2011) have argued that even within the most institutionalized settings, genuine learning is necessarily self-organizing—an autonomous reconfiguration of knowledge rather than its passive reception. This insight echoes through the few systematic studies of the phenomenon, notably in Joan Solomon's *The Passion to Learn: An Inquiry into Autodidacticism* (2003), where the autodidact is described as one who "would rather not be taught, but does enjoy learning for themselves" (p. 194). Here the emphasis falls not only on cognition but on emotion: curiosity, pride, defiance, the quiet pleasure of mastery achieved without mediation.

Yet, as soon as one begins to idealize self-teaching, a paradox arises. Can anyone truly be *self-taught*? Are not all acts of learning—no matter how solitary—shadowed by the presence of others, whose language, tools, and ideas we unknowingly inherit? More socially attuned interpretations of autodidacticism thus propose a spectrum rather than a dichotomy: degrees of independence within the inevitable web of social learning. Even the most stubborn autodidact is, in some sense, an apprentice to the culture they resist.

The psychological and philosophical roots of this paradox reach back to the foundational theorists of learning. Piaget, with his genetic epistemology, viewed the learner as an active constructor of knowledge, while Vygotsky, in

his sociocultural model, placed that construction within a network of relations. Both converge on a vision of autonomy that is never absolute but dialogical. The scientist, too, as John Ziman (2003) reminds us, must be an autodidact, for the frontier of knowledge is, by definition, a place without teachers. "All modes of learning," he writes, "are at heart autodidactic."

In contemporary life, the frontier has shifted to digital environments, where expertise germinates in virtual communities and knowledge circulates in collaborative loops of creation, imitation, and critique. These cyber-communities have begun to unsettle traditional hierarchies of education, creating new possibilities for what might be called counter-hegemonic learning (Fisher & Fisher, 2007). The figure of the digital autodidact—connected yet self-governing, inventive yet communal—embodies this tension between freedom and structure, between the solitary and the social. Still, even these new images of learning are haunted by older pedagogical ideals; the myth of self-creation remains entwined with the legacy of schooling.

To name this activity is to multiply its synonyms: *informal learning*, *DIY education*, *self-learning*, *unschooling*, *discovery learning*, *learner-driven inquiry*, and many others. Each term refracts a different light, yet they all gesture toward a single principle—the learner's agency. The autodidact chooses subject, pace, and method, guided not by external compulsion but by an inward necessity: curiosity, determination, self-discipline, and the quiet joy of understanding something through one's own effort.

I turn now to the two examples that frame this inquiry into autodidacticism.

Ibn Tufayl and Hayy ibn Yaqzān

Abū Bakr Ibn Tufayl—known in Latin translation as Abubacer—was born in the early twelfth century near Granada, in that luminous and learned world of *al-Andalus* where medicine, philosophy, and theology still conversed across languages and faiths. Trained as a physician, he first served the governor of Granada, and later became court physician and adviser to the Almohad sultan Abū Yaʿqūb Yūsuf, with whom he shared counsel not only on the body's ailments but on the subtler diseases of the intellect and the state. At this court—renowned for its curiosity, its measured tolerance, and its appetite for philosophical debate—Ibn Tufayl occupied a position both practical and speculative: healer, theologian, and philosopher of the human condition. It was he, famously, who recommended that his younger contemporary Ibn Rushd (Averroës) be commissioned to write his great commentaries on Aristotle. When Ibn Tufayl died in Marrakesh in 1185, he left behind but a single surviving work—a modest corpus, yet one that would reverberate through centuries of philosophical reflection (Goodman, 2009; Ben-Zaken, 2011).

Context for self-learning

That surviving work, *Hayy ibn Yaqzān* (*Alive, Son of the Vigilant*), written around 1169, is a philosophical tale that reads at once as parable, pedagogical treatise, and metaphysical allegory. It tells of a boy, Hayy, who comes into being on a deserted island—Wāqwāq in the Indian Ocean—without parents, language, or society. Two possible origins are offered: in one, Hayy emerges spontaneously from the natural elements, born of the earth and divine will; in the other, he is the secret child of a noblewoman who, fearing scandal, sets him adrift in a small vessel. Whatever his genesis, Hayy grows up in solitude, guided only by his senses, his reason, and the patient rhythms of nature.

His education unfolds not in classrooms but through the living world itself. At first he imitates the animals who share his island, learning from them how to feed, shelter, and protect himself. A doe becomes his nurse and companion; her death, when it comes, introduces him to the mystery of mortality. Unable to understand her stillness, he opens her body in search of what has departed—an act of grief that becomes his first experiment, his entry into empirical inquiry. From this moment, observation and reflection interlace: he studies the habits of creatures, the cycles of the stars, the structure of his own mind, and through long contemplation he ascends from the tangible to the abstract, from the visible to the divine. By the end, Hayy has achieved what his author calls *maʿrifa*—an intimate knowledge of God and of the unity of all being—attained not through revelation or instruction but through self-directed discovery.

The philosophical audacity of *Hayy ibn Yaqzān* lies in this claim: that unaided human reason, working in concert with experience and inner illumination, can attain both scientific and spiritual truth. The narrative thus offers, centuries before the Enlightenment, a meditation on the possibility—and the peril—of absolute intellectual autonomy. Ibn Tufayl's solitary learner is the archetype of the autodidact, whose knowledge, untainted by custom or authority, is both pure and perilously untranslatable.

The role of self-learning and autodidacticism

One of the most radical dimensions of Ibn Tufayl's vision is that Hayy reaches enlightenment without teachers, texts, or social exchange. His education is conducted entirely through engagement with his surroundings—the soil he touches, the animals he observes, the heavens he contemplates. This process follows a discernible epistemological progression: it begins with sensory perception and imitation, advances through reasoning and analogy, and culminates in mystical insight. Here empirical inquiry and spiritual contemplation are not opposites but stages in a single ascent. In this respect, Ibn Tufayl anticipates both the classical Islamic tradition of gradual illumination and later developmental models of learning, which view cognition as emerging from interaction with the environment.

Autodidacticism as natural and ideal

In Ibn Tufayl's universe, self-learning is not merely possible; it is ideal. Hayy's knowledge, formed through solitary inquiry, is internalized, experiential, and transformative. It arises from direct encounter rather than transmission, from observation rather than obedience. Against the pedagogical orthodoxy of his time—dominated by religious authority and scholastic repetition—Ibn Tufayl sets the figure of the learner who learns because he must, compelled by wonder rather than by instruction. Yet the allegory turns tragic in its final act. When Hayy encounters visitors from a neighboring island—men bound by ritual, language, and doctrine—he tries to communicate his discoveries, but finds them deaf to his insights. Their inherited beliefs veil them from the truth he has come to know intuitively. Disillusioned, he returns to solitude, carrying with him both illumination and loneliness. The implication is unmistakable: institutionalized education breeds conformity, while the solitary pursuit of understanding, though it may isolate the seeker, leads to authenticity.

Critique of institutionalized learning

The system Ibn Tufayl implicitly critiques is one of rigid hierarchy and doctrinal repetition, where knowledge is memorized rather than understood and authority replaces inquiry. Even in the intellectually fertile milieu of *al-Andalus*, such practices often constrained genuine reflection. Through Hayy, Ibn Tufayl suggests that true education begins only when the learner breaks free from external compulsion and listens to the quiet dialectic of perception and reason within. His parable anticipates, by many centuries, the critiques later advanced by Illich and Reimer—that formal schooling, by institutionalizing learning, may extinguish the very curiosity it claims to cultivate. And yet, *Hayy ibn Yaqzān* does not wholly reject community: it merely warns that when teaching becomes mechanical, it estranges the soul from truth. The autodidact's tragedy, finally, is that what is learned alone cannot easily be taught; his insight resists translation into the language of the schooled.

Ibn Tufayl's vision of self-learning

Beneath the allegory lies a profound epistemological optimism—a conviction that the human mind, unaided but attentive, can reach toward the real. Knowledge, for Ibn Tufayl, is not the property of clerics or academies; it is the birthright of perception and contemplation. Authentic learning requires no institutional validation; it arises from a synthesis of empirical investigation and inward revelation. Still, this vision is not without paradox. Hayy's isolation makes his story a thought experiment rather than a practicable pedagogy. His belated acquisition of language, in middle age and through his encounter with Absal from the neighboring island, raises difficult questions: can

knowledge exist without the mediation of words? Can one think fully without the presence of others? Such questions resonate still, echoing modern debates about the social foundations of cognition.

Legacy and influence

Hayy ibn Yaqzān stands as one of the earliest and most luminous articulations of autodidactic philosophy—an intersection of Islamic metaphysics, empirical observation, and mystical insight (Günther, 2018). It affirms that truth can be attained through reason and reflection, and that institutions, however venerable, often obscure more than they reveal. Though the story remains an allegory, its influence radiated far beyond its immediate world. Scholars have traced its impact across centuries and civilizations—from Pico della Mirandola and Spinoza to Locke and Rousseau (Conrad, 1996; Attar, 2010; Ben-Zaken, 2011; Aravamudan, 2014). In this sense, Ibn Tufayl belongs not only to the Islamic intellectual tradition but also to the pre-history of the European Enlightenment, that vast endeavor to reconcile faith and reason, nature and mind. Ben-Zaken goes further, suggesting that Ibn Tufayl's imaginary island—part laboratory, part paradise—served as a prototype for later utopian fictions: More's *Utopia*, Bacon's *New Atlantis*, Campanella's *City of the Sun*, and Defoe's *Robinson Crusoe*. The solitary child of Wāqwāq, learning to know the world by touching it, thus becomes the ancestor of all who would learn freely, by their own light, in defiance of the schools that claim to enlighten them.

Illich and Reimer

Ivan Illich (1926–2002) was born in Vienna, a city whose very air once seemed saturated with the dialectic between faith and reason, empire and exile. Educated in Italy and Austria, he was ordained as a Catholic priest in 1951, and, with that paradoxical mixture of discipline and compassion characteristic of his temperament, embarked upon missionary work in Latin America. There, amid the contradictions of poverty and progress, he came to recognize that the institutions meant to liberate the human spirit often served, instead, to bind it. In the 1960s, in Cuernavaca, Mexico, he co-founded the Center for Intercultural Documentation (CIDOC)—a space that was less a school than an intellectual commons, where priests, teachers, and thinkers gathered to examine the moral costs of modernization. Within its walls, one might hear, on any given afternoon, the mingled voices of liberation theologians, anarchist utopians, and pedagogical radicals—each seeking, in his or her own idiom, to redeem learning from bureaucracy.

From this crucible of conversation emerged a critique of what Illich called the *service industries* of modernity: education, medicine, transportation, labor, and even justice itself. His diagnosis was unsparing: schools, he argued,

impede learning; cars immobilize by their very excess; medicine makes people sick; justice manufactures crime (Bartlett & Schugurensky, 2020, p. 69). The institutions that claimed to heal and enlighten, he observed, too often produced dependency, passivity, and a subtle estrangement from one's own capacities.

Illich did not work alone. In Everett Reimer he found a close interlocutor—a fellow traveler in the art of intellectual insurrection. Their collaboration was both personal and conceptual: each cited the other as essential companion in a joint pursuit of pedagogical emancipation. The two seminal works that issued from this partnership—Illich's *Deschooling Society* (1971) and Reimer's *School is Dead: Alternatives in Education* (1971)—were shaped by the same constellation of contemporary thinkers: John Holt, whose *How Children Fail* and *How Children Learn* reimagined childhood as curiosity unspoiled; Paul Goodman, whose *Compulsory Miseducation* lamented the schooling of conformity; and Paulo Freire, whose *Pedagogy of the Oppressed* transformed education into a political act. At CIDOC, these voices converged—each a different accent in the same polyphonic call for educational liberation.

Illich's critique of institutionalized education

Illich and Reimer perceived that schooling, in its institutional form, had become the great paradox of modernity: an enterprise devoted to learning that, in practice, discourages it. Schools, they wrote, reproduce hierarchies under the guise of equality, monopolizing access to knowledge by conferring credentials that gatekeep opportunity. In this economy of merit, curiosity becomes obedience, and imagination is disciplined into submission. Through the rituals of curricula, grades, and examinations, students are gently persuaded to mistrust their own inquiries and to measure their worth against the yardsticks of authority.

To *deschool* society, for Illich, was not merely to close its schools but to expose the ideology that sustains them—the belief that learning requires institutional mediation. True education, he insisted, must be lifelong, self-directed, and emancipated from bureaucratic form.

The role of self-learning and learning webs

Yet Illich was not an apostle of solitude. His was a vision of learning as conviviality—an art of shared inquiry among equals. Against the hierarchy of classrooms, he proposed *learning webs*: decentralized, open networks where knowledge could circulate freely between those who wished to learn and those who wished to teach. In these webs, he imagined three essential functions:

> It should provide all who want to learn with access to available resources at any time in their lives; empower all who want to share what they know to find those who want to learn it from them; and furnish all who want to present an issue to the public with the opportunity to make their challenge known. (Illich, 1971, p. 40)

In such a world, learning would arise from desire, not duty; from curiosity, not compulsion. The teacher would cease to be a figure of authority and become, instead, a peer among peers—one node in an infinite conversation. The proposals Illich advanced—peer matching, skill exchange, open access to shared resources—were astonishingly prescient, anticipating by half a century the decentralized, digital learning environments that now proliferate across the internet (Bartlett & Schugurensky, 2020, p. 71).

Self-learning and learning webs as autodidacticism

In Illich's thought, self-learning is both autonomous and communal. Freedom, he reminds us, is not isolation but relation freely chosen. Each learner determines what, how, and with whom to study; yet this independence only flourishes within a democratic ecology of access. The learning web becomes, in effect, a social architecture of autodidacticism—an order without rulers, sustained by trust, reciprocity, and shared curiosity.

Such a vision, luminous as it is, invites critique. Not everyone possesses the same resources—material, cognitive, or emotional—to thrive as a self-directed learner. What of children, or of those whom society has systematically deprived of confidence and opportunity? Can the web truly compensate for inequality, or does it risk mirroring it in digital form? And what of the tenderness that schools sometimes offer—their role as spaces of care, companionship, and the daily ritual of belonging? Illich's utopia, some argue, underestimates the human need for guidance, structure, and the warmth of collective learning.

Yet his influence endures. Educational theorists and technologists continue to cite him as a prophet of decentralization and lifelong learning. In our age—when open-source platforms, peer-to-peer networks, and online learning communities have become part of everyday life—Illich's dream of convivial learning seems, at moments, to have materialized.

When the world, in 2020, was silenced by a pandemic, the doors of schools closed and learning retreated into the domestic sphere. Millions of children became, overnight, reluctant autodidacts. What Illich had once imagined as a philosophical provocation seemed to unfold in historical fact—not by deliberate design, but by the twin forces of digital technology and biological necessity. The *deschooling of society*, Bartlett and Schugurensky (2020, p. 77) observe, occurred not through policy but through contagion: a sudden return of learning to the home, mediated by screens rather than chalkboards.

Illich's vision of learning as liberation

At the heart of Illich's radical pedagogy lies a conviction as old as Ibn Tufayl's island: that knowledge, to be real, must be discovered rather than delivered. Education, he insists, is not a service but an act of freedom. To learn is to reclaim one's agency against the machinery of certification, to rediscover the joy of understanding as an end in itself. Illich knew well that his vision was utopian, perhaps unattainable; but he also knew that without utopias, education becomes merely administration.

In the end, his work—like Reimer's, like the solitary meditations of Hayy ibn Yaqzān—invites us to imagine learning not as submission to authority, but as an art of living: a free, convivial, and unending pursuit of meaning shared among equals.

Two visions of autodidacticism: Ibn Tufayl and Ivan Illich

Separated by nearly a millennium, and by worlds that seem to belong to different planets of thought, Ibn Tufayl and Ivan Illich stand as distant yet strangely resonant figures in the long genealogy of learning outside the walls of the school. The one a court physician and philosopher of twelfth-century *al-Andalus*, the other a twentieth-century priest turned social critic in Latin America, both discerned in the human capacity to learn alone—and to learn freely—the seed of intellectual and moral emancipation. They wrote in languages that could never have met, and yet both gave voice to an idea that transcends time: that education, to be true, must be neither commanded nor confined.

Their visions may be read as parallel meditations on four interwoven dimensions: self-learning, the critique of institutions, the ideal of the learner, and the place of learning in society.

For Ibn Tufayl, *self-learning* unfolds in perfect solitude. Hayy, abandoned to an island without human speech, becomes the living allegory of knowledge arising from observation, reflection, and communion with the natural order. His education proceeds through the senses to the soul, from the visible to the invisible, until empirical curiosity becomes mystical illumination.

Illich's autodidact, by contrast, is not alone among animals and trees but enmeshed in networks of human exchange. His solitude is elective, not absolute; his learning, convivial rather than monastic. Knowledge grows not in the silence of isolation but in dialogue with peers, through webs of mutual teaching and shared discovery. The one learns to see the divine in nature; the other, the human in community.

Illich's *critique of institutions* is frontal, modern, and sociological. Institutions, he contends, convert learning into dependency. They monopolize access to knowledge and convert curiosity into certification. The school, in his eyes,

has become the church of a secular faith in credentials, reproducing inequality under the guise of merit.

Ibn Tufayl's challenge, though articulated in another idiom, is no less subversive. He does not speak of "institutions," for such structures had not yet hardened into their modern forms, but he exposes the suffocating weight of orthodoxy, the inertia of received belief, the peril of mistaking authority for truth. Both thinkers, in their different centuries, write against obedience as an educational virtue.

Hayy, the island philosopher, is the exemplar of solitary illumination: he learns through wonder, experiments through intuition, and attains a serenity born of union with the divine. His education culminates not in mastery but in transcendence.

Illich's *ideal learner*, by contrast, is neither saint nor hermit. His is a secular saintliness—ethical rather than mystical—founded upon solidarity, dialogue, and the freedom to learn with others. If Hayy's journey ends in contemplative stillness, Illich's begins in the restless movement of social becoming. The one seeks revelation; the other, liberation.

When Hayy, after a lifetime of solitude, finally encounters other humans, his heart is filled not with joy but disappointment because of the state of *learning in society*. He finds that the people, shaped by custom and doctrine, are deaf to truth. The solitude that once nourished his discovery becomes his refuge from misunderstanding.

Illich, though no less critical of society's institutions, refuses despair. Influenced by liberation theology and by Paulo Freire's pedagogy of the oppressed, he imagines that once the chains of institutional dependency are broken, communities can rediscover their capacity to learn together. Where Ibn Tufayl's vision closes in elegiac isolation, Illich's opens toward a collective hope.

Contextual differences

To trace these two visions across their immense historical distance is to be reminded that learning is always entangled with its means of transmission—with its tools, its languages, and its metaphysics. Between Ibn Tufayl's twelfth-century Granada and Illich's twentieth-century Cuernavaca lies not merely time but an entire transformation of the human condition.

In *al-Andalus*, access to knowledge was both sacred and scarce. Books were precious objects, hand-copied and guarded in mosques; learning was an act of devotion mediated through the living voice of the *shaykh*. To know was to remember, to recite, to transmit. Orality was the pulse of knowledge, and memorization its discipline. The learner's autonomy was bound to lineage and authority, for knowledge itself was conceived as finite—a divine trust, not a human invention. Originality, if it strayed too far from orthodoxy, risked being mistaken for heresy.

By contrast, the twentieth century's learner inhabited a world of plenitude. Literacy was widespread; libraries and media offered what Ibn Tufayl's contemporaries could scarcely imagine: abundance. The book was no longer a relic but a commodity; the word, no longer sacred but ubiquitous. Illich's autodidact navigated not scarcity but excess. Tools of learning multiplied—printed texts, films, radios, computers—transforming knowledge into a field of infinite recombination.

Motivations, too, diverged. In Ibn Tufayl's world, learning was an act of piety, a duty of the soul toward God. In Illich's, it became an act of self-realization, sometimes of rebellion. Knowledge ceased to be inherited and became constructed, experimental, secular. If the medieval mind regarded learning as remembrance of divine order, the modern mind, influenced by Marx, Freud and Vygotsky alike, treated it as creation within human history.

Socially, Ibn Tufayl's *al-Andalus* was stratified, its intellectual life sustained by courts and mosques, its freedoms delicate and provisional. Independent thought required discretion and the subtle rhetoric of allegory. The reign of the Almohads, under whom Ibn Tufayl served, was marked by a rare curiosity beyond dogma—but also by the ever-present shadow of doctrinal power.

Illich's century, no less hierarchical, clothed its authority in the language of progress. Schools, universities, and professional bodies became the temples of secular knowledge. His deschooling manifesto arose not from the margins but from the heart of institutional modernity, its critique made possible precisely because institutions had grown so pervasive.

The ideological frameworks that shaped their thought could scarcely be more distinct. For Ibn Tufayl, knowledge was revealed—divine, bounded, luminous, and complete. For Illich, it was constructed—human, provisional, and open to revision. Yet across this divide, the two meet in a shared intuition: that truth must be experienced, not administered; that the path of learning, whether it leads to God or to freedom, must be walked in self-chosen steps.

Personal reflection

When I look back to those last months of compulsory schooling with which I began this essay, I see myself as one might recall the dim interior of a room long since abandoned: the air still heavy with the scent of routine, the walls lined with the instruments of instruction, yet somewhere a window—slightly ajar—through which another air was already entering. The anti-indoctrination campaigns of that time, though I scarcely understood their full intent, brushed against me like a passing wind, stirring a vague but insistent intuition that learning, if it were to mean anything, must begin in freedom. Those first seeds of doubt, perhaps nourished by the broader countercultural murmur that drifted even into our classrooms, began to root themselves quietly within me.

By the time I left secondary school, I was no longer content to be merely taught; I wished to discover. The world itself, with all its unmarked paths and sudden illuminations, became my library. My *Wanderjahre* unfolded like an education without syllabus or sanction—each conversation, each book found by accident, each place slept in, a lesson of its own. There was a sweetness in that uncertainty, and a gravity too: for to learn alone is to become, in some measure, responsible for one's own truth.

Seven years later, I returned to the university, not to surrender my autonomy but to test it—to see whether the spirit of questioning I had carried through those wandering years might survive the lecture hall. I came back wary, but also curious, resolved to study the very structures from which I had once fled. It is, perhaps, the paradox of every autodidact who reenters the institution: to learn from within what one has learned to distrust.

In tracing, through this essay, the figures of Ibn Tufayl and Ivan Illich, I have sought to show that autodidacticism is less a doctrine than a landscape—vast, varied, and haunted by the dreams of those who have tried to learn without masters. In the solitude of Hayy and the convivial networks of Illich's learners, I find mirrored the two halves of my own search: the yearning for inner illumination and the need for shared understanding. Between them lies the open question that continues to move me—the question of what learning might yet become when liberated from both fear and authority, when it is allowed, once again, to follow the quiet, stubborn path of curiosity itself.

Epilogue

And so I return, as one always does, to that faintly lit classroom of my youth—not to dwell in its confines, but to listen for the echo of the moment the window first trembled open. The world beyond, which once seemed distant and forbidden, has by now become both my teacher and my text. In its shifting lights and silences, I hear the same invitation that called to Hayy on his island and to Illich in his Mexican convent: to learn without permission, to think as an act of love. Perhaps, after all, learning has no true beginning and no final lesson—only the long awakening of attention, renewed each time we dare to ask, once more, what it means to know.

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Do linguists know what a natural language is?

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Introduction

In this essay I will discuss what a natural language is, and how we can understand it. But space is limited, and life is short, so I will choose just to discuss a small set of what I take to be misleading or doubtful assumptions about language, communication, imagination, experiences, and thinking. These assumptions have misled many "victims", both "ordinary language users" and academics ("experts", primarily formal linguists). So what follows here will be a mix of divergent though important things.

1. Language: Systems of signs or practices

If we scrutinise history and traditions in the language sciences and linguistics, we will find that there are two competing ways of looking at language. The most traditional approach is that language is basically *language structures and systems*, often combined with the assumption that the systems are stores of *signs* of different kinds. Structuralism (Saussure, 1964) and generativism (Chomsky, 1965, 1995), the predominating approaches in 20th century linguistics, belong to this traditional "camp". Generativism, in particular, argues that rules and items of language must be formalised in scientific accounts. Saussure (1964) considered language to be formal, but he did not formalise. In formal linguistics, there is basically *no* convincing evidence that the rules and units, the basic concepts in, e.g., generativism, are operative in the minds of language users when they exercise production and comprehension in real life. The central concepts in language systems, I argue, are only peripherally operative in real practices.

Some scholars, including myself, argue that language is performance, that is, linguistic and communicative *practices*: *actions* and *activities*. I shall therefore use the term '*languaging*' which is supposed to be a verbal derivation ("to language" or "doing language") etc. (for more discussion, see Linell (2022a, b).)

Many of the points below are implied by my conviction that language is basically practices: languaging. Language is not primarily about sets of abstract 'signs'. Instead, languaging is a resource for social interaction and communication, imagination, thinking and cognition. However, these phenomena too must involve some structures (but not as many as formal linguists tend to

suggest). I will return to the point that surface utterances are patterned, i.e. contain structures (see below, this paragraph). Yet, languaging must be regarded as primary, with abstractions of structures (language as systems) as secondary.

Structuralism, largely instigated by Saussure, abstracts the structures (often called "pure form") from linguistic practices, thus excluding "substance" from the language system. Substance involves *concrete* phenomena, including phonetics, the use of vocal, acoustic, and other verbal gestures, and other bodily aspects, the use of the "vocal tract", etc. In addition, "substance" comprises aspects of social interaction, language learning and language use, the role of situations and other contexts, and communication, thinking and imagination (provided that these involve aspects of language).

A reasonable approach to both spoken languaging and substance can be made by describing the properties of their central units, i.e., *utterances*:

1. Utterances are hearable, visible and other tangible actions (cf. § 7).
2. Utterances are integrated in situations/contexts (situations are equally important as the formulation of what participants say.)
3. Utterances belong to the participants, not the abstract language.
4. Utterances support linguistic, e.g., phonological and grammatical, functions.
5. Utterances are analysed and understood in the situation.
6. Utterances are the core of *turns*, and *contributions* to discourse and *dialogue*.

In structural linguistics, by contrast, phonology, syntax, logical semantics, are all regarded as non-substantial; linguists have killed living language and made languaging secondary. In other words, utterances are belittled in structuralism (language as systems; "abstract objectivism"; Rommetveit, 1988, p. 14). Nonetheless, linguistic practices are by necessity to some extent recognised in structuralism. But they are derived from "underlying" (abstract) regularities, rather than from concrete aspects. This, then, amounts to presenting language upside-down.

There are genres in which language as systems are necessary. Logical and mathematical texts are cases in point, and more generally, written, printed or computer-borne texts. One may note that this concerns written texts (Linell, 2005), not spoken languaging.

2. On national languages and their characteristics

It is commonplace that particularly lay persons (but also among untaught linguists) tend to think of national languages as fully *unified, integrated systems*. Languages, such as English, Swedish, Russian, Thai, and many other

"languages" are examples, in which there are consolidated grammars, vocabularies, regular semantics and logics, etc.

However, many *believe* that languages – with their own and other people's national languages being the most typical examples – are both unitary and integrated systems. This misleading assumption that has been around for a long time, especially among politicians and religious (faithful) people, is simply not generally true. The idea was radicalised by structuralists and generativists among linguists.

There may be different requirements among national languages regarding which integrated systems, and how many, are assumed by the specific authorities. Yet, we can say that national "languages" are not unitary and integrated, but *distributed* (Cowley, 2011) across varieties of use in communities of users, genres, lexical domains, professional languages, literary varieties, youth languages (particularly in big cities and urban areas), slang, jargons, mixed language with foreign accents (again mostly in big cities). These varieties overlap, intersect, and constitute meshworks (Cowley's pertinent analogy), within the whole distributed system. It has therefore been claimed in parts of linguistics, philosophy of language, sociolinguistics, etc. that national languages are not relevant cases for linguistic studies by experts, because the national standard languages have been strongly regulated by politicians (particularly in governments), administrators and experts of different kinds, in legal, religious, literate, and academic sections of society. Several influential language scholars, as different as J.R. Firth in sociolinguistics, Noam Chomsky in theoretical linguistics, and Mikhail Bakhtin in language philosophy, have discarded national languages as objects of studies of language (whether they are systems or practices). Yet, the British language professor Roy Harris (1980, 1981, 2002) claimed that linguists were the true "language-makers", and, consequently, responsible for various "language myths" (some of which will be taken up in this text.) However, some of Harris's claims are often criticized as overstated (Joseph, 1997; Linell, 2005).

Despite what has been said above, national languages *are* used as important data for many modern linguists. In fact, linguists have influenced their conventional or official versions in dictionaries, grammar books, etc. Cowley's idea of 'distributed language' is undoubtedly sound. But the idea presupposes that there is a kernel of facts which define fundamental features of phonology, lexicon, morphology and syntax, parts of which must be known and used by most speakers in a majority of the overlapping communities. Without that, there would not be *a* language, and there would be no significant distribution.

3. The myth behind the idea of unitary, integrated languages

In the previous section, I argued that national languages are not the kind of unitary, integrated languages that we often naïvely believe. We have already seen that unity and integration are *not* very common properties among

languages, although the case of national languages is perhaps particularly salient. I would argue that the general claim is a myth. It reflects people's efforts to stick to one language, or their belief that they do so.

Unity and integration have sometimes been seen as necessary conditions for languages to work as ingrained and easily communicative requirements. This is, however, the case mostly for small groups of speakers, with a high degree of social solidarity and consensus. These conditions are not particularly probable for wide-spread languages, such as national languages, which tend be distributed (§ 2). Moreover, if users try to talk and think with great precision and versatility, they would probably have access to several overlapping linguistic resources.

It seems reasonable to argue that the idea of a language which is highly unified and integrated has a backing in the more general assumption that people constitute a community of cooperation and collaboration. Seen as an axiom this is a dubious assumption.

4. The myth that utterances in external dialogues only serve co-operative and "democratic" goals

Section 3 involved the myth that whole languages (especially national languages) are unitary and integrated, and that the explication behind the myth was that people (unconsciously) want to be part of the same community or nation. In this section (§ 4) we encounter a myth about communication which has, somewhat surprisingly, a similar explication: interactants assume that they necessarily co-operate within the same consensual community.

It is often assumed that when we participate in friendly conversations, these external (and internal) dialogues are designed to create common and shared understandings (Schegloff, 1992). This idea undoubtedly rests on the unfounded and *taken-for-granted* assumption that real communication must lead to, or ought to lead to, shared understandings. From the vagueness of the origin (§ 5) via some enrichment (how this would be organised is hardly known) to the actual execution and monitoring of the utterance, which is characterised by *sequentiality* between the parties' utterances, which is the result of sticking to a constant kind of interest and the insistent, obliging, mutual *responsivity*. Without responsivity, the dialogue would not produce coherent and co-operative relations between the successive contributions by the different participants. But this does not mean that a total consensus must emerge. Matusov (1996) argues that even friendly attitudes can generate semantic and referential divergences. The intersubjectivity created in a dialogue is seldom perfect; some dialogues contain a fair amount of disagreements. This view would mean that we do not always go for consensus in conversations; we may instead be interested in slight differences between oneself and the others among participants. There are opportunities and occasions for disregarding differences in opinions as we forget about potentially "lost" understandings (von Wright,

1974; Josephs, 1998). In fact, we learn a good deal by our experiences of so-far unfamiliar ideas.

Both myths in § 3-4 are built upon the same assumption, namely, that we tend always to work within interactions that are characterised by "democratic" symmetry, equality, co-operation, sharedness, etc.

5. The origin of an utterance or a new episode

When somebody is engaged in starting a conversational "episode" (van Dijk, 1982), i.e. beginning a public utterance with a new topic, (s)he does not start out from a complete representation of the upcoming utterance. Instead, the beginning is usually a "general thematic introduction" (van Dijk, op.cit., p. 184). This means that (s)he normally departs from a rather vague idea, and usually from a situation of *indeterminacy* (§ 6). If the episode is carried on by the participants, the introduction is usually followed by a number of "specifications" (ibid.) of topics. The episode is normally finalised with "opinions" and "general statements" (ibid., p. 185-187) from different participants. The environment is generally difficult to survey, and it is usually chaotic and rich (both these characterisations are apt). It would be a surprise if such predicaments do not influence the process!

Despite what was said in the prior paragraph, it might be natural to assume that somebody who starts to talk on a new topic "knows what (s)he is going to say". However, this is only seldom the case. Of course the person in question may have spent time on planning what to say. This would probably necessitate some kind of deliberation and rehearsal on the part of the prospective speaker.

An utterance is very often produced piece-by-piece. Hesitations, silences and pauses are often used by speakers who try to tackle a topic which seems sensitive and therefore difficult. Such a case is the following snippet from an interview (the utterance/turn is rather long):

(5:1) DIFFICULT TO SAY (From a talk show in Swedish television (Linell, 2022a:232). Translated into English here. I is the interviewer, G is a well-known writer and columnist, who appears here as guest and respondent. `Courier` is used to mark words actually spoken)

01. I: `eh (.) many of us probably believe that we know you (.)`
02. `do we?`
03. G: `(0.5) hhhh (0.5) he he (°it was°) ehm I but I`
04. ((< --AS crosses his arms ---------->))
05. G: (l.5 cntnd) `believe it's difficult—(0.5) it's like this,`
06. G: `it's difficult to answer (.) simply. I use, y'know, my`
07. G: ((<--AS touches his cheek -->)) `life for telling stories, and-eh`
08. G: ((<-- AS waves his hand open-->)) `for me the sto- the stories`

09. G: come before the truth if you understand what I mean
10. G: ((<-- waves his hand to and fro---------->
11. I: no not really

G is asked to tell the audience something he finds difficult to talk about. Already in line 3 he is sighing ("hh hh"), followed by a light laughter. He then claims once more that it would be difficult to talk about the topic (lines 3-6). Later, he demonstrates the "difficulty" by saying that for him, "telling stories comes before the truth", something which obviously is difficult for G to get across. Other indications of embarrassment involve arm crossing, self-touches, i.e., aspects that seem to show that he is embarrassed. His attempts to save the situation by using several verbal and non-verbal indications of problems. Indeed, he fails to make the female journalist understand him (line 11). The idea is that a person who is about to formulate an initiating utterance or a longer chunk in a public situation can seldom start out from a definite point of departure. It might be natural to assume that somebody who starts to talk on a new topic "knows what (s)he is going to say". Prospective speakers are often forced to start with a rather vague idea. But we must remember that talking is not just about entertaining people or making them informed.

Today, many cognitivists assume that first actions, such as immanent decisions, utterances on a new topic or any other initiatives, have their origins in situations of *indeterminacies*. Among philosophers, Dennett (1987, 1996) doubts that agents must have precise intentions before they get going with their projects. I argued already in Linell (1979) that an initiating speaker usually cannot tell from the beginning "what (s)he is going to say".[12]

6. The function of utterances are never just their linguistic meaning

If users believe in the integration of their common language in an external dialogue between two or more participants, the composition of *linguistic (primarily "lexical") items*, i.e., words and grammar (morphology, phrases and clauses/sentences), *will determine a lion's part of the meanings of utterances*: This assumption, however, is one of the most misleading ones in most of linguistics. It misses out on the fact that utterances are *always* dependent for its interpretation(s) on the social contexts of the *situations* in which the utterances are exercised by participants. These situations may be perceived and understood differently by participants. This includes the significant happenings that occur in the occasional changes over time.

It is important to note that if we are only equipped with a written *sentence* it can turn up in different contexts in time and space (as opposed to an

[12] Interestingly, Hegel (1807) discussed the term "symbol" used about a piece of art that is not yet ready (finalised). In such a case, the symbol expresses something which is not expressible, or expressed (Liedman, 2006:293). The piece of art (a sculpture, a painting) is something the artist has not fully realized, the symbol to be created in the future.

occasioned utterance). This is one of the important circumstances, which would distinguish (most) written (that is, artefact-based) languaging from (most of) spoken languaging. The misleading assumption in this section would be a central component of the "written language bias in linguistics" (§ 9; Linell, 2005), i.e. it would be taken for granted that what was typical of written language could also (erroneously) be applied in the analysis of spoken communication.

Some derived points above are implied by the choice of a language-system or languaging theory from (§ 2) and (§ 3). In the following argumentation there are more such examples (§ 10-11).

One may wonder how structuralists could argue that a language and its "systems" are just "pure form" (§ 10: "form" = "structure")[13]. There must be something more in language than structures (§ 1). Indeed, most structuralists excluded what they called "substance" (a concept borrowed from Aristotle!). But even if there is something which deserves to be called "substance", all of it is not really part of language for structuralists. So what is "substance" according to structuralism? Here is a brief list (cf. § 1): these "substantial" points are not abstractions.

a) Linguistic practices (language use) in conversations, also writing and reading in written languaging, or in digital languaging, performance, language acquisition;
b) Interactions, purposes, genres, contexts, complex activities;
c) Mind- and sense-making in somatic and mental diseases (aphasia, abnormal gesticulation, schizophrenia);
d) Comprehensive activities, professional genres, societal sections (news media, science and research, healthcare, judicial systems, private life, etc., collisions between such sectors);
e) Bodily organs which are crucial for talk and speech: respiratory organs (rhythm, strength), larynx (prosodic-vocal effects): mouth cavity (articulation of vowels, consonants, and syllables)

Perhaps the last points (body organs) are important since they produce different emotional talk fulfilling different functions. Voices are raised (aggressive) or they are lowered or become softer or more composed. In this context, the respiratory strength and the variation in laryngeal outputs (prosodic or non-verbal) are most important, but the mouth cavity can contribute many nuances. What I sketched in the prior paragraph shows that language and languaging, and its words and constructions, are not fixated (§ 8). Instead, we as communicants meet with countless situations, in which participants have to press the

[13] Several structuralists insisted that logical structures of language were "pure forms": But some were less "hard-nosed" (radical) than others; for example, moderate—Saussure, R. Jakobson, Cassirer, B. Malmberg; radical—Alpatov, Chomsky, Coseriu, Hjelmslev.

limits of their language. In languaging we draw out and stretch the limits of language. (Naturally, this does not hold for logical formulas and professional terms.)

7. Is language abstract or concrete?

Most ordinary speakers probably look upon (natural) language as a practical resource. Yet, another presumption about language is that it is fundamentally abstract; many users, who speak coherently or, above all, write texts carefully, regard language as an abstract system. The latter group has adopted some of the evaluations in the Written Language Bias (see § 9). This is an appraisal which does not fit all improvised activities.

Language models are in general seen as *units and rules* for combining basic units into complex structures. Some adherents of language as abstract structure (as a more concrete term) may suggest that a language is a large storehouse of more or less ready-made *signs.* Units (or signs) that have commonly been posited are logical formulas (as opposed to concrete utterances and contributions to particular dialogues), sentences and clauses, propositions (roughly the semantic sides of sentences and clauses), morphemes and morphological paradigms, *words* (lexical items), phonemes, etc.

Most of these traditional units have not been confirmed as operative in actual bodily language use. By 'operative' I mean that there should be evidence that the units in question are used in the production and interpretation of linguistic products (speech, writing).

A full-blown language is either a huge set of *signs,* or a repertoire of dynamic *actions* that users have at their disposal in different situations. Actions include claims, questions, instructions, requests, affirmations, promises, threats, and numerous others.

In a theory of spoken languaging I would propose that the two obvious unit types of *utterances* and *syllables* are primarily*,* and vowels, consonants and segments of syllables, are arguably operative in performance too.

However, we should also posit *lexical units* (words); some of these are lexicalised phrases (some are compounds) and clauses. In other words, they are more or less ready-made expressions. These are clearly operative in languaging; they are *concrete* and used all the time in speaking and in interpreting speech. They are therefore frequently attended to in practices.

The issue of abstractness vs. concreteness (§ 7) is troublesome since structuralism preferably describes aspects of language as abstract ("pure form"), whereas adherents of (spoken) languaging theory focus on concrete aspects that are describable as "substance". The two approaches are summarised in § 10 as (A) and (B), respectively. It might be better to talk about *potentialities* and *fixations* than abstract and concrete units. I will do this in § 8.

8. Words as potentialities or fixations

It must be stressed that complex units are often produced in actual languaging. This holds especially for the pragma-semantic side, where we find meaning potentials in the case of words, message potentials in the case of complete utterances, and situations with their situated (situation) potentials. *Potentials* suggest that the items in question can be exploited in different ways; there are different options in situ at the semantic and pragmatic sides (meaning, message, situation potentials). Semantic potentials are by definition *not fixated*; they are often *subjected to negotiation* in situ.[14] (In other words, many aspects of languaging are dynamic.[15])

The best way to put language sciences on a sound course is in my opinion to go for *concreteness* (cf. utterances, § 1), rather than abstractness. Concreteness means briefly that actual things and topics are dealt with, and *abstractness* concerns aspects that have been defined and abstracted out from underlying representations or from the concrete facts.

Another point is that potentialities (Norén & Linell, 2007) are more fruitful theoretical principles than fixation. So why should we go for concreteness when we try to understand language? The best reasons have to do with the facts that spoken languaging (which are presupposed in this essay) is about phenomena that belong to everyday realities. We use language and languaging for a large share of our time of existence during our lives.

It must be stressed that complex units are constructed in actual languaging. But many language users believe that words and other signs have stable or fixated meanings. Rommetveit (1988) calls this "the myth of literal meaning." He goes on to describe the idea of stable or "literal" meanings as something like "*stories told* by prominent scholars" (including linguists) and as "*a reality lived* by enlightened laymen" (*italics* in original; p. 15)

Rather than stable meanings, words and other linguistic signs have *meaning potentials* that allow different situated meanings. I shall give some examples of words that illustrate their potentialities: *bald* (bald people are not "bald" in one and the same manner), *blood* (with different associations depending on the contexts, e.g., blood donation and war), *it* (deictic, abstract pointing vs. a formal place-holder in "it is…"), *democracy, nationalism* (political concepts with divergent interpretations among politicians and language users), *banana* (the whole fruit and the eatable part; Rommetveit, 1988, p. 26f.), *lavender* (with contexts like seasoning spices and garden plants). Potentialities of meanings are commonplace, but there are activities, such as professions and science/scholarship, in which fixated meanings are important. But these are not common everyday words but *terms*.

[14] If I am correct, the concept of 'potentials' was invented by Rommetveit (1974). On lexico-semantic potentials, see Norén & Linell (2007).

[15] The term 'dynamic' is not meant as a simple boost-word; it simply means that the phenomenon in question adapts to specifics of the situation at hand.

Potentialities are relevant also for complex linguistic constructions, and non-linguistic gestures. A complex (phrasal) construct is *my eldest sister* (which is either a straight-forward construction built upon the constituent words and the phrase structure); note, however, that the utterance in question may be situational message potential (Rommetveit, 1974) meaning that the person referred to simply behaves as if she were "my eldest sister"). A case of the latter category (non-linguistic gestures) is the gesture "thumbs up".

The presence of potentialities is related to other points. One is that language is not entirely an abstract phenomenon, despite that this too is a classical assumption (§ 8). However, language and languaging (§ 1) is *concreteness:* basic resources like utterances, syllables, gestures, which can be heard, seen, touched and felt. Of course, those who construct digital, logical, coded systems work with abstract materials. Another resource is the presence of signboards and sign-posts in the landscape. These examples have an evolutionary history in natural languages, but now they have become cognitive and communicative artifacts.

The formal representations that are central in formal logic (e.g. Chomsky, 1995), are not false, but they are misleading. Formalists have not been able to show that the minds of real people organise their brain processes in anything that is similar to the formal models. Consequently, such forms and rules do not seem to be operative; language users in different communities do not necessarily recognise the academic structures.

Instead of the "pure form" of structuralism we should focus on "substance" (bodily resources, social interaction). The structuralist solution, going back to Saussure (1964), was initiated in order to make linguistics a well-defined and strictly limited discipline, with narrow theories, models and boundaries. To do better, we have to work with interdisciplinary studies including knowledge from psychology (cognition), sociology (social interaction), situation studies, cultural studies (including literature studies), and biology (evolutionary studies).

Linguistics cannot really treat semantics and pragmatics (which *are* parts of present-day linguistics, but it lacks concrete insights from contexts and situations, social life, dialogical activities (not just structures), and human existence (Linell, 2022a, b). CA in interactional studies suffer from the absence of contexts and situations.

9. Speaking and Writing: The Written Language Bias in Linguistics

Traditionally, written language has enjoyed a higher status than spoken language/languaging (often called "dialects") in many countries. My project "The Written Language Bias (WLB) in Linguistics", conducted approximately 1981-2004, was not about history but more about how linguistic variants have steered the analysis of written or spoken language or languaging. Methods and analytic results in written language theories have dominated linguistics,

irrespective of whether there have been any explicit reasons given. There has been a WLB in linguistics on many points; I identified 101 points in Linell (2005).

10. What and Where is Language?

I have ascertained that the history of language philosophy has included two competing ideas, namely, language-system theory, which also assumed that the system is an integrated set of structures involving numerous *signs* at different levels of structuration. Ordinary language users usually think of the signs as words, word constellations such as phrases, clauses and sentences. (Notice that these terms have their origins in readers and writers, i.e., the Written Language Bias (§ 9). Educated linguists have usually worked with more sophisticated and disparate categories.

The two perspectives, which I earlier called language-system theories (A) and languaging (B) theory, both involve both signs and actions, and are therefore not entirely irreconcilable. I will therefore reclassify the data into three categories, as follows:

a) Maximally abstract: The logical (or perhaps semantic) structures, "pure forms" according to European structuralism or "underlying representations" in Chomsky (1995); or his "deep structures"(1965).
b) "Deep-&-surface-structural" model: Chomsky (1965) launched a model which involved a "deep" level which could use derivations to arrive at "surface structures". This obviously allowed for intermediate levels with "representations" and perhaps "signs". However, a lexical level was missing.
c) Spoken languaging: Concrete surface-level units and utterances (hearable, visible, haptic-tactile, etc.)

Here, (a) and partly (b) contain deep-seated signs and representations, whereas (c) is radically concrete. Language-system (A) models and Languaging (B) remain the two alternatives, but there is space for overlapping, especially when we consider signs, in particular lexical units.

The language-system theory (A) has dominated linguistics until very recently. It has only relatively recently got a rival in languaging theory (B). The (A) alternative has struggled with some weaknesses in its great difficulties to find the whereabouts of the language systems of signs. Where are they? Since it has hardly been the property of a single or small group of competent language users, linguists have often come up with the rather empty and meaningless attribute of "superindividuality". Another suggestion is that language-systems are "virtual"; they are distributed across different electronic stocks of

information. A more material basis can be found if data are written in inscriptions of various kinds (papers, printed books, note-books, regulations in official texts, digital systems, etc.).

As stated above (§ 1), hyperstructuralist ideas have claimed that the fundamental ("underlying") structures are simply "pure forms", stripped of the substances which are common in concrete language use. The absence of substances is of course another weakness of the (A) alternative.

The strength of languaging-theory (B) is of course that the core of it is precisely the substance. A related strength in (B) is the concreteness it provides utterances with. (B) therefore is more accessible to a larger majority of people.

The weakness of (B) is the lack of a theory of systems. However, it is based on utterances. Important structures are present in the utterances themselves, both grammatically and phonetically (§ 1). This would suddenly turn the odds of (A) and (B).

Having said this, I would claim that there has been a long mistake in language sciences when they have preferred signs to understandings and sensemakings.

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